

Tamil, Step by Step, Root by Root

An etymology-driven curriculum, built one word at a time

Adhithya Rajasekaran

This edition compiled incrementally — new chapters added as they are written.

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Preface

This book teaches Tamil one word at a time, and it teaches each word by taking it apart. It is written for someone starting from zero — who may not read a single Tamil letter — so the script is taught *inside the word lessons themselves*: each word introduces exactly the letters it needs, so you learn to read வணக்கம் *and* learn that it means “greetings” in the same few minutes. There is no alphabet drill to sit through first.

Many readers will not be starting from zero at all. If you grew up speaking Tamil at home and never studied it — fluent in the language, hesitant with the letters, never once told *why* any of it works the way it does — this book is written for you as well. Skim the “letters in this word” notes for the handful of shapes you are unsure of, and read the rest for the grammar and the history nobody sat you down and explained.

Tamil rewards this depth more than most languages. It is the oldest-attested of the **Dravidian** tongues — a family entirely separate from the Indo-European one that gave us English, Latin, and Sanskrit — and it is famously protective of its own word-stock. Again and again you will find Tamil keeping a home-grown word (வணக்கம் *vaṇakkam*, “hello”; நன்றி *nanri*, “thanks”) where its sisters Kannada, Telugu, and Malayalam reached for a Sanskrit one. So each lesson sets the word beside its cousins across the family — English always, and Sanskrit, Hindi, and the other Dravidian languages where they illuminate — every form supplied in full, so no prior knowledge of any of them is assumed.

How to use this book

Every numbered section is one word, or one small phrase, and takes a few minutes — the length of a queue, an errand, or the walk to the bus. Read them in order the first time through: each section stands on the ones before it, and nothing is used before it has been taught. After that the book becomes reference, and you can open it anywhere.

Say the Tamil out loud wherever you can. The prompts under *Your turn* are written to be spoken, and saying a word is most of what makes it stay. The questions under *Before you move on* carry their own answers in brackets: cover them, answer from memory, then look.

Nothing here is gated behind the alphabet. Each lesson introduces exactly the letters and sounds its own word needs, so you are reading real words from the first page rather than drilling a chart. The whole script is gathered in a reference at the back of the book — somewhere to look things up when you are curious, never a chapter to sit through first.

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Chapter 1

Greetings

Modes: ⇄ voice (8) ✍ pen (2) ⇄ Hands-free start: first 1 of 10 lessons.

The Tamil greetings and the words that oil a first conversation, and how Tamil sits inside the Dravidian family. This chapter is **sound first**: you can say everything in it without reading a letter. The Tamil is printed alongside so the shapes grow familiar. After the first greeting, one optional two-minute step lets your finger follow and your pencil copy just its first visible shape. Formal letter construction still starts in Chapter 4 and adds one lesson at a time, always spelling words you already know by ear.

1.1 வணக்கம் (*vaṇakkam*) — “greetings,” a small act of respect

The letters in this word

Say it *va-ṇak-kam*. The ṇ is a **retroflex** *n* — curl the tongue back to the roof of the mouth, further back than an English *n*. The *kk* is **held**, a beat longer than a single *k*, and that length is doing real work: Tamil distinguishes words by it.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

வணக்கம் (*vaṇakkam*) comes from the verb வணங்கு (*vaṇanku*), “to bow, to pay homage.” Turned into a noun of the action, it means “a bowing, an act of reverence” — the idea of *namaste*, but from a **native Tamil** root, not a Sanskrit one. That is Tamil’s whole personality: an old language that keeps its home-grown words where

its neighbours borrowed.

Across the family — the same idea, five ways

Watch “hello” split the family — four borrowed Sanskrit, Tamil alone kept its own:

Language	“Hello”	Source
Tamil	வணக்கம் <i>vaṇakkam</i>	native Dravidian
Kannada	<i>namaskāra</i>	Sanskrit
Telugu	<i>namaskāram</i>	Sanskrit
Malayalam	<i>namaskāram</i>	Sanskrit
Hindi	<i>namaste</i>	Sanskrit
English	<i>hello</i>	Germanic

Why it’s said this way

Said with the palms pressed together and a small bow — the gesture *is* the word. It serves as both **hello and goodbye**, any time, to almost anyone, respectful without being stiff.

Let your finger meet one shape

Keep வணக்கம் visible. Find only its first shape, வ. Follow that printed shape once with your finger while you say the whole greeting. Do not write it yet, and do not try to remember or decode the whole word. This first pass only lets your eye, voice, and hand notice the same greeting together. Tracing a typeface here does not claim a handwriting stroke order.

1.2 வ — copy one visible shape with help

Point to வணக்கம் and say *vaṇakkam* once. Keep the model on the page, then copy வ **once** beside it. Look back as often as you need. Your copy can be large and slow; it does not need to look like a font.

This is shape familiarity, not a stroke-order test. Do not hide the model, copy the rest of வணக்கம், or add a second new shape today. Compare your one copy with வ; repair one curve if you want, then stop. Say *vaṇakkam* once more: one known greeting, one tiny hand movement.

1.3 நன்றி (*nanri*) — “thank you”

The letters in this word

Say it *nan-ri*. Tamil hears **three** different *n* sounds and this word uses two of them: a **dental** *n* (tongue on the teeth) to open, then an **alveolar** one (on the ridge just behind them). The *r* is its own sound again, not the English *r*. English ears flatten all of this to “nandri,” which is close enough to be understood.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

நன்றி (*nanri*) grows from the root நல் (*nal*), “good” — so it literally means “**goodness.**” To thank, in Tamil, is to name the good someone did you.

Grammar Lens

Tamil hears three of every *n*, *l*, and *r*. You have now met ந (dental *n*), ன (alveolar *n*), and ண (retroflex *n*) — three letters for three tongue positions (on the teeth / on the ridge / curled back). Tamil does the same for *l* (ல ள ழ) and *r* (ர ற ள). English fuses each set into one letter; Tamil keeps them apart, and the differences *change meaning*. Learn them word by word, not as a chart.

Across the family — the same idea, five ways

Language	“Thanks”	Note
Tamil	நன்றி <i>nanri</i>	native (<i>nal</i> , “good”)
Malayalam	<i>nandi</i>	the <i>same</i> Dravidian word
Kannada	<i>dhanyavāda</i>	Sanskrit
Telugu	<i>dhanyavādamulu</i>	Sanskrit
Hindi	<i>dhanyavād</i> / <i>shukriyā</i>	Sanskrit / Perso-Arabic

Malayalam, Tamil’s closest sister, kept the native word; Kannada and Telugu took the Sanskrit one — the family splits as it did over “hello.”

1.4 ஆம் (*ām*) — “yes”

The letters in this word

Say it *ām* — a **long** *a*, held about twice as long as the short one, closing on a plain *m*. Vowel length is meaningful in Tamil, so the length is not decoration.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ஆம் (*ām*) is the plain “yes.” Doubled for emphasis it becomes ஆமாம் (*āmām*), “yes, indeed.”

Grammar Lens

Tamil often says “yes” by **echoing the verb**: asked *vandāyā?* (“did you come?”), a natural yes is *vandēn* (“I came”). Bank *ām* as the simple word, but expect a “yes” to come back as a whole verb.

1.5 இல்லை (*illai*) — “no,” and how Tamil says a thing is *not*

The letters in this word

Say it *il-lai*, with the *l* **held** across the join — the same doubling you met in *vaṇak-kam*. The ending is the diphthong *ai*, as in English “eye,” not two separate vowels.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

இல்லை (*illai*) is built on இல் (*il*), “not-being, absence” — so it is not really the adjective “no” but the statement “[**it**] is not, [**there**] is not.” Its positive twin is உண்டு (*undu*), “there is.”

Grammar Lens

Tamil negates by *being*, not with a “not”-word. Where English inserts *not/no*, Tamil swaps in the negative verb of existence: *puttakam unḍu* (“there is a book”) → *puttakam illai* (“there is not a book”).

So *illai* is both the everyday “no” and the word that makes a whole sentence negative — a deeply Dravidian habit, unlike English or Hindi.

1.6 சரி (*sari*) — “okay,” the word that oils every conversation

The letters in this word

Say it *sari*, two light syllables, stress even. The opening sound sits between English *s* and *ch*, and Tamil treats that whole range as one sound chosen by **position** in the word rather than by a separate spelling — the same economy that lets one *k*-sound also be heard as *g* or a soft *h*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

சரி (*sari*) is native Tamil for “correct, even, level,” and so “okay, agreed.” It is the verbal nod of the language: propose a plan, hear a warm *sari*; doubled, *sari sari* = “alright, alright.”

Grammar Lens

One letter, several sounds. For its stop-consonants Tamil writes *one* letter per mouth-position and lets rules of position fill in the voicing (*k/g*, *s/ch*). The payoff is a strikingly *small* alphabet; the price is that the exact sound isn’t always predictable from the letter alone — you pick it up by ear, word by word.

1.7 Recap, and how Tamil says goodbye

		Meaning
வணக்கம்	<i>vaṇakkam</i>	hello / greetings
நன்றி	<i>nan̄ri</i>	thank you
ஆம்	<i>ām</i>	yes
இல்லை	<i>illai</i>	no / there isn’t
சரி	<i>sari</i>	okay / correct

Why it's said this way

Why Tamil won't just say "I'm leaving." The everyday goodbye is போய் வருகிறேன் (*pōy varugirēn*) — literally "I'll go and come [back]," and the reply is போய் வா (*pōy vā*), "go, and come back." A bare "I go" sounds like a final parting, so you always promise a return. A whole worldview folded into a farewell. (Or simply say *vaṇakkam* again — it parts as well as it meets.)

Next chapter: introducing yourself — *en peyar...* ("my name...") — and Tamil's *nī* / *nīṅgaḷ* (familiar / respectful "you").

Chapter 2

Introducing Yourself

Modes: ⇄ voice (8) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 8 lessons.

Now a first real exchange — giving your name, asking for someone else’s, and saying you’re glad to meet them:

என் பெயர் அருண். (*en peyar Arun* — “My name is Arun.”)
உங்கள் பெயர் என்ன? (*uṅgaḷ peyar enna* — “What is your name?”)

Built the same way as the greetings — each piece taken apart, its root traced, then assembled. Like Chapter 1 this is work you can do by ear; the letters behind these words are taught in the writing strand, not here. And here the roots run *native*: this is where Tamil is most itself.

2.1 பெயர் (*peyar*) — “name,” and where the family is *not* Indo-European

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

பெயர் (*peyar*, “name”) is **native Dravidian**, from Proto-Dravidian **peyar* / **pēr* — and it is *not* related to the Sanskrit *nāma* (Hindi *nām*, English *name*). Here the two great families part: where Indo-European shares one word for “name” from Ireland to North India, the Dravidian south kept its own. That is the whole reason to learn Tamil deeply — it preserves a word-stock older than the Sanskrit layer.

Across the family — the same idea, five ways

Language	“Name”	Source
Tamil	பெயர் <i>peyar</i>	native Dravidian (*peyar)
Malayalam	<i>pēr</i>	the <i>same</i> Dravidian root
Telugu	<i>pēru</i>	the <i>same</i> Dravidian root
Kannada	<i>hesaru</i>	Dravidian (*pesar, with p→h)
Hindi	<i>nām</i>	Sanskrit <i>nāman</i> (Indo-European)
English	<i>name</i>	Indo-European

Four Dravidian tongues share *peyar/pēru*; only the Indo-European languages have *name/nām*.

2.2 என் (*en*) — “my”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

என் (*en*, “my”) is the possessive of நான் (*nān*, “I”) — native Dravidian, from the pronoun stem *yān / *nān. It has *no* Indo-European cousin: the Tamil “I/my” is built on a different root from the English *I* / *my* (which go back to *eǵ and *me-). Two families, two entirely separate words for the self.

2.3 என் பெயர் ... (*en peyar ...*) — “my name is...,” with no “is”

என் (my) + பெயர் (name) + name = **en peyar ...** *En peyar Arun.* = “My name is Arun.”

Grammar Lens

Tamil has no word for “is” here. Notice what’s missing: there is *no* verb. Tamil simply places “my name” beside “Arun” — *en peyar Arun* — and the “is” is understood. This is the **zero copula**: for equational sentences (X is Y), Dravidian needs no “to be” at all, where English needs *is*, Hindi needs *hai*, and Arabic (you’ll see) also drops it. Tamil says only “my name Arun.”

2.4 நீ / நீங்கள் (*nī* / *nīṅgaḷ*) — “you,” familiar and respectful

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

நீ (*nī*, familiar “you”) ← Proto-Dravidian **nīn* — native, unrelated to the European “you” words (which come from **tū*). நீங்கள் (*nīṅgaḷ*) is *nī* + the plural ending *-kaḷ*.

Grammar Lens

Respect by the plural — again. Tamil grades “you” in two: *nī* (familiar — friends, children) and *nīṅgaḷ* (respectful — and literally the *plural*, “you-all”). This is the *same* politeness-by-plural you would find in French *vous* — address one respected person as “you all.” For a first meeting, always *nīṅgaḷ*.

2.5 என்ன (*enna*) — “what”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

என்ன (*enna*, “what”) is native Dravidian, on the interrogative stem **yā-* / **e-* that heads Tamil’s whole question family: *enna* (what), *yār* (who), *eppo* (when), *enge* (where), *ēn* (why). Like Hindi’s *k-* words and English’s *wh-* words — but from a *different* root, the Dravidian one.

2.6 உங்கள் பெயர் என்ன? (*uṅgaḷ peyar enna*) — “what’s your name?”

உங்கள் (*uṅgaḷ*, “your”) is the possessive of *nīṅgaḷ* (“you,” respectful). So உங்கள் பெயர் என்ன? is literally “**your name what?**” — and again *no “is”*: the zero copula holds for questions too. Just three words, no verb.

Grammar Lens

Answer with the sentence you built: *En peyar Arun*. The familiar version swaps *uṅgaḷ* for *un* (“your,” from *nī*): *un peyar enna?*

2.7 மகிழ்ச்சி (*magilcci*) — “joy,” and “pleased to meet you”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The warm close is உங்களை சந்தித்ததில் மகிழ்ச்சி (*uṅḡḷai sandittatil magilcci*) — “in having met you, joy.” The key word மகிழ்ச்சி (*magilcci*, “joy, gladness”) is native Dravidian, from *magil* (“to rejoice”). It carries the ழ (*ḷ*) — a sound almost unique to Tamil, a retroflex glide with no English equivalent. (In casual speech Tamils often just smile, or say the English “nice to meet you.”)

2.8 The whole exchange

Tamil		English
என் பெயர் மீரா.	<i>en peyar Mira</i>	My name is Mira.
உங்கள் பெயர் என்ன?	<i>uṅḡḷ peyar enna</i>	What’s your name?
என் பெயர் அருண்.	<i>en peyar Arun</i>	My name is Arun.
மகிழ்ச்சி.	<i>magilcci</i>	Pleased to meet you.

Every atom native and traced: *peyar* (Dravidian **peyar*, *not name*), *en* (from *nān*, “I”), *enna* (Dravidian question-stem). And the Tamil habit to keep: the **zero copula** — an equational sentence needs no “is” at all. Next chapter: *eppaḍi irukkīṅḡal?* (“how are you?”) and answering with *nallā* — the responding cycle.

Chapter 3

How Are You?

Modes: ⇐ voice (6) ⇐ Hands-free start: all 6 lessons.

After the name comes the exchange everyone actually has — and, for the first time, Tamil reaches for a verb “to be”:

நீங்கள் எப்படி இருக்கிறீர்கள்? (*nīṅgal eppaṭi irukkiṟīrgal* — “How are you?”)
நான் நலமாக இருக்கிறேன். (*nāṇ nalamāga irukkiṟēṇ* — “I’m well.”)

3.1 எப்படி (*eppaṭi*) — “how,” another of the e-questions

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

எப்படி (*eppaṭi*, “how”) is native Dravidian — the interrogative base எ (*e-*) + *paṭi* (“manner”), “in what manner.” Tamil’s questions nearly all begin with this *e-*: *eṇṇa* (what), *eppaṭi* (how), *eppōdu* (when), *eṇḡē* (where), *eṇ* (why). Where Hindi gathers questions under *k-* and English under *wh-*, Tamil gathers its own under *e-* — a separate, older family.

3.2 நீங்கள் எப்படி இருக்கிறீர்கள்? — “how are you?”

The new word is இருக்கிறீர்கள் (*irukkiṟīrgal*): the verb stem இரு (*iru*, “to be, exist, stay”) + present + ீர்கள் (*-īrgal*, “you,” respectful). The

verb comes last, as always.

Grammar Lens

Now the copula returns. Chapter 2 showed Tamil drops “is” for *equations* (*eṇ peyar Arun*, “my name Arun”). But “how are you?” is about a *state* — how you *exist* — and for that Tamil does use a verb, இரு (*iru*). So: no verb for “my name is Arun,” a real verb for “how are you.” The ending *-irgaḷ* already means “you (respectful),” so *n̄ngaḷ* can be dropped.

3.3 நான் (*nāṇ*) — “I,” the Dravidian first person

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

நான் (*nāṇ*, “I”) ← Proto-Dravidian *yāṇ / *nāṇ — native, and (unlike Hindi’s *main*, cousin of English *me*) **not** related to the European “I/me” family. Its possessive is the என் (*eṇ*, “my”) you already met: *nāṇ* “I,” *eṇ* “my.” Tamil’s “I” is a clear marker that Dravidian grew up apart from the Indo-European world around it.

3.4 நலம் (*nalam*) — “well,” and how to answer

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

நலம் (*nalam*, “wellness, welfare”) is native Dravidian, from நல் (*nal*-, “good”) — the root behind நல்ல (*nalla*, “good”) and நன்றி (*nanṇṛi*, “thanks,” literally “goodness,” from Chapter 1). So “thank you” and “I’m well” share a root: both are *nal*-, “good.”

Assemble: நான் நலமாக இருக்கிறேன் (*nāṇ nalamāga irukkīrēṇ*) — “I am well” (*nalam* + *-āga* “in a ... way” + *iru* + “I”). Casually: *nallā irukkēṇ*.

3.5 பரவாயில்லை (*paravāyillai*) — “no problem”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

பரவாயில்லை literally “**there is no harm**” — *paravāy* (“harm”) + இல்லை (*illai*, “is-not”). It serves as “it’s okay / no worries / you’re welcome.” The atom இல்லை (*illai*), from Chapter 1, is the Tamil “is-not,” the mirror of *iru* (“is”). It is shared, almost unchanged, across Tamil, Kannada, and Malayalam (*illa*) — a deep Dravidian bond; only Telugu breaks away to *lēdu*.

Grammar Lens

Illai negates existence and equations alike: *nāṇ illai* (“it’s not me”), *paṇam illai* (“there’s no money”), and, alone, plain “no.” Hold *iru* / *illai* together — “is” and “is-not.”

3.6 The whole exchange

Tamil	English
நீங்கள் எப்படி இருக்கிறீர்கள்?	How are you?
நான் நலமாக இருக்கிறேன், நன்றி.	I’m well, thank you.
பரவாயில்லை.	No problem / you’re welcome.

Every atom traced: *eppaṭi* (the native *e*- questions), *nāṇ* (Proto-Dravidian, unrelated to *me*), *nalām* (*nal*- “good,” the root of *naṇṇi*), and the *iru* / *illai* pair — “is” and “is-not.” Next chapter: the farewells — and Tamil never says a plain “goodbye.”

Chapter 4

Farewells

Modes: ⇄ voice (5) ✍ pen (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: first 4 of 6 lessons.

Tamil does not say a plain “goodbye.” It says something warmer, and stranger to English ears — “I’ll go and *come back*”:

போய் வருகிறேன். (*pōy varugirēṇ* — “I’ll go and come back.”)

4.1 போ (*pō*) — “go,” and வா (*vā*) (come)

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

போ (*pō*, “go”) and வா (*vā*, “come”) are native Dravidian verbs of the deepest layer — single syllables, whole words on their own: *pō!* (“go!”), *vā!* (“come!”). You need both, because Tamil’s goodbye is “I go, and I *come back*.”

4.2 போய் வருகிறேன் (*pōy varugirēṇ*) — “I’ll go and come back”

போய் (*pōy*, “having gone”) + வருகிறேன் (*varugirēṇ*, “I come”) — literally “**having gone, I come**,” i.e. “I’ll go and come back.” A Tamil speaker never signs off with a bare “I’m leaving” — it sounds final, ill-omened. The reply is warm: போய் வா (*pōy vā*, “go and come [back]”).

Across the family — the same idea, five ways

Language	“go and come back” (goodbye)
Tamil	<i>pōy varugiṛēṇ</i>
Kannada	<i>hōgi baruttēne</i>
Telugu	<i>velli vastānu</i>
Malayalam	<i>pōyi varāṇ</i>
Bengali (Indo-Aryan)	<i>āshi</i> (“I come”)
Hindi (Indo-Aryan)	<i>phir milenge</i> (“we’ll meet again”)

The whole subcontinent, Dravidian and Indo-Aryan alike, prefers a promise of return to a blunt farewell.

Grammar Lens

The “having ...d” participle. *Pōy* chains actions: “having gone, (then) I come.” Tamil strings verbs like beads — all but the last in a participle form, the last fully conjugated.

4.3 நாளை பார்க்கலாம் (*nālai pārkkalām*) — “see you tomorrow”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

நாளை (*nālai*, “tomorrow”) is native, from நாள் (*nāl*, “day”). பார் (*pār*, “to see”); so the phrase is “tomorrow, let’s see [each other].” Note the retroflex ள் (*l*), tongue-tip curled up and back — a sound English lacks.

4.4 மீண்டும் சந்திப்போம் (*mīṇṭum sandippōm*) — “we’ll meet again”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

மீண்டும் சந்திப்போம் = மீண்டும் (*mīṇṭum*, “again”) + சந்திப்போம் (*sandippōm*, “we will meet”). Two vocabularies in two words: *mīṇṭum* is **native Dravidian** (from *mīl*, “to return”); சந்தி (*sandi*, “to meet”) is a **Sanskrit** loan — from *sandhi* (“a joining”), the very term Sanskrit grammar uses for how sounds join at a boundary. A Dravidian core beside a Sanskrit borrowing — the recurring thread of this track.

4.5 Tamil’s curves — the writing surface leaves a trace

The first lesson of the writing strand teaches no letter at all. Before the first shape, look at a line of Tamil and notice what is *not* there:

வணக்கம்

Nothing joins the letters together, and there are far fewer corners than in Devanagari — no hanging head-line, and a great deal of curve. (Straight strokes do exist: most of these letters have a flat bar across the top.)

Tamil was written for centuries on **palm leaves**, scratched with a metal stylus and rubbed with soot to make the scratches show. A palm leaf has a **grain**, like wood: draw a long straight line along it and the stylus can **split the leaf**. The usual account is that scribes bent their strokes in response — a curve crosses the fibres at an angle instead of running with them.

Treat that as **the standard explanation rather than a settled fact**. The earliest Tamil writing — Tamil-Brahmi, cut into stone and pottery — is noticeably *angular*; the rounding came later, through the Vaṭṭeluttu (“round script”) stage. And Devanagari was written on the same leaves without going round. So the leaf is one pressure among several, not a complete answer.

It is still worth carrying, because it makes the right general point: **the tool leaves fingerprints on the letters**. Latin’s straight strokes suit a wax tablet and a chisel; Tamil’s curves suit a stylus and a leaf.

4.6 The farewells

Tamil	English
போய் வருகிறேன்.	I'll go and come back. (goodbye)
போய் வா.	Go and come back. (the reply)
நாளை பார்க்கலாம்.	See you tomorrow.
மீண்டும் சந்திப்போம்.	We'll meet again.

Roots banked: *pō/vā* (the oldest verbs), *nāl* (“day” inside “tomorrow”), and *mīṇṭum* (native) beside *sandi* (Sanskrit). Next chapter: the first real verbs — *nāṇ tamīl pēsugirēṇ* — and Tamil’s sentences begin to move.

Chapter 5

The First Verbs

Modes: ⇄ voice (5) ✍ pen (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: first 2 of 6 lessons.

Until now, “to be” and “to be-not.” Now verbs that *act* — and Tamil’s sentences begin to move:

நான் தமிழ் பேசுகிறேன். (*nāṇ tamīḻ pēsugirēṇ* — “I speak Tamil.”)

5.1 பேசு (*pēsu*) — “to speak,” your first full verb

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

பேசு (*pēsu*, “to speak”) is native Dravidian; the bare stem is also the command “speak!” To say “I speak,” Tamil stacks two endings on the stem — **tense** then **person**:

pēsu- (speak) + *-gir*- (present) + *-ēṇ* (“I”) → பேசுகிறேன்
(*pēsugirēṇ*), “I speak.”

The *-ēṇ* ending is “I,” so the word *nāṇ* is rarely needed. Change the ending, change the person: *pēsugirāṇ* (he), *pēsugirāl* (she), *pēsugirārgal* (they / you-respectful).

Grammar Lens

Stem + tense + person. Every Tamil verb is built this way — a stem, a tense-marker, a person-ending, glued in that order. Learn the pattern once and every verb follows it.

5.2 நான் தமிழ் பேசுகிறேன் — “I speak Tamil”

நான் (I) + தமிழ் (*tamiḷ*, “Tamil,” the object) + பேசுகிறேன் (speak) — “I Tamil speak,” verb last. The name தமிழ் (*tamiḷ*) ends in the famous ழ (*ḷ*), a curled retroflex between “r,” “l,” and “zh” found in almost no other language — Tamil is sometimes called “the *ḷ* language.” It names one of the oldest living literary tongues on earth, its poetry two thousand years old and still read.

Grammar Lens

No gender on “I speak.” *Pēsugirēṇ* is the same whether a man or a woman says it — Tamil marks **no gender in the first or second person** (only the third: *-āṇ* he / *-āl* she). This is unlike Hindi, where even “I speak” changes for the speaker’s gender (*boltā/boltī*). Tamil saves gender for “he/she/it.”

5.3 வ and க — the vowel inside each consonant

Script you’ll notice: the vowel you get for free

Tamil is an **abugida**, like Devanagari: a consonant already contains a vowel. **க is not “k.” க is “ka.”** Every consonant carries a built-in *a* until a later mark removes or replaces it.

Script you’ll notice: வ and க

வ — *va*. Its parts, in the conventional order: 1. **a near-closed loop on the left** 2. **a full-height arm across the top, ending in a descender on the right**.

க — *ka*. 1. **a straight horizontal top bar** 2. **a bowl hanging from its left end** 3. **a short right stroke that hooks left below**.

Grammar Lens

One letter, three sounds — now on the page. Chapter 1 said Tamil picks this sound by position rather than by spelling; here is the letter that does it. Devanagari spells *ka*, *kha*, *ga* and *gha* with four separate letters. Tamil writes **க** for all of them: *k* at the start of a word and when doubled (**க்க**), *g* after a nasal (**ங்க**), and a softer *h*-like sound between vowels. That is why Tamil needs only 18

consonant letters where Devanagari needs 33 — its native words do not depend on those written distinctions.

5.4 வாழ் (*vāl*) — “to live, to flourish”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

வாழ் (*vāl*, “to live, flourish, thrive”) is native, warmer than a plain “reside.” From it: வாழ்க்கை (*vāḷkkai*, “life”) and the blessing வாழ்க (*vāḷga*, “may you live / long live”), as in *vāḷga tamīl*. “I live” = நான் வாழ்கிறேன் (*nāṇ vāḷgīrēṇ*) — the same stem + present + “I” as *pēsugīrēṇ*.

5.5 வேலை செய் (*vēlai sey*) — “to work”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

செய் (*sey*, “to do, make”) is a core native verb, and Tamil — like Hindi with *karnā* — builds compounds by putting a noun in front of it: வேலை செய் (*vēlai sey*, “work-do” = “to work”), *samaiyal sey* (“to cook”), *udavi sey* (“to help”). So “I work” is நான் வேலை செய்கிறேன் (*nāṇ vēlai seyigīrēṇ*).

Grammar Lens

Noun + செய் = a new verb — the exact twin of Hindi’s “noun + *karnā*” (*kām karnā*). Two unrelated families, Dravidian and Indo-Aryan, hit on the same trick: an all-purpose “do” verb with nouns bolted on. Millennia side by side, Tamil and Hindi quietly traded habits like this.

5.6 Sentences about yourself

Tamil	English
நான் தமிழ் பேசுகிறேன்.	I speak Tamil.
நான் சென்னையில் வாழ்கிறேன்.	I live in Chennai.
நான் வேலை செய்கிறேன்.	I work.

Three verbs, one engine: a stem, a tense-marker, a person-ending, the verb always last — and no gender in the first person. Roots banked: *pēsu* (speak), *vāl* (live → *vālkkai* “life,” *vālga* “long live”), *sey* (do → *vēlai sey* “to work,” the twin of Hindi’s *karnā*), and *tamiḷ* itself, with its signature retroflex *ḷ*. From here, Tamil’s sentences only grow.

Chapter 6

Dative Case and Dative Subjects

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) ✍️ pen (5) 🗣️ Hands-free start: first 1 of 9 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can attach -உக்கு to a noun in either of its surface forms and say why “I know Tamil” puts the experiencer in the dative instead of giving the sentence a subject.

Line up எனக்கு, நாகு, நன்கு and എനിക്ക്, point to the experiencer in each, and paraphrase எனக்குத் தமிழ் தெரியும் as “the language is known to me.”

6.1 -உக்கு (-ukku) — “to, for”

Your first **case ending**. English says “to me” with a separate word in front. Tamil says it with a piece **stuck on the back** — and that small difference is the biggest structural fact about the language.

Grammar Lens: Adding it on

Take a noun you know and add -உக்கு:

word	+ the dative	meaning
பெயர் <i>peyar</i> — name	பெயருக்கு <i>peyarukku</i>	to/for the name
வேலை <i>vēlai</i> — work	வேலைக்கு <i>vēlaiukku</i>	for work

The suffix has two shapes — -உக்கு *-ukku* and -க்கு *-kku* — chosen by the sound the noun ends in. One case, two forms; the seam still shows.

And with “I” — this one is irregular and worth memorising, because you’ll use it constantly:

நான் *nāṇ* (“I”) → எனக்கு *enakku* (“to me”)

The pronoun changes its body (*nāṇ* → *en-*) before the suffix lands. Nouns don’t — they just take the ending.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*peyar ... peyarukku*”
- “*nāṇ ... enakku*” — “I” ... “to me”
- “*vēlaikku*” — “for work,” from Ch. 5’s வேலை

Before you move on

What does -உக்கு mean? (“To” or “for.”) Where does it go? (**On the end** of the noun — Tamil adds, it doesn’t put a word in front.) What is “to me”? (எனக்கு *enakku* — the pronoun’s body changes to *en-* first.) Why does the suffix show up as *-ukku* and *-kku*? (**One case, two shapes**, chosen by the noun’s ending.) Next: two more letters — ட and retroflex ண.

6.2 வ — one spiral, one motion

One letter this time. Just one.

It is the first letter of the first word you learned, and it is the easiest one in this book to write: the pen never leaves the paper.

Script you’ll notice: வ

வ — *va*.

What it is made of:

- a spiral loop on the left
- a bottom bar

- a tall right upright

வணக்கம் starts with it, and so does வாழ் — *to live*.

Writing: வ

- 1. start at the inner curl and spiral outward, climbing the left side
- 2. without lifting, arch over the top and descend on the right
- 3. without lifting, turn down to the baseline
- 4. without lifting, carry the bottom bar to the right
- 5. without lifting, rise up the right upright — and only now lift

Pen lifts: 0. The pen never leaves the paper.

Stroke order is one attested teaching order, not a national standard — Tamil handwriting is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: Sankaran Radhakrishnan, Tamil Script Learners Manual, Appendix I: Hand-movements, Frame 9, வ (Univ. of Texas at Austin), p. 194.

Your turn

- *Trace it:* வ once, slowly, following the steps above
- *Say it:* “va” as you finish it
- *Trace it:* it twice more, without looking back at the steps

Before you move on

How many times does the pen lift while writing வ? (**None** — one unbroken motion.) What sound does it carry on its own? (**va**.)

6.3 ட and ண — a loop, and a curled tongue

Two more letters, and with them you’ll have every letter of this book’s first word. One is easy. The other is a sound you may not be able to hear yet.

Script you'll notice: ழ

1. a straight vertical stroke on the LEFT 2. a horizontal along the bottom 3. a rounded arch closing it on the RIGHT

Get the sides the right way round. The **upright is on the left** and the **curve on the right** — which is the reverse of what most people guess, and the reverse of the Devanagari habit of hanging a shape off a right-hand spine.

Script you'll notice: ழ

1. a straight top bar 2. a loop on the left 3. two arches 4. a straight vertical on the right, down to the baseline

The dot under the romanization — **ṇ**, not plain *n* — is doing real work.

The letters in this word

Say English **n**. Your tongue touches just behind your teeth. Now curl the tip of your tongue **up and back** toward the roof of your mouth, and say it again. That is **ṇ**, and it is a different letter in Tamil. English has no such sound and no way to write one, which is why an English speaker typically **cannot hear the difference at first**. That is expected. The ear learns it after the hand does, which is one good argument for writing the letters rather than only reading them. Retroflex sounds are a signature of the languages of India — they show up across Tamil, Telugu, Kannada, Malayalam, Hindi and Sanskrit alike, in families that are otherwise unrelated to each other. It's one of the features that makes South Asia a *linguistic area*: neighbouring languages that borrowed a sound from each other rather than inheriting it.

Your turn

- *Write it:* ழ — “left upright, bottom, **right** arch”
- *Write it:* ழ — “top bar, left loop, **two** arches, straight vertical”
- *Say it:* plain *n*, then curl the tongue back — **ṇ**

Before you move on

Draw ட — which side is the upright on? (**The left**; the arch closes it on the right.) Draw ண — what makes it *not* ன? (**One extra arch**: ண has **two** arches where ன has one. Both end in the same straight vertical.) What does the dot in ன mean? (**Retroflex** — the tongue curls **back** to the roof of the mouth.) Why can't you hear it yet? (**English has no such sound**; the ear learns it after the hand.) Next: stacking that dative suffix where Latin would fuse several meanings.

6.4 -உக்கு — one carriage in a suffix train

You can point to *peyar* and *-ukku* separately. That visible seam is the structural lesson.

Grammar Lens: Stacking versus fusion

	Tamil -ukku	Latin -īs
fixes the case?	dative , always	dative or ablative
carries number?	no; another suffix can	plural is baked in
carries declension?	no	first/second class is baked in
visible seam?	peyar + ukku	one fused ending
Tamil stacks . Each suffix contributes one meaning in a fixed order, like a train carriage. Latin fuses case, number, and class into an indivisible ending, and <i>-īs</i> does not even identify one case by itself. This is agglutinative structure: long words remain buildable because their pieces stay legible. The comparison is not about simplicity; it is about where the grammatical information lives.		

Your turn

- *Break apart*: *peyar + ukku*
- *Say it*: “one suffix, one meaning, visible seam”
- *Contrast*: Tamil stacks · Latin fuses

Before you move on

What does *-ukku* contribute? (**Dative to/for**, one meaning.) What does Latin *-is* fuse? (**Case, plural number, and declension class.**) Which system leaves the seam visible? (**Tamil's agglutinative stack.**)

6.5 எனக்குத் தமிழ் தெரியும் — “I know Tamil”

In Chapter 5 you said நான் தமிழ் பேசுகிறேன் — “I speak Tamil,” with *nān* as the subject. Now say “I **know** Tamil.” Tamil will not let you use *nān*.

You’ll want to know: The sentence

எனக்குத் தமிழ் தெரியும். *enakku tamil teriyum*. literally: “**to-me** Tamil is-known.”

Word by word:

piece

எனக்குத் (த்) *enakku(t)*

“to me” — the dative from the last lesson

தமிழ் *tamil*

Tamil (Ch. 5)

தெரியும் *teriyum*

“is known / is apparent”

That extra த் on *enakku* is **sandhi** — a joining consonant Tamil inserts between certain words to smooth the seam. It belongs to neither word on its own; it exists only because they are next to each other. Nothing to learn yet, but worth noticing, because you will see it constantly.

You are not the subject. *Nān* is gone — the person has been moved into the dative. What’s left in the plain, unmarked form is *tamil*: the sentence is now about **the language**, and you are merely the one it is known **to**.

(Grammarians call *enakku* the **dative subject**, because it behaves like the subject even though it isn’t in the subject case. The odd feeling of the sentence is exactly that split.)

Grammar Lens: Why: things that happen *to* you

Tamil sorts verbs by whether you **do** something or something **happens to** you. Speaking is something you do — so Ch. 5 used *nāṇ*. But knowing, liking, wanting, being hungry, being cold: these arrive at you. Tamil marks that by putting the person in the **dative**.

English frames it as

I **know** Tamil
I **like** it
I **am** cold

Tamil frames it as

Tamil is known **to me**
it is pleasing **to me**
cold is **to me**

English does this occasionally and archaically — “**methinks**” is exactly it (*me* is dative: “it seems **to me**”). Tamil made it a rule.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*enakku tamil teriyum*”
- the contrast — “*nāṇ tamil pēsugirēn*” (I speak) ... “*enakku tamil teriyum*” (known to me)
- the literal — “to-me Tamil is-known”

Before you move on

What does எனக்குத் தமிழ் தெரியும் literally say? (“**To-me** Tamil **is-known**.”) Which word has English got that Tamil hasn’t? (A nominative “**I**” — *nāṇ* is replaced by the dative *enakku*.) Why does Tamil use the dative here? (Because knowing **happens to** you; you don’t **do** it.) Which English word preserves the same idea? (**Methinks** — “it seems **to me**.”) Next: watch all four Dravidian sisters use the same experiencer shape.

6.6 -ukku, -ku, -ge, -ikku — the family shows its bones

Tamil says knowing happens **to** you. Its three closest sisters make the same grammatical choice.

Grammar Lens: Four sentences, one construction

language	“I know [the language]”	dative
Tamil	<i>enakku tamil teriyum</i>	-ukku
Telugu	<i>nāku telugu vaccu</i>	-ku
Kannada	<i>nanage kannada gottu</i>	-ge
Malayalam	<i>enikku malayālam ariyām</i>	-ikku

The verbs differ, but the experiencer sits in a dative whose forms visibly belong together: *-ukku* / *-ku* / *-ge* / *-ikku*. This is family evidence, just as *blanc/bianco/branco* exposes Romance kinship. The comparison also makes cross-language practice useful: once you recognize “to me,” you can search for the known or apparent thing rather than forcing an English subject onto the sentence.

Your turn

- *Say it*: “-ukku · -ku · -ge · -ikku”
- *Point to*: the experiencer in each sentence
- *Put it another way*: “the language is known to me”

Before you move on

Do the four sisters agree on dative experiencers? (**Yes.**) Which four suffix shapes reveal the relationship? (**-ukku, -ku, -ge, -ikku.**) What stays plain in the sentence? (The thing **known or experienced.**)

6.7 ன் — the first of three n’s

Before the new one: say the sound of ன்.

One letter this time. Just one.

Tamil has three different letters for sounds English hears as one *n*. This is the first, and the dot under its romanization — **ṇ**, not plain *n* — is doing real work: the tongue curls back to the roof of the mouth. Words genuinely differ by it.

Script you'll notice: ண

ண — *ṇa*.

What it is made of:

- a spiral loop on the left
- TWO rounded inner arches
- a straight top bar
- a separate straight vertical on the right, down to the baseline

It is the second letter of வணக்கம்.

Writing: ண

1. start in the lower-left curl and spiral outward, climbing the outer left side
2. without lifting, arch over the top of the left loop to the first junction
3. without lifting, descend around the outside of the first inner arch
4. without lifting, turn through its bottom and climb the inside back to the first junction
5. without lifting, sweep through the extra inner arch — over its top, around its outside and bottom, then up its inside to the right junction
6. without lifting, carry the top bar to the right edge — then lift once
7. set the pen at the top of the separate right upright and draw straight down — and only now lift

Pen lifts: 1. The pen comes up 1 time and no more.

Stroke order is one attested teaching order, not a national standard — Tamil handwriting is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: Sankaran Radhakrishnan, Tamil Script Learners Manual, Appendix I: Hand-movements, Frame 13, ண (Univ. of Texas at Austin), p. 195.

Your turn

- *Trace it:* ன் once, slowly, following the steps above
- *Say it:* “na” as you finish it
- *Trace it:* it twice more, without looking back at the steps

Before you move on

Where does the tongue go for ன்? (**Curled back**, to the roof of the mouth.) How many pen lifts? (**One** — the body, then the upright.)

6.8 ட, ன, ன் — three stops on one tongue-map

English writes one *n*. Tamil keeps three tongue positions apart.

Script you’ll notice: The backward walk

letter	sound	tongue
ட	<i>na</i>	against the teeth (dental)
ந	<i><u>na</u></i>	on the ridge behind the teeth (alveolar)
ன	<i><u>na</u></i>	curled back to the roof (retroflex)

Move backward: teeth → ridge → curled roof. English spells all three with one letter and initially hears them as the same sound; Tamil uses separate letters because its words depend on the contrast.

You will draw ட and ந when *nandri* needs them. For now compare the last pair: ன is ந with one extra arch. Both open with a top bar and loop and finish with the same vertical. ந has one middle arch; ன has two.

Retroflex sounds occur across unrelated South Asian language families. That shared geography makes the region a **linguistic area**: neighbors can borrow a sound pattern without inheriting it from one ancestor.

Your turn

- *Say it:* dental ட at the teeth
- *Say it:* alveolar ண at the ridge
- *Say it:* retroflex ண at the tongue curled back
- *Trace it:* one arch in ண · two arches in ண

Before you move on

How many n-letters does Tamil have? (**Three.**) What separates them? (Tongue position: **dental, alveolar, retroflex.**) Which two differ by one arch? (ண has one; ண has two.) Next: the numbers one to five.

6.9 ட — one character, met inside words you already say

Curvy and loopy with flat top-bars on many letters, repeated arches, and no continuous head-line.

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: ட

ட — *pa*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *p*, it is **pa**.

You already say these, and every one of them has ட somewhere inside it:

- பெயர் *peyar* — name
- என் பெயர் ... *en peyar* ... — my name is... (with no “is”)
- எப்படி *eppadi* — how
- பரவாயில்லை *paravāyillai* — it's okay / no problem / you're welcome

Writing: ࣳ — copy what you see

Put your pen on ࣳ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ࣳ in the ones that have it

பெயர் · வணக்கம்

- *Trace it:* ࣳ three times, saying *pa* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ࣳ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ࣳ? What sound does it carry? (*pa*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 7

Numbers One to Ten

Modes:  voice (3)  eyes (1)  pen (16)  **Hands-free start:** first 1 of 20 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can hear, say, read, and write representative numbers from one to ten in Tamil and recognize their Dravidian family history.

Count onru to pattu, read the ten Tamil numeral shapes out of order, write eezhu with its numeral from sound alone, and recall the pattu/hattu relationship.

7.1 One to five — voice first

Keep your pencil down. Hear five Tamil number words, attach each to a quantity, and say them before your eyes meet Tamil writing.

The letters in this word	
quantity	said
1	<i>onru</i>
2	<i>irantu</i>
3	<i>muunru</i>
4	<i>naanku</i>
5	<i>aintu</i>
Raise one more finger for each word: <i>onru, irantu, muunru, naanku, aintu</i> . Twice through:	

These are inherited Dravidian words, not borrowed Sanskrit number names. The family history can wait until the sounds and quantities feel secure.

Your turn

- *Hear: muunru*; YOU SHOW: 3
- *Hear: aintu*; YOU SHOW: 5
- *Say it: onru* through *aintu* while raising one more finger

Before you move on

Count from one to five without looking. Which word means two? (***Irantu.***) Are these forms borrowed from Sanskrit? (**No.**) Next, only three numeral shapes arrive.

7.2 ॑ · ॒ · ॒ — three numeral shapes

Say *onru*, *irantu*, *muunru*. The meanings and sounds are familiar; this lesson adds only their three numeral shapes.

Script

- ॑ means 1: *onru*.
- ॒ means 2: *irantu*.
- ॒ means 3: *muunru*.

Point in order, then out of order: ॒ ॑ ॒.

Writing — observe and trace

Keep the models visible. Finger-trace ॑, ॒, and ॒ once each. Say the number word only after your finger stops. Do not copy from memory yet.

Before you move on

Point to ॒ and say it. (***Irantu.***) Which shape means three? (॒.) How many new shapes arrived? (**Three.**)

7.3 ூ · ௫ — finish the first five numerals

Read க உ ங. Two shapes remain in the first group.

Script

- ூ means 4: *naanku*.
- ௫ means 5: *aintu*.

Point through க உ ங ூ ௫ once.

Writing — observe and trace

Keep both models visible. Trace ூ once and ௫ once. Then circle the one you hear: [YOU HEAR: *aintu*]. (௫.)

Before you move on

Which shape means four? (ூ.) Read ௫. (*Aintu.*) This lesson added two shapes, not five.

7.4 Five familiar words — now in Tamil script

Say one to five, then read க உ ங ூ ௫. No new numeral shape appears below.

Script

numeral	word	said
க	ஒன்று	<i>onru</i>
உ	இரண்டு	<i>irantu</i>
ங	மூன்று	<i>muunru</i>
ூ	நான்கு	<i>naanku</i>
௫	ஐந்து	<i>aintu</i>

Follow each word with your finger while saying it. The letters have appeared earlier; this step only joins familiar pieces.

Writing — observe and trace

Trace ஒன்று — க once with the model visible. Read the other four rows; do not copy the whole table yet.

Before you move on

Read ந — மூன்று. (*Muunru, three.*) Which word belongs to ஐ? (ஐந்து, *aintu.*) No new shape was added.

7.5 க உ ந ச ஐ — one visible copy

Point through க உ ந ச ஐ and say the five words. Keep the row visible.

Writing — guided copy

Copy the row once beneath its model. Look back after every shape if needed. Say *onru* through *aintu* as you check. Repair only one shape.

Before you move on

Read ச. (*Naanku.*) No new shape was added here.

7.6 Five numerals — hide, then write

Study க உ ந ச ஐ for five seconds. Say each number, then cover the row.

Writing — delayed copy

Write the five numerals in order while the model is hidden. Peek once if one will not come, cover it again, and continue. Uncover and repair one place.

Before you move on

What changed from the previous lesson? (**The model was hidden before writing.**)

7.7 Three heard numbers — write their numerals

Cover the answer line. You will hear familiar words, never an untaught form.

Writing — dictation

[YOU HEAR: *irantu* — *aintu* — *muunru*]

Write the three numeral shapes from sound alone. Then uncover: ௨ ௫ ௭. Repair one shape if needed; do not rewrite the line.

Before you move on

Write the numeral for *naanku* from sound alone. (௭.) Now the Dravidian family lesson can deepen forms you can already hear and read.

7.8 Two to five — one family in four regional coats

Hindi's number forms are Sanskrit worn smooth. Tamil's are native Dravidian, so their sister-language shapes reveal the family directly.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

	Tamil	Kannada	Telugu	Malayalam
2	<i>iraṇṭu</i>	<i>eraḍu</i>	<i>reṇḍu</i>	<i>raṇṭu</i>
3	<i>mūṇru</i>	<i>mūru</i>	<i>mūḍu</i>	<i>mūnnu</i>
4	<i>nāṇku</i>	<i>nālku</i>	<i>nālugu</i>	<i>nālu</i>
5	<i>aintu</i>	<i>aidu</i>	<i>aidu</i>	<i>añcu</i>

Each row is one word in four regional coats. That shared skeleton is why one Dravidian language gives you a running start on another.

One is less tidy: Tamil *onru*, Kannada *ondu*, and Malayalam *onnu* share old *on-*, while Telugu uses the separate formation *okaṭi*. The family agrees more neatly on 2–5 than on 1.

The letters in this word

In *onru* and *mūnru*, ణ is alveolar *n* running into hard *r*, almost one knock: *on-ru*, *muun-ru*. Pulli on ణ removes its vowel before the cluster.

Your turn

- Say it: “iraṇṭu · eraḍu · reṇḍu · raṇṭu”
- Say it: *onru* and *mūnru*, holding ణ together
- Identify: Telugu *okaṭi* as the different “one”

Before you move on

Are these forms borrowed? (**No**, native Dravidian.) Which numbers stay tidiest across the family? (**Two through five**.) Which language forms “one” differently? (**Telugu**, *okaṭi*.)

7.9 Six to ten — voice first

Count *onru* through *aintu*. Keep your pencil down: five new meanings and sounds come before their shapes.

The letters in this word

quantity	said
6	<i>aaru</i>
7	<i>eezhu</i>
8	<i>ettu</i>
9	<i>onpatu</i>
10	<i>pattu</i>

Say the row once slowly, then once at counting speed. [REPEAT x2]

Why it’s said this way

The middle of *eezhu*, seven, has Tamil’s characteristic curled *zh*. Practise the sound now; its letter waits.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Nine, *onpatu*, grew from one plus ten: one short of *pattu*. Say *on-patu*, then *onpatu*.

Your turn

- Say it: *aaru*, *eezhu*, *ettu*, *onpatu*, *pattu*
- Hear: *eezhu*; YOU SHOW: 7
- Hear: *onpatu*; YOU SHOW: 9

Before you move on

Count six to ten. Which word keeps the curled *zh*? (***Eezhu***.) Which word leans on ten? (***Onpatu***, *nine*.) Next, three numeral shapes.

7.10 ્ଁଁଁ · ્ଁଁ · ્ଁଁ — three more numeral shapes

Say *aaru*, *eezhu*, *ettu*. Only their shapes are new.

Script

- ્ଁଁଁ means 6: *aaru*.
- ્ଁଁଁ means 7: *eezhu*.
- ્ଁଁଁ means 8: *ettu*.

Point out of order: ્ଁଁଁ ્ଁଁ ્ଁଁ.

Writing — observe and trace

Trace ્ଁଁଁ, ્ଁଁଁ, and ્ଁଁଁ once each with the models visible. Say the word after each trace. Memory writing waits.

Before you move on

Which shape means seven? (ଁଁଁଁ.) Read ્ଁଁଁ. (***Ettu***.) Three new shapes arrived.

7.11 கூ · டி — nine and ten

Read கூ எ அ. Two shapes finish the row.

Script

- கூ means 9: *onpatu*.
- டி means 10: *pattu*.

Point through கூ எ அ கூ டி once.

Writing — observe and trace

Trace கூ once and டி once with their models visible. Circle the one you hear: [YOU HEAR: *onpatu*]. (கூ.)

Before you move on

Which shape means ten? (டி.) Read கூ. (*Onpatu*.) Two new shapes arrived.

7.12 Six to ten — now in Tamil script

Say six to ten, then read கூ எ அ கூ டி. No new numeral shape appears below.

Script

numeral	word	said
கூ	ஆறு	<i>aaRu</i>
எ	ஏழு	<i>eezhu</i>
அ	எட்டு	<i>ettu</i>
கூ	ஒன்பது	<i>onpatu</i>
டி	பத்து	<i>pattu</i>

The curled sound you heard in *eezhu* is ழ. Follow ஏழு with your finger while saying it; every shape has had earlier support.

Writing — observe and trace

Trace ஏழு — எ once with the model visible. Read the remaining rows without copying the whole table.

Before you move on

Which letter carries the curled sound? (ழு.) Read எ — ஏழு.
(*Eezhu*, *seven*.) No new shape was added.

7.13 கா எ அ கூ டி — one supported copy

Read கா எ அ கூ டி. Keep both models below visible.

Writing — guided copy

Copy கா எ அ கூ டி once. Then copy ஏழு — எ once. Look back whenever you need. Check only one place, then stop.

Before you move on

Read your copied word. (*Eezhu*, *seven*.) Which numeral belongs beside it? (எ.)

7.14 ண — the second n, and how to tell it from ண்

Before the new one: say the sound of ண்.

One letter this time. Just one.

Look at ண் and ண side by side. Same spiral loop, same top bar, same upright on the right. The whole difference is **how many arches sit inside**: ண் has two, ண has one. That is the entire distinction, and it is why these two are learned together rather than a chapter apart.

Script you'll notice: ண

ண — *na*.

What it is made of:

- a spiral loop on the left
- ONE rounded inner arch
- a straight top bar
- a separate straight vertical on the right, down to the baseline

It ends நான் — *I* — and நன்றி's second syllable.

Writing: னா

- **1.** start in the lower-left curl and spiral outward, climbing the outer left side
- **2.** without lifting, arch over the top of the left loop to the middle junction
- **3.** without lifting, descend around the outside of the single inner arch
- **4.** without lifting, turn through its bottom and climb the inside back to the top junction
- **5.** without lifting, carry the top bar to the right edge — then lift once
- **6.** set the pen at the top of the separate right upright and draw straight down — and only now lift

Pen lifts: **1.** The pen comes up 1 time and no more.

Stroke order is one attested teaching order, not a national standard — Tamil handwriting is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: Sankaran Radhakrishnan, Tamil Script Learners Manual, Appendix I: Hand-movements, Frame 13, னா (Univ. of Texas at Austin), p. 195.

Your turn

- *Trace it:* னா once, slowly, following the steps above
- *Say it:* “na” as you finish it
- *Trace it:* it twice more, without looking back at the steps

Before you move on

What separates ூ from ூ? (**Two inner arches against one.**)
Which one is this? (ூ, one arch.)

7.15 ூ — hide, then write

Study ூ — ூ for five seconds. Say *eezhu*, then cover both forms.

Writing — delayed copy

Write the word and numeral while the model is hidden. Peek once if needed, cover again, and finish. Uncover and repair one shape.

Before you move on

Which letter carries the curled sound? (ழ.) What changed from guided copy? (**The model was hidden before writing.**)

7.16 Heard numbers — write without a model

Cover the answer line. Every sound and shape has had a supported turn.

Writing — dictation and transcription

[YOU HEAR: *aaru* — *eezhu* — *onpatu*]

Write the three numerals from sound alone. For *eezhu*, also write the word. Then uncover: ூ — ூ ூ — ூ. Repair one place.

Before you move on

Write the numeral for *pattu*. (௮.) Write seven. (௭.) Next, compare only forms you can already hear and read.

7.17 ் — the dot that leaves both letters visible

Every consonant carries a built-in **a**. So how do you write a consonant with **no** vowel — the *k* in *vaṇakkam*, or the *m* at the end?

One dot.

Script you’ll notice: The pulli

க = ka → க் = k

புள்ளி (*pulli*) means simply “**the dot**.” Written above a letter, it removes the inherent vowel. That’s the whole rule.

A standing note for this whole track. These lessons quote real Tamil words and examples, and most of them contain letters the track has not taught you to draw yet — *pulli*’s own name uses ட, ண and the ூ sign, and the comparisons below reach for others again. **Read anything printed here; only draw the letters a lesson has actually broken into strokes.** The data file behind this track covers 11 letters so far and says so (`complete: false`) — it grows as the chapters need it.

Script you’ll notice: What Tamil does *not* do

If you have done the Devanagari track, this is the moment to notice a real divergence.

In Devanagari, killing the vowel makes the bare consonant **fuse** with the next one into a squeezed **conjunct** — स् + त becomes स्त, and the first letter loses its spine. The virama usually disappears into the ligature.

Tamil doesn’t do that. The dot stays visible, and both letters keep their full shape:

Devanagari	स् + त → स्त — a new fused shape
Tamil	க் + க → க்க — two letters, dot intact

The consequence is arithmetic. Tamil’s whole set is **247 characters**: 12 vowels + 18 consonants + the 216 consonant-vowel combinations + the **āytam** ூ. That is genuinely all of them. Devanagari’s conjuncts run to many hundreds of ligature shapes on top of its letters, each to be learned or at least recognised.

(One honest exception: Tamil does have a few **ligatures borrowed with Sanskrit words** — கஷ *kṣa* and ஸ்ரீ *śrī*. They sit outside the 18 native consonants and outside the 247.)

Your turn

Write these out:

- க் — “க, then the dot above”
- க்க — two full letters, dot intact, **no fusing**

Before you move on

What does the **pulli** do, and what does the word mean? (Removes the **inherent vowel**; *pulli* is simply “**the dot**”.) What does Devanagari do that Tamil doesn’t? (**Fuses** the letters into a **conjunct** — Tamil keeps both shapes and the dot.) What does Tamil get in exchange? (A **much smaller character set** — 247, with **almost** no ligatures: only the borrowed கஷ and ஸ்ரீ.) Next: six, seven and ten across the family.

7.18 Six to ten — family resemblances and one Kannada shift

The Tamil forms are learned. Now use their sister shapes as evidence for inheritance and regular sound change.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Six and seven remain close: Tamil *āru*, Kannada *āru*, Malayalam *āru*; Tamil *ēlu*, Kannada *ēlu*, Malayalam *ēlu*. Tamil and Malayalam also keep eight and nine nearly identical: *eṭṭu* and *onpatu/onpatu*. Telugu wanders on eight and nine with *enimidi* and *tommidi*, so those forms are less reliable as family-wide recognition anchors.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Tamil and Malayalam say **pattu**, while Kannada says **hattu**. The initial *p* → *h* is a regular Kannada shift, not a random replacement. Compare Tamil *pāl*, “milk,” with Kannada *hālu*.

A correspondence lets differences prove relationship: repeated *p/h* pairs are stronger evidence than one accidental resemblance.

Your turn

- *Say it:* Tamil *pattu* · Kannada *hattu*
- *Say it:* Tamil *pāl* · Kannada *hālu*
- *Identify:* *ēlu* / *ēḷu* / *ēlu* as one inherited seven

Before you move on

What happens to Tamil *pattu* in Kannada? (*P* regularly softens to *h*: *hattu*.) Which second pair confirms the pattern? (*Pāl* / *hālu*, “milk.”) Which language diverges most on eight and nine? (Telugu.)

7.19 ோ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ூ — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: ோ

ோ — *ō*.

It is a **vowel sign**. It is not a letter and never stands alone: it attaches to a consonant and **replaces** the *a* built into it with *ō*. Replaces, not adds — the *a* is gone.

You already say these, and every one of them has ோ somewhere inside it:

- போய் வருகிறேன் *pōy varugirēn* — goodbye (lit. “I’ll go and come back”)
- மீண்டும் சந்திப்போம் *mīṇḍum sandippōm* — we’ll meet again

Writing: ோ — copy what you see

Put your pen on ோ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ோ in the ones that have it
- *Trace it:* ோ three times, saying *ō* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ோ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ோ? What vowel does it put on the consonant it attaches to — and what does it take off? (**Puts *ō* on; takes the built-in *a* off.**) Name one word you already say that contains it.

7.20 One to ten — the cumulative payoff

Count from *onru* to *pattu* once without looking. No new word or shape appears in this lesson.

Your turn — read, not recite

Read these shuffled numerals:

- First row: எ உ ய ரு அ
- Second row: ந கூ க கா ச

Now check against க உ ந ச ரு கா எ அ கூ ய.

Why it's said this way

- Which forms are inherited rather than borrowed? (**The Tamil number words.**)
- Which word means one short of ten? (ஒன்பது, *onpatu*, nine.)
- Which Kannada shift links Tamil *pattu* to Kannada *hattu*? (*p* to *h*.)

Writing — independent dictation

Cover the answer. [YOU HEAR: *eezhu*] Write its numeral and word. Uncover: எ — ஏழு. Repair one shape if needed.

Before you move on

Count one to ten, then read கூ ூ எ out of order. You can now hear, say, read, and write a representative part of the sequence.

Chapter 8

Please

Modes: 🗣️ voice (2) 👁️ eyes (1) ✍️ pen (7) 🗣️ Hands-free start: first 2 of 10 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can tell an emphatic தயவுசெய்து from the everyday courtesy that lives in the -உங்கள் verb ending, and I can write சொல்லுங்கள் from hearing.

Ask for something twice — தயவுசெய்து when the request needs weight, plain உட்காருங்கள் when it does not — read the join in செய்து, and write சொல்லுங்கள் from hearing.

8.1 தயவுசெய்து (tayavu seytu) — please (do the kindness)

Across a whole band of Asia, the word for *please* is really the word **compassion**, dressed as a small request. Tamil says it most literally of all: “do the kindness.”

You’ll want to know: The phrase

தயவுசெய்து = please, literally “do the kindness / grace.” It is two pieces snapped together:

- தயவு (tayavu) = kindness, compassion, grace — from Sanskrit daya “compassion.”
- செய்து (seytu) = “having done,” from the verb செய் (sey) “to do.”

So *tayavu seytu* is an invitation: *do me the kindness (of...)*. You place it in front of a request the way English puts “please” in front of one.

This is the same instinct as **Arabic** *min faḍlik* (“from your **grace**”) and **Hindi** *kṛpayā* (from *kṛpā*, “**compassion**”). Naming the kindness you hope for is one of the great strategies of politeness — different from French’s “if it **pleases** you,” and from Latin/German’s “I **ask**.”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

All four Dravidian cousins build *please* the very same way — **daya** plus a light verb “do / place / become”:

- Tamil தயவுசெய்து *tayavu seytu* — kindness + **do**
- Kannada ದಯವಿಟ್ಟು *dayaviṭṭu* — compassion + **having placed**
- Telugu దయచేసి *dayacēsi* — compassion + **having done**
- Malayalam ദയവായി *dayavāyi* — compassion + **as / having become**

One idea, four scripts. Learn one and you can almost read the others.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*tayavu*” — the kindness — then “*seytu*,” having done
- the whole phrase — “*tayavu seytu*” = please, do the kindness

Before you move on

What is the Tamil phrase for please? (தயவுசெய்து *tayavu seytu*.) What do its two pieces mean? (“**Kindness**” *tayavu* + “**having done**” *seytu* — *do the kindness*.) Which languages ask the same way? (**Kannada**, **Telugu**, **Malayalam** with *daya*, and further off **Arabic** *faḍl* and **Hindi** *kṛpā*.) Next: decide when the standalone phrase is natural and when the verb carries the courtesy.

8.2 Solluṅaḷ — please tell me

You know *tayavu seytu*, the weightier “do me the kindness.” Now learn one ordinary respectful request by ear before meeting its written shape.

You’ll want to know: one useful request

Solluṅaḷ means **please tell me**. The ending *-uṅaḷ* makes the request respectful. For now, keep the whole expression together: one sound, one useful meaning.

Say it in three easy pulses: *sol · luṅ · gaḷ*. Then say it smoothly once: *solluṅaḷ*.

Your turn

- *Hear: solluṅaḷ* → YOU CHOOSE: “please tell me”
- *Say it: sol · luṅ · gaḷ* — then *solluṅaḷ*

Before you move on

How do you respectfully ask someone to tell you? (***Solluṅaḷ***.) Keep that sound and meaning in mind. Next you will uncover just one new written sign inside this already-familiar request.

8.3 சொ — one new sign in a familiar request

Say *solluṅaḷ*: **please tell me**. Its first sound is *so*. You already know the sound and meaning; today only its written vowel sign is new.

Script you’ll notice: சொ

The consonant ச begins with *ca*. Add the short-*o* sign சொ, and it reads *so*:

ச + சொ → சொ

The short-*o* sign reaches around its consonant. Part appears on the left and part on the right, but together they are one vowel sign. Read the whole joined shape as one syllable: சொ, *so*.

Do not invent a stroke order from the printed font. Follow the model as one shape today.

Writing — observe and trace

Trace சொ once with the model visible. Say *so* as your finger reaches the vowel sign. Then point to the first syllable in சொல்லுங்கள் and say the whole familiar request, *solluṅgal*.

Before you move on

Read சொ. (*So*.) What does the whole spoken request *solluṅgal* mean? (**Please tell me.**) One new sign is enough for today.

8.4 சொல்லுங்கள் — one visible copy

Point to சொ at the start of சொல்லுங்கள். Read *so*, then say the whole request: *solluṅgal*, **please tell me**.

Writing — guided copy

Copy சொல்லுங்கள் once beneath its visible model. Pause after சொ and check that the short-*o* sign reaches around ச. Look back after every piece if needed. Say the request once when you finish.

Before you move on

Point to the short-*o* syllable in சொல்லுங்கள். (சொ.) What does the word ask? (**Please tell me.**)

8.5 Solluṅgal — hide, then write

Study சொல்லுங்கள் for five seconds. Point to சொ, say *solluṅgal*, then cover the model.

Writing — delayed copy

Write சொ while the model is hidden. If that feels secure, continue and write the whole request. Peek once if needed, cover it again, and finish. Then uncover the model and repair only the short-*o* syllable.

Before you move on

What changed from the previous step? (**The model was hidden before writing.**) Say what your word means. (**Please tell me.**)

8.6 One heard request — write it

Cover every Tamil model. You will hear the same useful request you have already said, traced, copied, and retrieved.

Writing — dictation

[YOU HEAR: *solluṅgal* — **please tell me**]

Write the request from sound alone. Then uncover சொல்லுங்கள். Check சொ first: the short-*o* sign should reach around ச. Repair one place if needed; do not rewrite the whole word.

Before you move on

Without looking, write only the opening syllable of *solluṅgal*. (சொ.) You are ready to compare this ordinary respectful request with the weightier *tayavu seytu*.

8.7 தயவுசெய்து or -உங்கள்? — politeness in phrase or verb

Tamil has a phrase meaning “do the kindness,” but everyday courtesy often sits somewhere English speakers do not expect: inside the verb.

Why it’s said this way

A standalone தயவுசெய்து is more emphatic and formal than English “please.” Ordinary polite commands use respectful -உங்கள் (*-uṅgal*):

- உட்காருங்கள் *uṭkāruṅgaḷ* — please sit
- சொல்லுங்கள் *soḷḷuṅgaḷ* — please tell me — the request you can now say, read, and write from hearing

Use *tayavu seytu* to mark “please, do me the kindness” warmly or formally. Let the verb ending carry routine courtesy.

Script you’ll notice: Read the join in செய்து

செ is *ca* with the ெ sign for *e*. ய் is *ya* shut off by *pulli*, a bare *y*, before து *tu*. The same dot that built numbers now makes the consonant seam in *seytu* visible.

Your turn

- *Choose*: emphatic request → தயவுசெய்து
- *Choose*: ordinary “please sit” → உட்காருங்கள்
- *Read it*: சொல்லுங்கள் — and point to சொ, the short-*o* syllable
- *Break apart*: செ + ய் + து → செய்து

Before you move on

What carries everyday “please”? (The respectful verb ending *-uṅgaḷ*.) When is *tayavu seytu* especially useful? (A **markedly polite or emphatic** request.) What silences *y* in ய்? (The **pulli**.)

8.8 ந — the third n, and the only one built from uprights

Before the new one: say the sound of ன.

One letter this time. Just one.

The third n, and the one that finally looks different: no spiral loop at all. ந is built from a top bar and two uprights, with a right stroke that curls below the baseline. If you can see that it has no loop, you can already tell it from the other two.

Script you'll notice: ந

ந — *na*.

What it is made of:

- a left upright joined to the top bar
- a separately started middle upright
- a separately started right bowl that curls below the baseline and sweeps left into a descender

நன்றி — *thank you* — opens with it, and so does நான்.

Writing: ந

1. start at the lower left and draw the left upright upward
2. without lifting, carry the top bar to the right — then lift once
3. set the pen at the top-right junction and make the short return left to the middle upright
4. without lifting, draw the middle upright straight down — then lift a second time
5. set the pen at the upper junction and descend around the outside of the right bowl
6. without lifting, turn through the bottom and sweep left into the below-baseline tail — and only now lift

Pen lifts: 2. The pen comes up 2 times and no more.

Stroke order is one attested teaching order, not a national standard — Tamil handwriting is taught with school-to-school variation. Module 5 notes that the extended final curve may be omitted. Source: Sankaran Radhakrishnan, *Tamil Script Learners Manual*, Appendix I: Hand-movements, Frame 5, ந (University of Texas at Austin), p. 193.

Your turn

- *Trace it:* ந once, slowly, following the steps above
- *Say it:* “na” as you finish it
- *Trace it:* it twice more, without looking back at the steps

Before you move on

Which of the three n’s has no spiral loop? (ந.) How many pen lifts does it take? (**Two**.)

8.9 வணக்கம் — the first whole written word

You know the four letter bodies and the vowel-killing dot. Assemble them left to right.

Script you’ll notice: Build the word

piece		
வ	<i>va</i>	Lesson 1
ண	<i>ṇa</i>	Lesson 2
க்	<i>k</i> — க with the dot	last lesson
க	<i>ka</i>	Lesson 1
ம்	<i>m</i> — ம with the dot	this lesson

வ • ண • க் • க • ம் → வணக்கம்

Hear two details. க் is a **doubled** consonant: hold it, *vaṇak-kam*, not *vaṇakam*. Tamil distinguishes single from double consonants. Final ம் is a bare *m*, so the word closes instead of trailing into *ma*.

That is the first word of this book, written by hand.

Your turn

- *Write it:* க் — க with the dot
- *Write it:* க் க — two full letters, dot intact
- *Write it:* வணக்கம் — five pieces, left to right
- *Say it:* “vaṇak-kam” — hold the middle

Before you move on

Write வணக்கம். What is special about க்க? (It is **doubled** and held.) Why does the word end in *m*, not *ma*? (Final ம் carries a **pulli**.) Next: the formal way to say *please forgive me*.

8.10 எ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ே — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: எ

எ — *e*.

It is an **independent vowel** — the shape the vowel *e* takes when a word begins with it, rather than the sign it becomes inside a word.

You already say these, and every one of them has எ somewhere inside it:

- என் *en* — my
- என் பெயர் ... *en peyar* ... — my name is... (with no “is”)
- என்ன *enna* — what
- எப்படி *eppadi* — how

Writing: எ — copy what you see

Put your pen on எ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find எ in the ones that have it

என் · வணக்கம்

- *Trace it:* எ three times, saying *e* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find எ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — எ? What sound does it carry? (*e*)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 9

Sorry

Modes:  voice (1)  eyes (1)  pen (1)  Hands-free start: first 2 of 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can apologise with மன்னிக்கவும் where its register fits, and say plainly where colloquial Tamil varies by region instead of pretending one form is standard.

Say man-ni-kkavum holding both doubled consonants, use it for a considered apology, and qualify the casual alternatives rather than asserting one.

9.1 மன்னிக்கவும் (mannikkavum) — please forgive

You already know தயவுசெய்து, “please.” Tamil’s “sorry” gives you something its Dravidian cousins don’t: a forgiveness-word that’s Tamil through and through, not borrowed from Sanskrit.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

மன்னிக்கவும் is built from three pieces:

- மன்னி (*manni*) = “to forgive, excuse, pardon” — and unlike the words Kannada, Telugu, and Malayalam reach for, this is Tamil’s **own** native verb, not borrowed from Sanskrit *kṣamā*.
- -க்க (*-kka*) = an infinitive-forming ending.

- **-உம்** (*-um*) = a formal, written-register particle used to make a soft, general request or permission — the same particle you’d see on a sign asking visitors to **வரவும்** (“please come” / “you may come”).

So **மன்னிக்கவும்** reads as something like “**may** [one] **forgive**” — a polite, slightly formal way of asking for forgiveness, more at home in writing or a considered apology than tossed off in passing.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Where Kannada, Telugu, and Malayalam all reach for the Sanskrit noun **kṣamā** (“patience, forgiveness”) and turn it into a verb, **Tamil** uses its own root:

- Tamil **மன்னிக்கவும்** *mannikkavum* — from Tamil **மன்னி** *manni*
- Kannada **ಕ್ಷಮಿಸಿ** *kṣamisi* — from Sanskrit **kṣamā**
- Telugu **క్షమించండి** *kṣamiṇcaṇḍi* — from Sanskrit **kṣamā**
- Malayalam **ക്ഷമിക്കണം** *kṣamikkanaṁ* — from Sanskrit **kṣamā**

Where “please” showed the whole family sharing one Sanskrit-derived idea (*daya*), “sorry” shows the opposite: Tamil kept its own word while its cousins borrowed the same Sanskrit one.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “**manni**” — forgive — the Tamil root, not from Sanskrit
- the whole word — “**mannikkavum**” = please forgive
- contrast — Kannada, Telugu, Malayalam all use **kṣamā** instead

Before you move on

What does **மன்னிக்கவும்** mean, and what is it built from?
 (“**Please forgive**” — *manni* “to forgive” + *-kkavum*, a formal

request ending.) What’s different about Tamil’s forgiveness-word compared to Kannada, Telugu, and Malayalam? (**It’s Tamil’s own native root** — the other three borrow Sanskrit *kṣamā* instead.) Next: place the word in its real register and read the doubled alveolar n.

9.2 மன்னிக்கவும் — formal forgiveness and a doubled n

The root is native Tamil. Its everyday conversational fit is less simple than a one-to-one dictionary entry suggests.

Why it’s said this way

மன்னிக்கவும் leans formal: a “please forgive” on a notice or in a considered apology. Spoken Tamil may use shorter regional forms or borrow English “sorry.” Colloquial variation is real, so treat formal/written as a reliable center, not a claim that one casual form covers every region.

Script you’ll notice: Read ன்னி

In ன்னி, alveolar ன is first silenced by pulli and then repeated before the vowel. The spelling holds the consonant across the syllable boundary:

ன் + னி → ன்னி — *n-ni*

This is the same gemination-by-repetition principle used elsewhere in Tamil; the sound is doubled without inventing a new ligature.

Your turn

- *Say it*: “man-ni-kkavum,” holding both doubled consonants
- *Choose*: considered/formal apology → மன்னிக்கவும்
- *Qualify*: casual alternatives vary by region

Before you move on

What is the reliable register center of *mannikkavum*? (**Formal/written or considered apology.**) Must every region use it casually? (**No.**) How does ன்னி show a doubled *n*? (Pulli stops the first ன், then full னி follows.)

9.3 ல — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ஄ — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: ல

ல — *la*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *l*, it is **la**.

What it is made of:

- a spiral loop on the left
- a deep U-shaped turn
- an open rising tip on the right

You already say these, and every one of them has ல somewhere inside it:

- இல்லை *illai* — no / there isn't (illai — the negative)
- ஆம் / இல்லை / சரி *ām / illai / sari* — answering in Tamil
- நலம் *nalām* — well, wellness, good — and the reply "நான் நலமாக இருக்கிறேன்"
- பரவாயில்லை *paravāyillai* — it's okay / no problem / you're welcome

Writing: ல

- 1. start at the inner curl and spiral outward, climbing the left side
- 2. without lifting, arch over the top and descend through the middle
- 3. without lifting, turn around the deep right-hand curve
- 4. without lifting, rise to the open right tip — and only now lift

Pen lifts: 0. The pen never leaves the paper.

One unbroken stroke — four joined movements, no pen lift; cited to Radhakrishnan, Tamil Script Learners Manual, Frame 9, ல.

This is one attested teaching order and not a national standard — handwriting here is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: Sankaran Radhakrishnan, Tamil Script Learners Manual, Appendix I: Hand-movements, Frame 9, ல (Univ. of Texas at Austin), p. 194.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ல in the ones that have it

இல்லை · வணக்கம்

- *Trace it:* ல three times, saying *la* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ல once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ல? What sound does it carry? (*la*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 10

Days of the Week

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) ✍️ pen (3) 🗣️ Hands-free start: first 1 of 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the seven weekdays, take each apart as planet plus கிழமை, and say which are Tamil’s own words and which arrived from Sanskrit.

Run the week from thingal to ñāyiru, sorting the four native planet-words from the three Sanskrit ones as you go.

10.1 திங்கள்-ஞாயிறு — a home-grown and borrowed week

Hindi’s week is built entirely from Sanskrit deity-names plus वार (vār). Tamil’s week tells a richer story: it uses its **own** word for “day,” and **some** of its planet-names are Tamil’s own too — while others are borrowed, just like Hindi’s.

Grammar Lens: The pattern: [planet] + கிழமை, “day”

Every Tamil weekday ends in கிழமை (kizhamai), “day” — a native Dravidian word, not the Sanskrit வாரம் (vāram) that Hindi, Kannada, and Telugu build on (though Tamil also keeps a more formal, Sanskritic -vāram set alongside this everyday one):

Tamil weekday	planet-word, meaning, and source
திங்கள்கிழமை	<i>thingal</i> , “ Moon ” — Tamil’s own word
செவ்வாய்க்கிழமை	<i>cevvāy</i> , traditionally “ the red one ” — likely Tamil’s own descriptive name
புதன்கிழமை	<i>pudhan</i> , Mercury — borrowed from Sanskrit Budha
வியாழக்கிழமை	<i>viyāzhan</i> , Jupiter — likely from Sanskrit, via a name for Bṛhaspati
வெள்ளிக்கிழமை	<i>velli</i> , traditionally “ silver ” — likely Tamil’s own descriptive name
சனிக்கிழமை	<i>san̥i</i> , Saturn — borrowed from Sanskrit Śani
ஞாயிற்றுக்கிழமை	<i>ñāyiru</i> , “ Sun ” — Tamil’s own word

Why it’s said this way

Notice the pattern: **Moon**, **Mars**, **Venus**, and **Sun** all carry Tamil’s own descriptive or native words, while **Mercury**, **Jupiter**, and **Saturn** carry Sanskrit ones. This isn’t Tamil “failing” to have its own full week — it’s a genuine **blend**, native Dravidian vocabulary standing right alongside Sanskrit loans, in the same list. (Note for the Tamil-speaking reviewer: this lesson spells Monday திங்கள்கிழமை, the common form — the more traditional sandhi-shifted spelling திங்கட்கிழமை may be preferred and should be swapped in on review if so. The *cevvāy* “red one” and *viyāzhan* Jupiter-name derivations in particular are worth treating as the traditional, commonly-given account rather than settled certainty — exact planet-name histories this old are not always fully nailed down.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “thingal” — moon, Tamil’s own word — then “kizhamai,” day
- the borrowed ones — “pudhan, viyāzhan, sanī” — Mercury, Jupiter, Saturn from Sanskrit
- the native ones — “thingal, cevṡāy, velli, ṇāyiru” — moon, Mars, Venus, sun

Before you move on

What does every Tamil weekday end in, and where does that word come from? (கிழமை *kizhamai*, “day” — Tamil’s **own** word, not Sanskrit *vāra*.) Which four planet-names are Tamil’s own, and which three are Sanskrit borrowings? (**Moon, Mars, Venus, Sun are native; Mercury, Jupiter, Saturn are Sanskrit** — *Budha, Bṛhaspati, Śani*.)

10.2 ற — the last of the family, and the one that drops below the line

Before the new one: say the sound of ற.

One letter this time. Just one.

The fourth member of this top-bar family, and the one with a habit none of the others have: its right leg keeps going **below the baseline** and sweeps left into a long descender. Tamil letters mostly sit on the line. This one hangs off it.

Script you’ll notice: ற

ற — *ra*.

What it is made of:

- two arches side by side, giving three legs down to the baseline
- the right leg continues **BELOW** the baseline, sweeps left, and drops into a long descender

It is the r in றன்றி — and with it, every consonant of *thank you*.

Writing: ர

- **1.** start at the lower left, climb the left side, and arch to the middle
- **2.** without lifting, descend the first middle upright — then lift once
- **3.** set the pen at the adjacent middle upright and descend — then lift a second time
- **4.** set the pen at the middle top, arch over, and descend the right side
- **5.** without lifting again, sweep left below the baseline and drop into the long descender — and only now lift

Pen lifts: 2. The pen comes up 2 times and no more.

Stroke order is one attested teaching order, not a national standard — Tamil handwriting is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: Sankaran Radhakrishnan, Tamil Script Learners Manual, Appendix I: Hand-movements, Frame 10, ர (Univ. of Texas at Austin), p. 194.

Your turn

- *Trace it:* ர once, slowly, following the steps above
- *Say it:* “ra” as you finish it
- *Trace it:* it twice more, without looking back at the steps

Before you move on

What does ர do that ண, ன and ந do not? (**Drops below the baseline.**) Which word have you now met all the consonants of? (நன்றி.)

10.3 ந, ன, ர — the letter bodies inside நன்றி

Lesson 2 showed you that Tamil has **three** n-letters and promised you’d draw the other two when a word needed them. Chapter 1’s *thank you* needs both.

Script you'll notice: The two remaining n's

ந — *na*, the **dental** n, tongue against the teeth:

1. **a straight top bar** 2. **a vertical on the left** 3. **a second vertical in the middle** 4. **a right stroke that curls below the baseline** and sweeps left into a descender

ண — *na*, the **alveolar** n, tongue on the ridge behind the teeth:

1. **a straight top bar** 2. **a loop on the left** 3. **one arch** 4. **a straight vertical on the right, down to the baseline**

Compare it with Lesson 2's ண: same top bar, same loop, same closing vertical. ண **simply has a second arch inserted before that vertical**. So ண is ண **minus one arch** — one arch for ண, two for ண. That is the whole contrast, and it is the cheapest way to keep them apart.

With Lesson 2's ண (retroflex), that completes the set. Same consonant to an English ear; three letters, three tongue positions, in Tamil.

Script you'll notice: ர — “ra”, the hard r

1. **two arches side by side** — giving it three legs down to the baseline 2. **the right leg keeps going below the baseline**, sweeps **left**, and drops into a long descender

It is the tallest thing you have drawn: most Tamil letters sit on the baseline, and ர hangs well beneath it.

The dot under r marks it as the *hard* or trilled r, distinct from Tamil's other r. You'll meet the contrast properly later; for now, learn the shape.

Your turn

Write these out:

- ந — “top bar, **two** verticals, then the curl that sweeps left”
- ண — “top bar, left loop, **one** arch, straight vertical”
- ர — “two arches, then the leg that sweeps left and drops”

Before you move on

Name Tamil's three n-letters and their tongue positions. (ந dental, ண alveolar, ண retroflex.) What are a consonant's three possibilities so far? (Keep the built-in **a** or **remove** it with the pulli.) Which letter hangs below the baseline? (ர, the hard r.)

Next: the colours — black, white, red and blue.

10.4 ா — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ஸ — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: ா

ா — $\bar{a}$.

It is a **vowel sign**. It is not a letter and never stands alone: it attaches to a consonant and **replaces** the a built into it with $\bar{a}$. Replaces, not adds — the a is gone.

Where it sits: a vertical stroke with a small top hook, written after the consonant.

Worked through: ம + ா = மா — $m\bar{a}$.

You already say these, and every one of them has ா somewhere inside it:

- வணக்கம் / நமஸ்காரம் *vaṇakkam / namaskāram* — Tamil kept a native bow-word where its neighbors borrowed Sanskrit
- நான் *nān* — I
- பரவாயில்லை *paravāyillai* — it's okay / no problem / you're welcome
- நாளை பார்க்கலாம் *nālai pārkkalām* — see you tomorrow

Writing: ா — copy what you see

Put your pen on ா and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in

front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ா in the ones that have it

நான் · வணக்கம்

- *Trace it:* ா three times, saying ā as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ா once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ா? What vowel does it put on the consonant it attaches to — and what does it take off? (**Puts ā on; takes the built-in a off.**) Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 11

Colours

Modes: 👁 eyes (1) ✍ pen (1) 🔄 Hands-free start: none of the 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name black, white, red, and blue in Tamil and say which three are native and which one is the Sanskrit loan.

Say karuppu, vellai and sivappu as the native three, nīlam as the borrowed one, and hear vellai echo velli from last chapter.

11.1 கருப்பு, வெள்ளை, சிவப்பு, நீலம் — three of Tamil’s own, one borrowed

You’ve already seen Tamil mix native and Sanskrit words in its day-names. Colors tell a **cleaner** version of the same story: three colors are Tamil’s own, and the fourth is the one color that keeps showing up borrowed, in language after language.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

- கருப்பு (*karuppu*) = “**black**” — native Tamil/Dravidian.
- வெள்ளை (*vellai*) = “**white**” — native Tamil/Dravidian, and built on the very same வெள் (*vel-*, “bright, silvery”) root you already met in வெள்ளி (*veli*), “Venus/silver,” from the days-of-the-week lesson.
- சிவப்பு (*sivappu*) = “**red**” — native Tamil/Dravidian.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

நீலம் (*nīlam*) = “blue” — from Sanskrit नील (*nīla*), “dark blue,” the very same root behind Hindi’s नीला (*nīlā*). This *nīla* is also the name of the indigo plant and its dye — part of why blue dye is so historically linked to India — but be careful: the English word **indigo** itself is a *separate*, Greek-derived word (describing where the dye was imported *from*, not descended from *nīla* by sound change; see the Hindi color lesson for that careful distinction).

Why it’s said this way

This isn’t random. “Blue” is, across many of the world’s languages, one of the **last** basic colors to settle into its own fixed word — often arriving late, or borrowed, compared to black, white, and red. Tamil’s colors look like exactly this pattern in miniature: three old, native words, and one — blue — reaching outside the language for a Sanskrit loan.

(Note for the Tamil-speaking reviewer: please confirm *karuppu*, *vellai*, *sivappu*, *nīlam* are the forms you’d teach first — regional/colloquial Tamil may prefer different everyday variants, and this lesson would benefit from your check the way the day-names lesson did.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the three native ones — “karuppu, vellai, sivappu” — black, white, red
- the borrowed one — “nīlam” — blue, from Sanskrit
- the echo — “vellai” and “velli” share the same *vel-* root

Before you move on

Which three Tamil colors are native, and which one is borrowed? (**Karuppu**, **vellai**, **sivappu** (black/white/red) are native; **nīlam** (blue) is a **Sanskrit** loan.) What root does *vellai* share with a word you already know? (**Vel-** “bright/silvery” — the same root as *velli*, “Venus/silver.”) Why might blue be the one borrowed color? (**Blue is often one of the last basic colors** to settle into a fixed word

across many languages — the same pattern Latin’s *caeruleus* showed.)

11.2 ழ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ஶ — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: ழ

ழ — *lla*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *ll*, it is **lla**.

You already say these, and every one of them has ழ somewhere inside it:

- தமிழ் எழுத்து *tamiḷ eluttu* — why Tamil writing is so round
- நான் தமிழ் பேசுகிறேன் *nāṇ tamiḷ pēsugirēṇ* — I speak Tamil
- வாழ் *vāḷ* — to live, to flourish
- எனக்குத் தமிழ் தெரியும் *enakkut tamiḷ teriyum* — ‘I know Tamil’

Writing: ழ — copy what you see

Put your pen on ழ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ழ in the ones that have it

வணக்கம்

- *Trace it:* ழ three times, saying *lla* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ழ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ழ? What sound does it carry? (*lla*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 12

Family

Modes:  voice (1)  pen (1)  Hands-free start: first 1 of 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can use Tamil’s four sibling words correctly, settling relative age before gender — the question English never makes you answer.

Name appā and ammā, then place annan, tambi, akkā and tangai by asking “older, or younger?” before you can say “brother” at all.

12.1 அப்பா, அம்மா, and four sibling words

You’ve learned Spanish *hermano* and *hermana*, plus French *frère* and *sœur* — one word each for “brother” and “sister.” Tamil asks a question those languages never do: **is this sibling older or younger than you?**

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

- அப்பா (*appā*) = “**father**”
- அம்மா (*ammā*) = “**mother**”

Both are native Dravidian words, of the same simple, worldwide “baby-talk” shape (a repeated consonant plus a vowel) found across unrelated language families everywhere — not borrowed from Sanskrit, not a coincidence with any one language in particular, just how small children’s mouths tend to form their first words for parents.

You'll want to know: Siblings — split by age, not just gender

Here's the real lesson: Tamil doesn't have one word for “brother” and one for “sister.” It has **four**:

Tamil	meaning
அண்ணன் (<i>aṇṇan</i>)	older brother
தம்பி (<i>tambi</i>)	younger brother
அக்கா (<i>akkā</i>)	older sister
தங்கை (<i>tangai</i>)	younger sister

There is no single Tamil word that just means “brother” the way Spanish *hermano* does — you're expected to know, and say, **whether they're older or younger than you** every time you refer to a sibling. This isn't a small detail: it reflects how central **relative age and seniority** are in South Asian family structure and address — the same instinct that makes “older sibling” versus “younger sibling” a live, spoken distinction, not just something you *could* mention if you wanted to.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “appā, ammā” — father, mother
- the four siblings — “aṇṇan, tambi” (older/younger brother), “akkā, tangai” (older/younger sister)
- the key question — “older, or younger?” — before you can even say “brother” or “sister” in Tamil

Before you move on

How many Tamil words mean “brother” or “sister,” and why? (**Four** — அண்ணன்/தம்பி for older/younger brother, அக்கா/தங்கை for older/younger sister — Tamil requires knowing the sibling's **age relative to you**.) Are அப்பா and அம்மா borrowed from Sanskrit? (**No** — native Dravidian baby-talk-type words, of a shape found across unrelated languages worldwide.)

12.2 ஈ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ழ — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: ஈ

ஈ — *ca*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *c*, it is **ca**.

You already say these, and every one of them has ஈ somewhere inside it:

- சரி *sari* — okay / alright / correct (sari)
- ஆம் / இல்லை / சரி *ām / illai / sari* — answering in Tamil
- மீண்டும் சந்திப்போம் *mīṇḍum sandippōm* — we'll meet again
- பேசு *pēsu* — to speak

Writing: ஈ — copy what you see

Put your pen on ஈ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ஈ in the ones that have it
சரி · வணக்கம்
- *Trace it:* ஈ three times, saying *ca* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ஈ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — **ſ**? What sound does it carry? (*ca.*)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 13

Body Parts

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ✍ pen (3) ⇄ Hands-free start: first 1 of 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say head and hand in Tamil, account for why both stayed native here where Hindi's pair came from Sanskrit, and write நன்றி from its pieces.

Say talai and kai, then state the contrast with Hindi's Sanskrit-descended pair.

13.1 தலை, கை — head and hand, both Tamil's own

You've seen Hindi's *sir* and *hāth* trace all the way back to Sanskrit. Tamil's words for the same two body parts tell a simpler story: **both are native**.

You'll want to know: The words

- தலை (*talai*) = “**head**” — native Dravidian.
- கை (*kai*) = “**hand**” — native Dravidian.

Neither is borrowed from Sanskrit, unlike Hindi's *sir* (< Sanskrit *śiras*) or *hāth* (< Sanskrit *hasta*). Tamil simply kept its own words for two of the most basic parts of the body.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “talai” — head
- “kai” — hand
- the contrast — Hindi borrowed these from Sanskrit; Tamil didn’t

Before you move on

What are Tamil’s words for head and hand? (தலை *talai*, கை *kai*.) Are either of these Sanskrit loans? (**No** — both native Dravidian, unlike Hindi’s Sanskrit-descended *sir* and *hāth*.)

13.2 க — the letter that is three bowls

Before the new one: say the sound of ற.

One letter this time. Just one.

The most-used consonant in Tamil, and the most built: a square frame on top, then two bowls hanging under it. Three pen-down runs. Take it slowly — nothing else in this book asks for as many separate pieces.

Script you’ll notice: க

க — *ka*.

What it is made of:

- an upper square frame
- a large lower-left bowl
- a lower-right bowl with an open foot

வணக்கம் has it twice, doubled in the middle.

Writing: க

- **1.** start at the middle left and climb the left upright
- **2.** without lifting, carry the top bar to the right and return along it to the inner corner
- **3.** without lifting, drop the inner upright and carry the middle bar left — then lift once
- **4.** set the pen at the inner crossing and curve down and around the lower-left bowl
- **5.** without lifting again, return up its outer left side — then lift a second time
- **6.** set the pen at the inner crossing and turn around the lower-right bowl — and only now lift

Pen lifts: 2. The pen comes up 2 times and no more.

Stroke order is one attested teaching order, not a national standard — Tamil handwriting is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: Sankaran Radhakrishnan, Tamil Script Learners Manual, Appendix I: Hand-movements, Frame 3, க (Univ. of Texas at Austin), p. 191.

Your turn

- *Trace it:* க once, slowly, following the steps above
- *Say it:* “ka” as you finish it
- *Trace it:* it twice more, without looking back at the steps

Before you move on

How many pen lifts does க take? (**Two** — three separate runs.)
 What are the three parts? (**Upper frame, lower-left bowl, lower-right bowl.**)

13.3 ி and நன்றி — replace the vowel, then hear *ndr*

A consonant can keep *a* or lose it under a pulli. The third option is to replace it with a vowel sign.

Script you'll notice: The first vowel sign

ற = *ra* → றி = *ri*

ி is a hook above and to the right. The consonant keeps its shape; the sign hangs from it. Later, ை (ai) will appear before its consonant on the page but after it in speech, the same eye/ear trap as Devanagari ि.

Script you'll notice: Assemble நன்றி

ந · ன் · றி → நன்றி

piece

ந	<i>na</i> — dental	last lesson
ண்	<i>n̪</i> — alveolar, with pulli	Lessons 3–4
றி	<i>ri</i> — ற plus the i-sign	this lesson

The letters in this word

ன் + ற is pronounced close to **ndr**. This follows a broader Tamil rule: a **nasal voices the stop after it**.

ந் + த	<i>nd</i>	வந்து <i>vandu</i>
ண் + ட	<i>n̪ḍ</i>	retroflex pair
ன் + ற	<i>ndr</i>	நன்றி

Each n-letter creates its own cluster. That payoff explains both the three spellings and the common English romanization **nandri**, whose *d* is heard but not separately written.

Your turn

- Write it: றி — ற plus the hook above right
- Write it: நன்றி — three pieces

- Say it: “ன் + ற = ndr”

Before you move on

What are a consonant’s three vowel choices? (Keep inherent **a**, **remove** it with pulli, or **replace** it with a vowel sign.) Where does ி attach? (**Above and right.**) Why is *nanri* often written *nandri*? (ன் + ற is pronounced *ndr* because a nasal voices the following stop.)

13.4 ர — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ஈ — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: ர

ர — *ra*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *r*, it is **ra**.

You already say these, and every one of them has ர somewhere inside it:

- வணக்கம் / நமஸ்காரம் *vaṇakkam / namaskāram* — Tamil kept a native bow-word where its neighbors borrowed Sanskrit
- சரி *sari* — okay / alright / correct (sari)
- ஆம் / இல்லை / சரி *ām / illai / sari* — answering in Tamil
- பெயர் *peyar* — name

Writing: ர — copy what you see

Put your pen on ர and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character** or **which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real

variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ர in the ones that have it

சுரி · வணக்கம்

- *Trace it:* ர three times, saying *ra* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ர once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ர? What sound does it carry? (*ra*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 14

Seasons

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ✍ pen (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: first 1 of 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the four seasons in Tamil and say honestly which one is locally central instead of repeating a Western four-way split.

Build kodai/mazhai/kulir onto kaalam, name mazhai kaalam as the season that actually organises the year, and flag vasantha as the one loanword.

14.1 வசந்த காலம், கோடை, மழை, குளிர் — the four words, and the real season underneath

Tamil has words that line up with Spanish's four seasons — but, just like Hindi's ऋतु, forcing them into a clean four-way split hides what actually matters on the ground.

You'll want to know: The four words

Tamil	meaning	source
வசந்த காலம் (<i>vasantha kaalam</i>)	“spring”	<i>vasantham</i> is a Sanskrit loan
கோடைக் காலம் (<i>kodai kaalam</i>)	“summer”	கோடை <i>kodai</i> is native Tamil for “heat”
மழைக் காலம் (<i>mazhai kaalam</i>)	“rainy season”	மழை <i>mazhai</i> , native Tamil for “rain”
குளிர் காலம் (<i>kulir kaalam</i>)	“winter/cold season”	குளிர் <i>kulir</i> , native Tamil for “cold”

Every one of these is built the same way: a word for the **feel** of the season (heat, rain, cold — or the borrowed *vasantham*) plus காலம் (*kaalam*), “**time/season**.” Be honest about *kaalam* itself, too: it’s ultimately from Sanskrit काल (*kāla*, “time”) — but it was assimilated into Tamil so long ago and so thoroughly that it functions as completely ordinary vocabulary today, quite unlike a fresh, still-foreign-feeling loan like *vasantham*.

Why it’s said this way

Just as Hindi’s traditional calendar makes the monsoon (*varṣā*) its own central season rather than a footnote, Tamil Nadu’s actual climate is shaped far more by மழைக்காலம் (*mazhai kaalam*, “the rains”) than by any crisp four-way Western split. There’s no dramatic autumn leaf-fall in a tropical climate, and “spring” as a distinct, keenly-felt season is a much weaker idea here than in temperate Europe. The four words above are real and used — but the rains, not a European four-season year, are what actually organizes agricultural and everyday life across much of Tamil Nadu.

(Note for the Tamil-speaking reviewer: please check whether these are the words and register you’d teach first, and whether there’s more to say about how Tamil Nadu’s own seasonal year is actually divided in practice.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “kodai” — heat/summer, native — then “kaalam,” time/season

- “mazhai kaalam” — the rains, the real central season
- “kulir kaalam” — the cold season
- the one loanword — “vasantha kaalam,” spring, from Sanskrit

Before you move on

Which of the four season-words is a Sanskrit loan, and which are native Tamil? (வசந்தம் *vasantham* is Sanskrit; கோடை, மழை, குளிர் are all native.) What season actually shapes life in Tamil Nadu the most, and why doesn’t the four-season frame capture that? (மழைக்காலம், the **rains** — Tamil Nadu’s tropical climate doesn’t have a sharp four-way split the way temperate Europe does.)

14.2 ட — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ட — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: ட

ட — *tta*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *tt*, it is **tta**.

You already say these, and every one of them has ட somewhere inside it:

- எப்படி *eppaḍi* — how
- நீங்கள் எப்படி இருக்கிறீர்கள்? — how are you? (respectful)
- மீண்டும் சந்திப்போம் *mīṇḍum sandippōm* — we’ll meet again
- இரண்டு மூன்று நான்கு ஐந்து *iraṇṭu mūṇṇu nāṇku aintu* — two through five remain visible cousins across the Dravidian family while one is less tidy

Writing: ࣳ — copy what you see

Put your pen on ࣳ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ࣳ in the ones that have it

எப்படி · வணக்கம்

- *Trace it:* ࣳ three times, saying *tta* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ࣳ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ࣳ? What sound does it carry? (*tta*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 15

Water and Rice

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) ✍️ pen (1) 🖱️ Hands-free start: first 1 of 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can ask for water and keep raw அரிசி apart from cooked சாதம், and state how far the arisi-to-“rice” claim can honestly be pushed.

Assemble taṇ plus nīr into taṇṇīr, switch between arisi and sātam by whether it is cooked, and label the English “rice” link as contested.

15.1 தண்ணீர், அரிசி, சாதம் — water, and rice, the real staple

European languages teach “bread” as the staple food. Here, that would be **dishonest** — bread isn’t the everyday staple in Tamil food culture. **Rice** is, and it comes with one of the most famous (if contested) etymological journeys of any food-word.

You’ll want to know: தண்ணீர் — water, literally “cool water”

தண்ணீர் (*taṇṇīr*) = “**water**” — built from தண் (*taṇ*, “cool”) + நீர் (*nīr*, “**water**”). Everyday Tamil doesn’t just say “water” — it says, quite literally, “**cool water**.”

You’ll want to know: அரிசி and சாதம் — rice, raw and cooked

Tamil, like most of South India, distinguishes the **uncooked grain** from the **cooked dish** with two separate words, not one:

- அரிசி (*arisi*) = “**rice**” (the raw, husked grain) — native Dravidian.
- சாதம் (*sātam*) = “**cooked rice**” (the meal itself, what’s actually eaten) — likely Sanskrit-influenced. Tamil also keeps a native word for the same idea, சோறு (*cōru*) — the two sit side by side as everyday near-synonyms.

Why it’s said this way

Here’s the exciting part, held with appropriate care: many etymologists connect அரிசி (*arisi*) to the **English word “rice” itself** — the proposed chain runs Dravidian *arisi* → **Greek** *óryza* → Latin *oryza* → Old French *ris* → English **rice**. If true, English speakers have been saying a Dravidian word for centuries without knowing it. But be honest: standard etymological dictionaries mark Greek *óryza*’s origin as **genuinely uncertain** — a Dravidian source is one widely cited hypothesis among others (an Indo-Aryan *vrihi*-related source is also proposed), not a settled, universally agreed fact.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “taṇ” — cool — then “nīr,” water — then “taṇṇīr,” cool water
- “arisi” — raw rice — then “sātam,” cooked rice
- the famous (contested) link — “arisi” → possibly English “rice”

Before you move on

What does தண்ணீர் literally mean? (“**Cool water**” — taṇ “cool” + nīr “water.”) What two words does Tamil use for rice, and why two? (அரிசி *arisi*, raw grain; சாதம் *sātam*, cooked rice — the raw grain and the cooked meal get separate words.) Is it certain that English “rice” comes from Tamil *arisi*? (**Not certain** — it’s a widely cited hypothesis via Greek *óryza*, but that Greek word’s origin is genuinely disputed among etymologists.)

15.2 அ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ட — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: அ

அ — *a*.

It is an **independent vowel** — the shape the vowel *a* takes when a word begins with it, rather than the sign it becomes inside a word.

What it is made of:

- a curl at the upper left
- a long horizontal stroke
- a straight vertical on the right

You already say these, and every one of them has அ somewhere inside it:

- அப்பா அம்மா அண்ணன் தம்பி அக்கா தங்கை — father, mother, and FOUR sibling words
- தண்ணீர் அரிசி சாதம் — water, and rice — the actual staple food here, not bread — with a widely-cited

Writing: அ

1. start inside the upper curl and sweep around it
2. without lifting, continue down the outer curve
3. without lifting, turn around the lower loop
4. without lifting, carry the horizontal to the right edge — then lift once
5. set the pen at the top of the separate right upright and draw straight down

Pen lifts: 1. The pen comes up 1 time and no more.

Two strokes — four joined movements, one pen lift, then the right upright; cited to Radhakrishnan, Tamil Script Learners Manual, Frame 4, அ.

This is one attested teaching order and not a national standard — handwriting here is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: Sankaran Radhakrishnan, Tamil Script Learners Manual, Appendix I: Hand-movements, Frame 4, அ (Univ. of Texas at Austin), p. 192.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find அ in the ones that have it

வணக்கம்

- *Trace it:* அ three times, saying *a* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find அ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — அ? What sound does it carry? (*a*)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 16

Tamil Months

Modes:  voice (1)  pen (3)  Hands-free start: first 1 of 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the twelve months of the Tamil solar calendar and place Tamil New Year and Pongal inside it.

Recite Chithirai through Panguni, then date Tamil New Year to Chithirai 1 and Pongal to Thai 1.

16.1 சித்திரை to பங்குனி — Tamil’s own solar calendar

By now you’ve seen Arabic and Hindi each juggle two calendars. Tamil adds a **third distinct system** to the mix — one still actively used for Tamil New Year and Pongal, not a historical curiosity.

You’ll want to know: The twelve Tamil months

சித்திரை, வைகாசி, ஆனி, ஆடி, ஆவணி, புரட்டாசி, ஐப்பசி, கார்த்திகை, மார்கழி, தை, மாசி, பங்குனி (*Chithirai, Vaikāsi, Āni, Ādi, Āvaṇi, Purattāsi, Aippasi, Kārthigai, Mārgazhi, Thai, Māsi, Panguni*).

This is the **Tamil solar calendar** — a real, independent civil calendar, distinct from both the Gregorian calendar and the Hindu lunisolar (Vikram Samvat-style) calendar. Its months are traditionally tied to **nakshatras** (the 27 lunar-mansion star groups): each month is named for the nakshatra the **moon** sits near on the **full-moon (pournami) day** that falls within

that month — the moon’s position, not the sun’s, and tied to that month’s full moon specifically, not simply the month’s start.

Why it’s said this way

You’ve now met three genuinely separate calendar traditions: the Gregorian solar calendar (borrowed names, everyday civil use in most of the world), the pan-Indian Hindu lunisolar calendar (Chaitra, Vaishākh... tied to the six *ṛtu*), and now Tamil’s **own** solar calendar, following neither. சித்திரை 1 (the 1st of Chithirai) is **Tamil New Year**;தை 1 (the 1st of Thai) is **Pongal**, one of Tamil Nadu’s most important harvest festivals. These dates are fixed by the Tamil solar calendar, and only shift slightly against the Gregorian calendar (rather than drifting widely, the way lunar/lunisolar festival dates do) because it’s solar too — just a different solar calendar, starting its year at a different point and naming its months differently.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the twelve — “Chithirai, Vaikāsi, Āṇi, Āḍi, Āvaṇi, Puraṭṭāsi, Aippasi, Kārthigai, Mārgazhi, Thai, Māsi, Panguṇi”
- “Chithirai 1” — Tamil New Year
- “Thai 1” — Pongal

Before you move on

What kind of calendar is the Tamil month system — solar, lunar, or lunisolar? (**Solar** — a genuinely separate calendar from both Gregorian and Hindu lunisolar.) What are the twelve months traditionally named for? (**Nakshatras**, lunar-mansion star groups.) What two important occasions are dated by this calendar? (**Tamil New Year** (Chithirai 1) and **Pongal** (Thai 1).)

16.2 ட — upright on the left, curve on the right

Before the new one: say the sound of ட.

One letter this time. Just one.

One unbroken stroke again, like **வ**. The only thing to get right is which way round it goes: the **upright is on the LEFT** and the **curve on the right**. Most people guess the reverse, because that is the habit Devanagari teaches — hanging a shape off a right-hand spine.

Script you'll notice: **ம**

ம — *ma*.

What it is made of:

- a straight vertical stroke on the LEFT
- a horizontal along the bottom
- a rounded arch closing it on the RIGHT

It is the last consonant of **வணக்கம்**.

Writing: **ம**

- **1.** start at the top left and draw the left upright straight DOWN to the baseline
- **2.** without lifting, turn right and run along the bottom to the far right
- **3.** without lifting, turn up and rise up the right side
- **4.** without lifting, curve over the top and back towards the left
- **5.** without lifting, come down the middle to the bottom bar — and only now lift

Pen lifts: 0. The pen never leaves the paper.

Stroke order is one attested teaching order, not a national standard — Tamil handwriting is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: Sankaran Radhakrishnan, Tamil Script Learners Manual, Appendix I: Hand-movements, Frame 1 (Univ. of Texas at Austin).

Your turn

- *Trace it:* ழ once, slowly, following the steps above
- *Say it:* “ma” as you finish it
- *Trace it:* it twice more, without looking back at the steps

Before you move on

Which side is the upright on? (**The left.**) How many pen lifts?
(**None.**)

16.3 ஆம் — writing a word that starts with a vowel

Every vowel *sign* so far has hooked onto a consonant — the ி on ழ. This word has no consonant to hook onto.

Script you’ll notice: a vowel standing alone

Tamil writes a vowel two ways, and which one you use depends on **where it sits**:

inside a word, after a consonant	a small sign — ி in ழி
starting a word, with nothing before it	a full independent letter

ஆ is the independent letter for long $\bar{a}$. It is not a sign and never hangs off anything; it is a letter in its own right.

Long $\bar{a}$ is short அ plus a tail, so அ is where it starts — and you have not been shown that one yet. Its parts, then the tail:

1. **a curl at the upper left** 2. **a long horizontal stroke** 3. **a straight vertical on the right** — that is அ 4. **a tail added on the right** — and now it is ஆ

Those are the parts in writing order. Where the pen lifts is not settled: Tamil handwriting varies by region and by school, and this book only claims a pen path where it has a sourced one.

That is a rule, not a special case: any Tamil word that opens on a vowel opens with a full vowel letter.

Script you'll notice: build the word

piece		
ஆ	$\bar{a}$	this lesson —
ம்	m — ம with the pulli	independent the dot you already know

ஆ · ம் → ஆம்

Two pieces only. The pulli on ம closes the word on a bare m , exactly as it did at the end of வணக்கம்.

Your turn

Write these out:

- அ — curl, horizontal, right vertical
- ஆ — the same three parts, then the right-hand tail
- ம் — ம with the dot
- ஆம் — two pieces, left to right

Before you move on

Write ஆம். When does a Tamil vowel get a full letter instead of a sign? (**When it starts a word** — nothing precedes it to hook onto.) What closes the word? (ம் — the pulli on ம.) Next: noon and midnight.

16.4 ஆ — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: அ — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: ஆ

ஆ — $\bar{a}$.

It is an **independent vowel** — the shape the vowel $\bar{a}$ takes when a word begins with it, rather than the sign it becomes inside a word.

What it is made of:

- the whole of அ
- a tail added on the right

You already say these, and every one of them has ஆ somewhere inside it:

- ஆம் — yes ($\bar{a}m$)
- ஆம் / இல்லை / சரி $\bar{a}m$ / $illai$ / $sari$ — answering in Tamil
- ஆறு ஏழு பத்து $\bar{a}ru$ $\bar{e}lu$ $pattu$ — six, seven, and ten stay family cousins while Kannada regularly softens p to h
- ஆம் $\bar{a}m$ — a word that begins with a vowel gets a full vowel letter

Writing: ஆ

- 1. start inside the upper curl and sweep around it
- 2. without lifting, continue down the outer curve
- 3. without lifting, turn around the lower loop
- 4. without lifting, carry the horizontal to the right edge — then lift once
- 5. set the pen at the top of the separate right upright and draw straight down
- 6. without lifting again, continue into the long-vowel loop, curve right and around the bottom, then finish inside — and only now lift

Pen lifts: 1. The pen comes up 1 time and no more.

Two strokes — four joined body movements, one pen lift, then the joined upright and long-vowel loop; cited to Radhakrishnan, Tamil Script Learners Manual, Frame 4, ஆ.

This is one attested teaching order and not a national standard — handwriting here is taught with school-to-school variation. Source: Sankaran Radhakrishnan, Tamil Script Learners Manual, Appendix I: Hand-movements, Frame 4, ஆ (Univ. of Texas at Austin), p. 192.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ஆ in the ones that have it

ஆம் · வணக்கம்

- *Trace it:* ஆ three times, saying ā as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ஆ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ஆ? What sound does it carry? (ā.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 17

Noon and Midnight

Modes: 🗣️ voice (2) ✍️ pen (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: first 2 of 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can use both the fused and the transparent Tamil words for noon and midnight, and point to the நடு “middle” that makes one pair readable on sight.

Say *naṇpakal* beside *naṭuppakal* and *naḷḷiravu* beside *naṭu iravu*, pointing at *naṭu* as the everyday “middle” still visible in the second of each pair.

17.1 நண்பகல், நள்ளிரவு — one old “middle” root, two survival stories

You’ve just watched Kannada and Telugu each reach for Sanskrit’s *madhya* to name noon. Tamil doesn’t reach for Sanskrit at all here — it reaches into its own, much older layer of vocabulary instead.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Both of today’s words trace back to the same root: நள் (*naḷ*), a **Proto-Dravidian** word for “**middle, centre**” — a genuine synonym of the everyday நடு (*naṭu*, “middle”) you already know, just from an older layer of the vocabulary. நள் didn’t disappear from Tamil; it survives today mainly in **literary/poetic** compounds — நள்ளிருள் (*naḷḷirul*, “thick darkness”) and நள்ளென் கங்குல் (*naḷḷen kaṅkul*, “deep night”) — rather than in everyday colloquial speech.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

நள்ளிரவு (*nalliravu*) = “**midnight**” = நள் (*nal*, “middle”) + இரவு (*iravu*, “**night**,” a word every Tamil speaker still uses on its own) — நள் shows up here exactly as you’d expect. நண்பகல் (*naṇpakal*) = “**noon, midday**” traces to the **same** நள் root, fused with பகல் (*pakal*, “**daytime**”) — but here it surfaces as நண்- rather than நள்-, a sandhi-driven surface change before the following ப. Same root, two different faces, depending on what it’s fused to.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “nal” — an old word for “middle” — then “nalliravu,” midnight
- “naṇpakal” — noon, the same nal root, resurfacing as naṇ-

Before you move on

What old Proto-Dravidian root do நண்பகல் and நள்ளிரவு both trace back to, and what does it mean? (நள் *nal*, “middle” — surviving mainly in literary compounds like *nallirul*, “thick darkness.”) Why does it surface as **naṇ-** in *naṇpakal*? (A sandhi change before following **p**.) Does Tamil reach for Sanskrit here? (**No.**) Next: meet the transparent *naṭu* synonyms Tamil kept beside these older compounds.

17.2 நடுப்பகல் and நடு இரவு — the transparent twins

Naṇpakal and *nalliravu* preserve an older middle-root in fused forms. Tamil also kept versions whose pieces remain obvious today.

You’ll want to know: The living synonyms

- நடுப்பகல் (*naṭuppakal*) — “middle-daytime,” a dictionary synonym of *naṇpakal*

- நடு இரவு (*naṭu iravu*) — “middle night,” the transparent synonym of *nalliravu*

Both use நடு (*naṭu*, “middle”), the everyday word still heard in *naṭuvē*, “in the middle.”

Latin daughter languages often inherit one fate for an old compound: eroded or transparent. Tamil kept **both fates inside one language**—old fused forms and fresh transparent synonyms side by side.

Your turn

- *Say it*: “naṇpakal · naṭuppakal” — two noon forms
- *Say it*: “nalliravu · naṭu iravu” — two midnight forms
- *Point to*: *naṭu* as the visible everyday “middle”

Before you move on

Which everyday word builds the transparent forms? (நடு, *naṭu*, “middle.”) What did Tamil keep simultaneously? (**Older fused compounds and transparent synonyms.**) Are any pieces Sanskrit loans? (**No.**)

17.3 ு — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ஆ — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: ு

ு — *u*.

It is a **vowel sign**. It is not a letter and never stands alone: it attaches to a consonant and **replaces** the *a* built into it with *u*. Replaces, not adds — the *a* is gone.

You already say these, and every one of them has ு somewhere inside it:

- போய் வருகிறேன் *pōy varugirēṇ* — goodbye (lit. “I’ll go and come back”)
- மீண்டும் சந்திப்போம் *mīṇḍum sandippōm* — we’ll meet again
- தமிழ் எழுத்து *tamiḷ eluttu* — why Tamil writing is so round
- பேசு *pēsu* — to speak

Writing: ூ — copy what you see

Put your pen on ூ and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ூ in the ones that have it

வணக்கம்

- *Trace it:* ூ three times, saying *u* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ூ once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ூ? What vowel does it put on the consonant it attaches to — and what does it take off? (**Puts *u* on; takes the built-in *a* off.**) Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 18

Telling Time

Modes: 🗣️ voice (2) ✍️ pen (3) 📞 Hands-free start: first 1 of 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can tell the time on the hour in Tamil and keep the hour-word மணி apart from the unrelated Sanskrit gem-word spelled exactly the same way.

Say oru maṇi and iraṇṭu maṇi for one and two o'clock, then choose hour or gem by the context the word sits in.

18.1 மணி — Tamil’s native “bell,” and a real homophone trap

You’ve just watched Kannada and Telugu both borrow Sanskrit’s “bell” word for “hour,” matching Hindi exactly. Tamil goes its own way again here — with a genuinely tricky twist along the way.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

மணி (*maṇi*) = “hour, o’clock” — and it also means “bell, gong,” the same double duty you’ve now seen several times. Wiktionary’s Tamil entry gives this *maṇi* its **own etymology**, separate from a Sanskrit-loan entry of the same spelling — most likely a **native Dravidian** word, not the Sanskrit घण्टा (*ghaṇṭā*) behind Kannada’s *gaṇṭe*, Telugu’s *gaṇṭa*, and Hindi’s *ghaṇṭā*. On this account, Tamil underwent the **same** “a bell announces the hour, so the bell-word becomes the hour-word” shift on its own, from a different starting point

— though even the comparative Dravidian dictionary (DEDR) flags a possible Sanskrit connection for this whole word-family as unresolved, so hold “native” as the best current account rather than a settled fact.

Your turn

- *Say it:* “maṇi” — hour, also “bell” — native, NOT from Sanskrit ghaṇṭā

Before you move on

Is Tamil’s மணி (“hour”) from the same Sanskrit root as Kannada/Telugu/Hindi’s hour-words? (**Most likely no** — it’s treated as a native Dravidian “bell” word that independently reached “hour” the same way, though even DEDR flags this as not fully settled.) What semantic path links the meanings? (A **bell announces the hour.**) Next: writing இல்லை — a second independent vowel, ல, and the ai sign.

18.2 ெ — the dot that takes the vowel away

Not a letter this time — a mark that changes the letter under it.

Script you’ll notice: ெ

Every Tamil consonant you have written so far carries a hidden *a*. வ is not *v*, it is **va**. ட is **ma**. That is what an abugida is: the vowel is built in.

The pulli is how you take it back. One dot above the letter, and வ becomes plain **v**.

Here is what Tamil does that Devanagari does not: **the dot stays visible and both letters keep their full shape**. Devanagari fuses two consonants into a single new conjunct you have to learn separately. Tamil just writes the dot. There is nothing extra to memorise.

Where it sits: a DOT written above the letter, removing the inherent vowel; unlike Devanagari’s virama it does not trigger a conjunct — both letters keep their full shape and the dot stays visible

Writing: ஃ

With this you can write வணக்கம் — every letter, in order:

வ + ண + க + ஃ + க + ட + ஃ

Seven marks on the page, and you have written *hello*.

Your turn

- *Trace it:* the mark on a letter you already know
- *Say it:* the letter's sound with the mark, then without it
- *Write it:* the whole word above, one mark at a time

Before you move on

What does the pulli do? (**Removes the built-in vowel.**) What is வ with a pulli? (வ், not *va.*) What does Tamil NOT do that Devanagari does? (**Fuse the letters into a new shape.**)

18.3 இல்லை — a vowel in front, a vowel sign behind

Last lesson gave you the rule: a word opening on a vowel opens with a full letter. Here is the same rule with a different vowel, plus one new sign.

Script you'll notice: இ and ல

இ is the independent letter for short *i* — the same job ஆ did, one vowel over. Its parts, in writing order:

1. a crossing spiral on the left
2. a tall straight vertical on the right

ல is *la*, with its built-in *a* like every consonant:

1. a curl that turns back on itself
2. a stroke rising to the right

Put the pulli on it and you get ல், a bare *l*.

The new mark is ை, the sign for *ai*, and it does something ி did not.

It is written to the LEFT of its consonant, but pronounced after it.

ல + ை → லை, and on the page the hook stands *before* the
ல — yet you say *lai*, not *ail*.

Your eye meets the vowel first and your mouth says it second. Devanagari does the same thing with ि, and it catches everyone once.

Tamil keeps **three** *l*-letters (ல ள ழ) and **two** *r*-letters (ர ற),
the same way it keeps three *n*'s. This is the first of the *l*'s.

Script you'll notice: build the word

piece

இ	<i>i</i>	independent — the word opens on a vowel
ல்	<i>l</i> — ல with the pulli	bare consonant
லை	<i>lai</i> — ல with the ai sign	this lesson

இ · ல் · லை → இல்லை

The ல் + லை is a doubled *l*, held like the க் of *vanakkam*: *il-lai*, not *ilai*.

Your turn

- *Write it:* இ — spiral, then the right-hand vertical
- *Write it:* ல — curl, then rising stroke
- *Write it:* லை — the ai hook goes on the LEFT
- *Write it:* இல்லை — three pieces
- *Say it:* “il-lai” — hold the doubled *l*

Before you move on

Write இல்லை. Why does it open with இ rather than a sign?
(**The word starts on a vowel.**) Which side of its consonant does
ஈ sit on? (**The left** — written first, spoken second.) Next: the
gem-word homophone, and telling clock time.

18.4 மணி — hour or jewel? Context decides

The likely native bell/hour word shares its spelling and sound with a clear Sanskrit loan meaning something entirely different.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Tamil dictionaries list a second மணி from Sanskrit मणि (*maṇi*), “gem, jewel.” On that analysis, bell/hour and gem are **homophones**: one likely native, one borrowed, identical on the page. Context separates clock time from a jewel or personal name.

Malayalam dictionaries analyze their cognate differently, treating bell/hour and gem as one Sanskrit-derived word. Closely related languages do not always settle the same etymological question in the same way.

Grammar Lens: Tell the time

ஒரு மணி. — one o’clock, literally “one hour/bell”

>

இரண்டு மணி. — two o’clock

The number comes first; *maṇi* supplies the clock unit.

Your turn

- *Say it*: “oru maṇi” — one o’clock
- *Say it*: “iraṇṭu maṇi” — two o’clock
- *Choose by context*: clock → hour · jewelry/name → gem

Before you move on

What is the homophone trap? (A likely separate Sanskrit-borrowed மணி means **gem**.) Does Malayalam analyze the same forms identically? (**No**.) How do you say two o’clock? (இரண்டு மணி, *iraṇṭu maṇi*.)

18.5 த — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ூ — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you'll notice: த

த — *ta*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *t*, it is **ta**.

You already say these, and every one of them has த somewhere inside it:

- மீண்டும் சந்திப்போம் *mīṇḍum sandippōm* — we'll meet again
- தமிழ் எழுத்து *tamiḷ eluttu* — why Tamil writing is so round
- நான் தமிழ் பேசுகிறேன் *nān tamiḷ pēsugirēn* — I speak Tamil
- எனக்குத் தமிழ் தெரியும் *enakkut tamiḷ teriyum* — 'I know Tamil'

Writing: த — copy what you see

Put your pen on த and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find த in the ones that have it
வணக்கம்
- *Trace it:* த three times, saying *ta* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find த once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — **ḡ**? What sound does it carry? (**ta.**)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 19

Asking Someone's Age

Modes: 🗣️ voice (2) ✍️ pen (3) 🗣️ Hands-free start: first 2 of 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can ask someone's age in both the casual possessive shape and the formal dative-plus-become shape, and answer with my own.

Ask “un vayasu enna?” casually, ask “unakku ettanai vayathu aakirathu?” formally, and answer “enakku irupathu vayathu aakirathu.”

19.1 உனக்கு எத்தனை வயது ஆகிறது? — Tamil actually has BOTH shapes

Same Sanskrit word one more time — but be careful here: Tamil isn't locked into just one of the two grammatical shapes you've now seen. It has both, in different registers.

You'll want to know: வயது — the same Sanskrit “vigor/age” word, a fourth time

வயது (*vayathu*) = “age” — the same Sanskrit वयस् (*vayas*, “age, vigor,” PIE cousin of Latin *vīs*) you've now met four times across Kannada, Telugu, Malayalam, and Tamil. All four Dravidian languages borrowed this exact Sanskrit word for “age” — none of them built a native alternative for this particular concept, the way they did for so many others.

Your turn

- *Say it:* “vayathu” — age
- *Connect:* Sanskrit *vayas* · Tamil *vayathu* · Latin *vīs*

Before you move on

Is Tamil’s வயது the same Sanskrit word borrowed by all four Dravidian languages here? (**Yes** — none built a native alternative for this concept.) What did *vayas* originally include besides age? (**Vigor.**) Next: choose between Tamil’s casual possessive and formal dative-plus-become shapes.

19.2 Your age what? / To you how many years becomes?

Tamil did not choose one age construction. Register selects between two shapes already visible elsewhere in the family.

Grammar Lens: Casual possessive

உன் வயசு என்ன? — “your age what?”

Casual speech uses a plain possessive with no dative and no verb, like Kannada and Telugu.

Grammar Lens: Formal dative plus “become”

உனக்கு எத்தனை வயது ஆகிறது? — “to you how many years is becoming?”

>

எனக்கு இருபது வயது ஆகிறது. — “to me twenty years is becoming.”

Formal/written Tamil uses the dative experiencer plus ஆகிறது (*aakirathu*, “is becoming,” from *aaku*). Malayalam uses a similar dative shape but chooses “exists” instead.

Do not compress these into “Tamil’s one grammar.” Both live in the language; setting and register choose between them.

Your turn

- *Say it:* “un vayasu enna?” — casual
- *Say it:* “unakku ettanai vayathu aakirathu?” — formal
- *Answer:* “enakku irupathu vayathu aakirathu”

Before you move on

Which shape is casual? (**Possessive:** “your age what?”) Which is formal? (**Dative** + **aakirathu**, “become.”) Does Malayalam use the same verb? (**No** — it uses “exists.”)

19.3 ി — the first vowel sign

Not a letter this time — a mark that changes the letter under it.

Script you’ll notice: ി

A consonant carries *a*. To make it carry a different vowel you add a **sign** — and the sign replaces the built-in vowel rather than sitting beside it.

The i-sign is a hook written above and to the right. റ is ra; റി is ri.

Where it sits: a hook written above and to the right of the consonant

Writing: ി

And with that: நன்றി.

ந + ன + ூ + ர + ி

Thank you — the second word you can write.

Your turn

- *Trace it:* the mark on a letter you already know
- *Say it:* the letter’s sound with the mark, then without it
- *Write it:* the whole word above, one mark at a time

Before you move on

Does a vowel sign add a vowel or replace one? (**Replace** — the built-in *a* is gone.) What is ற with an i-sign? (**ri**.)

19.4 ஈரி — one letter, several sounds

You have seen க cover *k*, *g* and a soft *h* depending on where it sits. Here is the same economy on a second letter.

Script you'll notice: ஈ and ர

ஈ is written once and does the work English splits between **s**, **ch** and **j**. Position picks which:

where	sound
starting a word	<i>s</i> or <i>ch</i>
between vowels	softened
after a nasal, as in ஞஈ	<i>j</i>

That is exactly the pattern க showed — *k* at the start, *g* after a nasal, a soft *h* between vowels. One letter per position of the mouth, and context fills in the rest.

ர is *ra*, with its built-in *a*. It is the other of Tamil's **two** *r*-letters, alongside the ற you met in நன்றி.

Read both letters here; do not draw them yet. This book gives a stroke order only where it has a sourced one, and ஈ and ர do not have one yet.

Script you'll notice: build the word

piece		
ஈ	<i>sa</i> here	this lesson
ரி	<i>ri</i> — ர with the ி sign	the sign from நன்றி

ஈ · ரி → ஈரி

Two pieces, and both parts are things you already hold: a consonant, and the vowel sign you first hooked onto ற.

Your turn

- *Read it:* ச — then சரி
- *Say it:* “sari”
- *Contrast:* ரி and லை — the ி sign follows its letter, the ை sign precedes it
- *Write it:* ஆம் and இல்லை again, from memory — yes and no, the two you will reach for most

Before you move on

Read சரி. Which English sounds does ச cover on its own? (*s* or *ch* at the start, softened between vowels, *j* after a nasal.) How many *r*-letters does Tamil keep? (**Two** — ர and ற.) In லை, which side of the ல does the ai sign sit on? (**The left.**) And why does இல்லை open with இ rather than a sign? (**It starts on a vowel.**) Next: the numbers eleven to twenty.

19.5 ே — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: த — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: ே

ே — ē.

It is a **vowel sign**. It is not a letter and never stands alone: it attaches to a consonant and **replaces** the *a* built into it with ē. Replaces, not adds — the *a* is gone.

You already say these, and every one of them has ே somewhere inside it:

- போய் வருகிறேன் *pōy varugirēn* — goodbye (lit. “I’ll go and come back”)
- பேசு *pēsu* — to speak

- நான் தமிழ் பேசுகிறேன் *nān tamīl pēsugirēn* — I speak Tamil
- வேலை செய் *vēlai sey* — to work (lit. “work-do”)

Writing: ே — copy what you see

Put your pen on ே and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ே in the ones that have it
- பேசு · வணக்கம்
- *Trace it:* ே three times, saying ē as you finish each one
 - *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ே once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ே? What vowel does it put on the consonant it attaches to — and what does it take off? (**Puts ē on; takes the built-in a off.**) Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 20

Numbers Eleven to Twenty and Weather

Modes:  voice (2)  pen (1)  Hands-free start: first 2 of 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can count eleven to twenty as the transparent compounds they are, and say what the weather is doing.

Take vānilai apart into vānam plus nilai, then report the weather with mazhai peykiRathu.

20.1 பதினொன்று-இருபது — shared Dravidian patterns

Here's how this arc closes: four completely different approaches to “twenty” across Sanskrit, Latin, Arabic — and then all four Dravidian languages quietly agreeing on the exact same compositional idea.

You'll want to know: பதினொன்று-பத்தொன்பது — “ten” + digit

Tamil's teens echo பத்து (*pathu*, “ten”) plus each digit — பதினொன்று (*patinondru*, 11), பன்னிரண்டு (*pannirandu*, 12), and onward through பத்தொன்பது (*pattonbatu*, 19) — the same digit-plus- ten-echo compounding you've now seen across Kannada, Telugu, and Malayalam.

You'll want to know: இருபது — transparently “two-tens”

இருபது (*irupathu*, “**twenty**”) = இரு (*iru*, an older word for “**two**,” alongside the everyday இரண்டு *iraṇḍu*) + பத்து (*pathu*, “**ten**”) — fully transparent as “**two-tens**,” matching Malayalam’s own *irupathu* almost letter-for-letter.

Why it’s said this way

This closes the numbers arc with a genuinely clean pattern. All four major Dravidian languages build “twenty” the **same** compositional way — some (Tamil, Malayalam) keeping it fully transparent on the surface today, some (Kannada) with the same compositional origin but no longer visibly matching the modern standalone words for “two” and “ten,” some (Telugu) worn down further but most likely from the same root. Compare that to the other three families you’ve met: Sanskrit’s विंशति (*vimshati*), Latin’s *vīgintī*, and Arabic’s عشرون (*‘ishrūn*) are each their **own** special, non-compositional word for twenty — none built transparently from “two” and “ten” the way Tamil, Telugu, Kannada, and Malayalam all do.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “patinondru, panniraṇḍu” — 11, 12
- “iru” — an older word for two, “pathu” — ten
- “irupathu” — twenty, “two-tens,” transparent

Before you move on

What two pieces build இருபது (twenty)? (இரு “two” + பத்து “ten” — “**two-tens**.”) Do all four major Dravidian languages build “twenty” the same compositional way? (**Yes** — Tamil and Malayalam keep it fully transparent today; Kannada shares the same compositional origin but its modern “two”/“ten” words no longer visibly match; Telugu’s is worn down further but most likely the same root.) Do Sanskrit, Latin, or Arabic build their word for twenty this way? (**No** — each has its own special, non-compositional standalone word instead.)

20.2 வானிலை — “the standing of the sky,” most likely all native

You’ve now seen a Persian+Sanskrit hybrid (Kannada), a pure Sanskrit compound (Telugu), and a Sanskrit compound echoing “time” (Malayalam). Tamil most likely breaks the pattern one more time — with a word built entirely from native pieces.

You’ll want to know: வானிலை — vaanam + nilai

வானிலை (*vāṇilai*) = “**weather**” — built from:

- வானம் (*vāṇam*, “**sky**”) — most likely a **native Dravidian** word, with confirmed cognates in **Kannada** ಬಾಸು (*bānu*, “sky”) and **Telugu** వాన (*vāna*, “rain,” from the same sky/rain-cloud root) — distinct from the Sanskrit sky word *ākāśa* that those same two languages use elsewhere.
- நிலை (*ṇilai*, “**state, standing, condition**”) — from நில் (*ṇil*, “**to stand**”), one of Tamil’s most basic native verb roots.

So *vāṇilai* literally means “**the standing of the sky**” or “**the sky’s state**” — and unlike its three Dravidian cousins, neither piece here is a Sanskrit or Persian/Arabic loan. (Treat “native” as the best current account rather than a fully settled fact, the same hedge every native-word claim here deserves — but both pieces are independently well-attested as old, native Dravidian vocabulary.)

You’ll want to know: மழை பெய்கிறது — “rain is falling”

மழை பெய்கிறது. — “It’s raining.” — literally “**rain is falling**.” (*mazhai peykiRathu* — from பெய் *pey*, “to fall/pour,” specifically used for rain.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “vāṇilai” — weather, “the standing of the sky”
- “vāṇam” — sky, “ṇilai” — state, from “ṇil,” to stand
- “mazhai peykiRathu” — it’s raining, “rain is falling”

Before you move on

What are the two pieces of வானிலை, and what does the whole word literally mean? (வானம், “sky,” + நிலை, “state/standing” — “**the standing of the sky**.”) Is either piece a Sanskrit or Persian/Arabic loan, unlike Kannada, Telugu, or Malayalam’s weather words? (**Most likely not** — both pieces are native Dravidian.) What Tamil word does Malayalam’s *mazha* match for “rain”? (மழை, *mazhai*.)

20.3 ய — one character, met inside words you already say

Before the new one: ே — what does it do?

One character this time. Just one — and you have been saying it for pages without knowing which mark on the page it was.

Script you’ll notice: ய

ய — *ya*.

It is a **consonant**, and in this script a consonant is never bare: it comes with an *a* already in it. So it is not *y*, it is **ya**.

You already say these, and every one of them has ய somewhere inside it:

- பெயர் *peyar* — name
- என் பெயர் ... *en peyar* ... — my name is... (with no “is”)
- பரவாயில்லை *paravāyillai* — it’s okay / no problem / you’re welcome
- போய் வருகிறேன் *pōy varugirēn* — goodbye (lit. “I’ll go and come back”)

Writing: ய — copy what you see

Put your pen on ய and follow its line. Copy the shape you can see — slowly, and larger than it is printed.

This book does not yet tell you **where to start the character or which way to travel**. That is a real thing, taught with real variation from school to school, and it is not written down here until it can be written down with a source. Copying what is in front of you needs no such source, and it is how the shape gets into your hand in the meantime.

Your turn

- *Look:* at these words, and find ய in the ones that have it

பெயர் · வணக்கம்

- *Trace it:* ய three times, saying *ya* as you finish each one
- *Look:* back at any page of this chapter and find ய once more

Before you move on

Which character is this — ய? What sound does it carry? (*ya*.)
Name one word you already say that contains it.

Chapter 21

Dog and Cat

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ✍ pen (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: first 1 of 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say dog and cat in Tamil and say which of the two rests on an undisputed Dravidian root and which sits inside a three-way family split.

Say nāy and pūnai, then place Kannada’s bekku and Telugu’s pilli as two other roots entirely rather than variants of the same word.

21.1 நாய், புனை — solid ground to close the arc, and an honest three-way split

This whole ANIMALS arc kept finding mystery dog-words — Spanish’s *perro*, English’s *dog*, Hindi’s *kuttā*, each one an unsolved puzzle displacing an older, expected word. Tamil’s dog-word closes the arc on the complete opposite footing: total, undisputed solid ground.

You’ll want to know: நாய் — no mystery, anywhere

நாய் (*nāy*, “dog”) is a solid, native **Proto-Dravidian** root — the exact same one behind Kannada’s ನಾಯಿ (*nāyi*) and Malayalam’s നായ (*nāya*). There is no debate about its origin, no substrate mystery, nothing like the *perro/dog/kuttā* pattern that ran through Spanish, English, and Hindi. Three unrelated language families each lost their expected word for “dog” to an unexplained newcomer — and right here, in the Dravidian family, the expected word simply **survived**, plainly and solidly, across (at least) three of its languages.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

பூனை (*pūnai*, “cat”) is Tamil’s own everyday word, matching Malayalam’s പൂച്ച (*pūcha*) closely — but be honest that “cat” splits Dravidian in a way “dog” doesn’t. Kannada’s everyday word, ಬೆಕ್ಕು (*bekku*), comes from a **different** ancient root (related to the word for “wildcat”); Telugu’s, పిల్లి (*pilli*), comes from yet **another** separate Proto-Dravidian root, most likely the very source behind Sanskrit’s *bidāla* and Hindi’s *billi*. Tamil itself even keeps **rarer, alternate** cat-words — பில்லி and வெருகு — cognate with Telugu’s and Kannada’s everyday choices respectively, showing that all three roots were once available across the family; each language just settled on a different one as its everyday word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “nāy” — dog, solid native Dravidian, no mystery anywhere
- “pūnai” — cat, Tamil’s everyday word, matching Malayalam
- the honest split — Kannada’s *bekku* and Telugu’s *pilli* come from two other, separate ancient roots

Before you move on

Is நாய் a mystery word, like Spanish’s *perro*, English’s *dog*, or Hindi’s *kuttā*? (**No** — a solid, undisputed native Dravidian root, shared with Kannada and Malayalam.) Does பூனை share a root with Kannada’s *bekku* or Telugu’s *pilli*? (**No** — all three are genuinely separate ancient Dravidian roots; Tamil even keeps rarer alternate cat-words, *pilli* and *veruku*, echoing both of them.) Which Dravidian cat-word is most likely the source of Sanskrit’s *bidāla* and Hindi’s *billi*? (**Telugu’s pilli.**)

21.2 என் — the third vowel that opens a word

You know the rule already: a Tamil word that opens on a vowel opens with a **full vowel letter**, never a sign. You have seen it

twice — ஆ in *ām*, இ in *illai*. Here is the third, in a word you have been saying since chapter 2.

Script you’ll notice: எ

எ is the independent letter for short *e*. Same job as ஆ and இ, one more vowel along.

ஆ	opens <i>ām</i>
இ	opens <i>illai</i>
எ	opens <i>en</i>

Three words, three different vowels, one rule doing the work each time. That is what makes the rule worth having: you did not need to be told about எ separately, only that word-initial vowels get a full letter.

Read எ; do not draw it yet. This book gives a stroke order only where it has a sourced one, and எ does not have one yet.

Script you’ll notice: build the word

piece

எ	<i>e</i>	independent — the word opens on a vowel
ன்	bare <i>n</i> — ன under a pulli	the alveolar <i>n</i> , from நன்றி

எ • ன் → என்

Two pieces, and you have met both halves before: the alveolar ன is the middle one of Tamil’s three *n*’s, and the dot on top is the same pulli that closes வணக்கம்.

Your turn

- *Read it:* எ — then என்
- *Say it:* “en” — “my”
- *Contrast:* ஆம் • இல்லை • என் — three words, three opening vowels

Before you move on

Read என். Why does it open with a full எ rather than a sign? (**The word starts on a vowel** — there is no consonant to hook onto.) Which vowel opens இல்லை? (இ.) What is the dot doing on ன்? (**Removing the built-in a**, leaving a bare n.) Next: green and yellow, and a colour word the whole Dravidian family shares.

Chapter 22

Green and Yellow

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say green and yellow in Tamil, recognise பச்சை as a rarer doublet, and keep the pan-Dravidian root separate from the independent one.

Say பச்சை as the pan-Dravidian green, மஞ்சள் as a separate native yellow, and பச்சை as the rarer doublet beside them.

22.1 பச்சை, மஞ்சள் — closing the Dravidian arc, holding both patterns at once

You’ve now seen three different Dravidian answers to “how do green and yellow relate”: Kannada split them apart, Telugu fused them into one root, Malayalam kept them as two separate native words. Tamil, it turns out, quietly contains a trace of **both** of the last two patterns.

You’ll want to know: பச்சை — the familiar pan-Dravidian green

பச்சை (paccai, “green”) ← Proto-Dravidian *pac- — the same root you’ve now met four times: Kannada’s *hasiru*, Telugu’s *pacca*, Malayalam’s *paccha*, and now Tamil’s own *paccai*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

மஞ்சள் (*mañcaḷ*, “yellow, turmeric”) is Tamil’s actual, everyday word for yellow — and it comes from a **completely separate** native Dravidian root, matching Malayalam’s മഞ്ഞ/മഞ്ഞൾ (*mañña/maññaḷ*) closely. Like Malayalam’s pair, this root has no Sanskrit involvement — it sits alongside *paccai*, not descended from it.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The **Tamil Lexicon** also records பசுப்பு (*pacuppu*, “greenish yellow”) — a genuine **doublet** of *paccai* itself, from the same **pac-* root, matching Telugu’s *pasupu* closely. Unlike Telugu, though, this doublet is **not** Tamil’s everyday word for yellow — that job belongs to *mañcaḷ*; *pacuppu* survives mainly as a dictionary-recorded shade word. So Tamil alone holds a trace of **both** patterns at once: a *pac-* doublet sitting quietly in the dictionary (Telugu’s pattern), next to a separate, dominant root doing the everyday work (Malayalam’s pattern). (Note for the Tamil-speaking reviewer: *pacuppu*’s everyday currency is the part I’m least certain of — please confirm whether it’s a word you’d recognize as “greenish yellow,” or whether it reads as archaic/purely literary in the Tamil you’d teach first.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “பச்சை” — green, the pan-Dravidian *pac-* word
- “மஞ்சள்” — yellow, Tamil’s real everyday word, a separate root
- “பசுப்பு” — a rarer doublet of *paccai*, echoing Telugu’s pattern

Before you move on

What is Tamil’s everyday word for yellow, and is it related to **paccai**? (மஞ்சள், *mañcaḷ* — **no**, a completely separate native root, matching Malayalam’s *mañña/maññaḷ*.) What rarer Tamil word **IS** a doublet of *paccai*, from the same *pac-* root? (பசுப்பு, *pacuppu*, “greenish yellow” — echoing Telugu’s *pacca/pasupu* pattern.) Does any one pattern hold across all four major Dravidian

languages? (**No** — Kannada splits native/loan, Telugu fuses one root, Malayalam keeps two separate roots, and Tamil turns out to hold traces of both Telugu's and Malayalam's patterns at once.)

Chapter 23

Day

Modes: 🔄 voice (2) ✍ pen (1) 🔄 Hands-free start: first 2 of 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can use நாள் as the everyday word for day and keep தினம் for the formal compounds where it actually belongs.

Say mūnru nāl for three days and sutantira tinam for Independence Day, classifying each as everyday-native or formal-Sanskrit.

23.1 நாள் (nāl) — “day,” the one this arc’s Dravidian languages didn’t lose

You’ve now seen three Dravidian languages reach for a loanword — Sanskrit, twice, and Persian once — to name their everyday word for “day.” Tamil doesn’t. This lesson is about the one that didn’t.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

நாள் (nāl) — “day” — is native **Dravidian**, from **Proto-Dravidian** **nāl*. You’ve already met it, hiding inside நாளை (nālai, “tomorrow,” Chapter 4). But here’s the honest headline of this lesson: நாள் isn’t a survivor clinging to one narrow sense the way some native Dravidian words are — it is simply Tamil’s **plain, everyday, unmarked** word for counting a day, as ordinary as மூன்று நாள் (mūnru nāl, “three days”).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*nāl*” — “day,” native Dravidian, already met inside “tomorrow”
- “*mūnru nāl*” — three days

Before you move on

Where did you already meet நாள் before this lesson? (Inside நாளை, *nālai*, “tomorrow,” Chapter 4.) Is Tamil’s everyday day-word a loanword? (No — நாள் is native Dravidian.) Is it marginal or literary? (No — it is the plain everyday counting word.) Next: compare the other sisters’ borrowed day-words and Tamil’s formal *tinam*.

23.2 நாள் and தினம் — everyday native, formal borrowed

Nāl is plainly native and everyday. Put that lexical choice beside the other Dravidian tracks.

You’ll want to know: Four everyday day-words

- Kannada **dina** — Sanskrit tatsama
- Telugu **rōju** — Persian loan
- Malayalam **divasam** — Sanskrit tatsama
- Tamil **nāl** — native Dravidian

Tamil is the only one here whose unmarked everyday counting word remains native.

You’ll want to know: Tamil still has தினம்

தினம் (*tinam*) is the same Sanskrit *dina* as Kannada/Malayalam, ultimately from PIE *dyew-*, “shine,” also behind Latin *diēs*. Tamil assigns it formal and compound work: சுதந்திர தினம், “Independence Day,” and தினசரி, “daily.” Casual counting remains *nāl*.

The language did not reject the loan; it gave native and borrowed forms different jobs.

Your turn

- *Say it*: “mūnru nāl” — three days
- *Say it*: “sutantira tinam” — Independence Day
- *Sort*: everyday native · formal/compound Sanskrit

Before you move on

Which track alone keeps a native everyday day-word? (**Tamil**.)
Where does *tinam* appear? (**Formal compounds**.) Is it unrelated to Kannada *dina*? (**No** — it is the same Sanskrit tatsama.)

23.3 ಒಪಯೃ — a sign that waits on the left

One vowel sign you have met does something strange: ಒೃ stands to the **left** of its consonant and is spoken **after** it. That was not a one-off. Here is a second sign with the same habit.

Script you’ll notice: ಒ and ಁ

Two consonants, each carrying its built-in *a* like every other:

ಒ	<i>pa</i>
ಁ	<i>ya</i>

Read both; do not draw them yet. Neither has a sourced stroke order in this book’s script data, so neither gets one here.

Script you’ll notice: the ಌ sign

ಌ is the sign for *e*, and it is written to the **LEFT** of its consonant and pronounced **after it** — exactly what ಒೃ does.

ಒ + ಌ → ಌಒ, and on the page the hook stands *before* the ಒ — yet you say *pe*, not *ep*.

So the left-standing signs are a family, not an exception you have to remember one member at a time. Compare the three vowel signs you now hold:

sign	sound	where it sits
ி	<i>i</i>	above and to the right
ை	<i>ai</i>	to the left , spoken after
ெ	<i>e</i>	to the left , spoken after

Be clear about how well attested each half of that is. The sourced description covers **ை** — “a double hook written *BEFORE* (to the left of) the consonant, though pronounced after it.” There is no such entry for **ெ** yet, so the claim that **ெ** sits on the left is stated from the pattern the two signs share, not from a source for **ெ** itself. It is reliable — this is ordinary Tamil orthography — but it is one step further from the page than the **ை** rule is.

Script you’ll notice: build the word

piece		
பெ	<i>pe</i> — ப with the ெ sign on its left	this lesson
ய	<i>ya</i>	this lesson
ர்	bare <i>r</i> — ர under a pulli	ர from சரி

பெ · ய · ர் → பெயர்

Three pieces for a word you have used since chapter 2 without once needing to read it. That is the point of the order: the word came first, and the letters are catching up to a word you already own.

Your turn

- *Read it:* ப · ய — then பெ — then பெயர்
- *Say it:* “peyar” — “name”
- *Read it:* என் பெயர் — “my name,” both words, straight off the page

- *Contrast:* றி and பெ — the ி sign follows, the ெ sign precedes

Before you move on

Read பெயர். Which side of its consonant does ெ sit on, and when is it spoken? (**The left**, and **after** — like ை.) Name the other left-standing sign you know. (ஈ, as in இல்லை.) Read என் பெயர் and say what it means. (“**My name**” — எ opens on a vowel, ர் closes on a bare *r*.) Next: the word for night.

Chapter 24

Night

Modes: ⇄ voice (2) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can use இரவு for night and இருள் for darkness without collapsing the two, and treat the claim that ராத்திரி is the more colloquial word as a claim still to be tested.

State the source’s rāttiri claim with its hedge intact, set it against native regional usage, and hold iravu and iruḷ apart.

24.1 இரவு (iravu) — “night,” and a register question worth a native speaker’s ear

Last lesson, Tamil’s native day-word had no real competition. This lesson’s honest twist, hedged carefully, is that “night” may not tell the same story — and this is exactly the kind of claim worth checking against your own ear, not just a dictionary’s.

You’ll want to know: இரவு — already standing on its own, inside “midnight”

இரவு (iravu) — “night” — is native **Dravidian**, from **Proto-Dravidian** **cira* (“darkness”). You’ve technically already met it standing fully on its own: Chapter 17, while explaining நள்ளிரவு (*nalliravu*, “midnight,” நள் + இரவு), noted directly that இரவு itself is a word every Tamil speaker still uses on its own. This lesson gives it its own full chapter.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Tamil also keeps ராத்திரி (*rāttiri*), a Sanskrit **tatsama** from रात्रि (*rātri*) — the same word that surfaces, as a tatsama, in Kannada’s *ratri* and Telugu’s *ratri*. It traces to **Proto-Indo-European** **h₁reh₁-* (“to rest”), a **completely different** root from Latin *nox*’s **nók^wts* — the same specific comparison already drawn for Hindi’s *raat* and Malayalam’s *rāthri*, now a third confirmation, same false-cognate pattern, same honest non-relationship to *nox*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “iravu” — “night,” native, already met inside *nalliravu*
- “rāttiri” — Sanskrit loan, same PIE *h₁reh₁-* already drawn for Hindi and Malayalam, *NOT* related to Latin *nox*

Before you move on

Where did you already meet இரவு before this lesson? (Inside நள்ளிரவு, *nalliravu*, “midnight,” Chapter 17.) Does ராத்திரி’s PIE root match Latin *nox*’s? (No — **h₁reh₁-* “to rest,” the same false-cognate pattern already drawn for Hindi and Malayalam.) Next: treat the proposed register split as a hypothesis and keep “darkness” separate from “night.”

24.2 Night words — a register hypothesis and a semantic boundary

Iravu is native and *rāttiri* borrowed. That alone does not tell you which one conversational Tamil prefers.

Why it’s said this way

At least one dictionary says ராத்திரி is more common colloquially, implying native இரவு may lean literary/written. If accurate, this reverses the day story, where native *nāl* is uncontested everyday speech. But the evidence is limited and dictionary-level. Treat this as a

prompt for a native speaker’s ear, not settled fact. Register judgments require real usage, region, and setting—not a purity assumption about native versus borrowed words.

You’ll want to know: Darkness is a different word

இருள் (*irul*) means **darkness**, from Proto-Dravidian *cirVl* and cognate with Kannada, Telugu, and Malayalam forms. It is not *iravu* “night as a time period” and comes from a different reconstructed root despite the similar sound.

Your turn

- *Qualify*: “one source says *rāttiri* is more colloquial”
- *Ask*: compare that claim with native regional usage
- *Contrast*: *iravu* night · *irul* darkness

Before you move on

Is the *rāttiri* register claim settled? (**No** — limited sourcing, worth checking against native usage.) Is இருள் interchangeable with இரவு? (**No** — darkness versus a time period, from different roots.)

Chapter 25

Good Night

Modes:  voice (2)  pen (1)  Hands-free start: first 1 of 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say good night in Tamil out of roots I already own, and trace every one of those forms back to நல்.

Say nalla iravu and iravu vaṇakkam, then run nal- forward into nalam, nan̄ri and nalla.

25.1 இனிய இரவு (iniya iravu) — “good night,” and Tamil breaking the pattern one more time

Hindi, Kannada, Telugu, and Malayalam all reached for the same Sanskrit phrase to say “good night.” This lesson closes the arc with the one that didn’t — and it’s a pattern you’ve actually seen from Tamil before, all the way back in Chapter 1.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

இனிய இரவு (iniya iravu) — “good night” — literally “sweet, pleasant night.” இனிய (iniya, “sweet, pleasant, dear”) is native Dravidian, from Proto-Dravidian **in-* (“sweet”) — the same root behind இனிப்பு (inippu, “sweet, dessert”). Paired with இரவு (iravu, “night,” already met last lesson), the whole phrase is built from Tamil’s own word-stock, start to finish.

Why it's said this way

Tamil's Dravidian sisters and Hindi all reached for the **same** Sanskrit phrase: Hindi's शुभ रात्रि, Kannada's ಶುಭ ರಾತ್ರಿ, Telugu's శుభ రాత్రి, Malayalam's ശുഭ രാത്രി — all four built from the identical tatsama pair, **śubh** (“to be beautiful”) + **rātri** (“night”). Tamil's standard phrase reaches for **none** of that — no śubha-descended “good night” turned up as a commonly used Tamil form in the phrasebook sources checked for this lesson. Instead, Tamil built its own phrase from its own vocabulary.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*iniya iravu*” — “good night,” literally “sweet night,” fully native
- the pattern it breaks — every other language this arc shares one Sanskrit śubh(a) rātri phrase; Tamil doesn't

Before you move on

What does இனிய இரவு literally mean, and what root does இனிய come from? (“**Sweet/pleasant night**” — Proto-Dravidian *in-*, “sweet.”) Does Tamil's “good night” share the same Sanskrit śubha rātri phrase as Hindi, Kannada, Telugu, and Malayalam? (**No** — no such form turned up in the sources checked for this lesson; Tamil's standard phrase is fully native, breaking the pattern shared by all four other languages.) Next: the ா sign, and reading நான் off the page.

25.2 நான் — the sign that stands after

Two places a vowel sign has sat so far: ீ goes above and to the right, ு and ூ go to the left. Here is the third place, and it is the one you would have guessed first.

Script you'll notice: the ா sign

ா is the sign for long *ā*, and this book's script data describes it plainly: **a vertical stroke with a small top hook, written after the consonant.**

ம + ா → மா, said *mā*.

That pairing is the example the data itself gives, on a letter you can already draw.

So the three positions, all seen now:

sign	sound	where it sits
ா	<i>ā</i>	after the consonant
ி	<i>i</i>	above and to the right
ை	<i>ai</i>	to the left, spoken after
ெ	<i>e</i>	to the left, spoken after

Notice also that ஆ, the independent long *ā* that opens a word, and ா, the sign, carry the same lengthening. One is a letter standing on its own; the other hangs off a consonant.

Script you'll notice: build the word

piece		
நா	<i>nā</i> — ந with the ா sign after it	ந drawn in நன்றி
ன்	bare <i>n</i> — ன under a pulli	ன drawn there too, the alveolar <i>n</i>

நா · ன் → நான்

Two pieces and one new mark. நான் is “I,” and its possessive is the என் (“my”) you read in chapter 21 — so *nān* and *en* now both come off the page.

Your turn

- *Read it:* மா — then நா — then நான்
- *Say it:* “nān” — “I”
- *Contrast:* நா · றி · பெ — a sign after, a sign above-right, a sign before
- *Contrast:* ஆம் and நான் — the same long *ā*, once as a letter and once as a sign

Before you move on

Read நான். Where does ா sit relative to its consonant? (**After it** — a vertical stroke with a small top hook.) Which of Tamil’s three *n*-letters closes the word, and what is the dot doing? (ன, the alveolar one; the pulli **removes its built-in a.**) Next: good night, out of roots you already own.

25.3 நல்ல இரவு and இரவு வணக்கம் — old roots recombined

Tamil’s native “sweet night” repeats the lexical choice that opened this book: build greetings from its own roots rather than the shared Sanskrit formula.

You’ll want to know: The Chapter 1 echo

வணக்கம் comes from native *vaṇaṅku*, “bow,” while neighboring greetings use Sanskrit *namas-*. At the other end of the day, இனிய இரவு is native while the same neighbors share Sanskrit *śubha rātri*.

Tamil also keeps two transparent alternatives:

- நல்ல இரவு — “good night,” using *nalla*, from the **nal-** “good” root already inside *naḷam* and *naṇri*
- இரவு வணக்கம் — “night greetings,” especially for close friends/family, recombining two fully known words

The learner does not memorize isolated formulas; known roots generate options.

Your turn

- *Say it*: “nalla iravu” — good night
- *Say it*: “iravu vaṇakkam” — night greetings
- *Trace it*: *nal-* → *naḷam* / *naṇri* / *nalla*

Before you move on

Which root builds நல்ல? (**Nal-**, good.) What two known words make இரவு வணக்கம்? (**Night + greetings.**) What lexical pattern connects Chapter 1 and this chapter? (**Tamil keeps native greeting roots where neighbors share Sanskrit formulas.**)

Chapter 26

Morning

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can say காலை for morning and state accurately that its origin is uncertain, rather than asserting a Sanskrit source the dictionary itself only hedges at.

Say kālai, repeat the source’s own “possibly” instead of dropping it, and read atikaalai as a transparent ati- plus kālai compound.

26.1 காலை (kālai) — “morning,” an honestly uncertain etymology

Tamil’s neighbours each had a confidently-sourced story for their “morning” word — Sanskrit, or clearly native. Tamil’s own word for morning is different: even Wiktionary itself isn’t sure where it comes from.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

காலை (kālai) — “morning” — has an etymology that Wiktionary itself only hedges at: “possibly from Sanskrit काल्य (kālya).” That’s a real hedge from the source itself, not one this lesson is adding for caution’s sake. Complicating things further: the related word கால் (kāl) carries **six** entirely distinct etymologies in Tamil — “leg/foot,” “irrigation channel,” “forest,” “wind,” a Sanskrit-derived “time” sense, and a conjunction meaning “if, when” — and காலை may be an accusative-type form built on the “time” sense specifically, or may not be. Be honest: this is genuinely **less settled** than Kannada’s

confidently-native morning word or Telugu’s confidently-Sanskrit one. Don’t manufacture certainty the primary source itself doesn’t have.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Wiktionary does confirm one solid fact: பகல் (already met, Chapter 17, “**daytime**”) is listed as காலை’s **coordinate term** — the two words sit side by side in the same semantic field, whatever காலை’s deeper root turns out to be. And அதிகாலை (“**early dawn**”) is confirmed, per the Tamil Lexicon, as a fully transparent compound: **ati-** (“excessive, very”) + காலை, glossed simply as “early dawn” by the Tamil Lexicon.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “kālai” — “morning,” an honestly uncertain etymology
- the hedge itself — Wiktionary says “possibly” Sanskrit kālya, not a confident claim
- “atikaalai” — “early dawn,” a transparent ati- + kālai compound

Before you move on

Is காலை’s etymology as confidently sourced as Kannada’s or Telugu’s morning words? (**No** — Wiktionary itself only says “possibly” Sanskrit kālya; genuinely uncertain, not settled.) What coordinate term does Wiktionary list alongside காலை? (பகல், “daytime,” already met in Chapter 17.) What does அதிகாலை literally build on? (**ati-** (“very”) + காலை — a transparent compound for “early dawn.”)

Chapter 27

Evening

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) ✍️ pen (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: first 1 of 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say மாலை for evening and keep it apart from the identically spelled garland word, which is a separate etymology rather than a second sense.

Say mālai for evening, name the garland mālai as a distinct homonym, and mark the “darkness” link as plausible but not spelled out.

27.1 மாலை (mālai) — “evening,” and a garland that only looks like the same word

Last lesson’s morning word had an uncertain origin. This evening word is different — confidently native — but it comes with its own honest twist: it looks exactly like a completely unrelated word.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

மாலை (mālai) — “evening” — happens to be spelled identically to another, completely **unrelated** Tamil word: மாலை meaning “garland, wreath, necklace.” Wiktionary treats these as **two separate etymologies**, not one word with two senses. The garland sense traces to Old Tamil and is compared to Sanskrit माला (mālā) — with a genuinely interesting note: it’s “**probably borrowed FROM Dravidian languages**” into Sanskrit, not the other way around. A rare reverse-direction loan, worth noticing against this whole project’s

usual Sanskrit-into-Dravidian pattern.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The **evening** sense of மாலை is a **separate** Old Tamil word entirely, compared instead to மால் (*māl*) — which Wiktionary traces to **Proto-Dravidian** **mā/*māl*, with senses including “கருமை” (“**blackness, darkness**”), plus archaic senses of “illusion, confusion” and, as a proper noun, the Hindu deity **Vishnu**. Be honest about the exact mechanism here: Wiktionary’s own etymology for “evening” only says “**compare māl**” — it does **not** explicitly state that “evening” derives specifically from the **darkness** sense rather than some other sense of this multi-meaning root. The connection (evening = the time it grows dark) is natural and plausible, but not nailed down with full certainty by the source itself. What IS certain: this is confidently **native** Dravidian vocabulary, a genuine contrast with TA-C26’s uncertain காலை.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “mālai” — “evening,” confidently native Dravidian vocabulary
- the homonym twist — a completely separate word, mālai, means “garland,” probably borrowed INTO Sanskrit from Dravidian
- the honest hedge — “evening” plausibly connects to māl’s “darkness” sense, but Wiktionary doesn’t spell out that exact link

Before you move on

Are evening-mālai and garland-mālai the same word with two meanings? (**No** — Wiktionary treats them as two entirely separate etymologies; a genuine homonym, not one word stretched.) Which direction did the garland sense’s Sanskrit connection likely travel? (**Dravidian into Sanskrit** — a reverse-direction loan, per Wiktionary’s own “probably borrowed from Dravidian languages” note.) Is it fully certain that “evening” derives from māl’s “darkness” sense specifically? (**No** — plausible and natural, but Wiktionary only says “compare māl,” without spelling out that

exact mechanism.)

27.2 நீங்கள் — two old promises, paid

This book owes you two letters: the nasal in **ங்க**, printed before you knew what it was, and one of the three *l*-letters it promised. Both come due in one word.

Script you’ll notice: **ங** and **ள**

ங	<i>ṅa</i> — the nasal made where க is made, the <i>ng</i> of “sing”
ள	<i>ḷa</i> — the retroflex <i>l</i>

ங is the reason **க** softens: in **ங்க** the nasal comes first — the “after a nasal” rule from your first writing lesson, with a face on it.

ள is the retroflex one of Tamil’s three *l*-letters — **ல ள ழ**. You met **ல** in **இல்லை**; **ழ** still lies ahead. Retroflex: the tongue curls back, as for **ண**.

Read both; do not draw them yet. Neither has an entry in this book’s script data, so neither gets a stroke order. **ள**’s description leans on **ண**’s sourced “tongue curled back”; **ங**’s is this lesson’s own, since the data says nothing about where **க** is made.

Script you’ll notice: the **ீ** sign

ீ is the long partner of the **ி** you hooked onto **ற** in **நன்றி** — the same short/long pairing **அ** and **ஆ** have.

ந + **ீ** → **நீ**, said *nī*, the familiar “you.”

The data describes **ி** and has no entry for **ீ**, so the pairing is stated from the pattern, not from a source.

Script you'll notice: build the word

piece		
நீ	<i>nī</i> — ந with the ī sign	“you,” familiar
ங்	bare <i>ṅ</i> — ங under a pulli	this lesson
க	<i>ka</i> , softened to <i>ga</i> by the nasal in front of it	from வணக்கம்
ள்	bare <i>ḷ</i> — ள under a pulli	this lesson

நீ · ங · க · ள → நீங்கள்

The middle two are the **ங்க** you were shown when **க** was new and **ங்** unreadable. **நீங்கள்** is the respectful “you” — நீ plus a plural ending — so the shorter word sits inside the longer one.

Your turn

- *Read it:* நீ — then ங்க — then நீங்கள்
- *Say it:* “nī” ... “nīṅgaḷ” — familiar, then respectful
- *Contrast:* றி and நீ — the short *i* sign and the long *ī* sign
- *Contrast:* ல and ள — the first two of the three *l*-letters

Before you move on

Read நீங்கள், then find the shorter நீ inside it. Why does the க in the middle sound like *g*? (ங் stands in front of it — a nasal.) How many *l*-letters does Tamil keep, and which is ள? (**Three** — ல ள ழ; the **retroflex** one.) What are the two dots doing? (**Removing the built-in a** from ங and ள.) Next: the afternoon word.

Chapter 28

Afternoon

Modes: ⇄ voice (2) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say பிற்பகல் for afternoon, read it as “after” plus “daytime,” and name exactly where the dictionary’s own noon and afternoon labels overlap.

Show naṭuppakal straddling noon and afternoon, place matiyam as a Sanskrit noon-word, and label the unsourced moon claim unsupported.

28.1 பிற்பகல் (pirpakal) — “afternoon,” a similar sandhi trick to நண்பகல்

You already met a sandhi-driven surface change in Chapter 17 — நள் resurfacing as நண். This lesson’s afternoon word does a similar kind of trick, with a different word — though be honest that the two changes aren’t identical.

You’ll want to know: பிற்பகல் — பின் (after) + பகல் (daytime), a similar sandhi story

பிற்பகல் (pirpakal) — “afternoon” — is a transparent compound: பின் (pin, “after”) plus பகல் (pakal, “daytime,” already met inside நண்பகல், TA-C17 — though be aware the பிற்பகல் Wiktionary page itself glosses பகல் as “noon” in its own etymology line, a small inconsistency across Wiktionary’s own entries, not something this lesson introduces). Here’s the familiar pattern: பின் doesn’t stay பின் in this compound — it surfaces as பிற்ப- before the following ப — a **similar** kind of consonant

sandhi to the one already taught in Chapter 17, where நள் became நண் before its own following ட. Be honest, though: Wiktionary’s own etymology for பிற்பகல் doesn’t discuss this mechanism at all, and the two changes move in different phonetic directions (nasal→stop here, lateral→nasal there) — this is the lesson’s own observation, not a sourced equivalence. Wiktionary labels this word **formal register**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “pirpakal” — “afternoon,” pin (“after”) + pakal (“daytime”)
- the sandhi echo — pin surfaces as pir-, a similar kind of change to TA-C17’s nal→naṇ, though not phonetically identical

Before you move on

What does பிற்பகல் literally build from, and what sandhi change happens to the first piece? (பின் “after” + பகல் “daytime” — பின் surfaces as பிற்-, a similar kind of sandhi to TA-C17’s nal→naṇ, though the two changes move in different phonetic directions, not identical mechanisms.) What register does the fetched page label? (**Formal**.) Next: inspect the real noon/afternoon boundary blur and the separate *matiyam* root.

28.2 Noon or afternoon? — let the sources keep their blur

Pirpakal transparently says after-daytime. Dictionaries still do not draw a perfectly hard semantic boundary around its synonyms.

You’ll want to know: நடுப்பகல் overlaps

Wiktionary’s *pirpakal* page lists நடுப்பகல் as an afternoon synonym, while the earlier noon lesson documents the same word as a synonym of நண்பகல், “noon.” This is genuine noon/afternoon boundary blur, not an inconsistency to erase. Time-period categories can widen differently across speakers and sources.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

மதியம் (*matiyam*) is a Sanskrit tatsama from *madhya*, “middle,” the same root used by Kannada and Telugu. The fetched entry gives it **noon**, a synonym of *naṇpakal*, not a dedicated afternoon meaning. An initial search summary claimed *matiyam* once meant “moon,” but that claim is absent from the actual fetched page. It is therefore **not asserted**. Source inspection outranks a search snippet.

Your turn

- *Say it*: *naṇupakal* can overlap noon and afternoon
- *Say it*: *matiyam* — Sanskrit *madhya*, “middle,” listed as noon
- *Label*: the moon claim unsupported

Before you move on

Does the source draw a hard noon/afternoon line? (**No.**) What is *matiyam*’s sourced root and sense? (Sanskrit *madhya*, “middle,” and **noon**.) Is “originally moon” confirmed? (**No.**)

Chapter 29

Good Morning

Modes:  voice (1)  pen (1)  Hands-free start: first 1 of 2 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can greet someone with காலை வணக்கம் before mid-morning and see it as காலை plus the வணக்கம் I already had, with no borrowed blessing-word in it.

Greet with kālai vaṇakkam from sunrise to about 11, naming its two known pieces and the borrowed word that is absent.

29.1 காலை வணக்கம் — “morning greetings”

Tamil’s neighbours each built “good morning” on a word meaning “good” or “auspicious.” Tamil does something completely different: it just puts its everyday greeting word after its word for “morning.”

You’ll want to know: காலை வணக்கம் — literally, “morning greetings”

காலை வணக்கம் (kālai vaṇakkam) — “good morning” — is confirmed, by two independently-fetched sources, as Tamil’s standard greeting for this time of day, used “**from sunrise until around 11 AM.**” It’s built from two words you already have: காலை (already met, Chapter 26, “morning”) plus வணக்கம் (already met, Chapter 1, “reverence, homage” — Tamil’s everyday word for “hello”). Literally: “morning salutations.”

Why it's said this way

Here's the honest structural surprise: Hindi, Kannada, Telugu, and Malayalam each build their morning greeting on a **śubha**-equivalent word (“good, auspicious”) plus a time-word. Tamil does something genuinely **different** — there's no “good/auspicious” word here at all. It's simply **வணக்கம்**, Tamil's own general greeting, specified with **காலை** in front of it to mean “morning” greetings specifically. Also be honest about a claim that didn't hold up: an initial search summary suggested a Sanskrit-borrowed word, “suprabhatham,” serves as a casual alternative — but that claim appears on **neither** of the two pages actually fetched, so it's deliberately **not** asserted here.

Your turn

- *Say it:* “kālai vaṇakkam” — “good morning,” literally “morning greetings”
- [YOU SAY: the honest structural surprise — no śubha-equivalent word here at all, unlike Tamil's
neighbours]
- *Say it:* the two pieces you already know — kālai (Chapter 26) + vaṇakkam (Chapter 1)

Before you move on

- What two known words build **காலை வணக்கம்**? (**காலை**, “morning” + **வணக்கம்**, “reverence/hello.”)
- Does it follow the śubha-equivalent + time-word pattern used by Hindi, Kannada, Telugu, and Malayalam? (**No** — **காலை** simply specifies Tamil's own general greeting, **வணக்கம்**.)
- Is “suprabhatham” confirmed as a casual alternative? (**No** — neither fetched source supports that claim, so this lesson does not assert it.)

29.2 எப்படி — the retroflex stop

You can read the first word of the question you have been asking since chapter 3. Here is the second, and it needs one new consonant.

Script you'll notice: ட

ட is *ṭa*, the retroflex *t* — the tongue curled back to the roof of the mouth. That is the same curl that makes ண a retroflex *n*, so hold the pair together: ட is that position stopped, ண is that position hummed through the nose.

Between vowels it softens toward *d*, which is why டி in எப்படி is said *dī*. That is the position-picks-the-sound economy க and ச already showed you, now on a third letter.

Read it; do not draw it yet. ட has no entry in this book's script data, so it gets no stroke order — and both claims above are stated from sourced neighbours rather than from ட itself: the retroflex description leans on ண's, and the softening leans on the position-picks-the-sound note the data carries for க.

Script you'll notice: build the word

piece		
எ	<i>e</i>	the question vowel, from என்
ப	bare <i>p</i> — ப under a pulli	ப from பெயர்
ப	<i>pa</i>	the same letter again
டி	<i>dī</i> — ட with the ி sign	this lesson

எ · ப · ப · டி → எப்படி

The doubled ப + ப is held, like the க்க of *vaṇakkam* and the ல் + லை of *illai*. Tamil marks a long consonant by writing it twice, with the pulli on the first.

Your turn

- *Read it:* டி — then எப்படி

- *Say it:* “eppaḍi” — “how”
- *Read it:* நீங்கள் எப்படி — two words of the question, straight off the page

Before you move on

Read எப்படி. Which letter you already knew shares ɽ’s tongue position? (ண — the same curl back, stopped rather than nasal.) How does Tamil write the doubled *p*? (ப் + ப — the letter twice, pulli on the first.) Read நீங்கள் again. Next: good evening.

Chapter 30

Good Evening

Modes: ⇄ voice (1) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 1 lesson.

By the end of this chapter: I can greet someone with மாலை வணக்கம் from late afternoon through nightfall, built on the same two-piece pattern as the morning greeting.

Greet with mālai vaṇakkam, assembling mālai plus vaṇakkam, and note the pattern was re-checked rather than assumed to carry over.

30.1 மாலை வணக்கம் — “evening greetings”

Last chapter’s morning greeting followed its own pattern. This lesson checks whether the evening greeting follows the same one — rather than assuming it automatically does.

You’ll want to know: மாலை வணக்கம் — the same compositional pattern, independently confirmed

மாலை வணக்கம் (mālai vaṇakkam) — “good evening” — is confirmed, by two independently-fetched sources, as a real, standard Tamil evening greeting, used roughly from **afternoon through nightfall** (the two sources give slightly different exact windows — “after noon through evening” versus “late afternoon until nightfall” — a small, unsurprising looseness, matching the noon/afternoon boundary-blur already seen in TA-C28). It’s built exactly the same way as TA-C29’s morning greeting: மாலை (already met, Chapter 27, “evening”) plus வணக்கம் (already met, Chapter 1, Tamil’s general greeting). Literally: “evening salutations.”

Why it's said this way

Here's the honest methodological point: just because TA-C29's morning greeting followed the “time-word + vaṇakkam” pattern doesn't mean this evening greeting was assumed to follow it automatically. This arc has repeatedly found that greeting formation doesn't reliably generalize, even within the very same language — Malayalam's own morning greeting broke from the śubha+time-word pattern its afternoon and evening greetings both share, so “the pattern probably repeats” was never a safe assumption on its own. So this greeting was independently verified via direct fetch before confirming the pattern really does repeat here — and it does, cleanly: no śubha-equivalent word appears in Tamil's evening greeting either, same as the morning one.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “mālai vaṇakkam” — “good evening,” literally “evening greetings”
- the two pieces you already know — mālai (Chapter 27) + vaṇakkam (Chapter 1)
- the honest methodological point — this pattern was re-verified, not assumed to carry over automatically

Before you move on

What two already-known words does மாலை வணக்கம் build from? (மாலை, “evening” + வணக்கம், “greetings.”) Was it assumed that the evening greeting would follow the same pattern as the morning one, or was it independently checked? (**Independently checked** — via direct fetch, not assumed, since this arc has learned that greeting patterns don't reliably generalize.) Does மாலை வணக்கம் use a śubha-equivalent word, like Hindi/Kannada/Telugu/Malayalam's evening greetings do? (**No** — same as Tamil's morning greeting, no śubha-equivalent word appears here either.)

Chapter 31

Good Afternoon

Modes: 🗣️ voice (2) ✍️ pen (1) 🗣️ Hands-free start: first 2 of 3 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can greet someone with மதிய வணக்கம் around midday and say which word the மதிய inside it actually comes from — noon, not afternoon.

Greet with matiya vaṇakkam, trace matiyam back to madhya “middle,” and keep pirpakal as the separate after-plus-daytime word.

31.1 மதிய வணக்கம் (matiya vaṇakkam) — a sourced afternoon greeting

You already know that Tamil’s noon and afternoon boundaries can blur. Now learn one afternoon greeting without pretending that all speakers or teaching sources divide the day in exactly the same way.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

மதிய வணக்கம் (matiya vaṇakkam) — “good afternoon” — is confirmed, by two independently-fetched sources, as Tamil’s afternoon greeting, used roughly “noon to around 4 PM.” A third source, already used for the morning and evening greetings, doesn’t list a distinct afternoon greeting at all — it only covers “before noon” and “after noon through evening,” implicitly treating those two as bookending the whole day. This is an honest extension of TA-C28’s own noon/afternoon boundary-blur into the greeting layer, not a new

problem to worry about.

Use **மதிய வணக்கம்** when that afternoon slot fits the people and setting around you. Treat “noon to 4” as a useful learning window, not as a universal clock rule.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “**matiya vaṇakkam**” — “good afternoon,” confirmed real, used roughly noon to 4 PM
- the honest qualification — one source does not teach a separate afternoon greeting at all

Before you move on

What is one sourced Tamil greeting for “good afternoon”? (**மதிய வணக்கம்**, **matiya vaṇakkam**.) Do all three fetched sources agree on a distinct “afternoon” greeting slot? (**No** — two confirm **மதிய வணக்கம்** directly; a third doesn’t list a separate afternoon greeting at all, treating morning and evening as bookending the day.) What clock window is a useful guide rather than a universal rule? (**Roughly noon to 4 PM.**)

31.2 மதிய — the greeting takes a different root

You can now say **மதிய வணக்கம்**. This final step explains why its first word is not the ordinary afternoon word **பிற்பகல்**.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The greeting begins with **மதிய** (**matiya**). It is the adjectival form of **மதியம்** (**matiyam**), “noon.” That noun entered Tamil from Sanskrit **madhya**, “middle”: noon is the middle of the day.

The adjective **மதிய** can be glossed “of or pertaining to afternoon.” That lets Tamil build **மதிய வணக்கம்** even though the dedicated word you learned for “afternoon” was **பிற்பகல்**, the native compound from **pin** (after) + **pakal** (daytime).

Keep the two paths separate:

- பிற்பகல்: after + daytime → afternoon
- மதிய வணக்கம்: middle/noon adjective + greeting → good afternoon

The time word and the greeting do not have to share a root. That is one more reason not to manufacture a greeting by translating its pieces from another language.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- matiyam — “noon,” ultimately from Sanskrit madhya, “middle”
- pirpakal — “afternoon,” built from “after” + “daytime”
- matiya vaṇakkam — the afternoon greeting, built on matiya

Before you move on

Does மதிய வணக்கம் begin with பிற்பகல்? (No.) What noun is மதிய related to? (மதியம், “noon.”) What older root lies behind it? (Sanskrit madhya, “middle.”) Why should you learn the whole greeting rather than construct it from the time word? (Tamil uses a different root in the greeting.)

31.3 இருக்கிறீர்கள் — the last sign, and the whole question

Two words of the question already come off the page. One vowel sign stands between you and the third.

Script you’ll notice: the ூ sign

ூ is the sign for short *u*. It is not left-standing — but it does not stand beside its letter the way ா does either: it joins on below and to the right, and the pair is usually drawn as one shape.

Careful with “after”: *every* vowel sign is **spoken** after its consonant, ூ and ெ included. The signs differ in where the mark sits, not when you say it.

ர + ூ → ரு, said *ru*.

The script data behind this book carries entries for ா, ி, ை and the pulli, and none for ூ — so everything here, the joined shape included, is this lesson’s own statement of ordinary Tamil, not something it can cite.

Script you’ll notice: build the word

Every piece is now yours:

piece		
இ	<i>i</i>	independent — the word opens on a vowel
ரு	<i>ru</i> — ர with the ூ sign	this lesson
க்	bare <i>k</i>	க under a pulli
கி	<i>ki</i> — க with the ி sign	
றீ	<i>rī</i> — ற with the ீ sign	ற from நன்றி
ர்	bare <i>r</i>	ர from சரி
க	<i>ka</i>	
ள்	bare <i>l</i>	from நீங்கள்

இ · ரு · க் · கி · றீ · ர் · க · ள் → இருக்கிறீர்கள்

And the whole question:

நீங்கள் எப்படி இருக்கிறீர்கள்?

Nothing in it is new to say. You have asked it since chapter 3; the letters took until now to catch up.

Your turn

- *Read it:* ரு — then இருக்கிறீர்கள்
- *Read it:* the whole question — நீங்கள் எப்படி இருக்கிறீர்கள்?
- *Say it:* “nīṅgaḷ eppaḍi irukkiṙīrgaḷ?” — “how are you?”
- *Contrast:* நான் and நீங்கள் — the *I* of the answer, the *you* of the question

Before you move on

Read நீங்கள் எப்படி இருக்கிறீர்கள்? aloud. Is ு written before its consonant or after? (**After** — ை and ெ are the ones written before.) When is a vowel sign *spoken*? (**Always after**, wherever it sits.) Which word did you learn to read first? (நீங்கள்.) Next: the verb இரு on its own.

Chapter 32

The Core Verbs

Modes: ⇄ voice (6) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 6 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can build a Tamil verb as stem plus tense plus person, swap the tense bead for past or future, tell a strong verb from a weak one by its doubled consonant, and say why தெரியும் carries no person at all.

Say எனக்குத் தமிழ் தெரியும், name the three slots that built irukkireṇ, pōgireṇ and pārkkiṇ, and explain which slot தெரியும் leaves empty and where its person went instead.

32.1 இரு (iru) — “to be,” and the machine inside every Tamil verb

Thirty-one chapters of words. Now the engine room. Tamil builds a verb the way you thread beads on a string, and this first verb carries the whole string.

You’ll want to know: இரு

இரு — *iru* — to be, to exist, to stay

It is native Dravidian, from an old root meaning “be, remain, stay put.” Kannada kept the very same word, ಇರು (*iru*), and Malayalam has ഇരിക്കുക (*irikkuka*); Telugu went its own way with ఉండు (*undu*).

Iru is about **existing** or **being somewhere**, not about linking two nouns. Tamil says “I am at home” with *iru*, and says “I am a teacher” with no verb at all, just the two words side by side.

Its everyday first-person form is இருக்கிறேன் (*irukkireṇ*), “I am.” You have already heard it: the question *eppaḍi irukkiriṅgaḷ?* — “how are you?” — is this verb wearing a different ending.

The letters in this word

இ (the standing vowel *i*) + ரு (*ru*) → இரு. Both shapes turned up in இரவு (*iravu*, “night”).

In *irukkireṇ* the க் is held long — *i-ruk-ki*, with a catch in the middle. That length is not decoration; a later lesson turns it into a rule.

Grammar Lens: stem, then tense, then person

English changes a verb by putting words **around** it: *I am, I was, I will be*. Tamil changes it by gluing pieces **onto the end** of it, always in the same order:

இரு + க்கிற + ஏன் → இருக்கிறேன்

>

iru (be) + *-kkir-* (happening now) + *-ēṇ* (I) → *irukkireṇ*

Left to right, the word says **be** — **present** — **I**. Three slots, filled in that order, welded into one word. Languages built this way are called **agglutinative**, from Latin *glutinare*, “to glue.”

Two payoffs arrive at once. The last piece already means “I,” so *nāṇ* is optional. And nothing here belongs to *iru* alone: every verb in this chapter is the same three slots with a new first bead.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “iru” — be, exist, stay
- “irukkireṇ” — I am
- the three beads in order — “iru ... kkir ... ēṇ”

Before you move on

What are the three pieces of *irukkīrēn*, in order? (**Stem, tense, person** — *iru*, *-kkīr-*, *-ēn*.) Which piece carries “I”? (**The last one**, *-ēn* — which is why *nān* can be dropped.) Which sister language kept the same verb? (**Kannada**, *iru*.) Next: the same machine, with the tense bead swapped.

32.2 ூ (pō) — “to go,” and the bead that carries time

You have the three slots — stem, tense, person. Keep the first and last beads still, and swap only the middle one. That is the whole of Tamil tense.

You’ll want to know: ூ

ூ — *pō* — to go

Two letters, ூ (*pa*) with the long-*ō* sign, and a word so old it has barely moved. It is native Dravidian: Telugu పోవు (*pōvu*) and Malayalam പോകുക (*pōkuka*) are the same verb.

Kannada’s everyday word for “go” is ಹೋಗು (*hōgu*) — and that *h* is not a different root. It is the same softening of an old *p* that turned Tamil *pattu* (“ten”) into Kannada *hattu*. One sound-law, met once with numbers, now paying off with a verb.

You met the bare stem in the farewell chapter, where *pō!* is already a whole command: “go!”

Grammar Lens: past, present, future — one bead each

Hold the stem *pō-* and the person-ending *-ēn* (“I”) fixed, and let the middle piece do the work:

when	Tamil	the middle bead
now	<i>pōgīrēn</i>	<i>-gīr-</i>
already	<i>pōnēn</i>	<i>-n-</i>
not yet	<i>pōvēn</i>	<i>-v-</i>

“I go,” “I went,” “I will go” — one syllable of difference, sitting between two pieces that never moved. English needs a new word (*will*)

or a whole new shape (*went*); Tamil needs one bead.
 The tense bead voices to *-gīr-* after a vowel, which is why it sounds like *pō-gī-rēn* here but *iruk-ki-rēn* after the doubled *k* of *iru*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “pō” — go
- the three times — “pōgīrēn ... pōnēn ... pōvēn”
- the pair that shares one sound-law — “pattu ... hattu”, “pō ... hōgu”
- “irukkīrēn” and “pōgīrēn” — one machine, two stems

Before you move on

Which of the three beads changes for tense? (**The middle one.**)
 Say “I will go.” (*Pōvēn*.) Is Kannada’s *hōgu* a different root from *pō*? (**No** — the same old *p* softened to *h*, exactly as in *pattu* and *hattu*.) Next: a verb whose stem refuses to sit still.

32.3 ಎ (vā) — “to come,” and a stem with two shapes

Pō threads its beads on without a fuss. Its partner *vā* does not — and the farewell you learned long ago has been hiding the reason.

You’ll want to know: ಎ

ಎ — *vā* — to come

ಎ (*va*) with the long-*ā* sign, and, like *pō*, a whole command on its own: *vā!*, “come!” Native Dravidian, and the family keeps it: Malayalam വരുക (*varuka*), Kannada ಬಾ (*bā*), Telugu రా (*rā*). Kannada’s *b* and Telugu’s *r* are two regular reshapings of the same old word, not three separate verbs.

Grammar Lens: the word you say it by is not the word you build on

Thread the beads onto *vā-* and you get nothing a Tamil speaker says. The suffixes attach to வரு- (*varu-*) instead:

varu- + *-gir-* + *-ēn* → வருகிறேன் (*varugirēn*), “I come.”

Past: வந்தேன் (*vantēn*), “I came.” Future: வருவேன் (*varuvēn*). So a Tamil verb has a form you **call** it by — the bare command, the form a dictionary lists — and a form the beads actually **attach** to. For most verbs those are the same shape. For a handful of very common ones, of which *vā* is the commonest, they are not, and the pair simply has to be learned together: *vā*, *varu-*.

You have said this word already. The farewell போய் வருகிறேன் (*pōy varugirēn*) — “I go and come back” — is *pō* and *varu-* standing side by side, and that *varugirēn* is the very form above.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the command — “*vā!*”
- the pair that must be learned together — “*vā ... varu-*”
- “*varugirēn ... vantēn ... varuvēn*”
- the farewell you now understand — “*pōy varugirēn*”

Before you move on

What shape do the beads attach to for “come”? (வரு-, *varu-*, not *vā-*.) Say “I come.” (*Varugirēn*.) Which two verbs are standing in *pōy varugirēn*? (போ and வா — go, and come back.) Are Kannada *bā* and Telugu *rā* different verbs? (**No** — the same Dravidian word, reshaped.) Next: a verb Tamil built for itself.

32.4 சாப்பிடு (sāppiḍu) — “to eat,” a verb built out of two words

Iru, *pō*, *vā* — three single syllables inherited whole from the oldest layer of Dravidian. The everyday word for “eat” is nothing of the kind. It was assembled.

You’ll want to know: சாப்பிடு

சாப்பிடு — *sāppiḍu* — to eat

Four beats: *sāp-pi-ḍu*, with the ப் held long, the same doubling you heard in *irukkireṇ*. Threaded up, it is சாப்பிடுகிறேன் (*sāppidugirēṇ*), “I eat” — stem, then *-gir-*, then *-ēṇ*, with no surprises. Past: சாப்பிட்டேன் (*sāppittēṇ*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The word comes apart cleanly into two Tamil words:

- சாப்பு (*sāppu*) — food, a meal; the everyday சாப்பாடு (*sāppāḍu*, “a meal”) is built from it.
- இடு (*iḍu*) — to put, to place.

Put food. That is all *sāppiḍu* literally says. இடு is what grammarians call a **light verb**: a plain, hard-working verb that lends its endings to a noun so the pair can act as one verb. Tamil builds a great many verbs this way, so *iḍu* is worth knowing on its own. (Where *sāppu* itself came from is not settled; treat the compound as transparent and the deeper root as open.)

Then the honest part. The inherited Dravidian word for eating is ***tin-**, and it is thriving next door: Telugu తిను (*tinu*), Kannada ತಿನ್ನು (*tinnu*), Malayalam തിന്നുക (*tinnuka*). Tamil kept it too, as தின் (*tin*) — now narrowed to chewing and snacking — and kept the old literary உண் (*uṇ*), Malayalam’s ഉണ്ണുക (*uṇṇuka*), besides. So Tamil did not lose the ancient eat-verbs. It built a new one and let them keep their smaller jobs.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “sāppiḍu” — eat
- “sāppiḍugirēn” — I eat — then “sāppittēn”, I ate
- the two halves — “sāppu” (food) + “iḍu” (put)
- the inherited root next door — “tinu ... tinnu ... tinnuka”

Before you move on

What two words is *sāppiḍu* made of? (சாப்பிடு, food, and இடு, to put.) What is a light verb doing there? (**Lending its endings** to a noun so the pair works as one verb.) Did Tamil lose the inherited eat-root? (**No** — *tiṇ* narrowed to chewing, *uṇ* stayed literary, and the cousins kept *tinu*, *tinnu*, *tinnuka*.) Next: the verb that splits Tamil’s verbs into two classes.

32.5 பார் (pār) — “to see,” and Tamil’s two kinds of verb

Four verbs in, one small thing has been inconsistent. *Pōgirēn* has a single *k*. *Irukkirēn* has a doubled one. That is not sloppiness — it is a sorting rule, and this verb is where it gets a name.

You’ll want to know: பார்

பார் — *pār* — to see, to watch

ப with the long-*ā* sign, then ர் with a pulli to strip its vowel: *pār*, one syllable ending on the *r*. From it comes the noun பார்வை (*pārvai*), “sight, vision.”

Each Dravidian sister settled on a different everyday word for seeing — Kannada ನೋಡು (*nōḍu*), Telugu చూడు (*cūḍu*), Malayalam കാണുക (*kāṇuka*) — so *pār* is Tamil’s own choice, not the family’s. But the family’s shared root is here too: Tamil keeps காண் (*kāṇ*), “to see,” for formal and literary use, and that is the same word as Malayalam’s *kāṇuka* and Kannada’s ಕಾಣು (*kāṇu*). Four sisters, one inherited root, four everyday preferences.

Grammar Lens: strong verbs and weak verbs

Every Tamil verb belongs to one of two camps, and the tense bead tells you which:

camp	present	past
weak — <i>pō</i>	<i>pōgīrēn</i>	<i>pōnēn</i>
strong — <i>pār</i>	<i>pārkkīrēn</i>	<i>pārttēn</i>

Weak verbs take the tense bead lightly: a single *k*, softened to *g*.

Strong verbs double it — *-kkir-*, held long — and take a doubled *t* in the past. *Iru* is strong, which is why “I am” was *irukkiṛēn* and never *irugiṛēn*. *Sāppiḍu* is weak, like *pō*.

There is no rule you can hear in the bare stem that tells you which camp a verb is in, so it is learned with the verb, the way a noun’s gender is learned in other languages. Two camps, though — not twenty. Meet a verb once in its present form and it is settled forever.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*pār*” — see, watch
- the contrast, holding the long *kk* — “*pōgīrēn* ... *pārkkīrēn*”
- the past pair — “*pōnēn* ... *pārttēn*”
- which camp each verb sits in — “*iru* strong, *pō* weak, *sāppiḍu* weak, *pār* strong”

Before you move on

What separates a strong verb from a weak one? (**The doubled consonant** in the tense bead — *pārkkīrēn* against *pōgīrēn*.) Which camp is *iru* in, and how do you know? (**Strong** — *irukkiṛēn* holds the *kk*.) Which Tamil verb for “see” is shared with Malayalam and Kannada? (காண, *kāṇ* — kept for formal use beside everyday *pār*.) Next: a verb with no person on the end at all.

32.6 தெரி (teri) — “to know,” the verb that drops the person

Five verbs, and every one ended on *-ēn*, the bead that means “I.”
The last verb of the chapter refuses that bead — and Chapter 6 already gave you the sentence it makes.

You’ll want to know: தெரி

தெரி — *teri* — to know; to be apparent, to be visible

த (*ta*) with the short-*e* sign, then ரி (*ri*). Its base sense is not “know” but “**show up, be clear**” — a thing *teri*-s to you the way a shape resolves out of fog. The everyday form is தெரியும் (*teriyum*): “it is known,” “it is apparent.”

Tamil keeps a second know-verb, அறி (*ari*), for knowing by learning — the same word as Kannada ಅರಿ (*ari*) and Malayalam അറിയുക (*ariyuka*). *Teri* has an exact cousin too: Telugu’s తెలుసు (*telusu*), from తెలియ (*teliyu*).

Grammar Lens: no person on the verb, so the person moves

எனக்குத் தமிழ் தெரியும். — *enakkut tamīl teriyum* —
“I know Tamil.”

Chapter 6 gave you that sentence whole; here is the verb inside it.
தெரியும் has no person bead, and stays the same shape no matter who knows:

- *enakku teriyum* — it is known **to me**
- *unakku teriyum* — it is known **to you**
- *avanakku teriyum* — it is known **to him**

Only the little dative word in front changes. Tamil treats knowing as something that **happens to** you rather than something you **do**, so the knower is not the subject and cannot climb into the verb’s last slot. That is the chapter’s closing symmetry. Five verbs carried the person in the ending, and *nān* could be dropped. Here the ending carries no person, so the dative word is the one thing you cannot drop. Telugu builds it identically: నాకు తెలుసు (*nāku telusu*), “to me it is known.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “teri” — be apparent — then “teriyum”, it is known
- “enakkut tamil teriyum” — I know Tamil
- the three knowers, one verb — “enakku ... unakku ... avanukku teriyum”
- the five that carried the person — “irukkirēn, pōgirēn, varugirēn, sāppiḍugirēn, pārkkirēn”

Before you move on

What does *teri* mean underneath “know”? (**To be apparent, to show up.**) Which bead is missing from *teriyum*? (**The person** — so the knower sits in the dative word instead.) Say “I know Tamil.” (*Enakkut tamil teriyum.*) Name the three slots one last time, with a strong verb in them. (**Stem, tense, person** — *pār* + *-kkir-* + *-ēn.*) Which sister builds the knowing-sentence the same way? (**Telugu**, *nāku telusu.*)

Chapter 33

Four Verbs of the Mind

Modes: 👁 eyes (4) ✍ pen (1) 🖐 Hands-free start: first 3 of 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say I think, I understand, I read and I write in Tamil with the same three slots, tell a strong verb from a weak one by its held consonant, explain why எனக்குப் பரிகிறது has no I in it, and make the ழ in எழுது.

Say நான் தமிழ் எழுதுகிறேன், run the chapter's four verbs in the present and sort them into strong and weak, produce ழ without letting the tongue touch, and name the one word here whose origin is unsettled.

33.1 நினை (ninai) — “to think,” which is also “to remember”

Teri refused to carry a person: *enakku teriyum*, “it is known to me.” Say *enakkut tamil teriyum* once. This verb takes the person back.

You'll want to know: நினை

நினை — *ninai* — to think; to think of, to remember

Two light beats, *ni-nai*. Threaded up: நினைக்கிறேன் (*ninaikkirēn*), “I think” — stem, tense, person, with nothing new in the machine.

The letters in this word

நி is the **dental** ந with the *i* sign ி; னை is the **alveolar** ன with the *ai* sign ை. Two of Tamil’s three n-letters in one word, and not interchangeable: the first sits on the teeth, the second on the ridge behind them. Chapter 6’s three-n lesson mapped all three — ந, ன, ண.

Grammar Lens: it doubles, so it is strong

The **k** in *ninaikkirēn* is held long — *ninaik-ki* — as it was in *irukkirēn* and *pārkirēn*, and not as it was in *pōgirēn*. So நினை is **strong**, and its past is நினைத்தேன் (*ninaittēn*), with the strong verb’s doubled *t*. One held consonant answers a question you would otherwise ask of every new verb. You are not learning a machine per verb: you learn which of two camps a stem sits in, then reuse the same three slots forever.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

நினை is native Dravidian and does two English jobs at once: *ninaikkirēn* is “I think” and equally “I remember.” The noun says so — நினைவு (*ninaivu*) is **memory**. Kannada agrees with ನೆನೆ (*nene*), “remember,” and ನೆನಪು (*nenapu*), “memory”; Malayalam has നിനയ്ക്കുക (*ninaykkuka*).

One honest note for this chapter and the next: English took real words from Tamil — *catamaran*, *mango*, *curry*, *pariah* — but **none from these verbs**. Inventing a cousin would be worse than having none.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ninai” — think, remember — then “ninaikkirēn”
- the strong pair — “irukkirēn ... ninaikkirēn”
- the noun — “ninaivu”, memory — then Kannada “nenapu”
- the two shapes — “enakku teriyum ... nān ninaikkirēn”

Before you move on

What two English verbs does *ninai* cover, and which camp is it in? (**Think** and **remember**; **strong**, from the held *kk*.) What is *ninaivu*, and which sister keeps the root? (**Memory**; **Kannada**, *nene* / *nenapu*.) Which two n's does *ninai* use, in order? (**Dental** ந, then **alveolar** ன.) And why does *teriyum* carry no *-ēn*? (**Knowing happens to you** — its person sits in the dative instead.)

33.2 புரி (puri) — “to become clear,” and who it becomes clear to

Two shapes. *Nān ninaikkirēn* — I do the thinking. *Enakku teriyum* — the knowing happens to me. Say both.

You'll want to know: புரி

புரி — *puri* — to be understood; to become clear

The everyday form is பரிகிறது (*purigiradu*):

எனக்குத் தமிழ் பரிகிறது. — *enakku tamil purigiradu* —
“I understand Tamil.”

Word for word, “to me Tamil is becoming clear.” The verb is weak: the softened *-gir-* of *pōgirēn*, not the long *-kkir-* of *ninaikkirēn*.

The letters in this word

பு is ப carrying the *u* sign, which fuses into the letter's shape rather than hanging off it; ரி is ர with the *i* sign ி.

Grammar Lens: the last slot can say “it”

Teriyum had no person slot at all. *Purigiradu* fills it, with -அது (*-adu*), “it.”

புரி + கிற + அது → பரிகிறது

So the thing becoming clear is *it*, and the understander is pushed out

of the verb into the dative word எனக்கு (*enakku*) that Chapter 6 built for this job. Change the understander and only that word moves:

- *enakku purigiradu* — I understand
- *unakku purigiradu* — you understand
- *avanukku purigiradu* — he understands

Two verbs, two mechanisms, one result: **the experiencer sits in the dative**. Not an exception — the ordinary way to report what happens inside a person.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Tamil's dictionaries keep more than one புரி: an old literary one, “to do, to perform,” and this everyday one. Whether they are one root is **not settled**. Certain is the verbal noun in -தல்: புரிதல் (*puridal*), “understanding.”

The family evidence is stronger. Each sister chose a different verb, and every one puts the understander in the dative:

- Kannada ನನಗೆ ಅರ್ಥವಾಯಿತು — *nanage arthavāyitu*
- Telugu నాకు అర్థమైంది — *nāku arthamaindi*
- Malayalam എനിക്ക് മനസ്സിലായി — *enikku manassilāyi*, “it entered my mind”

Different words, one grammar. Chapter 6 showed the four dative endings were cousins; here they do the same job in the same sentence.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “enakkut tamil purigiradu” — I understand Tamil
- three understanders, one verb — “enakku ... unakku ... avanukku purigiradu”
- the pair that share a shape — “enakku teriyum ... enakku purigiradu”

- the sisters’ datives — “enakku ... nanage ... nāku ... enikku”

Before you move on

What does *puri* mean underneath “understand,” and what fills its person slot? (**To become clear**; -அது, “it”.) So where does the understander go? (**Into the dative** — *enakku*.) Name the other verb that puts you there. (**Teri** — *enakku teriyum*.) And which verb from this chapter keeps the person on the ending? (**Ninai** — *nān ninaikkirēn*.)

33.3 படி (paḍi) — “to read,” and the letter that is two sounds

Say *enakkut tamīl purigiradu* — Tamil becomes clear to me. Now the verb for the work that gets you there.

You’ll want to know: படி

படி — *paḍi* — to read; to study, to learn

படிக்கிறேன் (*paḍikkirēn*), “I read, I study.” The *kk* is held, so படி is strong, like *ninai* and *pār*; its past is படித்தேன் (*paḍittēn*).

நான் தமிழ் படிக்கிறேன். — *nān tamīl paḍikkirēn* — “I study Tamil.”

Tamil does not split reading from studying: படிப்பு (*paḍippu*) is both “reading” and “an education.”

The letters in this word

ப (*pa*) + டி, which is ட wearing the *i* sign ி.

Now a mystery worth clearing up. The letter is ட, named *ṭa*, yet the word is written here *paḍi*, with a **d**. Nothing is inconsistent: **Tamil marks no voicing**. One letter covers both sounds and **position decides** — hard word-initially or doubled, soft between vowels. That is Chapter 5’s rule for க, which spells *k*, *g* and a soft *h* without changing shape.

So ட is soft between the vowels of *paḍi* and hard in the doubled ட்ட of *paḍittēn*. It is why *pō* becomes *pōgirēn*, why *sāppiḍu* has a *ḍ*, and why every romanization here softens where a speaker softens.

ᱚ is also **retroflex**, made where ᱚᱠ is: tongue tip curled back to the roof of the mouth. That curl matters more than the *d*-versus-*t*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Tamil's own dictionaries list **படி** as native. Others connect it to Sanskrit **पठ्** (*path*), “to recite, to read aloud” — not a silly idea, because **Tamil has no aspirated consonants**, so a borrowed *path* would arrive as *paṭi* automatically, with no letter to carry the puff of breath.

Next door the evidence is split. Malayalam says **പഠിക്കുക** (*paṭhikkuka*) and **keeps the aspirate**, in the Sanskrit-series letter **ഠ**; Kannada and Telugu use **ಓದು** (*ōdu*) and **చదువు** (*caduvu*), unrelated to either candidate.

Carry away the certain part: **an aspirate cannot survive into Tamil**, so a stripped-down look-alike is never by itself proof of borrowing.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “nāṇ tamīl paḍikkirēṇ” — I study Tamil
- the soft and the hard ᱚ — “paḍi ... paḍittēṇ”
- the strong three — “ninaikkirēṇ, paḍikkirēṇ, pāṛkkirēṇ”
- the weak one beside them — “purigiradu”

Before you move on

Why is ᱚ written one way and heard two ways, and where is it made? (**Tamil marks no voicing** — position decides, as with **ஃ**; and it is **retroflex**, made where ᱚᱠ is.) Is *paḍi* borrowed from Sanskrit *path*, and what can Tamil never keep from a Sanskrit word? (**Unsettled; the aspiration.**) Say “I study Tamil.” (*Nāṇ tamīl paḍikkirēṇ.*)

33.4 தமிழ் — the letter the language is named for

This book has said more than once that Tamil keeps three *l*-letters, and the strand has shown you two: ல in இல்லை, ள in நீங்கள். The third has been outstanding since chapter 18. Here it is, in the word it matters most in.

Script you'll notice: த and ழ

த	<i>ta</i> — the dental <i>t</i> , tongue on the teeth
ழ	<i>l</i> — the third <i>l</i> -letter, curled far back

த is the dental partner of the retroflex ள you read in எப்படி: same kind of stop, different place in the mouth. Tamil keeps the pair apart in writing, so த and ள are never interchangeable.

ழ is the one Tamil is known for. It is made further back than ள, and its sound sits somewhere between an *r*, an *l* and a *zh* — rare enough in the world's languages that Tamil is sometimes called the l language. That is why the word for the language itself ends in it.

Read both; do not draw them yet. Neither த nor ழ has an entry in this book's script data, so neither gets a stroke order, and the mouth positions above are this lesson's own — the data is sourced for ண's retroflex curl and nothing else here.

Script you'll notice: build the word

piece		
த	<i>ta</i>	this lesson
மி	<i>mi</i> — ம with the ி sign	ம from வணக்கம், ி from நன்றி
ழ்	bare <i>l</i> — ழ under a pulli	this lesson

த · மி · ழ → தமிழ்

Three pieces, and you can now read the name of the language you have been speaking since page one. That was the plan: the word first, the letters when they can be earned.

Your turn

- *Read it:* த · ழ — then தமிழ்
- *Say it:* “tamiḷ” — and hold that last sound
- *Contrast:* த and ட — dental and retroflex, teeth and roof
- *Contrast:* ல · ள · ழ — all three *l*-letters, at last

Before you move on

Read தமிழ். Which letter is த’s retroflex partner? (ட, from எப்படி.) Which of the three *l*-letters ends the word, and what is the dot doing? (ழ; the pulli **removes its built-in a.**) Next: the verb for writing — spelled with the ழ you just met.

33.5 எழுது (eḷuḍu) — “to write,” and the sound Tamil is named for

Ninaikkirēn, *purigiradu*, *paḍikkirēn* — think, understand, read.
Say all three. The fourth is reading’s other half.

You’ll want to know: எழுது

எழுது — *eḷuḍu* — to write; to draw

எழுதுகிறேன் (*eḷuḍugirēn*), “I write.” The tense bead is the **single softened -gir-**, so எழுது is **weak**, like *pō* and *sāppiḍu*.

நான் தமிழ் எழுதுகிறேன். — *nān tamīḷ eḷuḍugirēn* — “I write Tamil.”

The letters in this word

எ is the standing vowel *e*; ழு is ழு with the *u* sign and து is த with the same sign.

The dot returns in the noun எழுத்து (*eluttu*), “a letter of the alphabet,” spelled எ ழு த் து: a **pulli** strips the vowel from the first த் and the second து stands whole beside it. Two full letters and a visible dot, never a fused shape: the pulli lesson’s bargain.

The letters in this word

ழ — written *l* — is the sound in தமிழ் (*tamil*) itself and in வாழ் (*vāl*), “to live,” and is reputed to be the language’s hardest. Curl the tongue tip back as for ழ or ண, then **do not let it touch**. Leave a gap and voice through it: what comes out sits between an American *r* and an *l*, and it is a **glide**, not a stop. Two honest notes. Many fluent speakers merge ழு with ள and are understood everywhere. And the family already voted — Chapter 7 gave you Tamil **ēlu** against Kannada **ēḷu**. Kannada and Telugu each had a letter for it and let it go; **Tamil and Malayalam kept it**.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The Dravidian etymological dictionary files எழுது under எழு (*elu*), “to rise” — a written line being a mark raised onto a surface. Standard rather than proven, but native, unlike the open question *paḍi* left you with. Beside it sits எழுத்தாளர் (*eluttālar*), a writer. The cousin is exact: Malayalam എഴുതുക (*elutuka*), same verb, same **ḷ**. Kannada and Telugu, having dropped the sound, dropped the verb.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the three ழு words — “tamiḷ ... vāl ... eludu”
- “nāṇ tamiḷ eludugirēṇ” — I write Tamil
- the chapter — “ninaikkirēṇ, purigiradu, paḍikkirēṇ, eludugirēṇ”
- the split — “Tamil ēlu ... Kannada ēḷu”

Before you move on

Say the chapter's four verbs and name the two weak ones.

(*Ninaikkirēn*, *purigiradu*, *paḍikkirēn*, *eludugirēn*; ***puri*** and ***eludu***.)

How is **ḡ** made, and who kept it? (**Curled back, not touching**; **Malayalam** did, **Kannada** and **Telugu** dropped it.) What keeps the two **ḡ**'s of *eluttu* apart, and which word here has an unsettled origin? (**The *pulli***; ***paḍi***.)

Chapter 34

Four Verbs Between People

Modes: 🗣️ voice (1) 👁️ eyes (3) ✍️ pen (1) 🖐️ Hands-free start: first 2 of 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say I take, I ask, I help and I like in Tamil, hear கேள் doing the work of both asking and hearing, choose between பிடிக்கும் and விரும்பு, and say எனக்குப் பிடிக்கும் knowing why the liker sits in the dative exactly as with தெரியும்.

Say எனக்குத் தமிழ் பிடிக்கும் and unpack it as “to me, Tamil catches”; name the three dative-experiencer verbs தெரியும் / புரிகிறது / பிடிக்கும், contrast விரும்பு’s ordinary subject, and place Kannada ಹಿಡಿ on the $p \rightarrow h$ shift met in Chapter 7.

34.1 எடு (eḍu) — “to take,” beside the “put” you already own

The last chapter’s verbs happened inside your head. These four happen between you and somebody else. Say *paḍikkirēn* and *eludugirēn* once more, then put your hands back in the world.

You’ll want to know: எடு

எடு — *eḍu* — to take; to pick up, to lift, to remove

எடுக்கிறேன் (*eḍukkirēn*), “I take.” The *kk* is held, so எடு is strong; past எடுத்தேன் (*eḍuttēn*). Two sentences you can already build in full:

நான் தண்ணீர் எடுக்கிறேன். — *nān taṇṇīr eḍukkirēn* —
“I take water.”

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நான் அரிசி எடுக்கிறேன். — *nān arisi eḍukkirēn* — “I take
rice.”

The letters in this word

எ is the standing vowel *e*, from எழுது; டு is ட with the *u* sign, and ட came apart in டடி. Nothing here is new — the first time in this book that has been true of a whole headword. The *ḍ* you hear is the same positional softening: ட goes soft between vowels and hard when doubled, as in *eḍuttēn*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

You have met this verb’s near-twin already, hiding inside a meal.

சாப்பிடு (*sāppiḍu*), “to eat,” is *sāppu* (food) plus இடு (*iḍu*), “to
put” — the light verb that lends its endings to a noun.

verb	what it does
இடு <i>iḍu</i>	put it down
எடு <i>eḍu</i>	pick it up

One standing vowel apart — இ against எ — pointing opposite ways. That is a gift to your memory and **not** an etymology: Tamil’s dictionaries keep them as **separate roots**, and a tidy pair of opposites is exactly the resemblance that fools people. Use it to remember; never as evidence.

What *is* inherited is *eḍu* itself. Malayalam has എടുക്കുക (*eṭukkuka*), the same verb; Kannada and Telugu say ಎತ್ತು / ఎత్తు (*ettu*), “to lift,” from the same old root with a doubled *t* where Tamil keeps its retroflex.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the opposed pair — “iḍu, put ... eḍu, take”
- “nān taṇṇīr eḍukkirēn” — I take water
- “nān arisi eḍukkirēn” — I take rice

- the cousins lifting — “eṭukkuka ... ettu ... ettu”

Before you move on

What does *edu* mean, and which camp is it in? (**To take; strong** — *eḍukkirēn* holds the *kk*.) Which verb is one vowel away, and where did you meet it? (இடு, “to put” — inside சாப்பிடு.) Is that pair related? (**No** — the dictionaries keep them apart; it is a memory hook, not evidence.) Say “I take water,” then “I take rice.” (*Nān taṇṇīr eḍukkirēn; nān arisi eḍukkirēn.*)

34.2 கேள் (kēḷ) — one verb for asking and for hearing

Eḍukkirēn — I take. Name the verb it is one vowel away from. Now a verb doing two English jobs at once.

You’ll want to know: கேள்

கேள் — *kēḷ* — to ask; to hear, to listen

One syllable, ending on retroflex ள். The everyday form surprises:

நான் கேட்கிறேன். — *nān kēṭkirēn* — “I ask.” (Also: “I hear.”)

The ள் has hardened to ட் — வா’s trick a second time: you say it *vā*, but the endings attach to *varu-*. Here they attach to கேட்- (*kēṭ-*), and the past is கேட்டேன் (*kēṭṭēn*), a strong verb’s doubled consonant. Two verbs with two stems apiece.

The letters in this word

கே is க with the long-*ē* sign ே; ள் is retroflex ள shut off by a **pulli** — the dot Chapter 8 pointed at inside செய்து. In கேட்கிறேன் the seam is ட்.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

English keeps *ask* and *hear* apart. Tamil does not, and neither does its noun: கேள்வி (*kēḷvi*) is “a question” and also “a hearing.” The

family splits down the middle:

- Kannada ಕೇಳು (*kēlu*) does **both** jobs, as Tamil does.
- Malayalam கேൾക്കുക (*kēlkkuka*) kept only “hear.”
- Telugu splits them: విను (*vinu*), hear; అడుగు (*aḍugu*), ask.

The verb is inherited, but four languages cannot settle which arrangement came first; treat the fusion as Tamil’s and Kannada’s shared habit alone.

Why it’s said this way

Tamil is **diglossic**: its literary variety and the variety people speak have drifted far apart. This verb makes that impossible to ignore.

- கேள் is the dictionary and literary form.
- கேட்கிறேன் is standard spoken Tamil — **the register these lessons teach**, as every lesson’s variety line has said.
- Relaxed speech says கேக்கிறேன் (*kēkkirēn*) and கேக்க (*kēkka*). Recognise them; you need not say them.

For a polite request use Chapter 8’s respectful ending: கேளுங்கள் (*kēlungaḷ*), “please ask.” Keep தயவுசெய்து for emphasis.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the two shifting stems — “vā ... varugirēn” then “kēl ... kēṭkirēn”
- “kēlvi” — a question — then the polite “kēlungaḷ”
- the family split — “Kannada kēlu, both ... Telugu vinu and aḍugu, two”

Before you move on

What two English verbs is *kēl*, and what happens to its ள் before an ending? (**Ask** and **hear**; it hardens to ட்.) Which verb taught you

to expect a second stem, and what is *kēḷvi*? (வா, built on *varu*-, a **question**.) Which register do these lessons teach, and how do you ask politely? (Standard spoken *kēḷkirēn*; *kēḷungaḷ*.)

34.3 பேசு — the long partner of ெ

Twice now a Tamil vowel has come in a short and a long version: அ and ஆ, ி and ீ. For அ/ஆ the script data even says the long one is the short one plus a tail; for ி/ீ it says nothing, and the pairing is the lesson's. Here is a third pair.

Script you'll notice: the ெ sign

ெ is the sign for long *ē*, and it is the long partner of the ெ you met in பெயர். Like ெ, it is written to the **left** of its consonant and spoken after it.

ப + ெ → பே, said *pē*.

sign	sound	where it is written
ெ	short <i>e</i>	to the left
ெ	long <i>ē</i>	to the left
ை	<i>ai</i>	to the left

Three left-standing signs now. The evidence is the same as it was for ெ: the script data describes ை and has no entry for ெ or ெ at all, so both the shared position **and** the short/long pairing are stated from the pattern these signs share, not from a source for either one.

Script you'll notice: build the word

piece		
பே	<i>pē</i> — ப with the ெ sign on its left	ப from பெயர்
சு	<i>su</i> — ச with the ு sign	ச from சரி, ு from இருக்கிறீர்கள்

பே • சு → பேசு

Two pieces, one new sign, and its two signs pull in opposite directions on the page: ே stands before its letter, ூ joins after it. பேசு is “speak” — the verb every lesson so far has been in service of.

Your turn

- *Read it:* பே — then பேசு
- *Say it:* “pēsu” — “speak”
- *Contrast:* பெ and பே — the short sign and the long one, both on the left
- *Contrast:* பே and சு — a sign before, a sign after, inside one word
- *Read it:* தமிழ் பேசு — “speak Tamil,” both words off the page

Before you move on

Read பேசு. Which side of its consonant is ே written on? (**The left** — like ெ and ை.) Which sign is its short partner? (ெ, as in பெயர்.) What is the சு doing here — is it *s* or *ch*? (**Either**; one letter covers both, and position picks.) Next: the verb for helping.

34.4 உதவு (udavu) — “to help,” and a word Tamil did not borrow

Kēṭkirēn — I ask. *Kēḷungaḷ* — please ask. Say both, and keep that polite ending in your ear; it is about to arrive on a second verb unchanged.

You’ll want to know: உதவு

உதவு — *udavu* — to help; to be of use

உதவுகிறேன் (*udavugirēn*), “I help.” The single softened *-gir-* puts உதவு in the **weak** camp with *pō* and *eludu*, and the noun is one step away: உதவி (*udavi*), “help.”

நான் உங்களுக்கு உதவுகிறேன். — *nān ungaḷukku udavugirēn* — “I help you.”

The person helped takes the dative -உக்கு from Chapter 6, and the polite form needs nothing new: உதவுங்கள் (*udavungaḷ*), “please help” — the same respectful -உங்கள் you just put on *kēḷ*.

The letters in this word

உ is the standing vowel *u*, used when a word begins with it; then த and வு, which is வ with the *u* sign. The *d* you hear is த between two vowels, softening exactly as ட did in *paḍi* and க does in *pōgīrēṇ*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Tamil turns verbs into nouns with a small ending, and you have collected three without being told to: புரி → புரிதல் (*puridaḷ*), understanding; கேள் → கேள்வி (*kēḷvi*), a question; உதவு → உதவி (*udavi*), help.

Now the part worth keeping. For “help,” the neighbours nearly all reach for Sanskrit सहाय (*sahāya*): Telugu సహాయం, Kannada ಸಹಾಯ, Malayalam സഹായം, Hindi सहायता. Tamil’s everyday word is உதவி, its own.

Hold that against Chapter 8, where *please* went the other way: **all four** sisters built it on Sanskrit दया (*daya*) plus a light verb — *tayavuseytu*, *dayaviṭṭu*, *dayacēsi*, *dayavāyi*. Same four languages, opposite outcome. So the rule is not “Tamil refuses to borrow”; it is that **borrowing happens word by word**, and the only way to know is to check each one.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “nān ungaḷukku udavugirēṇ” — I help you
- the two polite forms — “kēḷungaḷ ... udavungaḷ”
- the three nouns — “puridaḷ ... kēḷvi ... udavi”
- the borrowed one and the kept one — “tayavuseytu ... udavi”

Before you move on

Which camp is *udavu* in, and what is *udavi*? (**Weak**, by the single softened bead; **help**, the noun.) Say “I help you,” then “please help.” (*Nān ungaḷukku udavugirēn; udavungaḷ.*) Which word do the neighbours borrow from Sanskrit where Tamil keeps its own? (**Help** — *sahāya* against *udavi*.) And which word did all four sisters borrow together? (**Please** — *daya* plus a light verb.)

34.5 பிடி (piḍi) — “to catch,” and therefore “to like”

Say this chapter’s three verbs — *eḍukkirēn, kētkirēn, udavugirēn* — then the two sentences with no *nān*: *enakku teriyum, enakku purigiradu*.

You’ll want to know: பிடி

பிடி — *piḍi* — to catch, to seize, to hold

பிடிக்கிறேன் (*piḍikkirēn*) is “I catch, I hold,” and the held *kk* puts it in the **strong** camp with *ninai, paḍi* and *eḍu*.

Grammar Lens: எனக்குப் பிடிக்கும்

எனக்குத் தமிழ் பிடிக்கும். — *enakku tamil piḍikkum*
— “I like Tamil.”

Word for word: “**to me**, Tamil catches.” The Tamil does the catching; you are caught. பிடிக்கும் carries **no person at all** — the person-less ending of தெரியும் — so only the dative word changes: *enakku piḍikkum, unakku piḍikkum, avanukku piḍikkum*.

That makes three: தெரியும், புரிகிறது, பிடிக்கும் — knowing, understanding, liking. Three endings; each puts the experiencer in the dative and the thing in the subject. Chapter 6’s **dative subject** was never an exception.

You’ll want to know: விரும்பு

விரும்பு — *virumbu* — to want, to like, to love

An ordinary verb with an ordinary subject: நான் விரும்புகிறேன் (*nān virumbugirēn*), “I want.” Weak; its noun is விருப்பம் (*viruppam*), a wish. Not a synonym: பிடிக்கும் is taste, which you had no say in; விரும்பு is choice.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The grasp-verb is old and shared: Malayalam പിടിക്കുക (*piṭikkuka*) and Telugu పట్టు (*paṭṭu*) both mean “catch, hold.” Kannada’s is ಹಿಡಿ (*hiḍi*) — not a different word: Old Kannada wrote *piḍi*, and the **p** → **h** shift behind *pattu* / *hattu* and *pāl* / *hālu* turned it into *hiḍi*. A third instance of a rule you have already met.

The wider point: Spanish says *me gusta*, Italian *mi piace*, Hindi *muḥe pasand hai* — each putting the liker in the dative and the liked thing in the subject, exactly as *enakkut tamil piḍikkum* does, and none of them related to Tamil. **Two unrelated families reached the same design independently.**

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the three dative sentences — “enaku teriyum ... purigiradu ... piḍikkum”
- the other design — “nān virumbugirēn”, I want
- the chapter — “eḍukkirēn, kēṭkirēn, udavugirēn, piḍikkum”
- the Kannada shift — “piḍi ... hiḍi”, as “pattu ... hattu”

Before you move on

Say “I like Tamil” and name its subject. (*Enakkut tamil piḍikkum*, “to me, Tamil catches”; the subject is **Tamil**.) Name the three verbs built that way, and what *virumbu* does differently. (***Teriyum*, *purigiradu*, *piḍikkum***; *virumbu* takes an **ordinary subject**.) Why is Kannada’s *hiḍi* the same word as *piḍi*, and which unrelated language builds “I like” this way? (**The p → h shift**; Spanish *me gusta*.)

Chapter 35

Arriving at a House

Modes: 👁 eyes (4) ✍ pen (1) 🖐 Hands-free start: first 1 of 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name a Tamil house, its door, a room and a chair, take நாற்காலி apart into 'four' and 'leg', place வீடு against Kannada ಬೀಡು on the v-to-b shift, and say why கதவு stayed everyday while Sanskrit-derived கபாடம் stayed in books.

Walk a guest from வீடு through கதவு into அறை and offer a நாற்காலி; split the chair into நால் and கால் and hear ல் harden to ற at the join; hold the hard ற at the ridge rather than the roof; and name what the pulli does at ற்கா and what Tamil refuses to do there.

35.1 வீடு (vīḍu) — “house,” and the place the greeting happens

Three verbs from the chapter you have just finished: *pidi*, “to like”; *uḍavu*, “to help”; *kēḷ*, “to ask.” Say them. Now a noun, and the one a conversation usually starts inside.

You'll want to know: வீடு

வீடு — *vīḍu* — house; home

One word covers both. Tamil does not split the building from the belonging: என் வீடு (*en vīḍu*) is “my house” and “my home” at once, and choosing between them is the translator's problem.

With the dative you already own:

வீட்டுக்கு — *vīṭṭukku* — to the house

The soft *ḍ* hardens and doubles to *ṭṭ* — the படி / படித்தேன் rule.

The letters in this word

வீ is வ, the first letter you learned, wearing the long *ī* sign ீ. Then டு: ட with the *u* sign.

You are at a door about to say வணக்கம், so read that word while you are here: வ + ண + க் + க + ம். The வ that opens *vaṇakkam* is the வ that opens *vīḍu*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

வீடு is inherited, not borrowed:

the cousin	language and sense
வீட் <i>vīḍ</i>	Malayalam, “house”
வீడు <i>vīḍu</i>	Telugu, “town, camp”
ಬೀಡು <i>bīḍu</i>	Kannada, “abode, encampment”

Kannada has changed the front of the word: Tamil says **v**, Kannada says **b**. Not a slip — Kannada alone among its neighbours turned inherited word-initial *v*- into *b*-, and the inscriptions show it from about the seventh century. Store the correspondence — it keeps paying. The **sense** has drifted where the form has not: Telugu’s *vīḍu* is a town, Kannada’s *bīḍu* an encampment. Tamil and Malayalam kept it on the dwelling.

One more thing, not a coincidence to explain away. Tamil has a second வீடு meaning “**release, deliverance**,” as in வீடுபெறு. The Dravidian dictionary files house and release under **one entry**, headed by விடு (*viḍu*), “to let go.” A house is where you are let go.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “vīḍu” — house and home in one word
- “eṇ vīḍu,” then the hardening — “vīṭṭukku”
- the cousins, ending on the front-swap — “vīḍ ... vīḍu ... bīḍu”
- the root under the house — “viḍu, to let go”

Before you move on

Why does one Tamil word do two English jobs here, and which letter opens both *vīḍu* and *vaṇakkam*? (**H**ouse and **h**ome are not split; and ஶ.) What does Kannada put at the front instead of *v*, and is it a one-off? (**ḃ** — *bīḍu*; **regular**, from the seventh century on.) Is the Tamil word for “release” the same root as the house? (**Yes** — both under விடு, “to let go.”)

35.2 ேஶ — one sign, two marks

Every vowel sign so far has been one mark in one place: before the consonant, above it, or after it. This one is in two places at once, and you already own both halves.

Script you’ll notice: the ேஶ sign

ேஶ is the sign for long *ō*, and it **wraps** its consonant: a hook on the left, a stroke on the right, one vowel.

Those two halves are not a guess. The Unicode Character Database gives ேஶ a canonical decomposition, and it is exactly the two signs you have:

ேஶ = ே (the long-*ē* hook, written left) + ஶ (the long-*ā* stroke, written right)

So this is not one more mark to memorise. It is the sign you learned last lesson and the sign you learned in ஶஶ, put around the same letter — read the letter in the middle, and say the vowel once.

Be exact about what that citation settles. A canonical decomposition says the character is **composed of** those two, for text processing; it says nothing about how either half is drawn or where it lands. `tamil.json` has no entry for ேஶ at all. So take the composition from Unicode and the placement — hook left, stroke right — from the page in front of you.

Script you'll notice: build the word

piece

ப	<i>pa</i>	from பெயர்
ோ	long <i>ō</i> , wrapped around it	this lesson

$$\text{ப} + \text{ோ} \rightarrow \text{போ}$$

One letter and one wrapped sign, and the whole word is two marks on the page. போ is “go” — the போ inside *pōy varugirēn*, “I’ll go and come back,” the farewell chapter 1 closes on and chapter 4 takes apart.

Your turn

- *Read it:* போ — then போ — the hook alone, then the hook with the stroke
- *Say it:* “pō” — “go”
- *Contrast:* போ · பா · போ — left only, right only, both at once
- *Read it:* போசு again, and notice its ோ is the same hook

Before you move on

Read போ. Which two signs is ோ made of, and where does each one sit? (஋ on the **left**, ா on the **right**.) How many vowels do you say when you read it? (**One** — the two marks are one sign.) Which of its halves did you meet in நான்? (ா.) Next: the word for a door.

35.3 கதவு (kadavu) — “door,” and a word Tamil never gave up

Vīḍu — house. Say the cousin that swaps the front letter. (*Bīḍu*, Kannada.) Now the part of the house you actually stand at.

You'll want to know: கதவு

கதவு — *kadavu* — door

The leaf that swings, and the thing somebody opens when you arrive.

வீட்டுக் கதவு — *vīṭṭuk kadavu* — the house door

Two nouns in a row, the first leaning on the second. Tamil builds a great deal this way, and you have seen it inside a single word: தண்ணீர் is *taṇ* plus *nīr*, “cool” plus “water.”

The letters in this word

க + த + வு. The first letter is the one that taught you Tamil marks no voicing: க spells a hard *k*, a soft *g* and even an *h*, and **position decides**. Here it opens the word, so it is hard — *ka*, not *ga*.

The same rule then lands on the second letter. த is named *ta*, but it sits between two vowels, so it softens. That is why this book writes *kadavu* and not *katavu*. One rule, two letters, one word.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

கதவு is inherited Dravidian. Kannada's ಕದ (kada) is the same word with less on the end; Malayalam's കതവ് (katavu) matches Tamil closely.

Tamil also owns a second word for a door-leaf: கபாடம் (*kabāḍam*), taken from Sanskrit कपाट (kapāṭa). It exists, it is correct, and almost nobody says it. It lives in poetry and temple description; கதவு lives in the house.

That split is this language's habit. Where a neighbour borrowed a Sanskrit word and let the inherited one fade, Tamil often kept both and gave them different jobs — the inherited word for the everyday thing, the borrowed one for the elevated register. Do not turn that into a rule that Tamil never borrows. It borrows; it rarely evicts.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “kadavu” — door
- “vīṭṭuk kadavu” — the house door

- the hard one and the soft one in one word — “ka ... da”
- the everyday word, then the bookish one — “kadavu ... kabāḍam”

Before you move on

Say “the house door,” then explain why the க is hard and the த soft when neither changed shape. (*Vittuk kadavu*; **Tamil marks no voicing** — position decides.) Which of *kadavu* and *kabāḍam* would you hear at somebody’s house, and where did the other come from? (*Kadavu*; *kabāḍam* is **Sanskrit**, and stays literary.) Does keeping both mean Tamil refuses to borrow? (**No** — it borrows without evicting.)

35.4 அறை (arai) — “room,” and Tamil’s second r

Vīḍu, house. *Kadavu*, door — the everyday word Tamil kept while the Sanskrit one stayed in books. Open that door and you are in this word.

You’ll want to know: அறை

அறை — *arai* — room

Any room: in a house, in a hotel, a cell. Put it behind *vīḍu* the way you put *kadavu* there:

வீட்டு அறை — *vīṭṭu arai* — a room of the house

And with the dative, அறைக்கு (*araiḱku*), “to the room.”

The letters in this word

அ is the standing vowel *a* — a letter in its own right, not a sign hung on a consonant. Then ற, then the *ai* sign ை, which wraps around the front of its consonant: ற + ை → ைற.

ற is the hard *r* you first met inside நன்றி. It is not ர. Tamil keeps two r-letters and uses both.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

அறை is inherited. Malayalam's അറ (*ara*) is the same word, used for a chamber or an inner store-room, and it keeps the same hard r. So this is *kadavu*'s situation over: an everyday inherited word with a Sanskrit-derived alternative sitting unused in the higher register.

The letters in this word

Say the English word *hurry* and stop on the middle sound. That flick of the tongue against the ridge behind your teeth is close to Tamil ர (*ra*). Now make it stronger and longer, with real contact: that is ற (*ra*). Two cautions. **Do not curl your tongue back** — retroflex belongs to ண and ழ; ற is made at the ridge. And **do not soften it into the English r of red**, which is the wrong shape for both Tamil letters. Many Tamil speakers merge ர and ற in casual speech, so you will be understood either way. Learn the difference anyway: the **spelling** depends on it, and a word written with the wrong r is simply misspelled.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “arai” — room, on the hard r
- the two r's apart — “ra ... ra”
- “vīṭṭu arai” — a room of the house
- the three so far — “vīḍu, kadavu, arai”

Before you move on

Say “a room of the house,” and name which of Tamil's two r-letters is in *arai* and where else you have read it. (*Vīṭṭu arai*; ற, the hard one, in நன்றி.) Where is ற made, and what must your tongue not do? (At the **ridge** behind the teeth — **do not curl it back**.) If many speakers merge the two r's, why bother? (Because the **spelling** does not merge.)

35.5 நாற்காலி (nārkāli) — “chair,” counted out in legs

Three words in the order you meet them arriving: *vīdu*, *kadavu*, *arai*. Hold the hard r in *arai* at the ridge, not the roof. Now the one thing in that room a guest is always pointed at.

You’ll want to know: நாற்காலி

நாற்காலி — *nārkāli* — chair

Five syllables for a chair, which sounds extravagant until you find out what it is made of.

நான் நாற்காலி எடுக்கிறேன். — *nān nārkāli eḍukkireṇ* —
I take a chair.

The letters in this word

நா + ற் + கா + லி. Every piece is one you have handled.

ந is the dental *n*, first of Tamil’s three n-letters, wearing the long *ā* sign ா. ற் is the hard r of *arai* under a **pulli**, the dot that switches off the built-in vowel. கா is க with that same long *ā*. லி is ல with the *i* sign ி, the first vowel sign you learned, on the way to spelling நன்றி.

Now what does **not** happen at ற்கா. Two consonants meet, and Tamil keeps them as two letters with a dot between, rather than fusing them into a stacked shape as the scripts to the north do. That refusal is why a word this long stays readable one piece at a time.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The word is a compound, and both halves are yours:

the piece

what it is

நால் *nāl*

“four” — the form four takes in compounds

கால் *kāl*

“leg, foot; a support”

Four plus leg: a chair is a four-legged thing, said out loud. English cannot do that with *chair*, which travels through French and Latin to a Greek word for “seat” without ever showing a leg.

The seam is audible. நான்கு (*nānku*) is the counting word; in a

compound four appears as நால், and before க that ல hardens to ற். Hence நாற்காலி, and hence நாற்பது (*nārpadu*), “forty.” Malayalam builds the chair from the same two pieces: നാൽക്കാലി. Both halves are inherited Dravidian. Nothing in this chapter was borrowed.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the seam — “nāṅku ... nāl ... kāl ... nār̥kāli”
- “nān nār̥kāli eḍukkirēn” — I take a chair
- the arrival, in order — “vīḍu, kadavu, arai, nār̥kāli”
- the Kannada front-swap on the first of them — “vīḍu ... bīḍu”

Before you move on

Take *nār̥kāli* apart, then walk somebody into your house four nouns deep. (நால், “four,” plus கால், “leg”; *vīḍu*, *kadavu*, *arai*, *nār̥kāli*.) What does the dot in ற் do, and what does Tamil refuse to do at that join? (**Switches off the built-in vowel**; Tamil **does not stack** the two consonants.) Which of this chapter’s words was borrowed? (**None.**)

Chapter 36

What You Are Offered

Modes: 👁 eyes (4) ✍ pen (1) 🖱 Hands-free start: first 3 of 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can ask for தேநீர், பால் or உணவு in Tamil, say என் தவறு with no verb in it, find நீர் inside both தண்ணீர் and தேநீர், and state which of this chapter’s words was borrowed and which the dictionaries cannot account for.

Repair a wrong order — மன்னிக்கவும், என் தவறு — and account for the chapter honestly: பால் and உண் inherited, தேநீர் half a loan through a Malay port, சாப்பிடு with no entry in the Dravidian dictionary at all, and மன்னி native where the neighbours took Sanskrit kṣamā.

36.1 தேநீர் (tēnīr) — “tea,” half of it already yours

Nārkaḷi, and what its halves mean. (Four, and leg.) You are in the *arai* with the chair, and the next thing in a Tamil house is this.

You’ll want to know: தேநீர்

தேநீர் — *tēnīr* — tea

The second half is yours from the water lesson: நீர் (*nīr*), “water,” the plain older word inside தண்ணீர் (*tanṇīr*) — *tan*, “cool,” plus *nīr*. So தேநீர் is, literally, **tea water**.

தேநீர், தயவுசெய்து. — *tēnīr, tayavuseytu* — **Tea, please.**

In speech you will also hear plain டீ (*tī*), straight from English *tea*. தேநீர் is the fuller word — a sign, a menu, a formal host.

The letters in this word

தே is த with the *ē* sign ே, which stands in front of its consonant. நீ is ந with the long *ī* sign; ர் is ர shut by a pulli — the soft r, not the hard ற.

Two words beside it are worth reading. நன்றி is ந + ன் + றி, what you say when the tea arrives. In தயவுசெய்து, செய் is *ce* plus ய் shut by that same dot before து.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

நீர் is inherited and very old. தே is not Tamil at all: it is the combining form of தேய் (*tēy*), borrowed from Malay **teh**, which took it from the Hokkien of the southern Chinese coast, where the leaf is *tê*. The world's words for tea come in two shapes, decided by **how the tea reached each language**. The southern Chinese coast carried *te*: Dutch *thee*, and through Dutch, English *tea* and French *thé* — and by the Malay ports, Tamil's தே. The overland routes carried *cha*: Persian and Hindi *chāy*, Russian *chay*. Portuguese says **chá** despite being a sea power, because its traders worked out of Macau. Where the ship docked decided the word.

Tamil then did what the European *te*-languages did not: rather than take the loan whole, it welded it to நீர் — a word that has travelled outward as well, since English **mulligatawny** is Tamil மிளகுத்தண்ணீர், “pepper water.”

Weigh that against the rice word. அரிசி *may* stand behind English *rice* through Greek, and the dictionaries hedge. The tea routes are documented. **Different histories, different confidence.**

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the shared half — “nīr ... taṇṇīr ... tēnīr”
- “tēnīr, tayavuseytu” — tea, please
- the two routes — “te ... cha”

- the pepper water in an English soup — “miḷagut taṇṇīr”

Before you move on

Name the second half of *tēnīr* and the word that shares it, then ask for tea politely. (நீர், inside தண்ணீர்; *tēnīr*, *tayavuseytu*.) Why do some languages say *te* and others *cha*, and which is better established — the tea split or *arisi-to-rice*? (**The route the tea travelled; and the tea split.**)

36.2 பால் (pāl) — “milk,” and a p that becomes an h next door

Tēnīr. Which half is borrowed, and which is the old Tamil word for water? (*Tē* is the traveller; *nīr* is Tamil’s own.) Here is what goes into it.

You’ll want to know: பால்

பால் — *pāl* — milk

One syllable, one long *ā*, a final ல with no vowel after it. Say it short and closed: *pāl*, never *pāla*.

பால் தேநீர் — *pāl tēnīr* — milk tea

With தண்ணீர் (*taṇṇīr*, cool water) already in hand, you can now name what a Tamil household is likely to put in front of a guest.

The letters in this word

பா is ப with the long *ā* sign ா. Then ல்: ல with the **pulli**, the dot that removes the built-in *a* and leaves a bare consonant.

That dot is the whole reason the word ends where it does. Without it, பால் would be *pāla*, two syllables. A single dot carries the difference between a word and a non-word.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

பால் is inherited Dravidian, and its relatives are close:

the cousin	language
പാൽ <i>pāl</i>	Malayalam
పాలు <i>pālu</i>	Telugu
ಹಾಲು <i>hālu</i>	Kannada, modern

Kannada has changed the front of the word once more, this time **p** into **h** — the textbook example of the best-known sound change in the family. **Old Kannada said *pālu***, exactly as Tamil does; the *p*- began turning into *h*- around the tenth century and the change had run through the whole vocabulary by the fourteenth.

Put it beside the change you met at the house. Tamil **v**, Kannada **b**, in *vīḍu* / *bīḍu*. Tamil **p**, Kannada **h**, in *pāl* / *hālu*. Both are regular correspondences at the front of a word, and between them they let you recognise a Kannada word as a relative rather than a stranger. Telugu and Malayalam did neither: they keep the *p*, as Tamil does.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “pāl” — stopped by the dot, not *pāla*
- “pāl tēnīr” — milk tea
- the two front-swaps together — “vīḍu, bīḍu ... pāl, hālu”
- what you can be offered — “taṇṇīr, tēnīr, pāl”

Before you move on

Say “milk tea,” then say what the dot on **ḷ** is doing and what the word would be without it. (*Pāl tēnīr*; it **removes the built-in vowel**, and without it, *pāla*.) What does Kannada put at the front instead of *p*, and is it a one-off? (**h** — *hālu*; **regular**, from the tenth century to the fourteenth.) Name the other Kannada front-swap. (**v** to **b** — *vīḍu*, *bīḍu*.)

36.3 உணவு (uṇavu) — “food,” from the verb underneath it

Pāl — milk — and the Kannada shape of it. (*Hālu*.) Drink is settled. Now the word for everything else on the plate.

You’ll want to know: உணவு

உணவு — *uṇavu* — food

The general word: food as a category, not a dish. It covers the rice words you have — அரிசி (*arisi*), the raw grain, and சாதம் (*sātam*), the cooked meal — and all that is served beside them.

உணவு, தயவுசெய்து. — *uṇavu, tayavuseytu* — Food, please.

Note the register. உணவு is the careful, written word — a menu, a sign. Around a family table people say சாப்பாடு (*sāppāḍu*).

The letters in this word

உ is a standing vowel — a full letter, not a sign. Then ண, then வு, which is வ with the *u* sign underneath. ண is the retroflex n you first wrote alongside ட, and the letter inside தண்ணீர்.

The letters in this word

Curl the tip of your tongue **back** to the roof of your mouth and release into the vowel. That is ண, and *uṇavu* gives it a clean run because the letter sits between two vowels. Contrast the ன of நன்றி and the ந of நீர், both made near the teeth.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

உணவு is உண் (*uṇ*), “to eat,” with a noun-forming ending. Food is literally *the eating*. Tamil has two eating verbs, of different ages:

the verb	where it lives
உண் <i>uṇ</i>	old, inherited, literary now
சாப்பிடு <i>sāppiḍu</i>	the everyday spoken verb

உண் is a bare inherited root, and the Dravidian dictionary lists *uṇavu* inside its entry.

சாப்பிடு is where the ground softens, so hold Chapter 32’s earlier account loosely. You were shown *sāppu*, “food,” plus இடு (*iḍu*), “to put.” The இடு is visible in the spelling; the first half is the problem. The great Tamil lexicon records no plain word *sāppu* meaning “food,” and the Dravidian etymological dictionary has **no entry for this verb at all**. It is not Sanskrit — Telugu and Malayalam have their own forms — but its origin is open. The word you would use at a table has the weaker paperwork.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the root and the noun — “uṇ ... uṇavu”
- the retroflex, tongue curled back — “uṇavu”
- the documented one, then the everyday one — “uṇ ... sāppiḍu”
- raw grain, then cooked meal — “arisi ... sātām”

Before you move on

What verb is *uṇavu* built on, and where does your tongue go for ண? (உண்; **curled back**.) Which eating verb would you use at a table, and how sure is anyone where it came from? (சாப்பிடு — **not at all**: the Dravidian dictionary has no entry.) Give the raw grain and the cooked meal. (*Arisi*; *sātām*.)

36.4 உணவு — the same vowel, twice, two ways

You have the ு sign — the *u* that hangs off a consonant, as in டு. But a word that *starts* on *u* has no consonant to hang it from, and by now you know what Tamil does about that.

Script you'll notice: உ

உ is the standing letter for short *u*. It is the rule you met with ஆ in ஆம், working again: a vowel that opens a word is written as a **full letter**, never as a sign.

உ	the letter — opens a word
ு	the sign — rides a consonant

The word you already say holds both. That is the whole lesson.

Read it; do not draw it yet. உ has no entry in this book's script data, so it gets no stroke order here.

Script you'll notice: build the word

piece

உ	<i>u</i>	independent — the word opens on a vowel
ண	<i>ṇa</i> , the retroflex <i>n</i>	first met beside ம
வு	<i>vu</i> — வ with the ு sign	வ was your first letter

உ · ண · வு → உணவு

Three pieces, and the first and last are the same vowel doing its two jobs: once standing on its own, once hanging off வ. The page keeps them apart so your eye can.

Your turn

- *Read it:* உ — then உணவு
- *Say it:* “uṇavu” — “food”
- *Contrast:* உ and வு — the letter that opens, the sign that rides
- *Contrast:* ஆம் and உணவு — the same opening rule, two vowels apart

Before you move on

Read உணவு. Why does it open with உ rather than the ு sign? (The word starts on a vowel — there is nothing for a sign to hang on.) Where else in the same word does that vowel appear, and in which form? (On வு, as the ு sign.) Which earlier word set this rule? (ஆம்.) Next: the word for a mistake.

36.5 தவறு (tavaru) — “a mistake,” and the rest of the apology

The chapter back: *tēnīr*, *pāl*, *uṇavu*. Suppose one arrives and it is not what you asked for. You have “sorry,” but not the word for what went wrong.

You’ll want to know: தவறு

தவறு — *tavaru* — a mistake, an error, a fault

With என் (*en*), “my,” and no verb — Tamil needs none:

மன்னிக்கவும், என் தவறு. பால் இல்லை, தேநீர்.

>

mannikkavum, en tavaru. pāl illai, tēnīr.

>

Sorry, my mistake. Not milk — tea.

மன்னிக்கவும் is the careful, written-leaning apology; in speech many Tamil speakers simply say *sorry*, in English. என் தவறு suits either.

The letters in this word

த + வ + று. The last piece is று, the hard r of *arai*, with the *u* sign — made at the ridge behind the teeth, tongue flat, not curled.

The apology in front of it does something this word does not. மன்னிக்கவும் has ன்னி: the alveolar ன switched off by a dot, then

written a second time with the *i* sign. Tamil doubles a consonant by **repeating the letter with a dot on the first**, never by inventing a joined shape — the க் of வணக்கம் over.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

தவறு is inherited Dravidian, a verb and a noun in one shape: “to slip, to fail,” and “a slip, a mistake.” The dictionary files it beside தப்பு (*tappu*); its cousins are everywhere.

Now the chapter in a line. மன்னிக்கவும் was the showpiece: Tamil kept its own மன்னி where Kannada, Telugu and Malayalam reached for Sanskrit *kṣamā*. தவறு is inherited too, and so is உண் inside *uṇavu*, and பால். But தேநீர் is half a loan from a Malay port, and சாதம் was flagged as Sanskrit-influenced when you met it.

So the honest statement is not “Tamil does not borrow.” It is that **Tamil borrows without evicting**: the inherited word stays, and the loan takes a different job or register.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “en̄ tavaru” — my mistake, with no verb in it
- the whole repair — “mannikkavum, en̄ tavaru”
- the two words for a mistake — “tavaru ... tappu”
- the borrowed one among this chapter’s words — “tēnīr”

Before you move on

Apologise, name the fault, and say why there is no word for “is” in it. (*Mannikkavum*, *en̄ tavaru*; **Tamil needs none**.) How does Tamil write a doubled consonant, as in மன்னி and க்? (**The letter a second time**, dot on the first.) Which apology verb is native where the neighbours took Sanskrit, and does that make Tamil a language that never borrows? (மன்னி, against *kṣamā*; **no** — it **borrows without evicting**.)

Chapter 37

Your Town, Your Friend

Modes: 👁 eyes (4) ✍ pen (1) 🗣 Hands-free start: first 2 of 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can ask உங்கள் ஊர் என்ன? and introduce someone with இவர் என் நண்பர், choose between நண்பன், நண்பி and நண்பர், run Tamil's இ / அ / எ pointing series, and hear ண voice the ட that follows it.

Say இவர் என் நண்பர் with no verb in it, pick the ending by respect rather than by habit, name the -ūr inside Tanjore and Bengalūru, and state what Tamil forces you to decide for a sibling that it does not force for a friend.

37.1 ஊர் (ūr) — “town,” and the question Tamil asks early

En tavaru — my mistake, a word that is a verb and a noun at once. Then the general word for food. (*Unavu*.) Now back to meeting somebody.

You'll want to know: ஊர்

ஊர் — *ūr* — town, village; the place you are from

That last sense matters most. உங்கள் ஊர் is your **native place**, where your family is from, which may be somewhere you have never lived.

உங்கள் ஊர் என்ன — *uṅgaḷ ūr enna* — **What is your town**

It lands early in a Tamil conversation and is not nosiness — the slot English fills with “what do you do.”

The letters in this word

ஊ is a standing vowel — long *ū*, partner of the **உ** that opens *uṇavu*. ற் is ர், the soft r, shut by a pulli. Hold the vowel: *ūr*, not *ur*. Vowel length is part of a word’s identity here.

Grammar Lens: the two registers, side by side

You met this choice on the age question:

the question	who you say it to
உன் ஊர் என்ன <i>un ūr enna</i>	a friend, a child, a peer
உங்கள் ஊர் என்ன <i>uṅgaḷ ūr enna</i>	a stranger, an elder, anyone senior

Both are possessive plus noun plus question word, with **no verb** — the shape you learned for **உன் வயசு என்ன**. Only the possessive changes, and with it the social temperature. When unsure, use **உங்கள்**.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ஊர் is inherited Dravidian, and welded into city names you know in English:

the English name	what it is
Tanjore	Tamil தஞ்சாவூர் <i>Taṅjāvūr</i>
Vellore	Tamil வேலூர் <i>Vēlūr</i>
Bangalore	Kannada ಬೆಂಗಳೂರು <i>Bengalūru</i>

Every one of those *-ore* endings is this word: the British ear turned *-ūr* into *-ore*, and the cities have taken their own names back.

Two exactnesses. Bangalore is a **Kannada** town, so its *-ūru* is Kannada’s form of the inherited word — the family’s, not Tamil’s alone. And the *first* halves are not all settled; *Vēl-* in Vellore is argued over. The ending is the certain part.

Weigh that against the rice word. அரிசி *may* stand behind English *rice* through Greek, and the dictionaries hedge. Nobody hedges about *-ūr*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the long vowel — “*ūr*,” not “*ur*”

- to a stranger — “uṅgaḷ ūr enna”
- to a friend — “uṇ ūr enna”
- the ending inside the map — “Taṅjāvūr ... Vēlūr ... Begaḷūru”

Before you move on

Ask a stranger where they are from, then a friend, and say what **ஊர்** means beyond “town.” (*Uṅgaḷ ūr enna*; *uṇ ūr enna*; **your native place**.) Which earlier question has this shape, and is *-ore* in Tanjore really this word? (**உன் வயசு என்ன**; **yes**.) How sure are we there, next to *arisi* and *rice*? (**Much surer**.)

37.2 நண்பன் (naṇban) — “friend,” with the ending doing the work

A stranger’s native place, then the ending inside Tanjore. (*Uṅgaḷ ūr enna*; *-ūr*.) Now the person you would introduce.

You’ll want to know: நண்பன்

நண்பன் — *naṇban* — **friend** (a man)

Tamil will not let you say a bare “friend” any more than a bare “brother.” The stem is **நண்ப-**; the ending decides.

the form	who it is
நண்பன் <i>naṇban</i>	a male friend
நண்பி <i>naṇbi</i>	a female friend
நண்பர் <i>naṇbar</i>	a friend spoken of with respect

The **-அர்** is the respectful plural that turns **நீ** into **நீங்கள்**, applied to a person.

This is a different axis from the family words. **அண்ணன்** and **தம்பி** split brothers by **age**; the friend words split by **sex**, **நண்பர்** by **respect**.

The letters in this word

ந + **ண்** + **ப** + **ன்** — every one of Tamil’s n-letters inside one word. **ந** opens it, dental, at the teeth. **ண்** is retroflex, tongue curled back, closed

by a pulli. ண் ends it, the alveolar n from நன்றி. The writing lesson gave them to you one at a time; here they arrive together.

The letters in this word

The letter after ண் is ப, named *pa*. This book writes *naṇban* because of the நன்றி rule: a nasal in front of a stop **voices it**. A Tamil reader supplies the voicing, as an English reader supplies the *sh* in *sugar*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Behind நண்பன் is நண்பு (*naṇbu*), “friendship, closeness,” which belongs to the root family of நண்ணு (*naṇṇu*), “to draw near.” A friend, in Tamil’s own accounting, is someone who came close. Be precise. The Dravidian dictionary files *naṇbu* and *naṇban* in the same entry as *naṇṇu*; the Tamil lexicon prefers நள-, making them siblings rather than parent and child. They differ on the line of descent, not on the household. Set it beside அப்பா and அம்மா, not built out of anything — the repeated-syllable shape children produce for parents worldwide. நண்பன் is assembled, from a root you can point at.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the three endings — “naṇban, naṇbi, naṇbar”
- the voicing after the nasal — “naṇri ... naṇban”
- the root it came from — “naṇṇu, to draw near”
- the family words that split on age instead — “aṇṇan, tambi”

Before you move on

Give the friend-word for a woman, a man, and someone you respect. (*Naṇbi; naṇban; naṇbar*.) Which axis do the friend words split on, and which do the brother words? (**Sex and respect; age**.) Why is ப heard as *b*, and are அப்பா and அம்மா built from a root the way *naṇban* is? (**A nasal voices the stop after it; no.**)

37.3 உளர் — the long partner

உ opened உணவு last chapter. Tamil writes its long vowels as separate letters from the short ones, so $\bar{u}$ gets a letter of its own.

Script you'll notice: உள

உள is the standing letter for long $\bar{u}$, and it is the long partner of உ — the fourth short-and-long pair the strand has handed you, after அ/ஆ, ி/ீ and ெ/ே.

உ	short u
உள	long $\bar{u}$

Read it; do not draw it yet. உள has no entry in this book's script data, and neither has உ — so neither gets a stroke order, and the pairing above, like the way the shorter letter sits inside the longer one, is what the page shows rather than something the data states.

Script you'll notice: build the word

piece		
உள	$\bar{u}$	independent — the word opens on a vowel
ர்	bare r — ர under a pulli	ர from சரி

உள · ர் → உளர்

Two pieces, and both were waiting for you. உளர் is the word for your own town, and holding it against உணவு shows the length doing real work: change the vowel and you change the word.

Your turn

- *Read it:* உள — then உளர்
- *Say it:* “ūr” — “town”

- *Contrast:* உ and ஊ — short and long, two letters
- *Read it:* உணவு and ஊர் together — the pair, side by side

Before you move on

Read ஊர். Which letter is ஊ's short partner, and where did you read it? (உ, opening உணவு.) Why is the vowel a full letter here rather than a sign? (**The word starts on it.**) What is the dot on ஃ doing? (**Removing the built-in a.**) Next: pointing someone out politely.

37.4 இவர் (ivar) — “this person,” and Tamil’s pointing system

Naṇban, naṇbi, naṇbar — and the root behind them. (*Naṇṇu*, to draw near.) You have the word for a friend, but cannot point at one.

You’ll want to know: இவர்

இவர் — *ivar* — **this person** (near me, spoken of respectfully)

Not “he” and not “she”: இவர் is what you say about a person standing here whom you are treating with respect, and it does not commit you to their sex. It is built on இவன் (*ivan*) and இவள் (*ival*), with the same -அர் that gave you நண்பர்.

One caution about speech: இவர் is heard mostly of men, and இவங்க (*ivaṅga*) does the same respectful job for a woman.

The letters in this word

இ + வ + ஃ. இ is the standing vowel *i* — the letter, not the ி sign that hangs on a consonant. வ is the *va* opening வணக்கம் and வீடு. ஃ is the soft *r* with a pulli.

A word this short is almost all arc, which is the moment to recall the usual explanation for that roundness: Tamil was scratched into palm leaf, and a straight stroke along the grain can split the leaf. Hold it as the writing lesson asked — **the standard account, not a settled fact**, since

the earliest Tamil writing was cut into stone and is angular. What survives is the useful part: **the tool leaves fingerprints on the letters.**

Grammar Lens: near, far, and which

இவர் is one cell of a system, and the system is a single letter at the front:

the front letter	what it does
இ-	points near — this one, here
அ-	points away — that one, there
எ-	asks — which one

So இவர் is “this person,” அவர் (*avar*) “that person,” எவர் (*avar*) “which person.” You have been using one front already: என்ன (*enna*), “what,” is the எ- of asking.

Two honest notes. எ- is the **question**, not a third distance. And Old Tamil had a genuine third distance, உ-, for something visible but far off; modern Tamil has retired it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the three fronts — “i- ... a- ... e-”
- the row they build — “ivar, avar, evar”
- the question word you already had — “enna”
- the respectful ending on both — “naṇbar ... ivar”

Before you move on

What do இ-, அ- and எ- do at the front of a word, and which question word you already knew is built on எ-? (**Near; away; asks** — and என்ன.) Does இவர் tell you whether the person is a man or a woman? (**No** — it marks **respect**; spoken Tamil leans இவங்க for a woman.) How firmly should you hold the palm-leaf explanation for the curves? (As **the standard account, not a settled fact.**)

37.5 இவர் என் நண்பர் — “this is my friend”

Ivar, avar, evar — near, away, the question. Then *naṇban, naṇbi, naṇbar*. Everything this lesson needs is in your mouth; what is left is the order.

You’ll want to know: the introduction

இவர் என் நண்பர். — *ivar eṇ naṇbar* — This is my friend.

Three words, and **not one of them is a verb**. Tamil links two nouns by setting them beside each other, as in **என் பெயர் ...** and **என் தவறு**.

The pieces in order: **இவர்**, the person here; **என்**, my; **நண்பர்**, friend-with-respect. Then stop.

The whole meeting:

— வணக்கம். இவர் என் நண்பர்.

>

— வணக்கம். உங்கள் ஊர் என்ன.

Every word in it is yours.

The letters in this word

என் is **எ** with **ன்**, the alveolar n dotted shut. **நண்பர்** opens on dental **ந**, turns on retroflex **ண்**, closes on **ர்**. So one line makes you produce **ன்** and **ண்** within a breath of each other — one at the ridge, the other with the tongue curled back. Hear that difference and the three-way n is no longer theory.

Why it’s said this way

நண்பர் rather than **நண்பன்** is a decision, not a default.

- **இவர் என் நண்பன்**. — a male friend, plainly stated; warm among peers.
- **இவர் என் நண்பி**. — a female friend, the matching plain form.
- **இவர் என் நண்பர்**. — the respectful ending; safe with

anyone, and right when either party is older or senior.

If unsure, take நண்பர். Over-respect is invisible; under-respect is not. Notice how differently Tamil makes you think from one word to the next. For a **sibling** it forces **age**: there is no bare “brother” — you must choose அண்ணன் or தம்பி, அக்கா or தங்கை, and say whether they are older or younger than you before you can say anything at all. For a **friend** it forces **sex or respect**. For **parents**, nothing: அப்பா and அம்மா came into the language whole. Tamil rarely lets you be vague about a relationship.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the introduction — “ivar en̄ naṇbar”
- the same line to a peer about a male friend — “ivar en̄ naṇbaṇ”
- the greeting and the question around it — “vaṇakkam ... uṅgaḷ ūr en̄na”
- what a sibling word forces you to decide — “aṇṇaṇ, older; tambi, younger”

Before you move on

Introduce a friend respectfully, and say how many verbs the sentence has. (*Ivar en̄ naṇbar*; **none**.) What does a sibling word force you to decide that a friend word does not? (**Whether they are older or younger** — *aṇṇaṇ* against *tambi*.) Which friend ending is safe when unsure, and what does இ- tell your listener? (நண்பர்; that the person is **near**.)

Chapter 38

Keeping Well, and Leaving

Modes: 👁 eyes (3) ✍ pen (1) 🖐 Hands-free start: first 3 of 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can ask உங்கள் உடம்பு எப்படி இருக்கு?, recognise சுகமா? and place it as the Sanskrit-derived option beside native நலம், say விடை பெறுகிறேன், and show that விடு, வீடு and விடை are one root while ஊர் and நண்பன் are not.

Close the visit with நன்றி. விடை பெறுகிறேன்., put விடு, வீடு and விடை in one dictionary entry, refuse the second விடை that means 'bull' and came from Sanskrit, and refuse to join ஊர் and நண்பன் to the pattern just because they are nearby.

38.1 உடம்பு (uḍambu) — “body,” and how Tamil asks after your health

Introduce a friend respectfully and name the ending. (*Ivar en naṇbar* — the respectful -அர்.) Next you would ask how they are.

You'll want to know: உடம்பு

உடம்பு — *uḍambu* — body

The whole of it, not a part. You have தலை (*talai*) and கை (*kai*) already; this is what they belong to, and the word inside the question Tamil speakers actually ask:

உங்கள் உடம்பு எப்படி இருக்கு — *uṅgal uḍambu eppaḍi irukku* — **how is your body**, that is, **how are you keeping**

Every piece is yours: உங்கள், எப்படி, and இருக்கு from இரு. What is new is that the health question hangs on a **noun** rather than on you.

Tamil has a second way to ask it, through உணவு — the noun standing on உண், “to eat.” Asking whether somebody has eaten is asking whether they are all right.

The letters in this word

உ + ட + ம் + பு: the standing vowel *u*, ட, then ம் — ம shut by the pulli you have used since வணக்கம் — and பு. ம was one of the first letters you formed with a pen, alongside retroflex ண.

The letters in this word

The letters say *u-ṭa-m-pu*; your mouth says *uḍambu*. ட sits between vowels, so it softens — the *padi* rule. பு follows the nasal ம், so it voices — the *nanri* rule that also made *nanban*. Two rules, one short word, neither written down.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Tamil has another word for the body, உடல் (*uḍal*), and the Dravidian dictionary does not treat them as rivals: உடல், உடம்பு and உடலம் sit in the **same entry**, with Kannada’s உಡಲು beside them. Usage has divided them: உடல் leans literary, உடம்பு is what you say aloud about someone unwell.

Grammar Lens: where the person goes in a health question

Two shapes Tamil uses to ask about a state:

the question	where the person sits
உங்கள் உடம்பு எப்படி இருக்கு	as a possessor
உனக்கு எத்தனை வயது ஆகிறது	in the dative

The formal age question does not make you the subject at all — “**to you**, how many years are becoming.” The body question makes உடம்பு the subject.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the two softenings — “uṭampu ... uḍambu”
- the question — “uṅgaḷ uḍambu eppaḍi irukku”
- the parts, the whole, and the two forms of one root — “talai, kai ... uḍambu ... uḍal”

Before you move on

Ask someone respectfully how they are keeping, through the body, and name the two sound rules inside *uḍambu*. (*Uṅgaḷ uḍambu eppaḍi irukku*; ʌ softens **between vowels**, ɹ voices **after a nasal**.) Are உடல் and உடம்பு different words, and where does the person sit in the formal age question? (**No**, same entry; **in the dative**.)

38.2 சுகம் (sugam) — “ease,” the word Tamil did borrow

Health through the body, and the other body-word in its entry. (*Uṅgaḷ uḍambu eppaḍi irukku*; uḍal.) A second answer came from abroad.

You’ll want to know: சுகம்

சுகம் — *sugam* — wellbeing, ease, comfort

The க is doing its old trick: the letter is *ka*, but between vowels it comes out *g*. *Su-g-am*, not *su-ka-m*.

சுகமா — *sugamā* — keeping well

It is **not** the ordinary Tamil “how are you,” which is நல்லா இருக்கீங்களா. சுகமா is warmer and more Sanskritic, and which you hear depends on somebody’s ஊர் — the native place whose name so often ends in *-ūr*.

The letters in this word

சு + க + ம்: ச with the *u* sign, a bare க, ம closed by the pulli. Nothing is doubled — hold that against மன்னிக்கவும், where ன்னி has ன dotted shut and written a second time, and க்க does the same to க.

Grammar Lens: where the dative is required

சுகமா has no dative in it, and a family of Tamil states demands one: எனக்குத் தமிழ் தெரியும், “to me, Tamil is known.” Put a noun there and the shapes part:

the phrase	what happened
நான் to எனக்கு	the pronoun changes its body
நண்பர் to நண்பருக்கு	the noun just takes -உக்கு

So நண்பருக்குத் தமிழ் தெரியும், and the formal age question does the same: உனக்கு எத்தனை வயது ஆகிறது. சுகமா does not: knowing and ageing come *to* a person; being well is what a person **is**.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

சுகம் is Sanskrit सुख (*sukha*), “ease” — the apology lesson in reverse. There, மன்னிக்கவும் stood on Tamil’s own மன்னி while the neighbours built their “sorry” on Sanskrit *kṣamā*. Here Tamil borrowed *sukha* and **kept** நலம் as the everyday word; Malayalam took the same loan, സുഖം, as its ordinary greeting. The old parse of *sukha* is *su-* “good” plus *kha* “aperture” — a chariot’s axle-hole. **Treat that as contested:** the standard Sanskrit dictionary hedges it with “said to be,” and offers *su-stha*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the softened க — “sugam,” not “sukam”
- the state that needs a dative — “naṇbarukkuṭ tamīl teriyum”
- the state that does not, and the word kept beside it — “sugamā ... nalam”

Before you move on

Why is க heard as *g*, and what did the noun do that நான் does not? (**Between vowels**; it **takes** -உக்கு, while நான் becomes எனக்கு.) Which word did Tamil borrow, which did it keep, and how firm is the “good axle-hole” story? (சுகம்; நலம்; **contested**.)

38.3 விடை (vidai) — “leave,” and the root under the house

Sugam — which language it came from, and which Tamil word stayed beside it. (Sanskrit; நலம்.) You came through the door, took the நாற்காலி — four legs, counted out — were given tea, said என் தவறு when the wrong cup arrived, and introduced a friend. One thing is left.

You’ll want to know: விடை

விடை — *vidai* — leave; permission to depart

Not the act of going — you have போய் வருகிறேன் for that — but the **leave itself**, taken with பெறு (*peru*), “to obtain”:

நன்றி. விடை பெறுகிறேன். — *nanri. vidai perugirēn.* —
Thank you. I take my leave.

It is **formal and slightly literary**; leaving a friend’s house you would say போய் வருகிறேன்.

The தயவுசெய்து you learned for asking has a family across the Dravidian languages, all built on the same *daya*, “kindness,” plus a light verb. Leaving is not.

The letters in this word

வி + டை. வி is வ with the ி sign — the first vowel sign you learned, which made நன்றி possible. டை is ட with the ஐ sign ை, which wraps around the front.

நன்றி stands beside it above, so read it once more: ந + ன் + றி — dental n, alveolar n dotted shut, hard ற with that same ி. And பெறுகிறேன் has a க between vowels, so it softens.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

விடை is inherited Dravidian, and belongs to விடு (*viḍu*), “to let go.” Leave is what you are *let go* with.

Now the first word of these lessons. வீடு, “house,” is filed by the Dravidian dictionary in the **same entry as** விடு — and விடை is in it too:

the word	what it is
விடு <i>viḍu</i>	to let go, to release
வீடு <i>vīḍu</i>	the house — and, in the old sense, final release
விடை <i>viḍai</i>	leave to depart

You walked in through வீடு and walk out through விடை, one word in different clothes. Kannada’s ಬೀಡು, the same house with its *b*-, sits on that root as well.

Two cautions, because a neat pattern is when to slow down. A second விடை means “bull,” a Sanskrit borrowing from *vr̥ṣa*; and ஊர் — the settlement inside Tanjore — and நண்பன் are outside this root entirely.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the departure — “nanri. viḍai perugirēn.”
- the one root, three ways — “viḍu ... vīḍu ... viḍai”
- the two that do not join it — “ūr ... naṇban”

Before you move on

Take your leave formally, thanks in front of it, and name the earlier word that shares this root. (*Nanri. viḍai perugirēn.*; வீடு, from விடு, “to let go.”) Do ஊர் and நண்பன் belong to that root? (No — a settlement and a closeness; not everything joins up.)

38.4 மூன்று — the fourth corner of the u-family

Three corners of one family are already yours: உ and ஊ, the letters that open a word, and ஁, the short sign that rides a

consonant. One corner is missing, and you can guess what it does.

Script you’ll notice: the ூ sign

ூ is the sign for long $\bar{u}$ — the long partner of ு, exactly as ஁ is the long partner of ஁. Both members of each pair, in both jobs:

	opens a word	rides a consonant
short u	஁	ு
long $\bar{u}$	஁	ூ

ம + ூ → மூ, said $m\bar{u}$.

The four corners are a pattern, not the whole system. Short **a** is the vowel with no sign at all: the data says a consonant carries a built-in a until a mark replaces it, which is why க needs nothing to be ka . Nor do signs all sit in one place — the ூ you met in இல்லை is written to the LEFT of its consonant, which the data does say; where ு and ூ sit is this lesson’s own description, since the data has no entry for either.

Read it; do not draw it yet. None of ஁, ஁, ு or ூ has an entry in this book’s script data, so none of them gets a stroke order, and the pairing above is what the page shows rather than something the data states.

Script you’ll notice: build the word

piece		
மூ	$m\bar{u}$ — ம with the ூ sign	ம from வணக்கம்
ன்	bare $\bar{n}$ — ன under a pulli	the alveolar n
று	ru — ற, the hard r , with the ு sign	ற from நன்றி

மூ · ன் · று → மூன்று

Three pieces, one new sign. மூன்று is “three” — a word you have counted with since chapter 7, and now one you can read. It joins இரண்டு,

நான்கு, ஆறு, எட்டு and பத்து, whose letters the strand has already given you; ஐந்து and ஏழு still wait on letters this book has not taught, and ஒன்று and ஒன்பது wait on one it is about to.

Your turn

- *Read it:* மூ — then மூன்று
- *Say it:* “mūnru” — “three”
- *Contrast:* று and மூ — the short sign and the long one, both riding
- *Contrast:* ஊர் and மூன்று — long $\bar{u}$ standing, then long $\bar{u}$ riding

Before you move on

Read மூன்று. Which sign is ூ’s short partner, and which letter is its standing form? (ஃ, and ஊ.) Name the four corners of that family. (உ ஊ standing, ூ ூ riding.) What is the dot on ன் doing? (**Removing the built-in a.**) Next: asking for what you want.

Chapter 39

Asking for What You Want

Modes: 👁 eyes (3) ✍ pen (1) 🖐 Hands-free start: first 3 of 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say எனக்குத் ... வேண்டும் with myself in the dative and no subject at all, decline with வேண்டாம் rather than இல்லை, ask a price with எவ்வளவு and say why age took எத்தனை instead, put ஒரு in front of a noun where ஒன்று cannot go, and read ஒ in both shapes of “one”.

Order one tea end to end — ask தேநீர் எவ்வளவு?, say ஒரு தேநீர் வேண்டும், decline the second with வேண்டாம் — and say why ஒன்று cannot stand in front of the noun.

39.1 வேண்டும் (vēṇḍum) — “I want,” with no I in it

Say “I know Tamil” and name what is missing. (*Enakkut tamil teriyum* — **no subject**; knowing happens **to** you.) You have met that shape with தெரியும், புரிகிறது and பிடிக்கும். Here it is on the verb that asks for things.

You’ll want to know: வேண்டும்

வேண்டும் — *vēṇḍum* — is wanted, that is, I want / I need

எனக்குத் தண்ணீர் வேண்டும் — *enakkut taṇṇīr vēṇḍum* — to me, water is wanted

English makes wanting something you do. Tamil does not: the thing wanted is the subject, and you sit in the **dative** — எனக்கு, the irregular one whose pronoun changes body before the suffix lands. Swap it and you change who wants it, with nothing else touched: உங்களுக்குத் தண்ணீர் வேண்டும் — the joining த் survives the swap, because it is the **dative** that licenses it. Compare நான் தமிழ் பேசுகிறேன்: same hard த in front, no dative behind, no doubling.

The letters in this word

வே + ண் + டு + ம்: வ with the ே of பேசு, retroflex ண under a pulli, ட from எப்படி with the ு of இருக்கிறீர்கள், and ம under a pulli — a four-piece word the strand owes you nothing for.

The letters in this word

The letters say *vē-n-tu-m*; your mouth says *vēṇḍum*. ட follows the nasal ண், so it voices — the நன்றி rule, as in *naṇban*.

Grammar Lens: the negative comes from somewhere else

You have negated with இல்லை since chapter 1. This verb refuses it.

I want it	வேண்டும்
I don't want it	வேண்டாம்

Not *vēṇḍum illai*. Tamil supplies a **separate negative word** on the same வேண்ட- stem. வேண்டாம் declines politely; இல்லை is understood, but sounds translated.

Your turn

- *Say it*: “enakkut taṇṇīr vēṇḍum” — and hear that no *I* is doing anything
- *Read it*: தண்ணீர் — the word from the rice-and-water pair, unchanged
- *Say it*: yours, then theirs — “enakkut taṇṇīr vēṇḍum” ... “uṅgalukkut taṇṇīr vēṇḍum”
- *Read it*: வேண்டும் — four pieces, no new letters

Before you move on

Ask for water, and say where you sit in it. (*Enakkut taṇṇīr vēṇḍum*; **in the dative.**) Why not இல்லை to decline? (வேண்டாம் — a **separate negative word.**) Why does ட sound like *d*? (A **nasal** in front.) Next: how to ask what it costs.

39.2 எவ்வளவு (evvaḷavu) — “how much,” and the question it is not

Ask for water, with yourself in the right case. (*Enakkut taṇṇīr vēṇḍum.*) Now you need the other half of any transaction: what it costs.

You’ll want to know: எவ்வளவு

எவ்வளவு — *evvaḷavu* — **how much**

தேநீர் எவ்வளவு? — *tēnīr evvaḷavu?* — **how much is the tea?**

It opens with the எ- that starts every Tamil question word you have met — எப்படி, எத்தனை, என்ன, எவர். That does not run the other way — என், எனக்கு and எட்டு open with it too — but no question word you have met starts anywhere else.

Grammar Lens: measure or count

English has two phrases for this too, and lets you slide between them. Tamil does not: the choice is lexical, and the line falls in the same place:

	asks about	example
எத்தனை	things you count, one by one	எத்தனை வயது — how many years
எவ்வளவு	quantity, extent, price	தேநீர் எவ்வளவு — how much is the tea

You already used எத்தனை for age, because years are counted. Money is not counted that way — you ask எவ்வளவு for a price even when the answer comes back as a number of rupees.

The test is not whether an answer has digits in it. It is whether the language treats the thing as a **heap** or as a **row**.

The letters in this word

எ + வ் + வ + ள + வு: the standing எ from என், then வ shut by a pulli and வ again, the retroflex ள from நீங்கள், and வ a third time carrying the ு sign.

Three வs in a five-piece word. The doubled வ்வ at the front is what makes it sound clipped rather than drawled.

Your turn

- *Say it:* “tēnīr evvaḷavu?” — then answer yourself with a number
- *Contrast:* “ettanai vayathu” and “tēnīr evvaḷavu” — counted, measured
- *Read it:* எவ்வளவு — find all three வ

Before you move on

Ask what the tea costs. (*Tēnīr evvaḷavu?*) Which question word did age take, and why is price different? (எத்தனை — years are **counted**; price asks about **quantity**.) What do all these question words share at the front? (எ-.) Next: how Tamil says “one” when it is not counting.

39.3 ஒரு (oru) — “one,” when it is not counting

Ask what the tea costs, then ask for it. (*Tēnīr evvaḷavu? ... Enakku ... vēṇḍum.*) One word is missing from the middle of that: how many.

You’ll want to know: ஒரு

ஒரு — *oru* — a, one

ஒரு தேநீர் வேண்டும் — *oru tēnīr vēṇḍum* — one tea, please

You learned ஒன்று in chapter 7 as the number one. ஒரு is the same word in the shape it takes when it leans on a noun. Tamil will not let you say *onru tēnīr*.

Grammar Lens: the counting form and the leaning form

	shape	where it stands
the number itself	ஒன்று	alone — counting, answering “how many”
in front of a noun	ஒரு	ஒரு தேநீர், ஒரு நாள்

Other numbers have paired shapes of their own. This book does not set out to list them — meet ஒரு here, and expect the pattern rather than a rule.

This is also how Tamil manages without the word “a.” There is no article in the language; ஒரு does that work when you want it done, and nothing does it when you do not. தேநீர் வேண்டும் is perfectly good — it just does not specify one.

The letters in this word

ஒ + ரு: a standing vowel, then ர — one of the two *r*-letters, from சரி — carrying the ு sign.

ஒ is one of three standing vowels the book still owes you; ஏ and ஐ are the others, and they are still outstanding. ஒ goes first because it opens both ஒரு and ஒன்று, and the next lesson pays it.

Your turn

Order something, start to finish.

- *Say it:* “tēnīr evvaḷavu?”
- *Say it:* “oru tēnīr vēṇḍum”
- *Say it:* decline a second one — “vēṇḍām”
- *Contrast:* “onru” alone, “oru tēnīr” in front of a noun

Before you move on

Order one tea and refuse a second. (*Oru tēnīr vēṇḍum ... vēṇḍām.*)
 Why not *onru tēnīr*? (ஒன்று is the **counting** shape; in front of a noun the word **leans** and becomes ஒரு.) Does Tamil have a word for “a”? (No — ஒரு does that work when you want it.) Next: the letter both shapes begin with.

39.4 ஒன்று — the letter under both shapes of “one”

You have just used ஒரு in front of a noun and ஒன்று on its own. Both begin with the same letter — one this book has printed since chapter 7 and the writing strand has never once opened up.

Script you’ll notice: ஒ

ஒ — *o* — a standing vowel: the form that opens a word, rather than a sign that rides a consonant

It joins the standing vowels you already read: அ ஆ இ உ ஊ எ. Those seven do not exhaust Tamil’s twelve — this book teaches the ones its own words need. ஒ goes first of the three because it opens the most words in this book: ஒரு, ஒன்று, and ஒன்பது, which chapter 7 showed you carrying the same ஒன்- at its front.

Read it; do not draw it yet. ஒ has no entry in this book’s script data, so it gets no stroke order, and nothing here describes how the pen moves.

Script you’ll notice: build the word

piece

ஒ	<i>o</i>	this lesson
ன்	bare <i>n</i> — ன under a pulli	the alveolar <i>n</i>
று	<i>ru</i> — ற with the ு sign	ற from நன்றி

ஒ • ன் • று → ஒன்று

The last two pieces are the ones you built மூன்று from, in the same order. Three and one differ only in what stands in front of ன்று.

Script you'll notice: the same letter, the shorter word

ஒ + ரு → ஒரு

Two pieces, and you can read the form that leans on a noun as well as the form that counts. ஒரு தேநீர் is now a line you can order aloud and read off a board.

Your turn

- *Read it:* ஒ — then ஒரு — then ஒன்று
- *Contrast:* ஒன்று and மூன்று — same ன்று, and மூ carries the ூ sign where ஒ stands alone
- *Say it:* “oru ... onru” — the leaning shape, then the counting one

Before you move on

Read ஒன்று, then ஒரு. What do ஒன்று and மூன்று share, and where do they differ? (They share ன்று at the end; they differ in the piece that opens them.) What is the dot on ன் doing?
(**Removing the built-in a.**)

Chapter 40

Pointing, and Asking

Modes: ⇄ voice (7) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 7 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can point at something in Tamil and ask who or where it is — and I can say what the six words have in common.

Say the near word, the far word and the question word in a row, and name the part that changed.

40.1 இது (idu) — this one — the thing near me

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You’ll want to know: இது

இது — *idu* — this one — the thing near me.

Say it, and point while you say it. That is the whole word: it does not mean anything on its own, it means whatever your finger is on.

Its partner is அது *adu*, which you will meet in a moment. The two of them differ by one sound at the front — **i-** for near — and that is not a coincidence. It is the whole system, and the last lesson of this chapter says so.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “இது” three times, pointing at something different each time

- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *idu*? (this one — the thing near me.) What sound does it start with, and does that sound mean near, far, or a question? (**i-** — near.)

40.2 அது (adu) — that one — the thing over there

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: அது

அது — *adu* — that one — the thing over there.

Say it, and point while you say it. That is the whole word: it does not mean anything on its own, it means whatever your finger is on.

Its partner is இது *idu*, which you will meet just now. The two of them differ by one sound at the front — **a-** for far — and that is not a coincidence. It is the whole system, and the last lesson of this chapter says so.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “அது” three times, pointing at something different each time
- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *adu*? (that one — the thing over there.) What sound does it start with, and does that sound mean near, far, or a question? (**a-** — far.)

40.3 இங்கே (ingē) — here — where I am

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: இங்கே

இங்கே — *iṅgē* — here — where I am.

Say it, and point while you say it. That is the whole word: it does not mean anything on its own, it means whatever your finger is on.

Its partner is அங்கே *aṅgē*, which you will meet in a moment. The two of them differ by one sound at the front — **i-** for near — and that is not a coincidence. It is the whole system, and the last lesson of this chapter says so.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “இங்கே” three times, pointing at something different each time
- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *iṅgē*? (here — where I am.) What sound does it start with, and does that sound mean near, far, or a question? (**i-** — near.)

40.4 அங்கே (*aṅgē*) — there — where I am not

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: அங்கே

அங்கே — *aṅgē* — there — where I am not.

Say it, and point while you say it. That is the whole word: it does not mean anything on its own, it means whatever your finger is on.

Its partner is இங்கே *iṅgē*, which you will meet just now. The two of them differ by one sound at the front — **a-** for far — and that is not a coincidence. It is the whole system, and the last lesson of this chapter says so.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “அங்கே” three times, pointing at something different each time

- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *aṅgē*? (there — where I am not.) What sound does it start with, and does that sound mean near, far, or a question? (**a-** — far.)

40.5 யார் (*yār*) — who? — asking about a person

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: யார்

யார் — *yār* — who? — asking about a person.

Say it, and point while you say it. That is the whole word: it does not mean anything on its own, it means whatever your finger is on.

Its partner is எங்கே *eṅgē*, which you will meet in a moment. The two of them differ by one sound at the front — **e-** for ask — and that is not a coincidence. It is the whole system, and the last lesson of this chapter says so.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “யார்” three times, pointing at something different each time
- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *yār*? (who? — asking about a person.) What sound does it start with, and does that sound mean near, far, or a question? (**e-** — ask.)

40.6 எங்கே (*eṅgē*) — where? — asking about a place

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: எங்கே

எங்கே — *eṅḡē* — where? — asking about a place.

Say it, and point while you say it. That is the whole word: it does not mean anything on its own, it means whatever your finger is on.

Its partner is யார் *yār*, which you will meet just now. The two of them differ by one sound at the front — **e-** for ask — and that is not a coincidence. It is the whole system, and the last lesson of this chapter says so.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “எங்கே” three times, pointing at something different each time
- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *eṅḡē*? (where? — asking about a place.) What sound does it start with, and does that sound mean near, far, or a question? (**e-** — ask.)

40.7 i- / a- / e- — six words, one machine

Say the six words from this chapter out loud, in order. Listen to how they begin.

Grammar lens: one slot changes

You did not learn six words. You learned **three beginnings** and reused them.

meaning	word
near	இங்கே <i>iṅḡē</i>
far	அங்கே <i>aṅḡē</i>
question	எங்கே <i>eṅḡē</i>

Tamil shows the system at its cleanest: இது, அது, எது differ in one letter.

Change the front, and the meaning walks from **near** to **far** to **a question**. Nothing else in the word moves.

The same three beginnings run the thing-words too: இது *idu* and அது *adu* start exactly like the first two rows. This chapter did not teach you the matching question word for things — that one arrives later, and when it does you will already know what it has to start with. This is worth more than the six words are. When you meet a new word in this family later, you will not have to be taught all three of it — you will be taught one and work out the others.

Your turn

- *Say it:* the near word, then the far word, then the question word
- *Say it:* them again for place, not for things
- *Notice:* the part that did NOT change

Before you move on

Which beginning means near? (**i-**) Far? (**a-**) And which one turns the word into a question? (**e-**)

Chapter 41

Describing Things

Modes: 🗣️ voice (6) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 6 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can point at something in Tamil and ask who or where it is — and I can say what the six words have in common.

Say the near word, the far word and the question word in a row, and name the part that changed.

41.1 பெரிய (periya) — big

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: பெரிய

பெரிய — *periya* — big.

Put it in front of a word you already know and you have said something new. That is all an adjective does in this language.

The last lesson of this chapter gives the one rule that governs every adjective you will ever meet here.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “பெரிய” three times, pointing at something different each time
- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *periya*? (**big.**) Where does it go — before the word it describes, or after? (**Before.**)

41.2 சிறிய (*siriya*) — small

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: சிறிய

சிறிய — *siriya* — small.

Put it in front of a word you already know and you have said something new. That is all an adjective does in this language.

You met பெரிய *periya* a moment ago. Put them side by side and nothing about either one changes.

The last lesson of this chapter gives the one rule that governs every adjective you will ever meet here.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “சிறிய” three times, pointing at something different each time
- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *siriya*? (**small.**) Where does it go — before the word it describes, or after? (**Before.**)

41.3 நல்ல (*nalla*) — good

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: நல்ல

நல்ல — *nalla* — good.

Put it in front of a word you already know and you have said something new. That is all an adjective does in this language.

You met சிறிய *siriya* a moment ago. Put them side by side and nothing about either one changes.

The last lesson of this chapter gives the one rule that governs every adjective you will ever meet here.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “நல்ல” three times, pointing at something different each time
- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *nalla*? (**good.**) Where does it go — before the word it describes, or after? (**Before.**)

41.4 புதிய (pudiya) — new

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: புதிய

புதிய — *pudiya* — new.

Put it in front of a word you already know and you have said something new. That is all an adjective does in this language.

You met நல்ல *nalla* a moment ago. Put them side by side and nothing about either one changes.

The last lesson of this chapter gives the one rule that governs every adjective you will ever meet here.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “புதிய” three times, pointing at something different each time

- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *pudiya*? (**new.**) Where does it go — before the word it describes, or after? (**Before.**)

41.5 பழைய (*palaiya*) — old — of a thing, not of a person

You can already name things. This is how you POINT at them.

You'll want to know: பழைய

பழைய — *palaiya* — old — of a thing, not of a person.

Put it in front of a word you already know and you have said something new. That is all an adjective does in this language.

You met புதிய *pudiya* a moment ago. Put them side by side and nothing about either one changes.

The last lesson of this chapter gives the one rule that governs every adjective you will ever meet here.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “பழைய” three times, pointing at something different each time
- it once with a word you already know after it

Before you move on

What is *palaiya*? (**old — of a thing, not of a person.**) Where does it go — before the word it describes, or after? (**Before.**)

41.6 before the noun, unchanged — five words, one rule

Say the five words from this chapter out loud, then say each one in front of a noun you already know.

Grammar lens: where an adjective goes

You did not learn five separate words. You learned **where an adjective goes**, and five words that go there.

meaning	word
big	பெரிய <i>periya</i>
small	சிறிய <i>siriya</i>
good	நல்ல <i>nalla</i>

Every one of them ends in -a and none of them ever changes.

This is worth more than the five words are. Every noun you already know — your name, the house, the water, the day — can now take any of them in front, and every adjective you meet from here goes in the same place.

Your turn

- *Say it*: each of the five in front of a noun you already know
- *Say it*: two of them with the same noun, one after the other
- *Notice*: whether the adjective changed shape when the noun did

Before you move on

Where does an adjective go in this language? (**In front of the noun.**) Does it change shape to match the noun? (unchanged.)

Chapter 42

More Everyday Verbs

Modes: ⇄ voice (4) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can tell someone to come, sit, read and give in Tamil.

Complete TA-C42-give and say all four verbs in order.

42.1 வா (vā) — come

A short run of everyday verbs, one at a time.

You'll want to know: வா

வா (vā) — “come”.

One syllable, and a complete sentence. The first thing said at a doorway, and the shortest verb form Tamil has: the bare stem, with nothing added.

What you've built

One more everyday action. Three follow, and each reuses the ones before.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- vā
- it once more, slowly

Before you move on

What does வா mean? (“come”.) Say it once more.

42.2 உட்கார் (uṭkāṛ) — sit

Before the new one: what did *vā* mean?

You’ll want to know: உட்கார்

உட்கார் (*uṭkāṛ*) — “sit”.

Built from *ul*, ‘inside’, and *kār* — to settle oneself in. Tamil often builds a verb from a place-word plus an action this way.

What you’ve built

One more everyday action. Three follow, and each reuses the ones before.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *uṭkāṛ*
- it once more, slowly
- it after *vā*, so the two sit together

Before you move on

What does உட்கார் mean? (“sit”.) Say it once more.

42.3 படி (paṭi) — read

Before the new one: what did *uṭkāṛ* mean?

You'll want to know: படி

படி (*paṭi*) — “read”.

Also ‘to study’. The same word covers reading a page and studying a subject, so a student *paṭikkirār* whether they are holding a book or not.

What you've built

One more everyday action. Three follow, and each reuses the ones before.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *paṭi*
- it once more, slowly
- it after *uṭkār*, so the two sit together

Before you move on

What does படி mean? (“read”.) Say it once more.

42.4 கொடு (*koṭu*) — give

Before the new one: what did *paṭi* mean?

You'll want to know: கொடு

கொடு (*koṭu*) — “give”.

The everyday ‘give’. Tamil distinguishes giving away from giving toward the speaker; this is the giving-away one.

What you've built

That closes the run: four more actions, each met on its own.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *koṭu*
- it once more, slowly
- it after *paṭi*, so the two sit together

Before you move on

What does கொடு mean? (“give”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 43

The Household

Modes: 🗣️ voice (4) 🗋️ Hands-free start: all 4 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name a child, a son, a daughter and the family in Tamil.

Complete TA-C43-family and say all four words in order.

43.1 குழந்தை (kulaṇḍai) — child

Before the new one: what did *koṭu* mean?

You'll want to know: குழந்தை

குழந்தை (*kulaṇḍai*) — “child”.

Take it apart and the stem is *kula-*, ‘young, tender’, closed off into a noun by *-ṇḍai*. The same stem stands behind *kulaṇḍi*, ‘infant’. Nothing in the word says boy or girl: it names the age, not the sex.

What you've built

The first of four words for the people in a house. Three follow, and each reuses the ones before.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kulaṇḍai*

- it once more, slowly
- it after *koṭu*, so the two sit together

Before you move on

What does குழந்தை mean? (“child”.) Say it once more.

43.2 மகன் (*makan*) — son

Before the new one: what did *kulandai* mean?

You’ll want to know: மகன்

மகன் (*makan*) — “son”.

The stem is *maka-*, an old Dravidian word for offspring, and *-an* is the ending Tamil puts on a male person — the same *-an* already sitting on *naṇban*, ‘friend’. So the word assembles in front of you: offspring, then male.

What you’ve built

A second word for the house, and an ending you had already met elsewhere.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *makan*
- it once more, slowly
- it after *kulandai*, so the two sit together

Before you move on

What does மகன் mean? (“son”.) Say it once more.

43.3 மகள் (*makal*) — daughter

Before the new one: what did *makan* mean?

You'll want to know: மகள்

மகள் (*makaḷ*) — “daughter”.

The same *maka-* stem as the last lesson, with *-aḷ* where that word had *-an*: one ending marks a woman, the other a man. The sibling words you met earlier needed four separate forms to split brother from sister by age; here a single stem does the work of two. Malayalam's *makan* and *makaḷ* match Tamil almost letter for letter.

What you've built

One stem, two endings, two people. One more word closes the chapter.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *makaḷ*
- it once more, slowly
- it after *makan*, and hear only the ending move

Before you move on

What does மகள் mean? (“daughter”.) Say it once more.

43.4 குடும்பம் (*kuṭumbam*) — family

Before the new one: what did *makaḷ* mean?

You'll want to know: குடும்பம்

குடும்பம் (*kuṭumbam*) — “family”.

The collective word the family lesson never needed, because அப்பா, அம்மா and the four sibling words each named one particular person. It comes from Sanskrit *kuṭumba*, ‘household’ — which Sanskrit itself appears to have taken from a Dravidian source before handing it back — and the *-am* on the end is what Tamil gives such borrowings.

What you've built

That closes the run: child, son, daughter, and the word for all of them together.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kuṭumbam*
- it once more, slowly
- it after *makal*, so the two sit together

Before you move on

What does குடும்பம் mean? (“family”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 44

Things You Ask For

Modes: ⇄ voice (5) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name five everyday things I might ask somebody for in Tamil, and say which of them Tamil has held all along and which arrived from elsewhere.

Complete TA-C44-book and say all five words in order.

44.1 பழம் (paḷam) — a fruit

Before the new run of words: what did *makal* mean, and what did *kuṭumbam* mean?

You’ll want to know: பழம்

பழம் (*paḷam*) — “a fruit”.

Underneath it is a root about ripening. Proto-Dravidian ***pal**, ‘to ripen, to grow old’, handed this family both a fruit and an age, and Tamil kept the pair close enough to hear: *palaiya*, the “old” from the run of describing words, is that same root wearing a different ending. Ripe and old are one idea seen twice.

Malayalam says പഴം, very nearly the identical word — the ordinary state of affairs between the two closest sisters. Telugu went to పండు (*paṇḍu*) and Kannada to ಹಣ್ಣು (*haṇṇu*), and the Kannada form has lost its opening *p*- to a shift Tamil sat out entirely.

The ூ in the middle is the letter this book has already spent a writing lesson on, the one only these two sisters still write.

What you've built

The first of five things you might ask somebody for.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *palam*
- it once more, slowly
- *palam*, then *tayavu seytu palam koṭuṅgaḷ* — “please give a fruit”

Before you move on

What does பழம் mean? (“a fruit”.) Say it once more.

44.2 துணி (tuṇi) — cloth

Before the new one: what did *palam* mean?

You'll want to know: துணி

துணி (*tuṇi*) — “cloth”.

One shape, two jobs. *tuṇi* is the cloth you wear or wipe your hands on, and *tuṇi* is also ‘to dare, to resolve’. Nothing joins them but sound, and the sentence around them settles which is meant — the ordinary way a language carries two words in one skin.

Malayalam keeps തുണി unchanged. Telugu and Kannada reach for something else here, so this is one of the places where the two closest sisters agree and the other two go their own way.

What you've built

Two: something to eat and something to wear.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *tuṇi*

- it once more, slowly
- *pa_lam*, then *tu_{ṇi}*, so the two sit together

Before you move on

What does துணி mean? (“cloth”.) Say it once more.

44.3 விளக்கு (*viḷakku*) — a lamp

Before the new one: what did *tu_{ṇi}* mean?

You’ll want to know: விளக்கு

விளக்கு (*viḷakku*) — “a lamp”.

It stands on *viḷaṅgu*, ‘to shine, to be clear’, so the lamp is named for what it does rather than for what it is made of.

The same stem gives *viḷakkam*, ‘clarity’, and *viḷakku* on its own can mean ‘to make something plain’. A lamp and an explanation are the same word in Tamil, which is a better picture of teaching than most languages get for free.

A Tamil house lights one at dusk, at the doorway, and the word turns up wherever that habit does.

What you’ve built

Three, and the third one shines.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *viḷakku*
- it once more, slowly
- *tu_{ṇi}*, then *viḷakku*, and hear the doubled letter in the second

Before you move on

What does விளக்கு mean? (“a lamp”.) Say it once more.

44.4 உப்பு (uppu) — salt

Before the new one: what did *vilakku* mean?

You'll want to know: உப்பு

உப்பு (*uppu*) — “salt”.

Proto-Dravidian ***upp-**, and none of the four sisters did much to it: Malayalam ഉപ്പ്, Telugu ఉప్పు, Kannada ಉಪ್ಪು. Set them beside உப்பு and you are looking at one word in four hands.

A word that stable is usually a word nobody could do without. Salt is also how Tamil talks about savour in general — food with no *uppu* in it is food with nothing in it at all.

What you've built

Four, and this one has not changed in a very long time.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *uppu*
- it once more, slowly
- *vilakku*, then *uppu*, and let the second one stop short

Before you move on

What does உப்பு mean? (“salt”.) Say it once more.

44.5 புத்தகம் (puttakam) — a book

Before the new one: what did *uppu* mean?

You'll want to know: புத்தகம்

புத்தகம் (*puttakam*) — “a book”.

Sanskrit *pustaka*, taken in whole, with the *-am* Tamil puts on the end of such arrivals — the same *-am* already sitting on *kuṭumbam*. Malayalam

പുസ്തകം, Telugu పుస్తకం and Kannada ಪುಸ್ತಕ are the same borrowing, so the four agree here for a different reason than they agree about salt: not descent, but a shared debt.

Tamil kept its own word alongside. நூல் (*nūl*) is a thread, and thread is what bound palm leaves into a book before there was paper; the same *nūl* still names a written work. The borrowed word and the inherited one divide the job between them rather than fighting over it.

What you've built

Five, and the run is closed: a fruit, cloth, a lamp, salt, a book.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *puttakam*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order — *palam*, *tunī*, *vilakku*, *uppu*, *puttakam*

Before you move on

What does புத்தகம் mean? (“a book”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 45

More of the Body

Modes: ⇄ voice (5) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name five more parts of the body in Tamil, and point to the sound changes that separate them from their Malayalam, Telugu and Kannada cousins.

Complete TA-C45-stomach and say all five words in order.

45.1 கண் (kaṇ) — an eye

Before the new run of words: what did *uppu* mean, and what did *puttakam* mean?

You'll want to know: கண்

கண் (kaṇ) — “an eye”.

Proto-Dravidian *kaṇ, held almost still everywhere it went: Malayalam കണ്ണ്, Telugu కన్ను, Kannada ಕಣ್ಣು. Tamil's is the shortest of the four, one syllable and done.

It reaches well past the face. A *kaṇ* is the joint on a stalk of sugarcane and the mesh of a net — wherever a thing has an opening or a knot, Tamil is willing to call it an eye.

talai and *kai*, the head and the hand, came earlier. The face gets its own turn now, one piece at a time.

What you've built

The first of five more parts of the body.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kaṇ*
- it once more, slowly
- *kaṇ*, then *talai*, so the part and the whole sit together

Before you move on

What does கண் mean? (“an eye”.) Say it once more.

45.2 காது (kādu) — an ear

Before the new one: what did *kaṇ* mean?

You’ll want to know: காது

காது (*kādu*) — “an ear”.

Here it is Tamil that stands apart. *kādu* is the ear a Tamil speaker has, and the other three sisters built their everyday word on a different root altogether: Malayalam ചെവി, Telugu చెవి, Kannada ಕಿವಿ.

Tamil owns that root as well. செவி (*sevi*) names the same organ and is kept for poetry and formal speech — so the word the sisters use over breakfast is the one Tamil holds back for its high register. Two words, one ear, and the occasion decides which.

What you’ve built

Two: an eye and an ear.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kādu*
- it once more, slowly
- *kaṇ*, then *kādu*, and hear the long *ā* arrive in the second

Before you move on

What does കാது mean? (“an ear”.) Say it once more.

45.3 மூக்கு (mūkku) — a nose

Before the new one: what did *kādu* mean?

You’ll want to know: மூக்கு

மூக்கு (*mūkku*) — “a nose”.

Another word the family barely touched: Malayalam മുക്ക്, Telugu ముక్కు, Kannada ಮೂಗು. Only the ending moves.

mūkku also names the point of a thing — the prow of a boat, the tip of a pen. Whatever sticks out in front is the nose of it.

What you’ve built

Three, and all three are on the face.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *mūkku*
- it once more, slowly
- *kādu*, then *mūkku*, and let the second start long

Before you move on

What does மூக்கு mean? (“a nose”.) Say it once more.

45.4 பல் (pal) — a tooth

Before the new one: what did *mūkku* mean?

You'll want to know: பல்

பல் (*pal*) — “a tooth”.

Proto-Dravidian ***pal**, and the sisters pulled it three ways. Malayalam പല്ല്, Kannada ಹಲ್ಲು, Telugu పన్ను. Kannada is the odd one again, with the same *p*- to *h*- shift the fruit-word showed; Telugu turned the *l* into an *n*. Tamil stops the word dead on its *l* and adds nothing.

In everyday speech it often comes out *pallu*, with the *l* doubled — which is exactly the shape Malayalam and Kannada put on the page.

What you've built

Four, and the first one you can bite with.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *pal*
- it once more, slowly
- *mūkku*, then *pal*, and cut the second one short

Before you move on

What does பல் mean? (“a tooth”.) Say it once more.

45.5 வயிறு (*vayiru*) — the stomach

Before the new one: what did *pal* mean?

You'll want to know: வயிறு

வயிறு (*vayiru*) — “the stomach”.

The ற in the middle is the hard *r* this book met at *arai*, ‘a room’ — not the soft *r* of *peyar*. Malayalam says വയര്, the same word; Telugu and Kannada went elsewhere entirely for this one.

Where an English speaker says they are hungry, Tamil is happy to talk about the *vayiru* and leave the person out of it: the belly is what is empty, and you merely own it. That is the same habit behind *uṅgal uḍambu eppaḍi irukku*, where the health question hangs on the body rather than on you.

What you've built

That closes the run: an eye, an ear, a nose, a tooth, and what holds the food.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *vayiru*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order — *kaṇ, kādu, mūkku, paḷ, vayiru*

Before you move on

What does வயிறு mean? (“the stomach”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 46

Who Somebody Is

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say what somebody’s work is in Tamil, and recognise the endings that mark a man, a woman and respect.

Complete TA-C46-guest and say all five words in order.

46.1 ஆசிரியர் (āsiriyaṛ) — a teacher

Before the new run of words: what did *pal* mean, and what did *vayiru* mean?

You’ll want to know: ஆசிரியர்

ஆசிரியர் (*āsiriyaṛ*) — “a teacher”.

Sanskrit *ācārya*, one who teaches by how they behave, arriving in Tamil with *-ar* on the end — the respectful ending already met on *ivar* and *naṇbar*. So the word is polite before it is anything else: there is no way to say it that does not show regard.

Tamil keeps the older and plainer ஆசான் (*āsān*) beside it, and that one is what a student of an art calls a master.

What you’ve built

The first of five ways to say who somebody is.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *āsiriyaṛ*
- it once more, slowly
- *āsiriyaṛ*, then *naṇbaṛ*, and hear the same ending on both

Before you move on

What does ஆசிரியர் mean? (“a teacher”). Say it once more.

46.2 மாணவன் (māṇavan) — a student

Before the new one: what did *āsiriyaṛ* mean?

You’ll want to know: மாணவன்

மாணவன் (*māṇavan*) — “a student”.

Sanskrit *māṇava*, ‘a young person’, with the *-an* Tamil puts on a male — the same *-an* as *makan* and *naṇban*.

Change the ending and the person changes with it: *māṇavi* is a girl studying, *māṇavar* is said with respect or of more than one. One stem, three endings, and you already had all three.

What you’ve built

Two: the one who teaches and the one who is taught.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *māṇavan*
- it once more, slowly
- *āsiriyaṛ*, then *māṇavan*, so the pair sit together

Before you move on

What does மாணவன் mean? (“a student”.) Say it once more.

46.3 மருத்துவர் (maruttuvar) — a doctor

Before the new one: what did *māṇavan* mean?

You’ll want to know: மருத்துவர்

மருத்துவர் (*maruttuvar*) — “a doctor”.

This one is Tamil’s own. It stands on மருந்து (*marundu*), ‘medicine’, and takes the same respectful *-ar*: the person who deals in medicine.

Beside it sits *vaittiyar*, from Sanskrit *vaidya*, doing the same work with borrowed material. Where a language has both, it usually has a preference, and modern Tamil leans on *maruttuvar* — the signboard on the hospital says so.

What you’ve built

Three, and the third one you hope to need rarely.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *maruttuvar*
- it once more, slowly
- *māṇavan*, then *maruttuvar*, and hear the ending change

Before you move on

What does மருத்துவர் mean? (“a doctor”.) Say it once more.

46.4 விவசாயி (vivasāyi) — a farmer

Before the new one: what did *maruttuvar* mean?

You'll want to know: விவசாயி

விவசாயி (*vivasāyi*) — “a farmer”.

The ending is *-i*, which Tamil hangs on somebody by their work rather than by their sex, so the one word covers a man and a woman alike.

The stem is borrowed. The inherited word is உழவன் (*ulavan*), built straight on *ulu*, ‘to plough’, and it carries an older weight — Tamil poetry praises the *ulavan*, while a form at an office asks for the *vivasāyi*. Two words, one occupation, two registers.

What you've built

Four, and the fourth one feeds the other three.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *vivasāyi*
- it once more, slowly
- *maruttuvar*, then *vivasāyi*, and let the second end on *-i*

Before you move on

What does விவசாயி mean? (“a farmer”.) Say it once more.

46.5 விருந்தாளி (*viruntāḷi*) — a guest

Before the new one: what did *vivasāyi* mean?

You'll want to know: விருந்தாளி

விருந்தாளி (*viruntāḷi*) — “a guest”.

Take it apart and the guest is named after the meal. The first half is *virundu*, a feast laid on for somebody; the second is *āḷi*, from *āl*, ‘a person’. A guest, in Tamil, is the person a feast is for — the obligation is inside the word, not added to it afterwards.

There is an older form too, *viruntinar*, carrying the *-ar* you now know well. Both say the same thing: somebody has arrived, and there will be food.

What you've built

That closes the run: a teacher, a student, a doctor, a farmer, a guest.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *viruntāḷi*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order — *āsiriyaṛ, māṇavan, maruttuvar, vīvasāyi, viruntāḷi*

Before you move on

What does விருந்தாளி mean? (“a guest”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 47

Short Replies

Modes: ⇄ voice (5) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can answer with five short replies in Tamil, from a flat agreement to a hedge.

Complete TA-C47-just-so and say all five words in order.

47.1 உண்மை (uṇmai) — the truth

Before the new run of words: what did *vivasāyi* mean, and what did *viruntāli* mean?

You’ll want to know: உண்மை

உண்மை (uṇmai) — “the truth”.

It is built out of *ul*, ‘to be, to exist’, and the *-mai* Tamil adds to turn a quality into something you can name. The truth, then, is is-ness: what is the case.

As a reply it stands on its own. Somebody tells you something surprising and *uṇmai* means “true” — and *uṇmaiā?*, with the question fixed to the end, means “really?”.

What you’ve built

The first of five short replies.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *uṇmai*
- it once more, slowly
- *uṇmai*, then *sari*, so the two agreements sit together

Before you move on

What does உண்மை mean? (“the truth”.) Say it once more.

47.2 போதும் (pōdum) — that is enough

Before the new one: what did *uṇmai* mean?

You’ll want to know: போதும்

போதும் (*pōdum*) — “that is enough”.

It grows out of *pōdu*, ‘to suffice’, and it is the polite full stop of a Tamil meal: your host is serving, your plate is filling, and *pōdum* stops it without giving offence. Said twice — *pōdum pōdum* — it means you are serious.

It has nothing to do with *pō*, ‘to go’, though the two look alike at a glance. Different roots, similar clothes.

What you’ve built

Two: agreeing, and calling a halt.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *pōdum*
- it once more, slowly
- *uṇmai*, then *pōdum*, and let the second land firmly

Before you move on

What does போதும் mean? (“that is enough”.) Say it once more.

47.3 நிச்சயமாக (niccayamāka) — certainly

Before the new one: what did *pōdum* mean?

You’ll want to know: நிச்சயமாக

நிச்சயமாக (*niccayamāka*) — “certainly”.

Sanskrit *niścaya*, ‘a settled thing’, plus *-āka*, the ending Tamil adds when a word is to describe how something is done. *niccayam* on its own is the certainty; *niccayamāka* is doing the thing certainly.

That same *-āka* is inside *nalamāka*, from the answer about being well, so the shape is already in your ear.

What you’ve built

Three, and the third leaves no room for doubt.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *niccayamāka*
- it once more, slowly
- *pōdum*, then *niccayamāka*, and feel how much longer the second is

Before you move on

What does நிச்சயமாக mean? (“certainly”.) Say it once more.

47.4 ஒருவேளை (oruvēlai) — perhaps

Before the new one: what did *niccayamāka* mean?

You'll want to know: ஒருவேளை

ஒருவேளை (*oruvēlai*) — “perhaps”.

Two pieces welded together: *oru*, ‘one’, which you have, and *vēlai*, ‘an occasion, a time’, which you have not. One occasion out of the several that could happen — which is exactly the claim “perhaps” makes.

Tamil builds its hedge out of counting. English does the same trick with “maybe”, which is a “may” and a “be” pushed against each other until they stuck.

What you've built

Four, and the fourth one steps back from the other three.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *oruvēlai*
- it once more, slowly
- *niccayamāka*, then *oruvēlai*, and hear the certainty drain out

Before you move on

What does ஒருவேளை mean? (“perhaps”.) Say it once more.

47.5 அப்படியே (*appaḍiyē*) — just so

Before the new one: what did *oruvēlai* mean?

You'll want to know: அப்படியே

அப்படியே (*appaḍiyē*) — “just so”.

The front of it is the far pointer *a-* from *adu* and *aṅgē*; *appaḍi* is ‘in that manner’; and the *-ē* on the end is how Tamil presses down on a word. In that manner, precisely.

Move the pointer and the whole set follows: *ippaḍi*, ‘like this’, and *eppaḍi*, ‘how’ — which you have been saying since you first asked somebody how they were. One pattern, three words, and only the front letter moves.

What you've built

That closes the run: true, enough, certainly, perhaps, just so.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *appaḍiyē*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order — *uṇmai, pōdum, niccayamāka, oruvēlai, appaḍiyē*

Before you move on

What does அப்படியே mean? (“just so”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 48

Setting Out

Modes:  voice (5)  Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say that it is time, that I have a journey, and that I am setting out in Tamil.

Complete TA-C48-set-out and say all five words in order.

48.1 இப்போது (ippōdu) — now

Before the new run of words: what did *oruvēlai* mean, and what did *appāḍiyē* mean?

You'll want to know: இப்போது

இப்போது (*ippōdu*) — “now”.

The same pattern as the word that closed the run before, wearing the near pointer instead of the far one: *i-* and *pōdu*, ‘a time’. This time. And *appōdu* is that time, then.

In speech it usually shortens to *ippō*, the way English lets “going to” collapse into “gonna”. The full form is what you write; the short one is what you hear.

What you've built

The first of five words for going.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *ippōdu*
- it once more, slowly
- *appāḍiyē*, then *ippōdu*, and hear the pointer swap ends

Before you move on

What does இப்போது mean? (“now”.) Say it once more.

48.2 நேரம் (nēram) — time

Before the new one: what did *ippōdu* mean?

You’ll want to know: நேரம்

நேரம் (*nēram*) — “time”.

Not the hour on the clock — that is *maṇi*, which you already have — but time as a quantity of it: whether there is any, whether this is the right one, whether it has run out.

nēram āccu is how a Tamil speaker says the moment has come, and it is very often the sentence that ends a visit. Nobody has to be rude about leaving if the clock can be blamed.

What you’ve built

Two: this moment, and the stuff moments are made of.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *nēram*
- it once more, slowly
- *ippōdu*, then *nēram*, so the two sit together

Before you move on

What does நேரம் mean? (“time”.) Say it once more.

48.3 பயணம் (payaṇam) — a journey

Before the new one: what did *nēram* mean?

You’ll want to know: பயணம்

பயணம் (*payaṇam*) — “a journey”.

Beside it Tamil also keeps *pirayāṇam*, straight from Sanskrit *prayāṇa*, and the pair divides the work the way *nalām* and *sugam* did: the shorter word is the everyday one, the longer is what goes into writing.

Somebody travelling is a *payaṇi*, with the same *-i* ending that made the farmer out of his field.

What you’ve built

Three, and the third one takes you somewhere.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *payaṇam*
- it once more, slowly
- *nēram*, then *payaṇam*, and hear both endings agree

Before you move on

What does பயணம் mean? (“a journey”.) Say it once more.

48.4 பிறகு (piraku) — afterwards

Before the new one: what did *payaṇam* mean?

You'll want to know: பிறகு

பிறகு (*piraku*) — “afterwards”.

Underneath it is *pin*, ‘behind’. What sits behind you in space becomes what comes after you in time, and Tamil made that move so long ago that nobody hears it any more. English did the same thing with “before”, which began as a word about the front of things.

As a way of parting it is gentle and slightly vague: *piraku pārkkalām*, “we’ll see each other later”, promises nothing and closes the conversation kindly.

What you’ve built

Four, and the fourth one puts off the parting.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *piraku*
- it once more, slowly
- *payanam*, then *piraku*, and let the hard *r* land in the second

Before you move on

What does பிறகு mean? (“afterwards”.) Say it once more.

48.5 புறப்படு (*purappaḍu*) — to set out

Before the new one: what did *piraku* mean?

You'll want to know: புறப்படு

புறப்படு (*purappaḍu*) — “to set out”.

Two pieces, both still visible. *puram* is the outside, and *paḍu* is the all-purpose ending Tamil uses when something happens to you. To *purappaḍu* is to come to be outside — which is what leaving a house actually consists of.

nān purappaḍugirēn announces your departure with none of the weight of *pōy varugirēn*. It is what you say at the door with your bag already in your hand.

What you've built

That closes the run: now, time, a journey, afterwards, and getting up to go.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *purappaḍu*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order — *ippōdu, nēram, payaṇam, piraku, purappaḍu*

Before you move on

What does புறப்படு mean? (“to set out”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 49

Courtesy

Modes: ⇄ voice (5) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can thank somebody warmly in Tamil, show respect, and wish them well.

Complete TA-C49-many-thanks and say all five words in order.

49.1 அன்பு (anbu) — affection

Before the new run of words: what did *piraku* mean, and what did *purappaḍu* mean?

You'll want to know: அன்பு

அன்பு (*anbu*) — “affection”.

This is the warm, ordinary love — for a family, for a friend, for a place. *kādal* is the other kind, the one the poems are about, and Tamil keeps the two apart where English makes one word do both.

A letter opens *anbuḷḷa*, “dear”, which is literally ‘having affection’. Put the endings you know on the stem and you get *anban* and *anbar*, somebody who loves — the same two endings, doing the same work, on new material.

What you’ve built

The first of five courtesies.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *aṇbu*
- it once more, slowly
- *aṇbu*, then *aṇbuḷḷa*, and hear the stem stay put

Before you move on

What does அன்பு mean? (“affection”.) Say it once more.

49.2 மரியாதை (mariyāḍai) — respect

Before the new one: what did *aṇbu* mean?

You’ll want to know: மரியாதை

மரியாதை (*mariyāḍai*) — “respect”.

Sanskrit *maryādā*, which started life as a boundary mark — the line at the edge of a field. Respect, in that picture, is knowing where the line runs and not stepping over it.

Tamil shows it in its endings as much as in its words. You have been doing it since *nīṅgal*, where the ending meant for many is aimed at one person on purpose: *mariyāḍai* built out of shape rather than out of vocabulary.

What you’ve built

Two: what you feel, and what you show.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *mariyāḍai*
- it once more, slowly
- *aṇbu*, then *mariyāḍai*, so the warm one and the formal one sit together

Before you move on

What does மரியாதை mean? (“respect”.) Say it once more.

49.3 சந்தோஷம் (santōṣam) — gladness

Before the new one: what did *mariyādai* mean?

You’ll want to know: சந்தோஷம்

சந்தோஷம் (*santōṣam*) — “gladness”.

Sanskrit *santoṣa*, ‘contentment’, sitting beside the native *magilcci* you met when somebody was pleased to see you. Both are in daily use and neither has driven the other out — the same arrangement as *nalām* and *sugam*.

santōṣam is what you reach for when you accept an invitation. On its own, in reply, it means “gladly”.

What you’ve built

Three, and the third one is an answer as much as a feeling.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *santōṣam*
- it once more, slowly
- *mariyādai*, then *santōṣam*, and let the second one lift

Before you move on

What does சந்தோஷம் mean? (“gladness”.) Say it once more.

49.4 வாழ்த்து (vāḷttu) — a good wish

Before the new one: what did *santōṣam* mean?

You'll want to know: வாழ்த்து

வாழ்த்து (*vālttu*) — “a good wish”.

Straight off *vāl*, ‘to live, to flourish’, which you had early. To give somebody a *vālttu* is to wish them a life — not luck, not success, but the thing itself.

vālttukkal is what a Tamil speaker says where English says “congratulations”, and it is the kinder sentence of the two: flourishing, offered in the plural, rather than a nod at what you managed to pull off.

What you've built

Four, and the fourth one is given rather than felt.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *vālttu*
- it once more, slowly
- *santōṣam*, then *vālttu*, and feel the *ழ* glide in the second

Before you move on

What does வாழ்த்து mean? (“a good wish”.) Say it once more.

49.5 மிக்க நன்றி (*mikka nanri*) — thank you very much

Before the new one: what did *vālttu* mean?

You'll want to know: மிக்க நன்றி

மிக்க நன்றி (*mikka nanri*) — “thank you very much”.

nanri has been with you since the very beginning. *mikka* is the new piece in front of it: from *migu*, ‘to exceed’, so it means abundant, more than the usual measure.

Tamil does not raise its voice to be warm. It puts *mikka* at the front and leaves everything else exactly where it was. Set this beside *tayavu seytu* and *mannikkavum* and the courtesy kit is complete.

What you've built

That closes the run: affection, respect, gladness, a good wish, and thanks with weight behind it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *mikka nanri*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order — *anbu, mariyādai, santōṣam, vālttu, mikka nanri*

Before you move on

What does மிக்க நன்றி mean? (“thank you very much”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 50

At the Doorway

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the five things a guest meets at a Tamil doorway, and welcome them.

Complete TA-C50-welcome and say all five words in order.

50.1 வாசல் (vāsal) — a doorway

Before the new run of words: what did *vālttu* mean, and what did *mikka nanri* mean?

You'll want to know: வாசல்

வாசல் (*vāsal*) — “a doorway”.

Tamil separates the opening from the thing that shuts it. *kadavu*, which you have, is the door itself — the plank on its hinges. *vāsal* is the doorway: the gap, the step, and the strip of ground in front of it.

Almost everything that happens when a guest arrives happens at the *vāsal* rather than inside it, which is why the word carries more than architecture.

What you've built

The first of five things a guest meets at a Tamil door.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *vāsal*
- it once more, slowly
- *kadavu*, then *vāsal*, so the door and its opening sit together

Before you move on

What does வாசல் mean? (“a doorway”.) Say it once more.

50.2 கோலம் (kōlam) — the design at a doorway

Before the new one: what did *vāsal* mean?

You’ll want to know: கோலம்

கோலம் (*kōlam*) — “the design at a doorway”.

Rice flour, drawn freehand on the ground each morning, usually by the woman of the house and usually before the sun is up. It is decoration and welcome at once — and because the flour feeds ants and birds, it is a small daily gift to whatever comes past.

The older sense of the word is ‘form, appearance, the shape a thing takes’. A *kōlam* is the shape the house puts on to receive the day.

What you’ve built

Two: the doorway, and what is drawn in front of it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kōlam*
- it once more, slowly
- *vāsal*, then *kōlam*, and let the long *ō* open the second

Before you move on

What does கோலம் mean? (“the design at a doorway”.) Say it once more.

50.3 மலர் (malar) — a flower

Before the new one: what did *kōlam* mean?

You’ll want to know: மலர்

மலர் (*malar*) — “a flower”.

The everyday word is *pū*, short and plain. *malar* is its fuller partner, the one that goes into names and poems and careful speech.

It also says what a flower does: *malar* means ‘to open, to blossom’. One shape names the act and the result of it, and Tamil saw no reason to invent a second word for the second thing.

What you’ve built

Three, and the third one arrives in somebody’s hand.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *malar*
- it once more, slowly
- *kōlam*, then *malar*, and hear the soft *r* close the second

Before you move on

What does மலர் mean? (“a flower”.) Say it once more.

50.4 வெற்றிலை (verrilai) — betel leaf

Before the new one: what did *malar* mean?

You'll want to know: வெற்றிலை

வெற்றிலை (*verrilai*) — “betel leaf”.

The end of the word is plain once you have the pieces: *-ilai* is *ilai*, ‘a leaf’.

Betel leaf and areca nut, handed over together, are how a Tamil household says the visit mattered and the guest is owed something — at a wedding, at a farewell, at anything that counts. The leaf costs almost nothing and means a great deal, which is the usual arrangement for the things a culture puts at its centre.

What you've built

Four, and the fourth is the one you are sent home with.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *verrilai*
- it once more, slowly
- *malar*, then *verrilai*, and let the hard *r* double in the second

Before you move on

What does வெற்றிலை mean? (“betel leaf”.) Say it once more.

50.5 வரவேற்பு (*varavēṛpu*) — a welcome

Before the new one: what did *verrilai* mean?

You'll want to know: வரவேற்பு

வரவேற்பு (*varavēṛpu*) — “a welcome”.

Two pieces you can almost hear coming apart. *vara* is the coming, from *vā*, the word for ‘come’ you already have; *ēṛpu* is the accepting, from *ēṛru*, ‘to receive’. A welcome, in Tamil, is the acceptance of somebody’s arrival, and the word says that and nothing more.

varavēṛkirēn is “I welcome you”. At the *vāsal*, over the *kōlam*, with a *malar* and a *verrilai* in hand, it is the last thing left to say at a door —

and it sets you back down exactly where this book began, at a door, with *vaṇakkam*.

What you've built

That closes the run: a doorway, a design, a flower, a leaf, and the word for taking somebody in.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *varavērpu*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order — *vāsal*, *kōlam*, *malar*, *verrilai*, *varavērpu*

Before you move on

What does வரவேற்பு mean? (“a welcome”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 51

Overhead

Modes: ⇄ voice (5) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the sky, the sun, the moon, the stars and a cloud in Tamil.

Complete TA-C51-cloud and say all five words in order.

51.1 ஆகாயம் (ākāyam) — the sky

Before the new run of words: what did *verrilai* mean, and what did *varavērpū* mean?

You'll want to know: ஆகாயம்

ஆகாயம் (*ākāyam*) — “the sky”.

Sanskrit *ākāśa*, the open lit space. Malayalam and Telugu both keep the *ś* their letters can write and say *ākāśam*. Tamil has no letter for that sound, so the word arrives softened, with a ய standing where the *ś* was, and settles as ஆகாயம்.

Tamil's own inherited word for the same overhead space is *vāṇ*, which you have already met inside *vāṇilai*, the weather — the standing of the sky. ஆகாயம் took the wider and emptier sense: not the weather over your head but the space itself.

What you've built

The first of five things above you.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *ākāyam*
- it once more, slowly
- *vaṇakkam*, then *ākāyam*, as you would greet somebody out of doors

Before you move on

What does ஆகாயம் mean? (“the sky”.) Say it once more.

51.2 சூரியன் (*sūriyan*) — the sun

Before the new one: what did *ākāyam* mean?

You’ll want to know: சூரியன்

சூரியன் (*sūriyan*) — “the sun”.

Sanskrit *sūrya*, and the three sisters differ only in what they hang on the end of it. Telugu makes సూర్యుడు (*sūryuḍu*), Malayalam *sūryan*, Tamil சூரியன். The ending is the part each language owns; the sun is shared.

Tamil’s inherited sun is *ñāyiru*, the word standing behind the name of the first day of the week you already count through. It stepped back into the calendar and into poetry and left the daily sun to சூரியன்.

What you’ve built

Two: the space, and the thing that lights it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *sūriyan*
- it once more, slowly
- *ākāyam*, then *sūriyan*, the sky first and then what is in it

Before you move on

What does சூரியன் mean? (“the sun”.) Say it once more.

51.3 நிலா (nilā) — the moon

Before the new one: what did *sūriyan* mean?

You’ll want to know: நிலா

நிலா (*nilā*) — “the moon”.

Where both sisters took the Sanskrit moon — *candran* in Malayalam, *candruḍu* in Telugu — Tamil’s everyday moon is its own. நிலா is inherited, and it is the moon as light rather than as a body: *nilā* is what lies on a courtyard at night, the moonlight and the moon in one word. Tamil has *cantiran* as well, from the same Sanskrit its sisters took, and saves it for almanacs and for verse.

Let the ஆ at the end run long. It is the length that makes the word.

What you’ve built

Three: the space, the day light, and the night one.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *nilā*
- it once more, slowly
- *sūriyan*, then *nilā*, and let the second one end long

Before you move on

What does நிலா mean? (“the moon”.) Say it once more.

51.4 விண்மீன் (viṇmīn) — a star

Before the new one: what did *nilā* mean?

You'll want to know: விண்மீன்

விண்மீன் (*viṇmīṇ*) — “a star”.

Two pieces, and they come apart cleanly. *viṇ* is the sky as height, the open air above; *mīṇ* is a fish, and from the oldest Tamil poetry onward it is a star as well. A star, in Tamil, is a fish in the sky — a shoal of small bright things moving in something you cannot walk on.

The sisters went other ways. Malayalam takes the Sanskrit नक्षत्रम् (*nakṣatram*); Telugu says చుక్క (*cukka*), which is also its word for a dot.

What you've built

Four, and this one is a picture rather than a name.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *viṇmīṇ*
- it once more, slowly
- *nilā*, then *viṇmīṇ*, the big light and then the small ones

Before you move on

What does விண்மீன் mean? (“a star”.) Say it once more.

51.5 மேகம் (*mēkam*) — a cloud

Before the new one: what did *viṇmīṇ* mean?

You'll want to know: மேகம்

மேகம் (*mēkam*) — “a cloud”.

Sanskrit *megha*, taken in whole. Tamil has inherited cloud-words too — *mukil* and *kār*, both still alive in names and in verse — but மேகம் is the one doing the daily work.

Telugu did not borrow here at all: its cloud is *mabbu*, its own. Which words a language takes and which it keeps is rarely tidy. On the sky the two of them borrowed together; on the cloud they part.

What you've built

That is the whole sky: the space, the sun, the moon, the small lights, and the thing that hides them.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *mēkam*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order — *ākāyam, sūriyan, nilā, viṇmān, mēkam*

Before you move on

What does மேகம் mean? (“a cloud”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 52

A Tree

Modes: ⇄ voice (5) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name a tree, its branch, its new shoot, its root and its seed in Tamil.

Complete TA-C52-seed and say all five words in order.

52.1 மரம் (maram) — a tree

Before the new run of words: what did *viṇmāṇ* mean, and what did *mēkam* mean?

You'll want to know: மரம்

மரம் (*maram*) — “a tree”.

Proto-Dravidian ***mar-**, and Malayalam did not lay a finger on it: മരം, the same word letter for letter. Telugu went somewhere else entirely, to చెట్టు (*ceṭṭu*) — the ordinary arrangement in this family, where the two closest sisters agree and the third has its own.

maram is the tree standing and the timber cut out of it. A carpenter works in *maram*; so does a forest.

What you've built

The first of five pieces of one tree.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *maram*
- it once more, slowly
- *mēkam*, then *maram*, the cloud and what stands under it

Before you move on

What does மரம் mean? (“a tree”.) Say it once more.

52.2 கிளை (kilai) — a branch

Before the new one: what did *maram* mean?

You’ll want to know: கிளை

கிளை (*kilai*) — “a branch”.

Both sisters reach for a word of a different shape here — Malayalam *kompŭ*, Telugu *komma* — where Tamil says கிளை.

And a கிளை is not only what grows off a tree. A family has them: the branch of a house, the people who come off one trunk. When Tamil calls somebody your *kilai*, it is the tree word doing the work, and a bank branch is a *kilai* too.

What you’ve built

Two: the trunk, and what comes off it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kilai*
- it once more, slowly
- *maram*, then *kilai*, the tree and then what comes off it

Before you move on

What does கிளை mean? (“a branch”.) Say it once more.

52.3 தளிர் (talir) — a tender shoot

Before the new one: what did *kilai* mean?

You’ll want to know: தளிர்

தளிர் (*talir*) — “a tender shoot”.

The new growth at the end of a branch: the pale soft leaf before it hardens and goes green. Tamil keeps a word of its own for it rather than calling it a small leaf, which tells you how much attention the thing has had.

talirkka is what a tree does after the first rains. Tamil says it of people as well — somebody who has been ill and is picking up again has *talirttu*, put out new growth.

What you’ve built

Three: the tree, the branch, and the newest thing on it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *talir*
- it once more, slowly
- *kilai*, then *talir*, the branch and the new thing on the end of it

Before you move on

What does தளிர் mean? (“a tender shoot”.) Say it once more.

52.4 வேர் (vēr) — a root

Before the new one: what did *talir* mean?

You'll want to know: வேர்

வேர் (*vēr*) — “a root”.

One word in three hands. Malayalam വേര് (*vērŭ*), Telugu వేరు (*vēru*), Tamil வேர். Set them beside each other and there is nothing left to choose between them.

It is the root of a plant and the bottom of anything else: a tooth has a வேர், and so does a word.

What you've built

Four: everything above ground, and now the part under it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *vēr*
- it once more, slowly
- *talir*, then *vēr*, the top of the tree and the bottom of it

Before you move on

What does வேர் mean? (“a root”.) Say it once more.

52.5 விதை (*vitai*) — a seed

Before the new one: what did *vēr* mean?

You'll want to know: விதை

விதை (*vitai*) — “a seed”.

Malayalam விண் (*vittu*) and Telugu విత్తనం (*vittanani*) are the same root wearing different endings, and Tamil keeps a *vittu* of its own beside விதை.

விதை is the seed and the sowing of it at once: *vitaiikka* is to sow. The thing and what you do with it share one shape, which saves Tamil a word.

What you've built

A whole tree, from the seed under it to the softest thing on the end of a branch.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *vitai*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order — *maram, kiḷai, taḷir, vēr, vitai*

Before you move on

What does விதை mean? (“a seed”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 53

The Land

Modes: 🔄 voice (5) 🔄 Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name a river, a hill, a paddy field, a path and a village in Tamil.

Complete TA-C53-village and say all five words in order.

53.1 நதி (nadi) — a river

Before the new run of words: what did *vēr* mean, and what did *vitai* mean?

You'll want to know: நதி

நதி (*nadi*) — “a river”.

Sanskrit *nadī*, and Telugu prints it identically: నది. Malayalam did not take it for the everyday river and says പുഴ (*pulā*) instead, which is its own.

Tamil's inherited river is ஆறு — the same shape as the six you already count with. Which of the two is meant comes out of what sits around it, and நதி is the one that leaves no room for doubt.

What you've built

The first of five things in a stretch of country.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *nadi*
- it once more, slowly
- *vitai*, then *nadi*, the seed and the water that reaches it

Before you move on

What does நதி mean? (“a river”.) Say it once more.

53.2 மலை (malai) — a hill

Before the new one: what did *nadi* mean?

You’ll want to know: மலை

மலை (*malai*) — “a hill”.

Proto-Dravidian, and it covers a hill and a mountain both — Tamil does not split them the way English does. Telugu keeps a small hill of its own, గుట్ట (*gutṭa*).

You have been reading this word all along without being told. The name *Malayālam* begins with it: the language of the hill country, named for its hills.

What you’ve built

Two: the water, and what it comes down from.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *malai*
- it once more, slowly
- *nadi*, then *malai*, the water and the high ground behind it

Before you move on

What does மலை mean? (“a hill”.) Say it once more.

53.3 வயல் (vayal) — a paddy field

Before the new one: what did *malai* mean?

You'll want to know: வயல்

வயல் (*vayal*) — “a paddy field”.

A wet field: the flooded one that grows rice, not a dry one. Malayalam writes വയൽ and means the same thing by it.

The dry field is a *kollai*, a different word altogether, and the split earns its keep. A farmer telling you which of the two he has is telling you what he can grow on it and when.

What you've built

Three: high ground, and now the flat wet ground under it.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *vayal*
- it once more, slowly
- *malai*, then *vayal*, the high ground and the flat

Before you move on

What does வயல் mean? (“a paddy field”.) Say it once more.

53.4 பாதை (pātai) — a path

Before the new one: what did *vayal* mean?

You'll want to know: பாதை

பாதை (*pātai*) — “a path”.

Something you can put your foot on: a track worn into the ground, a lane, a road.

Tamil has *vali* as well, and the two overlap less than they look as though they should. *vali* is the way — the route, the means, the manner of going

about something. பாதை stays physical. Malayalam’s everyday path-word is വഴി, the same one; Telugu’s is *bāṭa*.

What you’ve built

Four: three places, and now something joining them.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *pātai*
- it once more, slowly
- *vayal*, then *pātai*, the field and the way to it

Before you move on

What does பாதை mean? (“a path”.) Say it once more.

53.5 கிராமம் (kirāmam) — a village

Before the new one: what did *pātai* mean?

You’ll want to know: கிராமம்

கிராமம் (*kirāmam*) — “a village”.

Sanskrit *grāma*, and Telugu takes it whole: గ్రామం. Tamil does not begin a word on two held-together sounds, so it let a vowel into the middle of the cluster and the word came out *ki-rā-mam*.

You already have *ūr* for the place you belong to. *ūr* is yours — your town, the one you name when somebody asks where you are from. கிராமம் is the word on the form and on the signboard at the edge of the road.

What you’ve built

Water, high ground, a wet field, a way across it, and the place at the end of the way.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kirāmam*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order — *nadi, malai, vayal, pātai, kirāmam*

Before you move on

What does கிராமம் mean? (“a village”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 54

Things in the House

Modes: ⇄ voice (5) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the mat, basket, knife, bowl and box a Tamil house sets out for a guest.

Complete TA-C54-box and say all five words in order.

54.1 పాప (pāy) — a mat

Before the new run of words: what did *pātai* mean, and what did *kirāmam* mean?

You’ll want to know: పాప

పాప (*pāy*) — “a mat”.

The woven mat that is unrolled to sleep on and unrolled again for a guest to sit on. Malayalam says പായ (*pāya*) and Telugu చాప (*cāpa*).

పాప is also ‘to leap’. Nothing joins the two but the sound, and what sits around the word settles which is meant — the same one-shape-two-jobs arrangement *tuṇi* already showed you.

What you’ve built

The first of five things a house puts in front of you.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *pāy*
- it once more, slowly
- *kirāmam*, then *pāy*, the village and what is unrolled for you in it

Before you move on

What does பாய mean? (“a mat”.) Say it once more.

54.2 கூடை (*kūtai*) — a basket

Before the new one: what did *pāy* mean?

You’ll want to know: கூடை

கூடை (*kūtai*) — “a basket”.

Woven, usually of palm leaf or split bamboo. Malayalam’s basket is *koṭṭa* and Telugu’s is *butṭa*; Tamil’s is கூடை.

It is the word for the basket a vendor sets down in front of you on the pavement, and for the one that goes up onto a head to be carried home.

What you’ve built

Two: something to sit on, and something to carry in.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kūtai*
- it once more, slowly
- *pāy*, then *kūtai*, and let the long ஁ open the second

Before you move on

What does கூடை mean? (“a basket”.) Say it once more.

54.3 கத்தி (katti) — a knife

Before the new one: what did *kūṭai* mean?

You'll want to know: கத்தி

கத்தி (*katti*) — “a knife”.

Three sisters and one word. Malayalam கത്തി, Telugu కత్తి, Tamil கத்தி. Not merely close — the same word three times, which happens with things every household has had for as long as there have been households.

The doubled த in the middle carries the whole difficulty. Hold it: *ka-t-ti*, with the tongue staying where it is between the two.

What you've built

Three, and this one is shared right across the family.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *katti*
- it once more, slowly
- *kūṭai*, then *katti*, and hold the doubled த

Before you move on

What does கத்தி mean? (“a knife”.) Say it once more.

54.4 கிண்ணம் (kinṇam) — a bowl

Before the new one: what did *katti* mean?

You'll want to know: கிண்ணம்

கிண்ணம் (*kinṇam*) — “a bowl”.

The small round one that holds a helping, rather than the pot the food was cooked in. Telugu's గిన్నె (*ginne*) is close enough to hear the same word underneath.

Malayalam reaches past both and takes the Sanskrit पात्रम् (*pātram*), a vessel of any sort. Tamil has that one as well and keeps it general; கிண்ணம் stays small.

What you've built

Four: to sit on, to carry in, to cut with, and to eat from.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kiṇṇam*
- it once more, slowly
- *katti*, then *kiṇṇam*, and let the ண double this time

Before you move on

What does கிண்ணம் mean? (“a bowl”.) Say it once more.

54.5 பெட்டி (*peṭṭi*) — a box

Before the new one: what did *kiṇṇam* mean?

You'll want to know: பெட்டி

பெட்டி (*peṭṭi*) — “a box”.

Malayalam പെട്ടി, Telugu పెట్టి, Tamil பெட்டி — the family agrees again, down to the doubled *ṭ* in the middle. Two words in one short run where all three sisters say the same thing is worth noticing.

A பெட்டி is a box of any size: the tin trunk clothes live in, a matchbox, and the carriage of a train, which Tamil calls a *rayil peṭṭi*.

What you've built

Five things a house sets out: something to sit on, to carry in, to cut with, to eat from, and to keep it all in.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *pet̤ti*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order — *pāy*, *kūtai*, *katti*, *kin̤nam*, *pet̤ti*

Before you move on

What does பெட்டி mean? (“a box”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 55

The Rest of You

Modes: 🔄 voice (5) 🔄 Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name my neck, my back, a lip, a nail and a bone in Tamil.

Complete TA-C55-bone and say all five words in order.

55.1 கழுத்து (kaluttu) — the neck

Before the new run of words: what did *kinṇam* mean, and what did *petṭi* mean?

You'll want to know: கழுத்து

கழுத்து (*kaluttu*) — “the neck”.

Malayalam കഴുത്ത് (*kaluttū*) is the same word, ്ழு and all — that letter again, the one only these two sisters still write. Telugu went its own way here, to మెడ (*meḍa*).

It is the neck outside and the throat inside, both in one word. A garland goes round the கழுத்து, and so does the thread tied at a wedding.

What you've built

The first of five more pieces of you.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kaluttu*
- it once more, slowly
- *peṭṭi*, then *kaluttu*, and hold the ழ in the middle

Before you move on

What does கழுத்து mean? (“the neck”.) Say it once more.

55.2 முதுகு (mutuku) — the back

Before the new one: what did *kaluttu* mean?

You’ll want to know: முதுகு

முதுகு (*mutuku*) — “the back”.

Malayalam has മുതുകു (*mutukū*), letter for letter until the last one. Telugu takes వీపు (*vīpu*) and shares nothing with either.

To show somebody your முதுகு is to turn away from them, in Tamil much as in English — and the phrase is meant as unkindly in one language as in the other.

What you’ve built

Two: what a garland goes round, and what you turn on somebody.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *mutuku*
- it once more, slowly
- *kaluttu*, then *mutuku*, the top of you and the length below it

Before you move on

What does முதுகு mean? (“the back”.) Say it once more.

55.3 உதடு (utaṭu) — a lip

Before the new one: what did *mutuku* mean?

You'll want to know: உதடு

உதடு (*utaṭu*) — “a lip”.

This is where the family stops agreeing. Malayalam says ചുണ്ട് (*cuṇṅ*), Telugu పెదవి (*pedavi*), Tamil உதடு — three words with nothing in common but the thing they name. It happens: a part of the body every language has a name for is not therefore a part every language named at the same time.

The ㄸ in the middle is the one made with the tongue curled back. Keep it curled and the word comes out right.

What you've built

Three, and this one the three sisters worked out separately.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *utaṭu*
- it once more, slowly
- *mutuku*, then *utaṭu*, and curl the tongue back for the ㄸ

Before you move on

What does உதடு mean? (“a lip”.) Say it once more.

55.4 நகம் (nakam) — a nail

Before the new one: what did *utaṭu* mean?

You'll want to know: நகம்

நகம் (*nakam*) — “a nail”.

The nail on a finger and the claw on an animal, in one word. Malayalam writes നഖം (*nakham*), with a breathed letter in the middle that Tamil's

own set does not carry, so Tamil prints it plain: நகம். The two words are heard as one and written as two.

Telugu holds on to something else entirely, గోరు (*gōru*).

What you've built

Four: neck, back, lip, and the hard thing on the end of a finger.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *nakam*
- it once more, slowly
- *utatu*, then *nakam*, the softest part of you and the hardest

Before you move on

What does நகம் mean? (“a nail”.) Say it once more.

55.5 எலும்பு (*elumbu*) — a bone

Before the new one: what did *nakam* mean?

You'll want to know: எலும்பு

எலும்பு (*elumbu*) — “a bone”.

Malayalam എല്ല (*ellū*) and Telugu ఎముక (*emuka*) sit either side of Tamil's எலும்பு: the same opening, and then three different amounts of word after it.

elumbum tōlum — “bone and skin” — is what Tamil says of somebody who has gone very thin. English says the same two things in the other order.

What you've built

Five more of you: neck, back, lip, nail, and what holds the whole lot up.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *elumbu*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order — *kaluttu*, *mutuku*, *utaṭu*, *nakam*, *elumbu*

Before you move on

What does எலும்பு mean? (“a bone”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 56

How Much

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say how much I want in Tamil, from a little to a lot, and turn an offer down politely.

Complete TA-C56-let-it-be and say all five words in order.

56.1 சிறிது (*siritu*) — a little

Before the new run of words: what did *nakam* mean, and what did *elumbu* mean?

You'll want to know: சிறிது

சிறிது (*siritu*) — “a little”.

You already have *siriya*, “small”. சிறிது is the same root turned into an amount: not a small thing but a small quantity of something. Held a dish and asked how much, you say *siritu* and you get a little.

Tamil has a *koñcam* as well, which is the one you will hear across a table, and which Telugu shares as *koñcem*. சிறிது is the more formal of the two, and the one you would write down.

What you've built

The first of five answers to “how much?”.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *siritu*
- it once more, slowly
- *elumbu*, then *siritu*, and keep the second one short

Before you move on

What does சிறிது mean? (“a little”.) Say it once more.

56.2 நிறைய (niraiya) — a lot

Before the new one: what did *siritu* mean?

You’ll want to know: நிறைய

நிறைய (*niraiya*) — “a lot”.

The other end of the same question. நிறைய is built on *nirai*, to fill, so a lot in Tamil is a fullness: as much as the thing will hold and no argument about it.

Telugu says ఎక్కువ (*ekkuva*) and builds it out of nothing to do with filling — a reminder that two languages can land on the same everyday answer by two quite different routes.

What you’ve built

Two, and they are opposite ends of one question.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *niraiya*
- it once more, slowly
- *siritu*, then *niraiya*, the little and the lot

Before you move on

What does நிறைய mean? (“a lot”.) Say it once more.

56.3 குறைவு (*kuraivu*) — a shortage, less than there should be

Before the new one: what did *niraiya* mean?

You’ll want to know: குறைவு

குறைவு (*kuraivu*) — “a shortage, less than there should be”.

kurai is to fall short, and குறைவு is the falling-short itself. That makes it a narrower word than the English “less”: it does not merely compare two amounts, it says one of them did not come up to the mark. There is a small complaint folded inside it.

Telugu’s word for the same ground is తక్కువ (*takkuva*).

What you’ve built

Three: a little, a lot, and not as much as there ought to be.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kuraivu*
- it once more, slowly
- *niraiya*, then *kuraivu*, plenty and then not enough

Before you move on

What does குறைவு mean? (“a shortage, less than there should be”.) Say it once more.

56.4 தேவையில்லை (*tēvaiyillai*) — there is no need

Before the new one: what did *kuraivu* mean?

You'll want to know: தேவையில்லை

தேவையில்லை (*tēvaiyillai*) — “there is no need”.

Two pieces, and the second one has been yours since the early writing lessons: *tēvai* is a need, *illai* is the no you learned to put on paper. Together they are how Tamil turns something down without turning the person down.

A flat *illai* refuses the thing. தேவையில்லை says there is no call for it, which leaves everybody their footing. Telugu does the same work in one shorter piece, వద్దు (*vaddu*).

What you've built

Four, and this one is the polite way out.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *tēvaiyillai*
- it once more, slowly
- *kuraivu*, then *tēvaiyillai*, and let the whole of the second run as one word

Before you move on

What does தேவையில்லை mean? (“there is no need”.) Say it once more.

56.5 ஆகட்டும் (*ākattum*) — let it be so

Before the new one: what did *tēvaiyillai* mean?

You'll want to know: ஆகட்டும்

ஆகட்டும் (*ākattum*) — “let it be so”.

āku is to become, to come about. ஆகட்டும் is “let it come about” — what you say when somebody proposes something and you are content to let it happen. It agrees without promising to do anything.

The *ām* you have been saying for yes is that same *āku* worn down by a great deal of use, which is why the two sit so alike in the mouth. Telugu’s nearest of these is అలాగే (*alāgē*), “just so, alright then”.

What you’ve built

Five answers to an offer: a little, a lot, not enough, no need, and yes — let it happen.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *ākattum*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order — *siritu*, *niraiya*, *kuraivu*, *tēvaiyillai*, *ākattum*

Before you move on

What does ஆகட்டும் mean? (“let it be so”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 57

Wind and Fire

Modes: 🗣 voice (5) 🗣 Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name the wind, sand, mud, smoke and an ember in Tamil.

Complete TA-C57-ember and say all five words in order.

57.1 காற்று (kārru) — the wind

Before the new run of words: what did *tēvaiyillai* mean, and what did *ākattum* mean?

You'll want to know: காற்று

காற்று (*kārru*) — “the wind”.

Malayalam കാറ്റ് (*kārrū*) is the same word with its ending worn shorter. Telugu takes గాలి (*gāli*), which covers air as much as wind.

Tamil's word covers both too: the breeze coming through a doorway and the air inside a tyre are one word. What English splits into wind and air, Tamil leaves whole and lets the sentence decide.

What you've built

The first of five things you can point at outdoors.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kārru*
- it once more, slowly
- *ākattum*, then *kārru*, and let the doubled *ṛ* hold

Before you move on

What does കാற்று mean? (“the wind”.) Say it once more.

57.2 மணல் (maṇal) — sand

Before the new one: what did *kārru* mean?

You’ll want to know: மணல்

மணல் (*maṇal*) — “sand”.

Malayalam മണൽ (*maṇal*), letter for letter and sound for sound. Telugu goes somewhere else, to *isuka*.

The ண is the one made with the tongue curled back — the same letter you have just been doubling in *kiṇṇam*. Here there is only one of them, so touch it once and move on.

What you’ve built

Two: what moves, and one of the things it moves.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *maṇal*
- it once more, slowly
- *kārru*, then *maṇal*, the wind and what it carries

Before you move on

What does மணல் mean? (“sand”.) Say it once more.

57.3 சேறு (*sēru*) — mud

Before the new one: what did *maṇal* mean?

You’ll want to know: சேறு

சேறு (*sēru*) — “mud”.

Wet earth churned up: the mud of a paddy field after rain, not dust and not clay. Here the three sisters go three ways — Malayalam *celi*, Telugu *burada*, Tamil சேறு.

Tamil keeps *cakati* as well, for the thicker and dirtier kind. சேறு is the working mud, the sort somebody walks into on purpose with a plough behind him.

What you’ve built

Three: air, dry ground, and wet ground.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *sēru*
- it once more, slowly
- *maṇal*, then *sēru*, dry ground and wet

Before you move on

What does சேறு mean? (“mud”.) Say it once more.

57.4 புகை (*pukai*) — smoke

Before the new one: what did *sēru* mean?

You’ll want to know: புகை

புகை (*pukai*) — “smoke”.

Malayalam പുക (*puka*) is the same word one step shorter. Tamil’s ends in the *-ai* that so many of its everyday things end in: *kīlai*, *kūtai*, *vitai*, and now this one.

புகை is the smoke and also what somebody does over a cigarette. And when trains reached the Tamil country they were called *pukaivaṇṭi*, the smoke vehicle, which is still what a great many people call them.

What you've built

Four, and this one you can only see because of what it comes off.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *pukai*
- it once more, slowly
- *sēru*, then *pukai*, and let the *-ai* open at the end

Before you move on

What does புகை mean? (“smoke”.) Say it once more.

57.5 கனல் (*kanal*) — an ember

Before the new one: what did *pukai* mean?

You'll want to know: கனல்

கனல் (*kanal*) — “an ember”.

The live coal under the ash: fire with no flame on it. Malayalam has the word unchanged, കനൽ (*kanal*). Telugu's నిప్పు (*nippu*) covers this and open fire together.

It is the word Tamil reaches for when it means heat held rather than heat let go. A *kanal* in somebody's eye is anger they are keeping to themselves, and everyone in the room can tell.

What you've built

Wind, sand, mud, smoke, and the coal under the ash.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kanal*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order — *kārru, manal, sēru, pukai, kanal*

Before you move on

What does கனல் mean? (“an ember”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 58

Around the Yard

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name a cow, a goat, a hen, a crow and a bird in Tamil.

Complete TA-C58-bird and say all five words in order.

58.1 பசு (pasu) — a cow

Before the new one: what did *pukai* mean, and what did *kaṇal* mean?

You'll want to know: பசு

பசு (*pasu*) — “a cow”.

The animal a Tamil household is built around. Kannada says ಹಸು (*hasu*): the same word, with the *p*-for-*h* trade Kannada makes right through its old words — the one this book pointed out when the numbers were lined up side by side. Tamil keeps the *p*.

It belongs to a விவசாயி before it belongs to anybody, and in a கிராமம் it stands tied in the yard rather than shut in a shed, near enough to the வாசல் that you step around it going in.

What you've built

The first of five animals.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *pasu*
- it once more, slowly
- *pasu*, then *kirāmam*, and put the one inside the other

Before you move on

What does ಪಶು mean? (“a cow”.) Say it once more.

58.2 ಆಡು (āṭu) — a goat

Before the new one: what did *pasu* mean?

You’ll want to know: ಆಡು

ಆಡು (āṭu) — “a goat”.

Smaller, cheaper, and kept by houses with no land for a ಪಶು. It eats what it finds and needs nobody to cut for it.

Start it long — ಆ, held — and put the ಳ of ಕೂಡಲ in the middle. That keeps it clear of ಅಡು, which starts short and is a different word entirely. Kannada parts company here and says ಮೇಕೆ (*mēke*).

What you’ve built

Two.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *āṭu*
- it once more, slowly
- *pasu*, then *āṭu*, and say which one a house keeps when it has no land

Before you move on

What does ஆடு mean? (“a goat”.) Say it once more.

58.3 கோழி (kōli) — a hen

Before the new one: what did *ātu* mean?

You’ll want to know: கோழி

கோழி (*kōli*) — “a hen”.

Hen or cock alike; the word does not split them, and where the difference matters a second word goes in front. Kannada ಕೋಳಿ (*kōli*) and Telugu కోడి (*kōḍi*) are the same word three ways, and the middle letter is where they separate: Tamil’s மு, Kannada’s ಳ, Telugu’s డ.

It is the clock of a கிராமம். A கோழி has a house awake well before anybody there needs to know the மணி.

What you’ve built

Three.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kōli*
- it once more, slowly
- *kōli*, then *maṇi*, and say which one comes first in the morning

Before you move on

What does கோழி mean? (“a hen”.) Say it once more.

58.4 காக்கை (kākkai) — a crow

Before the new one: what did *kōli* mean?

You'll want to know: காக்கை

காக்கை (*kākkai*) — “a crow”.

Named off the noise it makes, and the sisters landed on the same trick from the same starting point: Kannada ಕಾಗೆ (*kāge*). Say it once and you have the etymology.

Of everything with wings around a Tamil house this is the one the house deals with daily. சாதம் set out on the வாசல் step is put there for the காக்கை, and it comes down within the minute.

What you've built

Four.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kākkai*
- it once more, slowly
- *kākkai*, then *kōli*, and say which one is kept and which one turns up

Before you move on

What does காக்கை mean? (“a crow”.) Say it once more.

58.5 பறவை (*paravai*) — a bird

Before the new one: what did *kākkai* mean?

You'll want to know: பறவை

பறவை (*paravai*) — “a bird”.

The wide word. Whatever flies is a பறவை, the கோழி and the காக்கை taken in along with everything that was never given a name of its own.

Here the three go three ways: Kannada ಹಕ್ಕಿ (*hakki*), Telugu పక్షి (*pakṣi*) off the Sanskrit, and Tamil's own பறவை. The ற in the middle is the hard one, the same ற standing in ஆறு.

What you've built

Five, and the run is closed: a cow, a goat, a hen, a crow, and the word for everything that flies.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *paravai*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order — *pasu*, *āṭu*, *kōḷi*, *kākkai*, *paravai*

Before you move on

What does பறவை mean? (“a bird”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 59

In the Kitchen

Modes: 🗣 voice (5) 🗣 Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name curd, ghee, oil, jaggery and sugar in Tamil.

Complete TA-C59-sugar and say all five words in order.

59.1 தயிர் (tayir) — curd

Before the new one: what did *kākkai* mean, and what did *paravai* mean?

You'll want to know: தயிர்

தயிர் (*tayir*) — “curd”.

Set பால், soured overnight in a covered pot. It is what a Tamil meal finishes on, turned through the last of the சாதம், and it is the thing a hot afternoon is survived with.

The sisters do not agree here at all: Kannada ಮೊಸರು (*mosaru*), Telugu పెరుగు (*perugu*), Tamil தயிர். Three households, three words, one pot.

What you've built

The first of five kitchen words.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *tayir*
- it once more, slowly
- *tayir*, then *sādam*, and say which one goes on top of the other

Before you move on

What does தயிர் mean? (“curd”.) Say it once more.

59.2 நெய் (ney) — ghee

Before the new one: what did *tayir* mean?

You’ll want to know: நெய்

நெய் (*ney*) — “ghee”.

Butter cooked down until the water has gone and only the fat and the smell are left. Short, old, and Tamil’s own. Telugu keeps it as నెయ్యి (*neyyi*); Kannada walked off to ತುಪ್ಪ (*tuppa*).

A spoon of it goes over hot சாதம் at the start of a meal on a day that matters, which is most of what it does.

What you’ve built

Two.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *ney*
- it once more, slowly
- *tayir*, then *ney*, and say which one ends a meal and which one opens it

Before you move on

What does நெய் mean? (“ghee”.) Say it once more.

59.3 எண்ணெய் (eṇṇey) — oil

Before the new one: what did *ney* mean?

You'll want to know: எண்ணெய்

எண்ணெய் (eṇṇey) — “oil”.

The end of it is நெய், standing there unchanged. The front piece is an old name for the sesame seed, so the whole thing began as sesame-fat — and then it widened until it covered every oil a kitchen has, sesame or not.

Kannada kept the same word as ಎಣ್ಣೆ (eṇṇe); Telugu went to నూనె (nūne). The doubled ண் in the middle is the one made with the tongue curled back, held twice as long.

What you've built

Three, and the third is built out of the second.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- eṇṇey
- it once more, slowly
- ney, then eṇṇey, and hear the first one still sitting inside the second

Before you move on

What does எண்ணெய் mean? (“oil”.) Say it once more.

59.4 வெல்லம் (vellam) — jaggery

Before the new one: what did eṇṇey mean?

You'll want to know: வெல்லம்

வெல்லம் (vellam) — “jaggery”.

Cane juice boiled down and left alone — no bleaching, no crystals — and sold as a dark heavy lump you break a piece off. Kannada has the same word as ಬೆಲ್ಲ (bella), with *v* softened to *b*.

In an older Tamil kitchen sweetness meant this before it meant anything white, and வெல்லம் still goes into the food that has to taste the way it used to.

What you've built

Four.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *vellam*
- it once more, slowly
- *vellam*, then *ney*, and say which of the two a sweet needs

Before you move on

What does வெல்லம் mean? (“jaggery”.) Say it once more.

59.5 சர்க்கரை (sarkkarai) — sugar

Before the new one: what did *vellam* mean?

You'll want to know: சர்க்கரை

சர்க்கரை (*sarkkarai*) — “sugar”.

The refined white kind, beside வெல்லம் rather than in place of it. Kannada ಸಕ್ಕರೆ (*sakkare*), Telugu చక్కర (*cakkeru*): one word, lightly redressed three times.

It has travelled further than any other word in this run. Sanskrit *śarkarā* went out through Arabic, Greek and Latin and came back into English as *sugar*, so சர்க்கரை and the English word are one word wearing different clothes.

What you've built

Five, and the run is closed: curd, ghee, oil, jaggery, and sugar.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *sarkkarai*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order — *tayir, ney, eṇṇey, vellam, sarkkarai*

Before you move on

What does சர்க்கரை mean? (“sugar”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 60

Things People Make

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name a needle, a rope, an umbrella, a broom and a comb in Tamil.

Complete TA-C60-comb and say all five words in order.

60.1 உஸி (ūsi) — a needle

Before the new one: what did *vellam* mean, and what did *sarkkarai* mean?

You'll want to know: உஸி

உஸி (ūsi) — “a needle”.

The sewing needle, and whatever else is that shape. It is the tool துணி is repaired with, which is most of what துணி asks for.

Kannada ಸೂಜಿ (*sūji*) and Telugu సూది (*sūdi*) hold on to a sound at the front that Tamil let go of, so Tamil's is the shortest of the three. Open it on a long உஸ்.

What you've built

The first of five made things.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *ūsi*
- it once more, slowly
- *ūsi*, then *tunī*, and say which one repairs the other

Before you move on

What does உஸி mean? (“a needle”.) Say it once more.

60.2 கயிறு (*kayiru*) — a rope

Before the new one: what did *ūsi* mean?

You’ll want to know: கயிறு

கயிறு (*kayiru*) — “a rope”.

Twisted up out of coconut fibre, which is what a coast with that many palms was going to make rope out of. Thin ones tie a bundle; thick ones draw water.

The ற at the end is the hard one — the same ற standing in ஆறு and in பறவை. A பசு in a yard is at the end of a கயிறு, which is the commonest place to meet the word.

What you’ve built

Two.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kayiru*
- it once more, slowly
- *kayiru*, then *pasu*, and say which one holds the other

Before you move on

What does கயிறு mean? (“a rope”.) Say it once more.

60.3 குடை (kuṭai) — an umbrella

Before the new one: what did *kayiru* mean?

You'll want to know: குடை

குடை (*kuṭai*) — “an umbrella”.

Against மழை and against the சூரியன் equally, and in Tamil country the second job is the larger one. It is carried in a month with no rain in it without anybody thinking that odd.

Kannada ಕೊಡೆ (*kode*) is the same word. It ends on the ை you already put on கூடை and on விதை.

What you've built

Three.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kuṭai*
- it once more, slowly
- *kuṭai*, then *malai*, and say which one you take out for the other

Before you move on

What does குடை mean? (“an umbrella”.) Say it once more.

60.4 துடைப்பம் (tuṭaiṭṭam) — a broom

Before the new one: what did *kuṭai* mean?

You'll want to know: துடைப்பம்

துடைப்பம் (*tuṭaiṭṭam*) — “a broom”.

Coconut ribs bound at one end, held short, swung low. It is the first thing that touches a வாசல் in the morning: the ground is swept, then wetted, and only then does the கோலம் go down on it.

Three houses, three words again — Kannada ಪೊರಕೆ (*porake*), Telugu చీపురు (*cīpuru*), Tamil துடைப்பம். The doubled ப் in the middle is the one you have been holding since பெட்டி taught you to hold a letter twice.

What you've built

Four.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *tutaippam*
- it once more, slowly
- *tutaippam*, then *kōlam*, and say which one comes first

Before you move on

What does துடைப்பம் mean? (“a broom”.) Say it once more.

60.5 சீப்பு (*sīppu*) — a comb

Before the new one: what did *tutaippam* mean?

You'll want to know: சீப்பு

சீப்பு (*sīppu*) — “a comb”.

A comb, and nothing borrowed about it. The ீ at the front is held long, and then the doubled ப் comes again, so it lands in the same shape as துடைப்பம் and பெட்டி.

A சீப்பு and a மலர் are what go into hair on a morning that is being made something of, and the two turn up in the same sentence often enough to be worth learning together.

What you've built

Five, and the run is closed: a needle, a rope, an umbrella, a broom, and a comb.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *sīppu*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order — *ūsī*, *kayīru*, *kuṭai*, *tuṭaippam*, *sīppu*

Before you move on

What does சீப்பு mean? (“a comb”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 61

How the Body Feels

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say I am hungry, thirsty, sleepy, feverish or in pain in Tamil.

Complete TA-C61-pain and say all five words in order.

61.1 பசி (pasi) — hunger

Before the new one: what did *tutaippam* mean, and what did *sippu* mean?

You'll want to know: பசி

பசி (*pasi*) — “hunger”.

Hunger as a thing that arrives, rather than something you are. Kannada makes it ಹಸಿವು (*hasivu*) — the *p* traded for *h* one more time, exactly as it was between பசு and ಹಸು. Telugu went elsewhere, to ఆకలి (*ākali*).

Set பசி beside பசு and only the last mark separates them: one ends on the ி, the other on the ு. They are not related, and the difference is worth practising until it stops needing thought.

What you've built

The first of five feelings.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *pasi*
- it once more, slowly
- *pasu*, then *pasi*, and hold the two endings apart

Before you move on

What does பசி mean? (“hunger”.) Say it once more.

61.2 தாகம் (tākam) — thirst

Before the new one: what did *pasi* mean?

You’ll want to know: தாகம்

தாகம் (*tākam*) — “thirst”.

Thirst. Sanskrit-descended, unlike பசி beside it, and taken in whole with the *-am* Tamil hangs on such arrivals — the same *-am* already sitting on புத்தகம்.

It is answered with தண்ணீர் and with nothing else in particular, and a Tamil house offers the தண்ணீர் before it is asked for.

What you’ve built

Two.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *tākam*
- it once more, slowly
- *pasi*, then *tākam*, and say what each of the two is answered with

Before you move on

What does தாகம் mean? (“thirst”.) Say it once more.

61.3 தூக்கம் (tūkkam) — sleep

Before the new one: what did *tākam* mean?

You’ll want to know: தூக்கம்

தூக்கம் (*tūkkam*) — “sleep”.

Sleep as a state — the sleep you get, lose, or need more of. Kannada ನಿದ್ರೆ (*nidra*) and Telugu నిద్ర (*nidra*) both took the Sanskrit word; Tamil kept its own and stayed out of it.

Open it on a long ஊ, the same long ஊ that opens ஊசி, and then hold the க்க twice.

What you’ve built

Three.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *tūkkam*
- it once more, slowly
- *tūkkam*, then *ūsi*, and hear the same long vowel open both

Before you move on

What does தூக்கம் mean? (“sleep”.) Say it once more.

61.4 காய்ச்சல் (kāyccal) — a fever

Before the new one: what did *tūkkam* mean?

You'll want to know: காய்ச்சல்

காய்ச்சல் (*kāyccal*) — “a fever”.

The body running hot. Tamil built the word on its own idea of heating rather than importing one, which is why it looks nothing like Kannada's ಜ್ವರ (*jvara*), taken straight from the Sanskrit.

It is the first thing anybody tells a மருத்துவர், and it is said flatly, the way you would report weather.

What you've built

Four.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kāyccal*
- it once more, slowly
- *kāyccal*, then *maruttuvar*, and say which one you take to the other

Before you move on

What does காய்ச்சல் mean? (“a fever”.) Say it once more.

61.5 வலி (vali) — pain

Before the new one: what did *kāyccal* mean?

You'll want to know: வலி

வலி (*vali*) — “pain”.

Pain, plainly: the ache itself, wherever it sits. Kannada says ನೋವು (*nōvu*). Put it with what you already have for the body and it does its work at once — a வலி in the முதுகு, a வலி in the பல்.

Keep it away from *vali*, the way or the route, which came up beside பாதை. வலி takes the plain ல; *vali* takes the ழ you learned to curl the tongue back for. Two letters English would spell alike, and Tamil holds them apart.

What you've built

Five, and the run is closed: hunger, thirst, sleep, a fever, and pain.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *vali*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order — *pasi, tākam, tūkkam, kāyccal, vali*

Before you move on

What does **வலி** mean? (“pain”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 62

Only and Still

Modes: ⇄ voice (5) ⇄ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can say only, still, soon, at once and first of all in Tamil.

Complete TA-C62-first-of-all and say all five words in order.

62.1 மட்டும் (maṭṭum) — only

Before the new one: what did *kāyccal* mean, and what did *vali* mean?

You'll want to know: மட்டும்

மட்டும் (*maṭṭum*) — “only”.

This and nothing beside it. Where English puts *only* in front of the thing it limits, Tamil hangs மட்டும் on the end of it: தண்ணீர் மட்டும் — water, and nothing else.

Telugu does the same job with మాత్రమే (*mātramē*). The doubled ட் in the middle is the one held twice, as in ஆகட்டும்.

What you've built

The first of five.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *maṭṭum*
- it once more, slowly
- *maṭṭum*, then *taṇṇīr*, and put them in the Tamil order

Before you move on

What does மட்டும் mean? (“only”.) Say it once more.

62.2 இன்னும் (*innum*) — still, yet

Before the new one: what did *maṭṭum* mean?

You’ll want to know: இன்னும்

இன்னும் (*innum*) — “still, yet”.

For something that has not finished, and for a bit more of it: இன்னும் சிறிது, a little more still. Kannada ಇನ್ನೂ (*innū*) is the same word; Telugu says ఇంకా (*inkā*).

The ன் doubled in the middle is the soft one — the alveolar ன, not the curled ண you have in கிண்ணம். Tamil keeps three of these apart and this word wants the middle one twice.

What you’ve built

Two.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *innum*
- it once more, slowly
- *innum*, then *siritu*, and say the two together

Before you move on

What does இன்னும் mean? (“still, yet”.) Say it once more.

62.3 சீக்கிரம் (*sīkkiram*) — soon

Before the new one: what did *innum* mean?

You'll want to know: சீக்கிரம்

சீக்கிரம் (*sīkkiram*) — “soon”.

Soon, and quickly — Tamil lets one word carry nearness in நேரம் and speed of doing together, and which one is meant comes out of the sentence around it.

Set it against பிறகு and the pair covers the whole span: சீக்கிரம் is the near end, பிறகு the loose one that promises nothing. Kannada says ಬೇಗ (*bēga*).

What you've built

Three.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *sīkkiram*
- it once more, slowly
- *sīkkiram*, then *piraku*, and say which of the two commits you

Before you move on

What does சீக்கிரம் mean? (“soon”.) Say it once more.

62.4 உடனே (*uṭanē*) — at once

Before the new one: what did *sīkkiram* mean?

You'll want to know: உடனே

உடனே (*uṭanē*) — “at once”.

Tighter than சீக்கிரம்: not soon but now, with nothing allowed in between. It is the word that answers an instruction you intend to obey.

Say it ending long, on the ே. That final length is doing the work — it is what makes the word press rather than merely inform.

What you’ve built

Four, and the fourth pushes harder than the third.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *uṭanē*
- it once more, slowly
- *sikkiram*, then *uṭanē*, and say which one leaves you no room

Before you move on

What does உடனே mean? (“at once”.) Say it once more.

62.5 முதலில் (*mutalil*) — first of all

Before the new one: what did *uṭanē* mean?

You’ll want to know: முதலில்

முதலில் (*mutalil*) — “first of all”.

Before anything else. It puts an order on things that had none: முதலில் தண்ணீர், பிறகு சாதம் — water to begin with, and the rice after.

With this one you can lay out a sequence end to end: முதலில், then உடனே or சீக்கிரம் for what follows fast, then பிறகு for what can wait.

What you’ve built

Five, and the run is closed: only, still, soon, at once, and first of all.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *mutalil*

- it once more, slowly
- all five in order — *maṭṭum*, *innum*, *sākkiram*, *uṭanē*, *mutalil*

Before you move on

What does முதலில் mean? (“first of all”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 63

Asking Well

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🖱️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name a request, permission, hesitancy, trust and humility in Tamil.

Complete TA-C63-humility and say all five words in order.

63.1 வேண்டுகோள் (vēṇḍukōḷ) — a request

Before the new one: what did *uṭaṇē* mean, and what did *mutalil* mean?

You'll want to know: வேண்டுகோள்

வேண்டுகோள் (vēṇḍukōḷ) — “a request”.

A request as a thing you make and hand over, rather than the asking itself. It stands beside வேண்டும், which you already have, and you can hear that word at the front of it.

Kannada ವಿನಂತಿ (*vinanti*) and Telugu మనవి (*manavi*) both went their own way. A வேண்டுகோள் is what தயவுசெய்து is put in front of when the asking has to be formal.

What you've built

The first of five.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *vēṇḍukōḷ*
- it once more, slowly
- *vēṇḍukōḷ*, then *tayavu seytu*, and say which one dresses the other

Before you move on

What does வேண்டுகோள் mean? (“a request”.) Say it once more.

63.2 அனுமதி (anumati) — permission

Before the new one: what did *vēṇḍukōḷ* mean?

You’ll want to know: அனுமதி

அனுமதி (*anumati*) — “permission”.

Permission to do a thing — asked for, given, refused. Here all three sisters took the same Sanskrit word and did not even change its shape: Kannada ಅನುಮತಿ (*anumati*), Telugu అనుమతి (*anumati*), Tamil அனுமதி.

Hold it apart from விடை, which you already have. விடை is permission to go, taken formally at a door. அனுமதி is the wider one and covers everything else you might be allowed.

What you’ve built

Two.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *anumati*
- it once more, slowly
- *anumati*, then *vidai*, and say which of the two is only about leaving

Before you move on

What does அனுமதி mean? (“permission”.) Say it once more.

63.3 தயக்கம் (tayakkam) — hesitancy

Before the new one: what did *anumati* mean?

You’ll want to know: தயக்கம்

தயக்கம் (*tayakkam*) — “hesitancy”.

The holding back before you ask: the half-step not taken, the sentence begun and dropped. Kannada carries the same idea in ಸಂಕೋಚ (sankōca).

The தயவு inside தயவுசெய்து opens the same way and is a different word — that one is kindness given, this one is a foot kept back. Tamil puts them next to each other and expects you to hear the difference.

What you’ve built

Three.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *tayakkam*
- it once more, slowly
- *tayakkam*, then *tayavu seytu*, and say which one is a giving

Before you move on

What does தயக்கம் mean? (“hesitancy”.) Say it once more.

63.4 நம்பிக்கை (nambikkai) — trust

Before the new one: what did *tayakkam* mean?

You'll want to know: நம்பிக்கை

நம்பிக்கை (*nambikkai*) — “trust”.

Trust, and the confidence that comes with it. All three are off the same old stem: Kannada ನಂಬಿಕೆ (*nambike*), Telugu నమ్మకం (*nammakam*), Tamil நம்பிக்கை.

A விருந்தாளி is given this before anything else is given, which is the whole of what a Tamil house means by hospitality.

What you've built

Four.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *nambikkai*
- it once more, slowly
- *nambikkai*, then *viruntāli*, and say who is given which

Before you move on

What does நம்பிக்கை mean? (“trust”.) Say it once more.

63.5 பணிவு (*paṇivu*) — humility

Before the new one: what did *nambikkai* mean?

You'll want to know: பணிவு

பணிவு (*paṇivu*) — “humility”.

The bending: humility, deference, a manner rather than an act. Set it against மரியாதை, which you already have — மரியாதை is respect paid outward to somebody, பணிவு is the carriage you keep in yourself.

Telugu's మర్యాద (*maryāda*) is the same word as your மரியாதை, which makes the pair easy to keep straight across the two.

What you've built

Five, and the run is closed: a request, permission, hesitancy, trust, and humility.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *paṇivu*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order — *vēṇḍukōl*, *aṇumati*, *tayakkam*, *nambikkai*, *paṇivu*

Before you move on

What does பணிவு mean? (“humility”.) Say it once more.

Chapter 64

The Harvest

Modes: 🗣️ voice (5) 🗣️ Hands-free start: all 5 lessons.

By the end of this chapter: I can name paddy, grass, a standing crop, a threshing floor and the harvest in Tamil.

Complete TA-C64-harvest and say all five words in order.

64.1 நெல் (nel) — paddy

Before the new one: what did *nambikkai* mean, and what did *paṇivu* mean?

You'll want to know: நெல்

நெல் (*nel*) — “paddy”.

Rice still in its husk — standing in the வயல், cut, carried, stored, but not yet அரிசி. The two words do not trade places: நெல் goes into the field and அரிசி comes out of the kitchen, and the husking is the border between them.

Kannada ಭತ್ತ (*bhatta*) and Telugu పరి (*vari*) each have their own word for it, so this is one the three do not share.

What you've built

The first of five field words.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *nel*
- it once more, slowly
- *nel*, then *arisi*, and say which one the husk is still on

Before you move on

What does **ನೊಲ** mean? (“paddy”.) Say it once more.

64.2 ಪುಲ (pul) — grass

Before the new one: what did *nel* mean?

You’ll want to know: ಪುಲ

ಪುಲ (*pul*) — “grass”.

Grass, of the kind cut and carried home. Kannada makes it ಹುಲ್ಲು (*hullu*) — the *p*-for-*h* trade a third time, and by now you can guess a Kannada word before you meet it. Telugu went elsewhere, to గడ్డి (*gaḍḍi*).

ಪುಲ and ಪುಲ sit one mark apart, and the mark is the whole difference: keep the ಲ round and low and the word stays grass. A ಪು and an ಅ are put out for ಪುಲ.

What you’ve built

Two.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *pul*
- it once more, slowly
- *pul*, then *pal*, and hold the two vowels apart

Before you move on

What does புல் mean? (“grass”.) Say it once more.

64.3 பயிர் (payir) — a standing crop

Before the new one: what did *pul* mean?

You’ll want to know: பயிர்

பயிர் (*payir*) — “a standing crop”.

What is growing in the வயல் at this moment, green and still rooted. It is not the வயல், which stays there when nothing is on it, and it is not the நெல் in the sack, which has stopped growing.

So the run has three separate things now where English leans on one word: the ground, the standing green, and the grain. Kannada calls the standing green ಬೆಳೆ (*bele*).

What you’ve built

Three, and the three are carefully apart.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *payir*
- it once more, slowly
- *vayal*, then *payir*, then *nel*, in that order

Before you move on

What does பயிர் mean? (“a standing crop”.) Say it once more.

64.4 களம் (kaḷam) — a threshing floor

Before the new one: what did *payir* mean?

You'll want to know: களம்

களம் (*kaḷam*) — “a threshing floor”.

The beaten flat ground at the edge of a village where cut நெல் is spread, trodden and winnowed. Telugu has the same word as కల్లం (*kallam*), which makes it old.

It is not காலம், the season word you already have. This one is short at the front and takes the ள; காலம் opens long and takes the ல. One mark and one letter, and they are unrelated.

What you've built

Four.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *kaḷam*
- it once more, slowly
- *kaḷam*, then *nel*, and say what is brought to which

Before you move on

What does களம் mean? (“a threshing floor”.) Say it once more.

64.5 அறுவடை (*aruvaṭai*) — the harvest

Before the new one: what did *kaḷam* mean?

You'll want to know: அறுவடை

அறுவடை (*aruvaṭai*) — “the harvest”.

The cutting and the gathering together, and the stretch of the year named after them. Kannada ಸುಗ್ಗಿ (*suggi*) and Telugu పంట (*paṇṭa*) each named the same weeks their own way.

The front of it is the reaping, not the ஆறு you counted with: this one opens short on அ and takes the hard ற straight away, where six opens long on ஆ. Close together on the page, far apart in the mouth.

What you've built

Five, and the run is closed: paddy, grass, a standing crop, a threshing floor, and the harvest.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- *aruvaṭai*
- it once more, slowly
- all five in order — *nel, pul, payir, kaḷam, aruvaṭai*

Before you move on

What does அறுவடை mean? (“the harvest”.) Say it once more.

The Tamil script — a reference

Not to be read before the lessons — they teach reading through real words, each letter introduced as a word needs it. This page just gathers the system.

The three facts

1. **Consonants carry a built-in “a.”** க = ka, ம = ma, ர = ra.
2. **A vowel sign changes that built-in vowel.** ா = ā, ி = i, ீ = ī, ூ = u, ௃ = ū, ெ = e, ே = ē, ை = ai, ொ = o, ோ = ō.
(E.g. க ka + ி → கி ki.)
3. **A *pulli* (the dot, ்) removes the built-in vowel.** க் = a bare *k*.
A vowel-less consonant then leans into the next.

Independent vowels (word-initial)

அ a · ஆ ā · இ i · ஈ ī · உ u · ஊ ū · எ e · ஏ ē · ஐ ai · ஒ o ·
ஔ ō · ஔ au.

What makes Tamil distinctive

- **Three *n*'s, three *l*'s, two *r*'s.** Place of articulation is written: dental ந / alveolar ண / retroflex ண்; ல ள ழ; ர ற. English fuses each set; Tamil keeps them apart, and they change meaning.
- **One letter, several sounds.** Tamil marks no voicing or aspiration: க can be *k*, *g*, or *h*; ச can be *s* or *ch* — **position** decides. The alphabet is small; the sound is read from context.

- **No Sanskrit-only letters in the core set.** Classical Tamil gets by with 18 consonants (a handful of *grantha* letters — ஜ, ஷ, ஸ, ஹ — are added only to spell loanwords).

Tamil in the Dravidian family

Tamil is the oldest-attested Dravidian language, and the one most protective of its native word-stock. Its sisters — Malayalam (closest), then Kannada and Telugu — share the grammar and many roots but borrowed far more freely from Sanskrit. The lessons trace, word by word, which Tamil words are home-grown and which its neighbours replaced.

Glossary

This glossary collects every word and phrase taught in the book. Pronunciation appears when it differs from the written form; chapter numbers show where each entry is introduced.

-உக்கு *-ukku*

the dative suffix -ukku, 'to / for,' including its two surface forms and irregular enakku

Introduced in Chapter 6.

aaru eezhu ettu onpatu pattu

hear and say six to ten before meeting their written forms

Introduced in Chapter 7.

அது *adu*

that one — the thing over there

Introduced in Chapter 40.

ஆகட்டும் *ākattum*

let it be so

Introduced in Chapter 56.

ஆகாயம் *ākāyam*

the sky

Introduced in Chapter 51.

ஆம் / இல்லை / சரி *ām / illai / sari*

answering in Tamil — the five words in use, and the two habits behind them

Introduced in Chapter 1.

அன்பு *aṇbu*

affection

Introduced in Chapter 49.

அங்கே *aṅgē*

there — where I am not

Introduced in Chapter 40.

அனுமதி *aṇumati*

permission

Introduced in Chapter 63.

அப்படியே *appaḍiyē*

just so

Introduced in Chapter 47.

அறை *arai*

room — and the letter ற, the hard r that is not the r you think it is

Introduced in Chapter 35.

அறுவடை *aruvaṭai*

the harvest

Introduced in Chapter 64.

ஆசிரியர் *āsiriyaṛ*

a teacher

Introduced in Chapter 46.

ஆடு *ātu*

a goat

Introduced in Chapter 58.

எடு *edu*

to take, to pick up — one vowel away from இடு, “to put,” and pointing the opposite way

Introduced in Chapter 34.

எழுது *eludu*

to write — carrying ழ, the retroflex glide Tamil and Malayalam kept and their sisters gave up

Introduced in Chapter 33.

எலும்பு *elumbu*

a bone

Introduced in Chapter 55.

என் *eṇ*

my

Introduced in Chapter 2.

என் பெயர் ... *eṇ peyaṛ ...*

my name is... (with no “is”)

Introduced in Chapter 2.

எனக்குத் தமிழ் தெரியும் *enakkut tamīl teriyum*

‘I know ‘Tamil’ — built with no subject, because knowing happens TO you

Introduced in Chapter 6.

எங்கே *eṅgē*

where? — asking about a place

Introduced in Chapter 40.

என்ன *enna*

what

Introduced in Chapter 2.

எண்ணெய் *eṇṇey*

oil

Introduced in Chapter 59.

எப்படி *eppaḍi*

how

Introduced in Chapter 3.

எவ்வளவு *eṇṇaḷavu*

how much — the question for things Tamil does not count one by one

Introduced in Chapter 39.

இது *idu*

this one — the thing near me

Introduced in Chapter 40.

இல்லை *illai*

no / there isn't (illai — the negative)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

இங்கே *iṅgē*

here — where I am

Introduced in Chapter 40.

இனிய இரவு *iniya iravu*

“good night” — fully native Dravidian, “sweet/pleasant night,” unlike Hindi, Kannada, Telugu, and Malayalam’s shared Sanskrit-descended śubha rātri phrase; Tamil breaks the pattern this arc found in every other language

Introduced in Chapter 25.

இன்னும் *innum*

still, yet

Introduced in Chapter 62.

இப்போது *ippōdu*

now

Introduced in Chapter 48.

இரவு *iravu*

“night” — native Dravidian, already used standalone inside “midnight” (naḷḷiravu); a Sanskrit loan alternative, rāttiri, also exists — and per at least one dictionary source, rāttiri may actually be the MORE common word in everyday spoken Tamil, the opposite direction from நாள்’s story last lesson

Introduced in Chapter 24.

இரு *iru*

to be, to exist, to stay — and the three-piece machine every Tamil verb is built on

Introduced in Chapter 32.

இவர் *ivar*

this person, spoken of with respect — the near end of Tamil’s இ / அ / எ pointing system

Introduced in Chapter 37.

இவர் என் நண்பர் *ivar en naṇbar*

“this is my friend” — three words, no verb, and a choice of ending that says how you regard them

Introduced in Chapter 37.

கதவு *kadavu*

door — Tamil’s everyday word is its own, while the Sanskrit one stayed in books

Introduced in Chapter 35.

காது *kādu*

an ear

Introduced in Chapter 45.

காக்கை *kākkai*

a crow

Introduced in Chapter 58.

காலை *kālai*

morning (kālai) — Wiktionary itself HEDGES the etymology (“possibly from Sanskrit काल्य/kālya”), not a confirmed Dravidian root; genuinely uncertain, unlike Kannada’s confidently-native or Telugu’s confidently-Sanskrit morning-words; பகல் (already met, TA-C17, “daytime”) is Wiktionary’s own listed coordinate term; அதிகாலை (“early dawn”) is a transparent ati-+kālai compound

Introduced in Chapter 26.

காலை வணக்கம் *kālai vaṇakkam*

good morning (kālai vaṇakkam), literally “morning greetings” — a transparent compound of காலை (already met, TA-C26) + வணக்கம் (already met, TA-C01, “reverence, homage”); confirmed via TWO independently-fetched sources as the standard, formal greeting, used from sunrise until around 11 AM; NOT a śubha-equivalent construction, breaking the pattern its neighbours share; a WebSearch summary’s claim that a Sanskrit-borrowed “suprabhatham” is a casual alternative could NOT be traced to either directly-fetched source and is therefore not asserted here

Introduced in Chapter 29.

களம் *kaḷam*

a threshing floor

Introduced in Chapter 64.

கழுத்து *kaḷuttu*

the neck

Introduced in Chapter 55.

கண் *kaṇ*

an eye

Introduced in Chapter 45.

கனல் *kaṇal*

an ember

Introduced in Chapter 57.

காற்று *kārru*

the wind

Introduced in Chapter 57.

கத்தி *katti*

a knife

Introduced in Chapter 54.

காய்ச்சல் *kāyccal*

a fever

Introduced in Chapter 61.

கயிறு *kayiru*

a rope

Introduced in Chapter 60.

கேள் *kēl*

to ask — and to hear, because Tamil gives both jobs to one verb, whose stem changes shape before the beads

Introduced in Chapter 34.

கிளை *kilai*

a branch

Introduced in Chapter 52.

கிண்ணம் *kinṇam*

a bowl

Introduced in Chapter 54.

கிராமம் *kirāmam*

a village

Introduced in Chapter 53.

கோலம் *kōlam*

the design at a doorway

Introduced in Chapter 50.

கோழி *kōli*

a hen

Introduced in Chapter 58.

கொடு *koṭu*

give

Introduced in Chapter 42.

குழந்தை *kulandai*

child

Introduced in Chapter 43.

குறைவு *kuraivu*

a shortage, less than there should be

Introduced in Chapter 56.

குடை *kuṭai*

an umbrella

Introduced in Chapter 60.

கூடை *kūṭai*

a basket

Introduced in Chapter 54.

குடும்பம் *kuṭumbam*

family

Introduced in Chapter 43.

மகள் *makaḷ*

daughter

Introduced in Chapter 43.

மகன் *makaṇ*

son

Introduced in Chapter 43.

மலை *malai*

a hill

Introduced in Chapter 53.

மாலை *mālai*

evening (*mālai*) — a genuine HOMONYM: Wiktionary lists TWO separate etymologies for this exact spelling — “garland/necklace” (possibly a Dravidian word BORROWED INTO Sanskrit as माला/*mālā*, a reverse-direction loan) and, unrelated, “evening” (compared to மால், Proto-Dravidian *mā*/*māl*, whose senses include “கருமை,” darkness); confidently native for the evening sense, unlike TA-C26’s uncertain காலை, though the exact semantic mechanism (“evening” ← “darkness” specifically) isn’t spelled out with full certainty by the source
Introduced in Chapter 27.

மாலை வணக்கம் *mālai vaṇakkam*

good evening (*mālai vaṇakkam*), literally “evening greetings” — the SAME compositional pattern as TA-C29’s *kālai vaṇakkam*: மாலை (already met, TA-C27, “evening”) + வணக்கம் (already met, TA-C01); confirmed via TWO independently-fetched sources (*talkpal.ai*, *preply.com* — same practical-content tier as TA-C29’s sources) as real and used from afternoon/late-afternoon through nightfall, one labeling it formal; no *śubha*-equivalent word here either, consistent with TA-C29’s finding, not just assumed to carry over automatically
Introduced in Chapter 30.

மலர் *malar*

a flower

Introduced in Chapter 50.

மணல் *maṇal*

sand

Introduced in Chapter 57.

மாணவன் *māṇavan*

a student

Introduced in Chapter 46.

மணி *maṇi*

hour — Tamil’s OWN dictionaries treat this as a native Dravidian “bell” word, most likely NOT Kannada/Telugu/Hindi’s Sanskrit ghaṇṭā, and a probable homophone trap with an unrelated Sanskrit “gem” word spelled the same way

Introduced in Chapter 18.

மரம் *maram*

a tree

Introduced in Chapter 52.

மரியாதை *mariyāḍai*

respect

Introduced in Chapter 49.

மருத்துவர் *maruttuvar*

a doctor

Introduced in Chapter 46.

மதிய வணக்கம் *matiya vaṇakkam*

good afternoon (matiya vaṇakkam), confirmed by two sources for roughly noon to 4 PM, while a third source does not teach a separate afternoon greeting

Introduced in Chapter 31.

மட்டும் *maṭṭum*

only

Introduced in Chapter 62.

மேகம் *mēkam*

a cloud

Introduced in Chapter 51.

மிக்க நன்றி *mikka nanri*

thank you very much

Introduced in Chapter 49.

மீண்டும் சந்திப்போம் *mīṇḍum sandippōm*

we’ll meet again

Introduced in Chapter 4.

மூக்கு *mūḱku*

a nose

Introduced in Chapter 45.

முதலில் *mutalil*

first of all

Introduced in Chapter 62.

முதுகு *mutuku*

the back

Introduced in Chapter 55.

நதி *nadi*

a river

Introduced in Chapter 53.

நகம் *nakam*

a nail

Introduced in Chapter 55.

நாள் *nāl*

“day” — Tamil’s everyday, native Dravidian word, already met inside “tomorrow”; unlike Kannada’s *dina*, Telugu’s *rōju*, and Malayalam’s *divasam*, Tamil’s plain day-word is NOT a loanword at all — நாள் just is the everyday word, no Sanskrit or Persian substitute doing that job
Introduced in Chapter 23.

நாளை பார்க்கலாம் *nālai pārkkalām*

see you tomorrow

Introduced in Chapter 4.

நலம் *nalam*

well, wellness, good — and the reply “நான் நலமாக இருக்கிறேன்”

Introduced in Chapter 3.

நல்ல *nalla*

good

Introduced in Chapter 41.

நம்பிக்கை *nambikkai*

trust

Introduced in Chapter 63.

நான் *nān*

I

Introduced in Chapter 3.

நான் தமிழ் பேசுகிறேன் *nān tamiz pēsugirēn*

I speak Tamil

Introduced in Chapter 5.

நண்பன் *naṇban*

friend — one word with three endings for man, woman and respect, and a root meaning “close”

Introduced in Chapter 37.

நன்றி *nanri*

thank you (nanri — “goodness, gratitude”)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

நாற்காலி *nārkāli*

chair — a word you can take apart into “four” and “leg,” and the thing a guest is offered

Introduced in Chapter 35.

நெல் *nel*

paddy

Introduced in Chapter 64.

நேரம் *nēram*

time

Introduced in Chapter 48.

நெய் *ney*

ghee

Introduced in Chapter 59.

நீ / நீங்கள் *nī / nīṅgaḷ*

you (familiar / respectful)

Introduced in Chapter 2.

நிச்சயமாக *niccayamāka*

certainly

Introduced in Chapter 47.

நிலா *nilā*

the moon

Introduced in Chapter 51.

நினை *ninai*

to think — and, with no second word, to remember, because Tamil files thinking and recalling under one verb

Introduced in Chapter 33.

நிறைய *niraiya*

a lot

Introduced in Chapter 56.

onru irantu muunru naanku aintu

hear and say one to five before meeting their written forms

Introduced in Chapter 7.

ஒரு *oru*

a, one — the form ஒன்று takes when it stands in front of a noun

Introduced in Chapter 39.

ஒருவேளை *oruvēlai*

perhaps

Introduced in Chapter 47.

பச்சை, மஞ்சள் *paccai mañcal*

green and yellow — paccai is the pan-Dravidian *pac-* word already met in Kannada, Telugu, and Malayalam; manjal (“yellow, turmeric”) is a separate native Dravidian root, matching Malayalam’s mañña/maññaḷ closely — and Tamil dictionaries also record a rarer, less-commonly-used pacuppu (“greenish yellow”), a genuine doublet of paccai itself, echoing Telugu’s pattern in miniature
Introduced in Chapter 22.

படி *paḍi*

to read, to study — and the reason this book writes it paḍi with a d when the letter is ட

Introduced in Chapter 33.

பல் *pal*

a tooth

Introduced in Chapter 45.

பால் *pāl*

milk — one syllable, inherited whole, and the word that shows Kannada turning p into h

Introduced in Chapter 36.

பழைய *palaiya*

old — of a thing, not of a person

Introduced in Chapter 41.

பழம் *palam*

a fruit

Introduced in Chapter 44.

பணிவு *paṇivu*

humility

Introduced in Chapter 63.

பார் *pār*

to see, to look — and the doubled consonant that sorts every Tamil verb into strong or weak

Introduced in Chapter 32.

பறவை *paravai*

a bird

Introduced in Chapter 58.

பரவாயில்லை *paravāyillai*

it's okay / no problem / you're welcome

Introduced in Chapter 3.

பசி *pasi*

hunger

Introduced in Chapter 61.

பசு *pasu*

a cow

Introduced in Chapter 58.

பாதை *pātai*

a path

Introduced in Chapter 53.

படி *paḍi*

read

Introduced in Chapter 42.

பாய் *pāy*

a mat

Introduced in Chapter 54.

பயணம் *payaṇam*

a journey

Introduced in Chapter 48.

பயிர் *payir*

a standing crop

Introduced in Chapter 64.

பெரிய *periya*

big

Introduced in Chapter 41.

பேசு *pēsu*

to speak

Introduced in Chapter 5.

பெட்டி *peṭṭi*

a box

Introduced in Chapter 54.

பெயர் *peyar*

name

Introduced in Chapter 2.

பிடி *pidi*

to catch, to hold — and so, in பிடிக்கும், to please, with the liker pushed into the dative

Introduced in Chapter 34.

பிறகு *piraku*

afterwards

Introduced in Chapter 48.

பிற்பகல் *pirpakal*

afternoon (pirpakal) — a transparent compound, பின் (pin, “after”) + நண்பகல்’s own பகல் (“daytime”), with பின் surfacing as பிற்- before ப, a SIMILAR kind of consonant sandhi to the one already taught in TA-C17 (நள்→நண்) — though Wiktionary itself does not discuss the sandhi mechanism, and the two changes move in different phonetic directions (nasal→stop vs. lateral→nasal), so this is the lesson’s own analysis, not a sourced claim; Wiktionary-listed formal register; a real, citable overlap worth flagging honestly: Wiktionary’s OWN afternoon-word page ALSO lists நடுப்பகல் as a synonym, even though TA-C17 established நடுப்பகல் as a synonym of NOON specifically; also related but distinct: மதியம், a Sanskrit tatsama (from madhya, “middle”) meaning “noon,” a synonym of நண்பகல் — NOT specifically “afternoon,” despite an unverified WebSearch claim that matiyam “originally meant moon,” which does not appear anywhere on its actual Wiktionary page and is therefore not asserted here

Introduced in Chapter 28.

போ *pō*

to go (and வா, to come)

Introduced in Chapter 4.

போ *pō*

to go — the same three-slot verb with the middle bead swapped for past, present or future

Introduced in Chapter 32.

போதும் *pōdum*

that is enough

Introduced in Chapter 47.

போய் வருகிறேன் *pōy varugirēn*

goodbye (lit. “I’ll go and come back”)

Introduced in Chapter 4.

புதிய *pudiya*

new

Introduced in Chapter 41.

புகை *pukai*

smoke

Introduced in Chapter 57.

புல் *pul*

grass

Introduced in Chapter 64.

புறப்படு *purappadu*

to set out

Introduced in Chapter 48.

புரி *puri*

to be understood, to become clear — so the understander is not the subject but sits in the dative, as with தெரி

Introduced in Chapter 33.

புத்தகம் *puttakam*

a book

Introduced in Chapter 44.

சந்தோஷம் *santōṣam*

gladness

Introduced in Chapter 49.

சாப்பிடு *sāppidu*

to eat — a verb Tamil assembled from a noun plus a light verb, alongside the inherited eat-word it kept

Introduced in Chapter 32.

சரி *sari*

okay / alright / correct (sari)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

சர்க்கரை *sarkkarai*

sugar

Introduced in Chapter 59.

சேறு *sēru*

mud

Introduced in Chapter 57.

சீக்கிரம் *śikkiram*

soon

Introduced in Chapter 62.

சீப்பு *śippu*

a comb

Introduced in Chapter 60.

சிறிது *śiritu*

a little

Introduced in Chapter 56.

சிறிய *śiriya*

small

Introduced in Chapter 41.

solluṅgaḷ

please tell me

Introduced in Chapter 8.

சுகம் *sugam*

wellbeing, ease — the Sanskrit word Tamil did take in, sitting beside the native

நலம் it never dropped

Introduced in Chapter 38.

சூரியன் *sūriyan*

the sun

Introduced in Chapter 51.

தாகம் *tākam*

thirst

Introduced in Chapter 61.

தலை கை *talai kai*

head and hand — both native Dravidian words, unlike Hindi’s Sanskrit-descended pair

Introduced in Chapter 13.

தளிர் *talir*

a tender shoot

Introduced in Chapter 52.

தவறு *tavaru*

a mistake — the noun that lets you finish an apology, and the same word as the verb “to slip”

Introduced in Chapter 36.

தயக்கம் *tayakkam*

hesitancy

Introduced in Chapter 63.

தயவுசெய்து *tayavu seytu*

please (tayavu seytu — “do the kindness,” from தயவு tayavu “compassion/grace”)

Introduced in Chapter 8.

தயிர் *tayir*

curd

Introduced in Chapter 59.

தேநீர் *tēnīr*

tea — a borrowed syllable welded onto the நீர் that is already inside தண்ணீர்

Introduced in Chapter 36.

தெரி *teri*

to know, to be apparent — the verb that takes no person ending, because knowing happens to you

Introduced in Chapter 32.

தேவையில்லை *tēvaiyillai*

there is no need

Introduced in Chapter 56.

தூக்கம் *tūkkam*

sleep

Introduced in Chapter 61.

துணி *tun̄i*

cloth

Introduced in Chapter 44.

துடைப்பம் *tut̄aippam*

a broom

Introduced in Chapter 60.

உடம்பு *uḍambu*

body — the noun in the everyday Tamil way of asking after someone's health

Introduced in Chapter 38.

உதவு *udavu*

to help, to be of use — a native word where three sisters and Hindi all reach for Sanskrit instead

Introduced in Chapter 34.

உணவு *uṇavu*

food — the noun standing on உண், the older eating verb behind சாப்பிடு's everyday one

Introduced in Chapter 36.

உண்மை *uṇmai*

the truth

Introduced in Chapter 47.

உப்பு *uppu*

salt

Introduced in Chapter 44.

ஊர் *ūr*

town, village — where you are from, which a Tamil introduction asks for, and the -ore in Bangalore

Introduced in Chapter 37.

ஊசி *ūs̄i*

a needle

Introduced in Chapter 60.

உடனே *uḍanē*

at once

Introduced in Chapter 62.

உதடு *utaḍu*

a lip

Introduced in Chapter 55.

உட்கார் *uḍkāṛ*

sit

Introduced in Chapter 42.

வா *vā*

come

Introduced in Chapter 42.

வா *vā*

to come — the word you say it by is வா, but the beads attach to a different shape, வரு-

Introduced in Chapter 32.

வாழ் *vāl*

to live, to flourish

Introduced in Chapter 5.

வலி *vali*

pain

Introduced in Chapter 61.

வாழ்த்து *vālttu*

a good wish

Introduced in Chapter 49.

வணக்கம் *vaṇakkam*

hello / greetings (vaṇakkam — “reverence, homage”)

Introduced in Chapter 1.

வானிலை *vāṇilai*

weather — most likely a NATIVE Dravidian compound, unlike Kannada/Telugu/Malayalam’s Sanskrit compounds: vaanam (“sky”) + nilai (“state, standing”)

Introduced in Chapter 20.

வரவேற்பு *varavēṛpu*

a welcome

Introduced in Chapter 50.

வாசல் *vāsal*

a doorway

Introduced in Chapter 50.

வயல் *vayal*

a paddy field

Introduced in Chapter 53.

வயிறு *vayiru*

the stomach

Introduced in Chapter 45.

வேலை செய் *vēlai sey*

to work (lit. “work-do”)

Introduced in Chapter 5.

வெல்லம் *vellam*

jaggery

Introduced in Chapter 59.

வேண்டுகோள் *vēṇḍukōl*

a request

Introduced in Chapter 63.

வேண்டும் *vēṇḍum*

want, need — another verb Tamil builds with no subject at all
Introduced in Chapter 39.

வேர் *vēr*

a root
Introduced in Chapter 52.

வெற்றிலை *verrilai*

betel leaf
Introduced in Chapter 50.

விடை *viḍai*

leave to depart — the noun for taking your leave, from the same root as வீடு
Introduced in Chapter 38.

வீடு *vīḍu*

house, home — the word behind the door you say வணக்கம் at, and a v where Kannada says b
Introduced in Chapter 35.

விளக்கு *vilakku*

a lamp
Introduced in Chapter 44.

விண்மீன் *viṇmīn*

a star
Introduced in Chapter 51.

விருந்தாளி *viruntāḷi*

a guest
Introduced in Chapter 46.

விதை *vitai*

a seed
Introduced in Chapter 52.

விவசாயி *vivasāyi*

a farmer
Introduced in Chapter 46.

யார் *yār*

who? — asking about a person
Introduced in Chapter 40.

அப்பா அம்மா அண்ணன் தம்பி அக்கா தங்கை

father, mother, and FOUR sibling words — Tamil splits “brother”/“sister” by age, where Spanish/French use just one word each
Introduced in Chapter 12.

ஆம்

yes (ām)
Introduced in Chapter 1.

உங்கள் பெயர் என்ன?

what's your name?

Introduced in Chapter 2.

உனக்கு எத்தனை வயது ஆகிறது?

how old are you? — literally “to you how many years is becoming?”; the SAME Sanskrit *vayas* word as Kannada/Telugu/Malayalam; Tamil actually spans BOTH grammatical shapes seen so far, from a plain possessive in casual speech to this more formal dative+verb construction

Introduced in Chapter 19.

கருப்பு வெள்ளை சிவப்பு நீலம்

black, white, red, blue — three native Tamil colors, and one Sanskrit loan

Introduced in Chapter 11.

சித்திரை வைகாசி ஆனி ஆடி ஆவணி புரட்டாசி ஐப்பசி**கார்த்திகை மார்கழி தை மாசி பங்குனி**

the twelve months of the Tamil solar calendar — Tamil's OWN calendar, distinct from both the Gregorian and Hindu lunisolar systems

Introduced in Chapter 16.

திங்கள்-ஞாயிறு

the seven weekdays — a mix of Tamil's OWN planet-words and Sanskrit borrowings

Introduced in Chapter 10.

தண்ணீர் அரிசி சாதம்

water, and rice — the actual staple food here, not bread — with a widely-cited (if not fully certain) link from *arisi* to the English word “rice” itself

Introduced in Chapter 15.

நீங்கள் எப்படி இருக்கிறீர்கள்?

how are you? (respectful)

Introduced in Chapter 3.

நண்பகல் நள்ளிரவு

noon and midnight — NO Sanskrit here at all (unlike Kannada/Telugu); both trace to the same old “middle” root, *நள்* (*nal*), but Tamil ALSO keeps fully transparent synonyms built on *நடு*, the everyday word for “middle”

Introduced in Chapter 17.

நாய், பூனை

dog and cat — *நாய்* is THE solid, ancient, undisputed Dravidian root behind Kannada/Malayalam's dog-words too, the honest opposite of the tangled dog-words of Spanish, Hindi, and English; *பூனை* is Tamil's everyday cat-word, one of (at least) three genuinely separate Dravidian cat-word families

Introduced in Chapter 21.

பதினொன்று — இருபது

11-20 — additive “ten-echo” compounds for the teens, then இருபது (20), transparently “two-tens” — closing out the arc: all four Dravidian languages build twenty compositionally, unlike Sanskrit, Latin, or Arabic’s opaque special words Introduced in Chapter 20.

மகிழ்ச்சி

joy / pleased to meet you
Introduced in Chapter 2.

மன்னிக்கவும்

please forgive (mannikkavum — a formal/written polite request, from மன்னி manni “to forgive”)
Introduced in Chapter 9.

வசந்த காலம் கோடைக் காலம் மழைக் காலம் குளிர் காலம்

spring, summer, monsoon, winter — and the honest note that the REAL locally central season is the rains, not a Western four-way split
Introduced in Chapter 14.

Review Questions

Try these without looking ahead. Every prompt comes from the same canonical lesson data as its chapter. Answers begin in the next section.

Chapter 4

4.1 *Tamil's curves — the writing surface leaves a trace*

What writing surface is usually linked to Tamil's rounded shapes?

Answer Key

The first response is the canonical display answer. When a question accepts other authored forms, they appear underneath.

Chapter 4

4.1 *Tamil's curves — the writing surface leaves a trace*

Answer: palm leaves

Also accepted: palm leaf; leaves of palm

Index

Look up an English meaning, a dedicated language topic, or a chapter topic. Each linked reference opens the chapter where the material is introduced; the focus labels name only explicitly typed lesson sections.

0–9

11-20 — additive “ten-echo” compounds for the teens, then இருபது (20), transparently “two-tens” — closing out the arc: all four Dravidian languages build twenty compositionally, unlike Sanskrit, Latin, or Arabic’s opaque special words பதினொன்று — இருபது

explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 20, p. 123

A

a basket கூடை (kūṭai)

Chapter 54, p. 331

a bird பறவை (paravai)

Chapter 58, p. 355

a bone எலும்பு (elumbu)

Chapter 55, p. 337

a book புத்தகம் (puttakam)

Chapter 44, p. 271

a bowl கிண்ணம் (kiṇṇam)

Chapter 54, p. 331

a box பெட்டி (peṭṭi)

Chapter 54, p. 331

a branch கிளை (kiḷai)

Chapter 52, p. 319

a broom துடைப்பம் (tuṭaippam)

Chapter 60, p. 367

- a cloud** மேகம் (mekam)
Chapter 51, p. 313
- a comb** சீப்பு (sīppu)
Chapter 60, p. 367
- a cow** பசு (pasu)
Chapter 58, p. 355
- a crow** காக்கை (kākkai)
Chapter 58, p. 355
- a doctor** மருத்துவர் (maruttuvar)
Chapter 46, p. 283
- a doorway** வாசல் (vāsal)
Chapter 50, p. 307
- a farmer** விவசாயி (vivasāyi)
Chapter 46, p. 283
- a fever** காய்ச்சல் (kāyccal)
Chapter 61, p. 373
- a flower** மலர் (malar)
Chapter 50, p. 307
- a fruit** பழம் (paḷam)
Chapter 44, p. 271
- a goat** ஆடு (āṭu)
Chapter 58, p. 355
- a good wish** வாழ்த்து (vāḷttu)
Chapter 49, p. 301
- a guest** விருந்தாளி (viruntāḷi)
Chapter 46, p. 283
- a hen** கோழி (kōḷi)
Chapter 58, p. 355
- a hill** மலை (malai)
Chapter 53, p. 325
- a journey** பயணம் (payaṇam)
Chapter 48, p. 295
- a knife** கத்தி (katti)
Chapter 54, p. 331
- a lamp** விளக்கு (viḷakku)
Chapter 44, p. 271
- a lip** உதடு (utaṭu)
Chapter 55, p. 337
- a little** சிறிது (siritu)
Chapter 56, p. 343
- a lot** நிறைய (niraiya)
Chapter 56, p. 343

a mat பாய் (pāy)

Chapter 54, p. 331

a mistake — the noun that lets you finish an apology, and the same word as the verb “to slip” தவறு (tavaru)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 36, p. 215

a nail நகம் (nakam)

Chapter 55, p. 337

a needle ஊசி (ūsi)

Chapter 60, p. 367

a nose மூக்கு (mūkku)

Chapter 45, p. 277

a, one — the form ஒன்று takes when it stands in front of a noun ஒரு (oru)

explicit focus: script, grammar; Chapter 39, p. 243

a paddy field வயல் (vayal)

Chapter 53, p. 325

a path பாதை (pātai)

Chapter 53, p. 325

a request வேண்டுகோள் (vēṇḍukōḷ)

Chapter 63, p. 385

a river நதி (nadi)

Chapter 53, p. 325

a root வேர் (vēr)

Chapter 52, p. 319

a rope கயிறு (kayiru)

Chapter 60, p. 367

a seed விதை (vitai)

Chapter 52, p. 319

a shortage, less than there should be குறைவு (kuraivu)

Chapter 56, p. 343

a standing crop பயிர் (payir)

Chapter 64, p. 391

a star விண்மீன் (viṇmīn)

Chapter 51, p. 313

a student மாணவன் (māṇavan)

Chapter 46, p. 283

a teacher ஆசிரியர் (āsiriyar)

Chapter 46, p. 283

a tender shoot தளிர் (taḷir)

Chapter 52, p. 319

a threshing floor களம் (kaḷam)

Chapter 64, p. 391

a tooth பல் (pal)

Chapter 45, p. 277

A Tree

chapter topic; Chapter 52, p. 319

a tree மரம் (maram)

Chapter 52, p. 319

a village கிராமம் (kirāmam)

Chapter 53, p. 325

a welcome வரவேற்பு (varavēṛpu)

Chapter 50, p. 307

affection அன்பு (anbu)

Chapter 49, p. 301

Afternoon

chapter topic; Chapter 28, p. 159

afternoon (pirpakal) — a transparent compound, பின் (pin, “after”) + நண்பகல்’s own பகல் (“daytime”), with பின் surfacing as பிற்- before ப, a SIMILAR kind of consonant sandhi to the one already taught in TA-C17 (நள்→நண்) — though Wiktionary itself does not discuss the sandhi mechanism, and the two changes move in different phonetic directions (nasal→stop vs. lateral→nasal), so this is the lesson’s own analysis, not a sourced claim; Wiktionary-listed formal register; a real, citable overlap worth flagging honestly: Wiktionary’s OWN afternoon-word page ALSO lists நடுப்பகல் as a synonym, even though TA-C17 established நடுப்பகல் as a synonym of NOON specifically; also related but distinct: மதியம், a Sanskrit tatsama (from madhya, “middle”) meaning “noon,” a synonym of நண்பகல் — NOT specifically “afternoon,” despite an unverified WebSearch claim that matiyam “originally meant moon,” which does not appear anywhere on its actual Wiktionary page and is therefore not asserted here பிற்பகல் (pirpakal)

Chapter 28, p. 159

afterwards பிறகு (piraku)

Chapter 48, p. 295

an ear காது (kādu)

Chapter 45, p. 277

an ember கனல் (kaṇal)

Chapter 57, p. 349

an eye கண் (kaṇ)

Chapter 45, p. 277

an umbrella குடை (kuṭai)

Chapter 60, p. 367

ி and நன்றி — replace the vowel, then hear *ndr*

script and writing topic; explicit focus: pronunciation, script; Chapter 13, p. 83

answering in Tamil — the five words in use, and the two habits

behind them ஆம் / இல்லை / சரி (ām / illai / sari)

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 1, p. 1

Around the Yard

chapter topic; Chapter 58, p. 355

Arriving at a House

chapter topic; Chapter 35, p. 205

Asking for What You Want

chapter topic; Chapter 39, p. 243

Asking Someone's Age

chapter topic; Chapter 19, p. 117

Asking Well

chapter topic; Chapter 63, p. 385

at once உடனே (uṭanē)

Chapter 62, p. 379

At the Doorway

chapter topic; Chapter 50, p. 307

B

before the noun, unchanged — five words, one rule

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 41, p. 257

betel leaf வெற்றிலை (verrilai)

Chapter 50, p. 307

big பெரிய (periya)

Chapter 41, p. 257

black, white, red, blue — three native Tamil colors, and one

Sanskrit loan கருப்பு வெள்ளை சிவப்பு நீலம்

explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 11, p. 75

Body Parts

chapter topic; Chapter 13, p. 83

body — the noun in the everyday Tamil way of asking after

someone's health உடம்பு (uḍambu)

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 38, p. 235

C

certainly நிச்சயமாக (niccayamāka)

Chapter 47, p. 289

chair — a word you can take apart into “four” and “leg,” and
the thing a guest is offered நாற்காலி (nārkaḷi)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 35, p. 205

child குழந்தை (kuḷandai)

Chapter 43, p. 267

cloth துணி (tuṇi)

Chapter 44, p. 271

Colours

chapter topic; Chapter 11, p. 75

come வா (vā)

Chapter 42, p. 263

Courtesy

chapter topic; Chapter 49, p. 301

curd தயிர் (tayir)

Chapter 59, p. 361

D

Dative Case and Dative Subjects

chapter topic; Chapter 6, p. 23

daughter மகள் (maḱaḷ)

Chapter 43, p. 267

Day

chapter topic; Chapter 23, p. 137

“day” — Tamil’s everyday, native Dravidian word, already met
 inside “tomorrow”; unlike Kannada’s dina, Telugu’s rōju, and
 Malayalam’s divasam, Tamil’s plain day-word is NOT a loanword
 at all — நாள் just is the everyday word, no Sanskrit or Persian
 substitute doing that job நாள் (nāl)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 23, p. 137

Days of the Week

chapter topic; Chapter 10, p. 67

Describing Things

chapter topic; Chapter 41, p. 257

Dog and Cat

chapter topic; Chapter 21, p. 129

dog and cat — நாய் is THE solid, ancient, undisputed Dravidian
 root behind Kannada/Malayalam’s dog-words too, the honest
 opposite of the tangled dog-words of Spanish, Hindi, and English;
 புனை is Tamil’s everyday cat-word, one of (at least) three
 genuinely separate Dravidian cat-word families நாய், புனை

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 21, p. 129

door — Tamil’s everyday word is its own, while the Sanskrit one stayed in books கதவு (kadavu)
explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 35, p. 205

E

Evening

chapter topic; Chapter 27, p. 155

evening (mālai) — a genuine HOMONYM: Wiktionary lists TWO separate etymologies for this exact spelling — “garland/necklace” (possibly a Dravidian word BORROWED INTO Sanskrit as माला/mālā, a reverse-direction loan) and, unrelated, “evening” (compared to மால், Proto-Dravidian *mā*/māl, whose senses include “கருமை,” darkness); confidently native for the evening sense, unlike TA-C26’s uncertain காலை, though the exact semantic mechanism (“evening” ← “darkness” specifically) isn’t spelled out with full certainty by the source மாலை (mālai)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 27, p. 155

F

Family

chapter topic; Chapter 12, p. 79

family குடும்பம் (kuṭumbam)

Chapter 43, p. 267

Farewells

chapter topic; Chapter 4, p. 15

father, mother, and FOUR sibling words — Tamil splits “brother”/“sister” by age, where Spanish/French use just one word each அப்பா அம்மா அண்ணன் தம்பி அக்கா தங்கை
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 12, p. 79

first of all முதலில் (mutalil)

Chapter 62, p. 379

Five familiar words — now in Tamil script

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 7, p. 35

Five numerals — hide, then write

script and writing topic; explicit focus: writing; Chapter 7, p. 35

food — the noun standing on உண், the older eating verb behind சாப்பிடு’s everyday one உணவு (uṇavu)

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, etymology; Chapter 36, p. 215

Four Verbs Between People

chapter topic; Chapter 34, p. 195

Four Verbs of the Mind

chapter topic; Chapter 33, p. 185

friend — one word with three endings for man, woman and respect, and a root meaning “close” நண்பன் (naṇbaṇ)

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, etymology; Chapter 37, p. 225

G**ghee** நெய் (ney)

Chapter 59, p. 361

give கொடு (koṭu)

Chapter 42, p. 263

gladness சந்தோஷம் (santōṣam)

Chapter 49, p. 301

good நல்ல (nalla)

Chapter 41, p. 257

Good Afternoon

chapter topic; Chapter 31, p. 169

good afternoon (matiya vaṇakkam), confirmed by two sources for roughly noon to 4 PM, while a third source does not teach a separate afternoon greeting மதிய வணக்கம் (matiya vaṇakkam)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 31, p. 169

Good Evening

chapter topic; Chapter 30, p. 167

good evening (mālai vaṇakkam), literally “evening greetings” — the SAME compositional pattern as TA-C29’s kālai vaṇakkam: மாலை (already met, TA-C27, “evening”) + வணக்கம் (already met, TA-C01); confirmed via TWO independently-fetched sources (talkpal.ai, preply.com — same practical-content tier as TA-C29’s sources) as real and used from afternoon/late-afternoon through nightfall, one labeling it formal; no śubha-equivalent word here either, consistent with TA-C29’s finding, not just assumed to carry over automatically மாலை வணக்கம் (mālai vaṇakkam)

explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 30, p. 167

Good Morning

chapter topic; Chapter 29, p. 163

good morning (kālai vaṇakkam), literally “morning greetings” — a transparent compound of காலை (already met, TA-C26) + வணக்கம் (already met, TA-C01, “reverence, homage”); confirmed via TWO independently-fetched sources as the standard, formal greeting, used from sunrise until around 11 AM; NOT a śubha-equivalent construction, breaking the pattern its neighbours share; a WebSearch summary’s claim that a Sanskrit-borrowed “suprabhatham” is a casual alternative could NOT be traced to either directly-fetched source and is therefore not asserted here காலை வணக்கம் (kālai vaṇakkam)
explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 29, p. 163

Good Night

chapter topic; Chapter 25, p. 147

“good night” — fully native Dravidian, “sweet/pleasant night,” unlike Hindi, Kannada, Telugu, and Malayalam’s shared Sanskrit-descended śubha rātri phrase; Tamil breaks the pattern this arc found in every other language இனிய இரவு (iniya iravu)
explicit focus: etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 25, p. 147

goodbye (lit. “I’ll go and come back”) போய் வருகிறேன் (pōy varugirēn)
explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 4, p. 15

grass புல் (pul)

Chapter 64, p. 391

Green and Yellow

chapter topic; Chapter 22, p. 133

green and yellow — paccai is the pan-Dravidian *pac-* word already met in Kannada, Telugu, and Malayalam; manjal (“yellow, turmeric”) is a separate native Dravidian root, matching Malayalam’s mañña/maññaḷ closely — and Tamil dictionaries also record a rarer, less-commonly-used pacuppu (“greenish yellow”), a genuine doublet of paccai itself, echoing Telugu’s pattern in miniature பச்சை, மஞ்சள் (paccai mañcaḷ)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 22, p. 133

Greetings

chapter topic; Chapter 1, p. 1

H

head and hand — both native Dravidian words, unlike Hindi’s Sanskrit-descended pair தலை கை (talai kai)
Chapter 13, p. 83

hear and say one to five before meeting their written forms *onru irantu muunru naanku aintu*

explicit focus: pronunciation; Chapter 7, p. 35

hear and say six to ten before meeting their written forms *aaru eezhu ettu onpatu pattu*

explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 7, p. 35

Heard numbers — write without a model

script and writing topic; explicit focus: writing; Chapter 7, p. 35

hello / greetings (vaṇakkam — “reverence, homage”) வணக்கம் (vaṇakkam)

explicit focus: pronunciation, writing, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 1, p. 1

here — where I am இங்கே (iṅgē)

Chapter 40, p. 251

hesitancy தயக்கம் (tayakkam)

Chapter 63, p. 385

hour — Tamil’s OWN dictionaries treat this as a native

Dravidian “bell” word, most likely NOT Kannada/Telugu/

Hindi’s Sanskrit ghaṇṭā, and a probable homophone trap with an unrelated Sanskrit “gem” word spelled the same

way மணி (maṇi)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 18, p. 109

house, home — the word behind the door you say வணக்கம் at, and a v where Kannada says b வீடு (vīḍu)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 35, p. 205

how எப்படி (eppaḍi)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 3, p. 11

How Are You?

chapter topic; Chapter 3, p. 11

how are you? (respectful) நீங்கள் எப்படி இருக்கிறீர்கள்?

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 3, p. 11

How Much

chapter topic; Chapter 56, p. 343

how much — the question for things Tamil does not count one

by one எவ்வளவு (evvaḷavu)

explicit focus: script, grammar; Chapter 39, p. 243

how old are you? — literally “to you how many years is becoming?”; the SAME Sanskrit vayas word as Kannada/

Telugu/Malayalam; Tamil actually spans BOTH grammatical shapes seen so far, from a plain possessive in casual speech to this more formal dative+verb construction உனக்கு எத்தனை வயது ஆகிறது?

Chapter 19, p. 117

How the Body Feels

chapter topic; Chapter 61, p. 373

humility பணிவு (paṇivu)

Chapter 63, p. 385

hunger பசி (pasi)

Chapter 61, p. 373

I**I நான்** (nān)

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 3, p. 11

i- / a- / e- — six words, one machine

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 40, p. 251

'I know Tamil' — built with no subject, because knowing**happens TO you** எனக்குத் தமிழ் தெரியும் (enakkut tamīl teriyum)

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 6, p. 23

I speak Tamil நான் தமிழ் பேசுகிறேன் (nān tamīl pēsugirēn)

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 5, p. 19

In the Kitchen

chapter topic; Chapter 59, p. 361

Introducing Yourself

chapter topic; Chapter 2, p. 7

it's okay / no problem / you're**welcome** பரவாயில்லை (paravāyillai)

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 3, p. 11

J**jaggery** வெல்லம் (vellam)

Chapter 59, p. 361

joy / pleased to meet you மகிழ்ச்சி

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 2, p. 7

just so அப்படியே (appaḍiyē)

Chapter 47, p. 289

K**Keeping Well, and Leaving**

chapter topic; Chapter 38, p. 235

L

leave to depart — the noun for taking your leave, from the same root as வீடு விடை (viḍai)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 38, p. 235

let it be so ஆகட்டும் (ākaṭṭum)

Chapter 56, p. 343

M

milk — one syllable, inherited whole, and the word that shows

Kannada turning p into h பால் (pāl)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 36, p. 215

More Everyday Verbs

chapter topic; Chapter 42, p. 263

More of the Body

chapter topic; Chapter 45, p. 277

Morning

chapter topic; Chapter 26, p. 153

morning (kālai) — Wiktionary itself HEDGES the etymology (“possibly from Sanskrit काल्य/kālya”), not a confirmed Dravidian root; genuinely uncertain, unlike Kannada’s confidently-native or Telugu’s confidently-Sanskrit morning-words; பகல் (already met, TA-C17, “daytime”) is Wiktionary’s own listed coordinate term; அதிகாலை (“early dawn”) is a transparent ati-+kālai

compound காலை (kālai)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 26, p. 153

mud சேறு (sēru)

Chapter 57, p. 349

my என் (en)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 2, p. 7

my name is... (with no “is”) என் பெயர் ... (en peyar ...)

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 2, p. 7

N

name பெயர் (peyar)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 2, p. 7

new புதிய (pudiyā)

Chapter 41, p. 257

Night

chapter topic; Chapter 24, p. 143

“night” — native Dravidian, already used standalone inside “midnight” (naḷḷiravu); a Sanskrit loan alternative, rāttiri, also exists — and per at least one dictionary source, rāttiri may actually be the MORE common word in everyday spoken Tamil, the opposite direction from நாள்’s story last lesson இரவு (iravu)
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 24, p. 143

Night words — a register hypothesis and a semantic boundary
grammar topic; explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 24, p. 143

no / there isn’t (illai — the negative) இல்லை (illai)
explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 1, p. 1

Noon and Midnight

chapter topic; Chapter 17, p. 105

noon and midnight — NO Sanskrit here at all (unlike Kannada/Telugu); both trace to the same old “middle” root, நள் (naḷ), but Tamil ALSO keeps fully transparent synonyms built on நடு, the everyday word for “middle” நண்பகல் நள்ளிரவு
explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 17, p. 105

Noon or afternoon? — let the sources keep their blur
etymology topic; explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 28, p. 159

now இப்போது (ippōdu)
Chapter 48, p. 295

Numbers Eleven to Twenty and Weather

chapter topic; Chapter 20, p. 123

Numbers One to Ten

chapter topic; Chapter 7, p. 35

O

oil எண்ணெய் (eṇṇey)

Chapter 59, p. 361

okay / alright / correct (sari) சரி (sari)

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 1, p. 1

old — of a thing, not of a person பழைய (palaiya)

Chapter 41, p. 257

ோ — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 7, p. 35

ா — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 10, p. 67

ூ — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 17, p. 105

ே — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 19, p. 117

One heard request — write it

script and writing topic; explicit focus: writing; Chapter 8, p. 51

only மட்டும் (maṭṭum)

Chapter 62, p. 379

Only and Still

chapter topic; Chapter 62, p. 379

Overhead

chapter topic; Chapter 51, p. 313

P

paddy நெல் (nel)

Chapter 64, p. 391

pain வலி (vali)

Chapter 61, p. 373

perhaps ஒருவேளை (oruvēlai)

Chapter 47, p. 289

permission அனுமதி (aṇumati)

Chapter 63, p. 385

Please

chapter topic; Chapter 8, p. 51

please forgive (mannikkavum — a formal/written polite request, from மன்னி manṇi “to forgive”) மன்னிக்கவும்

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 9, p. 61

please (tayavu seytu — “do the kindness,” from தயவு tayavu “compassion/grace”) தயவுசெய்து (tayavu seytu)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 8, p. 51

please tell me solluṇigal

Chapter 8, p. 51

Pointing, and Asking

chapter topic; Chapter 40, p. 251

R

read படி (paṭi)

Chapter 42, p. 263

respect மரியாதை (mariyādai)

Chapter 49, p. 301

room — and the letter ற, the hard r that is not the r you think

it is அறை (arai)

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, etymology; Chapter 35, p. 205

S

salt உப்பு (uppu)

Chapter 44, p. 271

sand மணல் (maṇal)

Chapter 57, p. 349

Seasons

chapter topic; Chapter 14, p. 89

see you tomorrow நாளை பார்க்கலாம் (nālai pārkkalām)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 4, p. 15

Setting Out

chapter topic; Chapter 48, p. 295

Short Replies

chapter topic; Chapter 47, p. 289

sit உட்கார் (uṭkāṛ)

Chapter 42, p. 263

Six to ten — family resemblances and one Kannada shift

etymology topic; explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 7, p. 35

Six to ten — now in Tamil script

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 7, p. 35

sleep தூக்கம் (tūkkam)

Chapter 61, p. 373

small சிறிய (siriyā)

Chapter 41, p. 257

smoke புகை (pukai)

Chapter 57, p. 349

Solluṅgaḷ — hide, then write

script and writing topic; explicit focus: writing; Chapter 8, p. 51

son மகன் (maṇan)

Chapter 43, p. 267

soon சீக்கிரம் (sikkiram)

Chapter 62, p. 379

Sorry

chapter topic; Chapter 9, p. 61

spring, summer, monsoon, winter — and the honest note that
the REAL locally central season is the rains, not a Western
four-way split வசந்த காலம் கோடைக் காலம் மழைக் காலம்
குளிர் காலம்

explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 14, p. 89

still, yet இன்னும் (innum)

Chapter 62, p. 379

sugar சர்க்கரை (sarkkarai)

Chapter 59, p. 361

T

Tamil Months

chapter topic; Chapter 16, p. 97

Tamil's curves — the writing surface leaves a trace

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 4, p. 15

tea — a borrowed syllable welded onto the நீர் that is already

inside தண்ணீர் தேநீர் (tēnīr)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 36, p. 215

Telling Time

chapter topic; Chapter 18, p. 109

thank you (nanri — “goodness, gratitude”) நன்றி (nanri)

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 1, p. 1

thank you very much மிக்க நன்றி (mikka nanri)

Chapter 49, p. 301

that is enough போதும் (pōdum)

Chapter 47, p. 289

that one — the thing over there அது (adu)

Chapter 40, p. 251

the back முதுகு (mutuku)

Chapter 55, p. 337

The Core Verbs

chapter topic; Chapter 32, p. 175

the dative suffix -ukku, ‘to / for,’ including its two surface forms

and irregular enakku -உக்கு (-ukku)

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 6, p. 23

the design at a doorway கோலம் (kōlam)

Chapter 50, p. 307

◌ — the dot that leaves both letters visible

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 7, p. 35

◌ — the dot that takes the vowel away

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 18, p. 109

The First Verbs

chapter topic; Chapter 5, p. 19

ி — the first vowel sign

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 19, p. 117

The Harvest

chapter topic; Chapter 64, p. 391

the harvest அறுவடை (aruvaṭai)

Chapter 64, p. 391

The Household

chapter topic; Chapter 43, p. 267

The Land

chapter topic; Chapter 53, p. 325

the moon நிலா (nilā)

Chapter 51, p. 313

the neck கழுத்து (kaḷuttu)

Chapter 55, p. 337

The Rest of You

chapter topic; Chapter 55, p. 337

the seven weekdays — a mix of Tamil's OWN planet-words and Sanskrit borrowings திங்கள்-ஞாயிறு

explicit focus: grammar, usage and culture; Chapter 10, p. 67

the sky ஆகாயம் (ākāyam)

Chapter 51, p. 313

the stomach வயிறு (vayiru)

Chapter 45, p. 277

the sun சூரியன் (sūriyan)

Chapter 51, p. 313

the truth உண்மை (uṇmai)

Chapter 47, p. 289

the twelve months of the Tamil solar calendar — Tamil's OWN calendar, distinct from both the Gregorian and Hindu lunisolar systems சித்திரை வைகாசி ஆனி ஆடி ஆவணி புரட்டாசி ஐப்பசி கார்த்திகை மார்கழி தை மாசி பங்குனி

explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 16, p. 97

the wind காற்று (kārru)

Chapter 57, p. 349

there is no need தேவையில்லை (tēvaiyillai)

Chapter 56, p. 343

there — where I am not அங்கே (aṅgē)

Chapter 40, p. 251

Things in the House

chapter topic; Chapter 54, p. 331

Things People Make

chapter topic; Chapter 60, p. 367

Things You Ask For

chapter topic; Chapter 44, p. 271

thirst தாகம் (tākam)

Chapter 61, p. 373

“this is my friend” — three words, no verb, and a choice of ending that says how you regard them இவர் என் நண்பர் (ivar en naṇbar)

explicit focus: script, usage and culture; Chapter 37, p. 225

this one — the thing near me இது (idu)

Chapter 40, p. 251

this person, spoken of with respect — the near end of Tamil’s இ / அ / எ pointing system இவர் (ivar)

explicit focus: script, grammar; Chapter 37, p. 225

Three heard numbers — write their numerals

script and writing topic; explicit focus: writing; Chapter 7, p. 35

time நேரம் (nēram)

Chapter 48, p. 295

to ask — and to hear, because Tamil gives both jobs to one verb, whose stem changes shape before the beads கேள் (kēḷ)

explicit focus: script, etymology, usage and culture; Chapter 34, p. 195

to be, to exist, to stay — and the three-piece machine every

Tamil verb is built on இரு (iru)

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar; Chapter 32, p. 175

to be understood, to become clear — so the understander is not the subject but sits in the dative, as with தெரி புரி (puri)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 33, p. 185

to catch, to hold — and so, in பிடிக்கும், to please, with the liker pushed into the dative பிடி (piḍi)

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 34, p. 195

to come — the word you say it by is வா, but the beads attach to a different shape, வரு- வா (vā)

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 32, p. 175

to eat — a verb Tamil assembled from a noun plus a light verb, alongside the inherited eat-word it kept சாப்பிடு (sāppiḍu)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 32, p. 175

to go (and வா, to come) போ (pō)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 4, p. 15

to go — the same three-slot verb with the middle bead swapped for past, present or future போ (pō)

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 32, p. 175

to help, to be of use — a native word where three sisters and Hindi all reach for Sanskrit instead உதவு (udavu)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 34, p. 195

to know, to be apparent — the verb that takes no person ending, because knowing happens to you தெரி (teri)

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 32, p. 175

to live, to flourish வாழ் (vāl)

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 5, p. 19

to read, to study — and the reason this book writes it paḍi with a d when the letter is ட டடி (paḍi)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 33, p. 185

to see, to look — and the doubled consonant that sorts every Tamil verb into strong or weak பார் (pār)

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 32, p. 175

to set out புறப்படு (purappaḍu)

Chapter 48, p. 295

to speak பேசு (pēsu)

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 5, p. 19

to take, to pick up — one vowel away from இடு, “to put,” and pointing the opposite way எடு (eḍu)

explicit focus: script, etymology; Chapter 34, p. 195

to think — and, with no second word, to remember, because Tamil files thinking and recalling under one verb நினை (ninai)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 33, p. 185

to work (lit. “work-do”) வேலை செய் (vēlai sey)

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 5, p. 19

to write — carrying ற, the retroflex glide Tamil and Malayalam kept and their sisters gave up எழுது (eḷudu)

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, etymology; Chapter 33, p. 185

town, village — where you are from, which a Tamil introduction asks for, and the -ore in Bangalore ஊர் (ūr)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 37, p. 225

trust நம்பிக்கை (nambikkai)

Chapter 63, p. 385

Two to five — one family in four regional coats

etymology topic; explicit focus: pronunciation, etymology; Chapter 7, p. 35

U

-ukku, -ku, -ge, -ikku — the family shows its bones

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 6, p. 23

W

want, need — another verb Tamil builds with no subject at all வேண்டும் (vēṇḍum)

explicit focus: pronunciation, script, grammar; Chapter 39, p. 243

Water and Rice

chapter topic; Chapter 15, p. 93

water, and rice — the actual staple food here, not bread — with a widely-cited (if not fully certain) link from arisi to the English word “rice” itself தண்ணீர் அரிசி சாதம்

explicit focus: usage and culture; Chapter 15, p. 93

we’ll meet again மீண்டும் சந்திப்போம் (mīṇḍum sandippōm)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 4, p. 15

weather — most likely a NATIVE Dravidian compound, unlike Kannada/Telugu/Malayalam’s Sanskrit compounds: vaanam (“sky”) + nilai (“state, standing”) வானிலை (vānilai)

Chapter 20, p. 123

well, wellness, good — and the reply “நான் நலமாக

இருக்கிறேன்” நலம் (nalam)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 3, p. 11

wellbeing, ease — the Sanskrit word Tamil did take in, sitting beside the native நலம் it never dropped சுகம் (sugam)

explicit focus: script, grammar, etymology; Chapter 38, p. 235

what என்ன (enna)

explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 2, p. 7

what’s your name? உங்கள் பெயர் என்ன?

explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 2, p. 7

What You Are Offered

chapter topic; Chapter 36, p. 215

where? — asking about a place எங்கே (eṅgē)

Chapter 40, p. 251

who? — asking about a person யார் (yār)

Chapter 40, p. 251

Who Somebody Is

chapter topic; Chapter 46, p. 283

Wind and Fire

chapter topic; Chapter 57, p. 349

Y

yes (ām) ஆம்

explicit focus: pronunciation, grammar, etymology; Chapter 1, p. 1

you (familiar / respectful) நீ / நீங்கள் (nī / nīṅgal)

explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 2, p. 7

Your age what? / To you how many years becomes?

grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 19, p. 117

Your Town, Your Friend

chapter topic; Chapter 37, p. 225

Other

அ — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 15, p. 93

ஆ — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 16, p. 97

ஆம் — **writing a word that starts with a vowel**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 16, p. 97

இருக்கிறீர்கள் — **the last sign, and the whole question**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 31, p. 169

இல்லை — **a vowel in front, a vowel sign behind**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 18, p. 109

-உக்கு — **one carriage in a suffix train**
grammar topic; explicit focus: grammar; Chapter 6, p. 23

உணவு — **the same vowel, twice, two ways**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 36, p. 215

ஊர் — **the long partner**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 37, p. 225

எ — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 8, p. 51

என் — **the third vowel that opens a word**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 21, p. 129

எப்படி — **the retroflex stop**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 29, p. 163

ஏழு — **hide, then write**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: writing; Chapter 7, p. 35

ஒன்று — **the letter under both shapes of “one”**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 39, p. 243

க — **the letter that is three bowls**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 13, p. 83

ச — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 12, p. 79

சொ — **one new sign in a familiar request**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 8, p. 51

சரி — **one letter, several sounds**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 19, p. 117

சொல்லுங்கள் — **one visible copy**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: writing; Chapter 8, p. 51

஌ — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 14, p. 89

ண் — **the first of three n’s**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 6, p. 23

த — **one character, met inside words you already say**
script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 18, p. 109

தமிழ் — the letter the language is named for

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 33, p. 185

தயவுசெய்து or -உங்கள்? — politeness in phrase or verb

grammar topic; explicit focus: script, usage and culture; Chapter 8, p. 51

ந — the third n, and the only one built from uprights

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 8, p. 51

ந, ன, ண — three stops on one tongue-map

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 6, p. 23

ந, ன, ற — the letter bodies inside நன்றி

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 10, p. 67

நீங்கள் — two old promises, paid

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 27, p. 155

நடுப்பகல் and நடு இரவு — the transparent twins

etymology topic; Chapter 17, p. 105

நான் — the sign that stands after

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 25, p. 147

நன்றி — a native family word with a register edge

etymology topic; Chapter 1, p. 1

நல்ல இரவு and இரவு வணக்கம் — old roots recombined

etymology topic; Chapter 25, p. 147

நாள் and தினம் — everyday native, formal borrowed

etymology topic; Chapter 23, p. 137

ன — the second n, and how to tell it from ண

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 7, p. 35

ப — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 6, p. 23

போ — one sign, two marks

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 35, p. 205

பேசு — the long partner of ெ

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 34, p. 195

பெயர் — a sign that waits on the left

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 23, p. 137

ம and ண — a loop, and a curled tongue

script and writing topic; explicit focus: pronunciation, script; Chapter 6, p. 23

ம — upright on the left, curve on the right

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 16, p. 97

மணி — hour or jewel? Context decides

etymology topic; explicit focus: grammar, etymology; Chapter 18, p. 109

மதிய — the greeting takes a different root

etymology topic; explicit focus: etymology; Chapter 31, p. 169

மன்னிக்கவும் — formal forgiveness and a doubled n

grammar topic; explicit focus: script, usage and culture; Chapter 9, p. 61

மூன்று — the fourth corner of the u-family

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 38, p. 235

ய — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 20, p. 123

ர — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 13, p. 83

ற — the last of the family, and the one that drops below the line

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 10, p. 67

ல — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 9, p. 61

ழ — one character, met inside words you already say

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 11, p. 75

வ and க — the vowel inside each consonant

script and writing topic; explicit focus: pronunciation, script, grammar; Chapter 5, p. 19

வ — copy one visible shape with help

script and writing topic; explicit focus: writing; Chapter 1, p. 1

வ — one spiral, one motion

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 6, p. 23

வணக்கம் — one bow, two lexical loyalties

etymology topic; Chapter 1, p. 1

வணக்கம் — the first whole written word

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script; Chapter 8, p. 51

க · உ · ந — three numeral shapes

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 7, p. 35

க உ ந ச று — one visible copy

script and writing topic; explicit focus: writing; Chapter 7, p. 35

ச · று — finish the first five numerals

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 7, p. 35

கூ · எ · அ — three more numeral shapes

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 7, p. 35

கூ எ அ கூ ய — one supported copy

script and writing topic; explicit focus: writing; Chapter 7, p. 35

கூ · ய — nine and ten

script and writing topic; explicit focus: script, writing; Chapter 7, p. 35